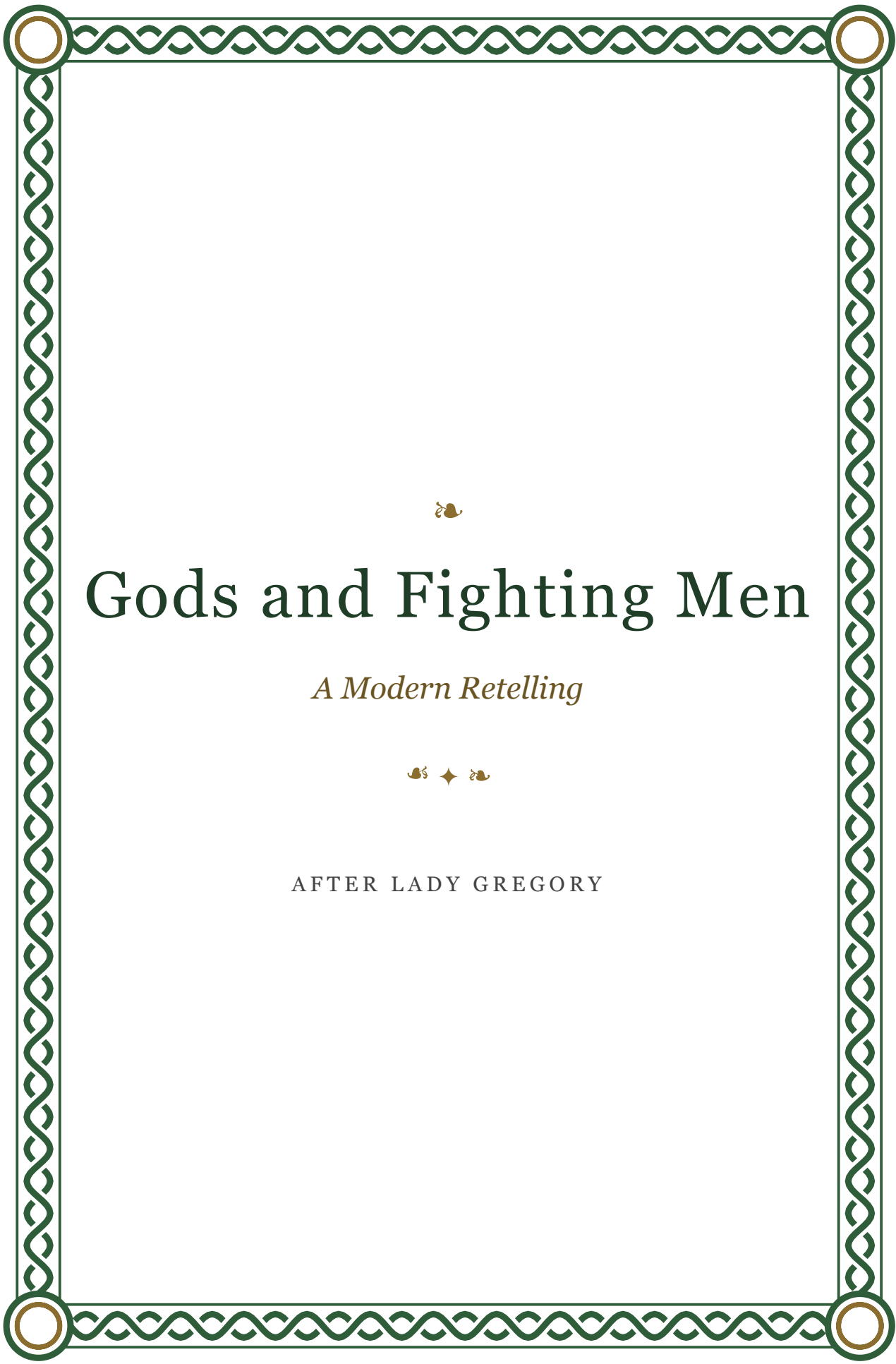




Gods and Fighting Men

A Modern Retelling



AFTER LADY GREGORY

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PART ONE: THE GODS

Book One: The Coming Of The Tuatha De Danaan



CHAPTER I

The Fight With The Firbolgs



They came in a mist.



Nuada Airgetlám — First King of the Tuatha Dé Danann — Lord of the Silver Hand



Lugh Lámfhada — God of Light, Skill, and Craftsmanship — Master of All Arts

The Tuatha de Danaan, the people of the gods of Dana — some called them the Men of Dea — came through the air and the high air to Ireland, and nobody saw them come.

They came from the north. In the place they had left behind there had been four cities, and in those cities they had fought their long battle for learning: great Falias, and shining Gorias, and Finias, and rich Murias that lay to the south. Each city had a wise man to teach the young men skill and knowledge and perfect wisdom. Senias taught in Murias. Arias, the fair-haired poet, taught in Finias. Urias of the noble nature taught in Gorias. And Morias taught in Falias itself.

From those four cities they brought four treasures, and you should remember them, because treasures in stories like this are never only treasures.

From Falias they brought a Stone of Virtue, the Lia Fail, the Stone of Destiny.

From Gorias they brought a Sword.

From Finias they brought a Spear of Victory.

And from Murias they brought the Cauldron. No company ever went away from that Cauldron unsatisfied. Not one.

Nuada was king of the Tuatha de Danaan in those days. But Manannan, son of Lir, was greater than the king, and everybody knew it, and Nuada knew it too.

There were others who stood high among them. There was Ogma, the king's brother, who taught them writing. There was Diancecht, who understood healing. There was Neit, a god of battle. There was Credenus the Craftsman, and Goibniu the Smith.

And the women. The greatest among their women were Badb, a battle goddess; and Macha, whose mast-feeding — the acorns she fattened on, as a pig fattens in an oak wood — was the heads of men killed in battle; and the Morrighu, the Crow of Battle. There were Eire and Fodla and Banba, the three daughters of the Dagda, and each of the three would give her name to Ireland in the time to come. There was Eadon, the nurse of poets.



The Dagda — Father of the Gods — Lord of Perfect Knowledge — The Good God

And there was Brigit.

Brigit was a woman of poetry, and the poets worshipped her, for her sway was very great and very noble. She was a woman of healing too, and a woman of smith's work, and it was Brigit who first made the whistle for calling from one person to another through the night. One side of her face was ugly. The other side was very comely. Her name meant Breosaighit, a fiery arrow.

There were many others among the women, shadow-forms and great queens. But beyond them all was Dana, who was called the Mother of the Gods.

Three things they held above all others: the plough, and the sun, and the hazel-tree. So it was said, long after, that Ireland was divided between those three — Coll the hazel, and Cecht the plough, and Grian the sun.

Below the sea they had a well. Nine hazels of wisdom grew over it — the hazels of inspiration, of the knowledge of poetry. Their leaves and their blossoms broke out in the same hour, and fell together on the well in a shower that raised a purple wave. Five salmon waited in that water. They ate the nuts as they fell, and the colour of the nuts came out in the red spots of their skin, and anyone who ate one of those salmon would know all wisdom and all poetry. Seven streams of wisdom sprang from that well and turned back into it again, and the people of many arts have all drunk from it, whether they knew it or not.

It was on the first day of Beltaine, that we call May Day now, that the Tuatha de Danaan came, and they landed in the north-west of Connacht.

The Firbolgs were in Ireland before them. The Men of the Bag, they were called, and they had come up from the South. When the Tuatha de Danaan landed, the Firbolgs saw nothing at all. Only a mist, lying on the hills.

Eochaid, son of Erc, was king of the Firbolgs, and messengers came to him at Teamhair. A new race of people had come into Ireland, they said, and whether they had come out of the earth, or down from the skies, or in on the wind, nobody could say. They had settled themselves at Magh Rein.

The messengers expected Eochaid to be astonished.

He was not. A dream had come to him in the night, and when he asked his Druids what it meant, they told him that it would not be long until a strong enemy came against him. So he had been waiting.

Eochaid took counsel with his chief advisers, and they agreed to send a good champion of their own to look at the strangers and to speak with them. They chose Sreng, a great fighting man. Sreng rose up and took his strong red-brown shield, and his two thick-handled spears, and his sword, and his head-covering, and his thick iron club, and he set out from Teamhair towards the place where the strangers were, at Magh Rein.

The watchers of the Tuatha de Danaan saw him before he got there. They sent out a champion of their own to meet him and talk with him. His name was Bres, and he carried his shield and his sword and his two spears.

The two champions walked towards each other slowly. Each kept a careful watch on the other, and each wondered at the other's weapons. When they were close enough to talk, they stopped, and each put his shield in front of his body and struck it hard into the ground, and they looked at one another over the rims.

Bres spoke first.

When Sreng heard that it was Irish he was speaking — his own tongue — he was less uneasy. They drew closer, and asked each other about family and race, as men do.

After a while they put their shields away. Sreng admitted he had raised his in dread of the thin, sharp spears Bres was holding. Bres said he had been in dread of the thick-handled spears Sreng carried, and asked whether all the Firbolgs were armed like that. Sreng undid the tyings of his spears to show them better, and Bres marvelled at them: so strong, so heavy, and sharp along the sides even though they had no points.

"These are called Craisech," said Sreng. "They break through shields. They crush flesh and bone. A thrust from one is death, or a wound that never heals."

Then he looked at the spears Bres carried — sharp, thin, hard-pointed.

In the end they exchanged spears, so that the fighters on each side could see what weapons the others were used to.

And Bres gave Sreng a message to take back. If the Firbolgs would give up half of Ireland, his people would take that half and be content, and there would be peace. If they would not give up that much, there would be a battle.

Before they parted, the two men said to one another that whatever happened afterwards, they themselves would be friends.

Sreng went back to Teamhair. He gave the message, and he showed them the spear, and he told his people what he thought: share the country, and do not go into battle against a people whose weapons were so much better than their own.

Eochaid and his chief men talked it over. And in the end they said, "We will not give up half the country to these strangers. If we do, they will soon take the whole of it."

It is not clear they were wrong.

As for the Men of Dea: when Bres came back and showed them the heavy spear, and told them about the strong, fierce man he had got it from, how sturdy he was and how well armed, they thought it likely there would soon be a battle. So they moved from where they were to a better place, farther west in Connacht. They settled themselves on the plain of Magh Nia, and built walls and dug ditches, with the great mountain Belgata at their backs.

And while they were moving and building, three of their queens went to Teamhair, where the Firbolgs were making their plans. Badb and Macha and the Morrighu. By the power of their enchantments they brought mists and clouds of darkness over the whole place, and sent down showers of fire and showers of blood upon the people, so that for three days nobody could see anybody else, or speak to them.

At the end of the three days the three Druids of the Firbolgs broke the enchantment. Their names were Cesarn and Gnathach and Ingnathach.

The Firbolgs gathered their men. They came with eleven battalions and took their stand at the eastern end of the plain of Magh Nia.

Nuada, king of the Men of Dea, sent his poets to make the same offer as before: give up half the country, and he would be content with it. King Eochaid told the poets to put the question to his chief men, who were gathered there, and when they heard it they would not consent.

"When will you begin the battle, then?" asked the messengers.

"We need a delay," they said. "We want time to put our spears and our armour in order, to brighten our helmets and sharpen our swords, and to have spears made like the ones you carry. And as for you," they said, "you'll be wanting spears like our Craisechs made for yourselves."

So they agreed on a delay of a quarter of a year, for preparation. That is how battles were fought, then. Everybody was to be ready.

It was on a Midsummer day that the battle began.

Three times nine hurlers of the Tuatha de Danaan went out against three times nine hurlers of the Firbolgs. The Tuatha de Danaan lost, and every one of them was killed.

Eochaid sent a messenger to ask whether they would fight every day or every second day. Nuada answered that they would fight every day, but that there should always be exactly the same number of men fighting on each side. Eochaid agreed, but he was not pleased, for the Firbolgs had more men than the Men of Dea, and he had been counting on that.

The battle went on for four days. Great feats were done on each side, and a great many champions came to their deaths. And every evening, for those who were still alive, the physicians of each side made a bath of healing, with every healing plant and herb in it, so that the men would rise whole and strong for the next day's fighting.

On the fourth day the Men of Dea got the upper hand, and the Firbolgs were driven back.

In the middle of the fighting a great thirst came on Eochaid, their king. He went off the field to look for a drink, with three fifties of his men to guard him. Three fifties of the Tuatha de Danaan followed them, all the way to the strand called Traigh Eothaile. There

was a fierce fight on that strand, and at the end of it King Eochaid fell. They buried him there, and raised a great heap of stones over his grave.

He had only wanted a drink of water.

When there were no more than three hundred men left out of the eleven battalions of the Firbolgs, with Sreng at the head of them, Nuada offered them peace, and their choice of any one of the five provinces of Ireland. Sreng said they would take Connacht. He and his people lived there after, and their children after them. Ferdiad came of that people in the time to come, who made so good a fight against Cuchulain; and so did Erc, son of Cairbre, who gave Cuchulain his death.

That battle, the first the Men of Dea fought in Ireland, is called by some the first battle of Magh Tuireadh.

The Tuatha de Danaan took Teamhair for themselves.

It had other names. Druim Cain, the Beautiful Ridge. Liathdruim, the Grey Ridge. Druim na Descan, the Ridge of the Outlook. All of those were Teamhair. And from that time on it stood above every other place, for the king who held it was the High King over all Ireland.

The king's rath lay to the north. The Hill of the Hostages lay to the north-east of the High Seat, and the Green of Teamhair lay west of the Hill of the Hostages. North-east, in the Hill of the Sidhe, was a well called Nemnach, and out of it flowed a stream called Nith, and on that stream the first mill in Ireland was built.

North of the Hill of the Hostages stood the stone, the Lia Fail. It roared under the feet of every king who would take possession of Ireland. It still knew what it was for.

Near the House of the Women was the Wall of the Three Whispers. The House of the Women had seven doors to the east and seven doors to the west, and the feasts of Teamhair were held there. There was the Great House of a Thousand Soldiers, too, and near it, to the south, the little Hill of the Woman Soldiers.

That was Teamhair. The gods had it now.

But a king who has won a country must still keep it, and there was a thing about Nuada that nobody had spoken of yet.



Book Two: Lugh Of The Long Hand



The Reign Of Bres



Nuada won the battle. But he lost his arm in it. Sreng struck it off, and from that loss came trouble and vexation on all his people.

This was the law of the Tuatha de Danaan: no man who was not perfect in his shape could be king. It did not matter that Nuada had won. It did not matter that he had lost the arm winning. The law was the law, and they put him out of the kingship.

The king they chose in his place was Bres.

Bres was the most beautiful of all their young men. He was so beautiful that when people wanted to praise anything beautiful — a plain, a dun, ale, a flame, a woman, a man, a horse — what they said was, "It is as beautiful as Bres." His mother was a woman of the Tuatha de Danaan. Who his father was, nobody knew but her.

Beauty is not the same as luck, and it is not the same as goodness. Bres's reign brought no good fortune to his people.

The Fomor lived beyond the sea — or below the sea, to the west, some say — and in the days of Bres they began to put tribute on the Men of Dea, so as to bring them under their own rule.

The Fomor had first come to Ireland long before. They were dreadful to look at, and maimed: they had only one foot, or only one hand, and they were led by a giant and his mother. No army more horrible or more dreadful than that army of the Fomor ever came to Ireland. They had been friendly enough with the Firbolgs, and content to leave Ireland to them. But between the Fomor and the Men of Dea there was jealousy.

The tax they put on them was hard. A third part of their corn. A third part of their milk. A third part of their children. There was no smoke rising from any roof in Ireland that was not under tribute to the Fomor.

And Bres made no stand against them. He let them have their way.

Bres had his own tax, too. On every house in Ireland he put a demand for the milk of hornless dun cows, or of cows of some other single colour — enough milk for a hundred men.

Once, to deceive him, Nechtan singed every cow in Ireland in a fire of fern, and smeared them with the ashes of flax seed, so that they were all dark brown. He did that on the advice of the Druid Findgoll, son of Findemas.

Another time they made three hundred cows out of wood, with dark brown pails where their udders should have been, and filled the pails with black bog stuff. Bres came to look at the cows and to watch them being milked, and Cian, the father of Lugh, was there. When the cows were milked it was the bog stuff that squeezed out. Bres drank it, thinking it was milk, and he was not the better of it for a long time.

There was another thing against Bres. He was not open-handed.

The chief men of the Tuatha de Danaan grumbled. Their knives were never greased with meat in his house. However often they visited him, they went home with no smell of ale on their breath. There was no pleasure in his house and no merriment, and there was no call for poets, or singers, or harpers, or pipers, or horn-blowers, or jugglers, or fools. They had been used to watch their champions in trials of strength. Now the only use anybody's strength was put to was working for the king.

Ogma himself, the shining poet, was ordered to bring firewood to the palace every day, for the whole army, from the Islands of Mod. He was so weak for want of food that every day the sea swept away two-thirds of his bundle.

The Dagda was put to building raths, for he was a good builder, and he dug a trench round Rath Brese. The work tired him often. Once he nearly gave out altogether for want of food, and this is how that happened.

There was an idle blind man in the house, Cridenbel by name, with a sharp tongue, and he coveted the Dagda's share of food, for he thought his own was small beside it. He said to the Dagda, "For the sake of your good name, let the three best bits of your share be given to me."

The Dagda gave in to that, every night. And he suffered for it, because what the blind man called a bit was the size of a good pig, and with his three bits he took a full third of everything.

One day, when the Dagda was down in the trench, he saw his son, Angus Og, coming towards him.

"That's a good meeting," said Angus. "But what's wrong with you? You don't look well today."

"There's a reason for that," said the Dagda. "Every evening Cridenbel the blind man demands the three best bits of my share of food, and takes them from me."

"I'll give you some advice," said Angus. He put his hand into his bag and took out three pieces of gold and gave them to his father.

"Put these into the three bits you give Cridenbel this evening," he said. "Then they'll be the best bits in the dish. And the gold will turn inside him, and he'll die."

That evening the Dagda did it. No sooner had Cridenbel swallowed the gold than he died.

Some of the people went to the king. "The Dagda has killed Cridenbel," they said. "He gave him some deadly herb."

The king believed it. He was angry with the Dagda, and gave orders that he should be put to death.

"That is not the right judgment of a prince," said the Dagda. And he told them everything: how Cridenbel used to say, "Give me the three best bits in front of you, for my own share isn't good tonight." "And tonight," said the Dagda, "the three best things in front of me were three pieces of gold. So I gave them to him. And he died."

The king ordered the body to be cut open. They found the gold inside, and they knew the Dagda had told the truth.

The next day Angus came to him again. "Your work will soon be done," he said. "When they come to pay you your wages, take nothing they offer until the cattle of Ireland are brought

before you. Then choose a heifer, black and black-maned. I'll tell you how to know her."

So when the Dagda had finished his work, and they asked him what reward he wanted, he did what Angus had told him. Bres thought that was foolishness. He had expected the Dagda to ask for far more than one heifer.

Then, at last, a poet came to the king's house looking for hospitality. He was Corpre, son of Etain, a poet of the Tuatha de Danaan.

This is how he was treated. They put him in a little, dark, narrow house, with no fire in it, no furniture, no bed. For his feast they brought him three small cakes, dry ones, on a little dish.

When he rose up in the morning he was not thankful. As he crossed the green, this is what he said:

"Without food ready on a dish; without milk enough for a calf to grow on; without shelter; without light in the darkness of night; without enough to pay a story-teller: may that be the prosperity of Bres."

From that day there was no good luck with Bres. He went downhill from then on, and he never stopped going.

That was the first satire ever made in Ireland. It will not be the last. Words, in Ireland, are weapons, and poets know it, and so, eventually, do kings.

Now, as for Nuada. After his arm was struck off he lay sick for a while. Then Diancecht the healer made him an arm of silver, with movement in every finger of it, and fitted it on him. From that day he was called Nuada Argat-lamh, Nuada of the Silver Hand.

But Miach, son of Diancecht, was a better healer than his father, and had done many things.

He met a young man at Teamhair once who had only one eye. "If you're a good physician," said the young man, "you'll put an eye in the place of the one I lost."

"I could put the eye of that cat in your lap in its place," said Miach.

"I'd like that well," said the young man.

So Miach put the cat's eye in his head. And the young man would as soon have been without it afterwards. When he wanted to sleep, that was when the eye would start open at the squeaking of the mice, or the flight of birds, or the movement of the rushes. And when he wanted to watch an army or a gathering, that was when the eye was sure to be fast asleep.

Miach was not satisfied with what his father had done for the king. He took Nuada's own hand, the one that had been struck off, and brought it to him and set it in its place.

"Joint to joint," he said, "and sinew to sinew."

Three days and three nights he stayed with the king. On the first day he held the hand against Nuada's side. On the second day he held it against his breast, until it was covered with skin. On the third day he laid bulrushes on it that had been blackened in the fire. And at the end of that time the king was healed.

Diancecht was vexed to see his son do a better cure than he had done himself.

He threw his sword at Miach's head. It cut the flesh, but the boy healed the wound with his skill. Diancecht threw it again. This time it reached the bone, and the boy was able to heal that too. Then Diancecht struck him a third time, and a fourth, until he cut out the brain, because he knew there was no physician who could cure that.

Miach died, and his father buried him.

Herbs grew up out of his grave, one for every joint and sinew in his body: three hundred and sixty-five of them. Airmed, his sister, came and spread out her cloak, and laid the herbs out on it in order, according to their virtues.

Diancecht saw her doing it. He came and mixed up the herbs.

That is why nobody knows all their right powers, even to this day.

When the Tuatha de Danaan saw Nuada as whole as he had been before, they gathered at Teamhair, where Bres was, and told him to give up the kingship, for he had held it long enough. He had to give it up, though he was not willing, and Nuada was king again.

Bres was sick with anger. He searched his mind for a way to be revenged on those who had put him out, and for a way to gather an army against them. And he went to his mother, Eri, daughter of Delbaith, and asked her to tell him what his race was.

"I know that well," she said.

She told him then that his father was a king of the Fomor, Elathan, son of Dalbaech. He had come to her once over a level sea, in some great vessel that seemed to be made of silver — she could never see its shape. He looked like a young man with yellow hair, and his clothes were sewn with gold, and he wore five rings of gold about his neck. She had refused the love of all the young men of her own people. She gave her love to him. And when he left her, she cried.

He had given her a ring from his hand, and told her to give it only to the man whose finger it would fit. Then he went away the same way he had come.

She brought out the ring for Bres. He put it on his middle finger, and it fitted him well.

They went together to the hill where she had stood when she saw the silver vessel coming, and down to the strand, and she and Bres and his people set out for the country of the Fomor.

When they came to that country they found a great plain, with many gatherings of people on it. They went to the gathering that looked the best, and the people there asked where they came from, and they said they came from Ireland.

"Have you hounds with you?" the people asked. It was the custom then, when strangers came to a gathering, to offer them some friendly challenge.

"We have hounds," said Bres.

The hounds were matched against each other, and the hounds of the Tuatha de Danaan were better than the hounds of the Fomor.

"Have you horses for a race?"

"We have," said Bres. And the horses of the Tuatha de Danaan beat the horses of the Fomor.

Then they asked whether anyone among them was good with a sword, and they said Bres was the best of them. But when Bres put his hand to his sword, Elathan his father, who was there in the gathering, knew the ring on it.

"Who is this young man?" he asked.

Then Bres's mother answered, and told him the whole story, and that Bres was his own son.

His father was sorrowful at that. "What drove you out of the country you were king over?" he asked.

And Bres, to his credit, told the truth. "Nothing drove me out but my own injustice and my own hardness. I took their treasures from the people, and their jewels, and their very food. There were never taxes on them before I was their king."

"That is bad," said his father. "It was their prosperity you should have thought of, more than your own kingship. Their good-will would have been better to you than their curses. And what have you come here looking for?"

"I've come looking for fighting men," said Bres, "so that I can take Ireland by force."

"You have no right to get it by injustice," said his father, "when you could not keep it by justice."

"What advice have you for me, then?" said Bres.

Elathan told him to go to the chief king of the Fomor, to see what advice and what help that king would give him.

The chief king of the Fomor was Balor of the Evil Eye.

CHAPTER I

The Coming Of Lugh



After Nuada of the Silver Hand was back in the kingship, he held a great feast at Teamhair.

There were two door-keepers at Teamhair: Gamal, son of Figal, and Camel, son of Riagall. A young man came to the door where one of them stood, and asked to be brought in to the king.

"Who are you?" said the door-keeper.

"I am Lugh," said the young man. "Son of Cian of the Tuatha de Danaan, and of Ethlinn, daughter of Balor, King of the Fomor. I am foster-son of Tailte, daughter of the King of the Great Plain, and of Echaid the Rough, son of Duach."

"And what are you skilled in?" said the door-keeper. "Nobody without an art comes into Teamhair."

"Question me," said Lugh. "I am a carpenter."

"We don't want you. We have a carpenter already: Luchtar, son of Luachaid."

"Then I am a smith."

"We have a smith already: Colum Cuaillemech of the Three New Ways."

"Then I am a champion."

"No use to us. We have a champion: Ogma, the king's brother."

"Question me again," said Lugh. "I am a harper."

"No use to us. We have a harper: Abhean, son of Bicelmos, that the Men of the Three Gods brought out of the hills."

"I am a poet," said Lugh, "and a teller of tales."

"No use. We have a teller of tales: Ere, son of Ethaman."

"And I am a magician."

"No use. We have plenty of magicians, and people of power."

"I am a physician."

"No use. We have Diancecht for our physician."

"Let me be a cup-bearer."

"We don't want you. We have nine cup-bearers."

"I am a good worker in brass."

"We have a worker in brass already: Credne Cerd."

Then Lugh said, "Go and ask the king whether he has any one man who can do all of these things. If he has, I won't ask to come into Teamhair."

The door-keeper went in to the king and told him all of it. "There's a young man at the door," he said, "and his name ought to be the Ildánach, the Master of All Arts. Every single thing the people of your house can do, he can do all of them."

"Try him at the chess-boards," said Nuada.

The chess-boards were brought out. Every game that was played, Lugh won.

When Nuada was told that, he said, "Let him in. The like of him never came into Teamhair before."

So the door-keeper let him pass, and Lugh came into the king's house and sat down in the seat of knowledge.

There was a great flagstone in that house that four times twenty yoke of oxen could hardly have moved. Ogma picked it up and hurled it out through the house, so that it landed outside Teamhair. It was a challenge. Lugh hurled it back, and it landed in the middle of the king's house.

Then he played the harp for them. He had them laughing, and then he had them crying, and at the end he put them all to sleep with a sleepy tune.

When Nuada had seen all the things Lugh could do, he began to think that with this young man's help the country might get free of the taxes and the tyranny the Fomor had put on it. And this is what he did: he came down from his throne, and he put Lugh on it in his place for thirteen days, so that they could all listen to the advice he would give.

A king who will step down from his own throne for the sake of his people is rarer than a king with a silver hand.

This is the story of the birth of Lugh.

In the days when the Fomor used to come to Ireland, Balor of the Strong Blows — or, as some called him, Balor of the Evil Eye — lived on the Island of the Tower of Glass. It was dangerous for ships to go near that island, for the Fomor would come out and take them.

Some say that the sons of Nemed, in the old time before the Firbolgs came to Ireland, passed close to it in their ships. What they saw was a tower of glass in the middle of the sea, and on the tower something that looked like men. They went against it with Druid spells, and the Fomor worked against them with Druid spells of their own. The sons of Nemed attacked the tower, and it vanished, and they thought they had destroyed it. Then a great wave rose over them, and all their ships went down, and everybody in them.

And the tower was there as it had always been, and Balor living in it.

This is why he was called Balor of the Evil Eye. There was a power of death in one of his eyes, so that nobody could look into it and live. It got that power like this: once, when he was young, he passed a house where his father's Druids were making spells of death. The window was open and he looked in, and the smoke of the poisonous spells was rising, and it went into his eye. From that day on he had to keep that eye closed, unless he wanted to be the death of some enemy. Then the men who were with him would lift the eyelid with a ring of ivory.

A Druid once foretold that Balor would get his death from his own grandson.

At that time Balor had only one child, a daughter named Ethlinn. When he heard what the Druid said, he shut her up in the tower on the island. He put twelve women with her to take charge of her and guard her, and he told them never to let her see a man, or hear the name of a man.

So Ethlinn grew up in the tower, and she grew very beautiful. Sometimes she saw men passing in their currachs. Sometimes she saw a man in her dreams. But when she spoke about it to the women, they would give her no answer.

You can lock a girl in a tower. You cannot lock up what she dreams.

So Balor had no fear. He went on with war and robbery the way he always had, seizing every ship that passed, and sometimes crossing over to Ireland to do destruction there.

Now it happened that at that time three brothers of the Tuatha de Danaan lived together in a place called Druim na Teine, the Ridge of the Fire. They were Goibniu, and Samthainn, and Cian. Cian was a lord of land. Goibniu was the smith with the great name.

Cian had a wonderful cow, the Glas Gaibhnenn, and her milk never failed. Everyone who heard of her coveted her, and many had tried to steal her, so she had to be watched night and day.

Once Cian wanted some swords made, and he went to Goibniu's forge, leading the Glas Gaibhnenn by a halter. When he got to the forge both his brothers were there, for Samthainn had brought some steel to have weapons made for himself. Cian asked Samthainn to hold the halter while he went in to speak with Goibniu.

Balor had set his mind on the Glas Gaibhnenn a long time before, but he had never been able to get near her. Now he was watching, not far away. When he saw Samthainn holding the cow he put on the appearance of a little red-haired boy, and came up to him, and told him he had heard the two brothers in the forge saying to each other that they would use all of Samthainn's steel for their own swords, and make his out of iron.

"By my word," said Samthainn, "they won't cheat me so easily. You hold the cow, little lad, and I'll go in to them."

He rushed into the forge in a great rage. And the moment Balor had the halter in his hand he set off, dragging the Glas behind him, down to the strand and across the sea to his own island.

When Cian saw his brother come in, he rushed out. There were Balor and the Glas, out on the sea.

There was nothing he could do then but reproach his brother, and wander about as if his wits had left him, not knowing any way to get his cow back from Balor. At last he went to a Druid for advice. The Druid told him that while Balor lived the cow would never be brought back, for nobody would go within reach of his Evil Eye.

Then Cian went to a woman-Druid, Birog of the Mountain, for her help.

She dressed him in a woman's clothes and carried him across the sea on a blast of wind, to the tower where Ethlinn was. She called up to the women in the tower and asked them for shelter for a high queen she had just saved from some hardship. The women did not like to refuse a woman of the Tuatha de Danaan, and they let her in, and her companion with her. Then Birog put them all into a deep sleep with her enchantments, and Cian went to speak with Ethlinn.

When Ethlinn saw him, she said that was the face she had seen in her dreams.

She gave him her love. After a while he was taken away again, on a blast of wind.

When her time came, Ethlinn gave birth to a son. When Balor knew of it he ordered his people to wrap the child in a cloth, fasten it with a pin, and throw him into a current of the sea. As they were carrying the child across an arm of the sea, the pin dropped out, and the child slipped out of the cloth into the water, and they thought he had drowned.

But Birog of the Mountain took him away and brought him to his father, Cian. And Cian gave him to be fostered by Taillte, daughter of the King of the Great Plain.

That is how Lugh was born and reared.

Some say Balor came afterwards and struck the head off Cian on a white stone, and that the stone has the marks of blood on it to this day. It is more likely that it was some other

man whose head he struck off, for it was the sons of Tuireann who brought Cian to his death. That is a different story, and a worse one.

After Lugh had come to Teamhair and made up his mind to join his father's people against the Fomor, he set himself to the work. He went to a quiet place in Grellach Dollaid, with Nuada and the Dagda and Ogma, and Goibniu and Diancecht were sent for to join them there. A full year they stayed there, making their plans in secret, so that the Fomor would not know they meant to rise against them until everything was ready, and until they knew their own strength. From that council the place got its name afterwards: the Whisper of the Men of Dea.

They broke up the council and agreed to meet again on that same day three years later. Each of them went his own way, and Lugh went back to his own friends, the sons of Manannan.

A good while after that, Nuada was holding a great assembly of the people on the Hill of Uisnech, to the west of Teamhair. They had not been there long when they saw an armed troop coming towards them from the east, across the plain. There was a young man at the front of the troop, commanding the rest, and the brightness of his face was like the setting sun, so that they could not look at him for the brightness of it.

When he came nearer they knew him. It was Lugh Lamh-Fada, Lugh of the Long Hand, come back to them.

With him were the Riders of the Sidhe from the Land of Promise, and his own foster-brothers, the sons of Manannan: Sgoith Gleigeil, the White Flower; and Goitne Gorm-Shuileach, the Blue-eyed Spear; and Sine Sindearg, of the Red Ring; and Donall Donn-Ruadh, of the Red-brown Hair.

This is how Lugh came.

Under him was Manannan's horse, the Aonbharr, of the One Mane. She was as swift as the naked cold wind of spring. The sea was the same as dry land to her. And nobody riding her was ever killed on her back.

On him was Manannan's breastplate, which kept whoever wore it from wounds.

On his head was a helmet with two beautiful precious stones set in the front and one at the back. When he took it off, his forehead was like the sun on a dry summer's day.

And at his side was Manannan's sword, the Freagarthach, the Answerer. Nobody wounded by it ever got away alive. And when that sword was bared in a battle, any man who saw it coming against him had no more strength left in him than a woman in childbirth.

The troop came up to where the King of Ireland was with the Tuatha de Danaan, and they welcomed each other.

They had not been there long before they saw another troop coming, a surly, slovenly one. It was nine times nine of the messengers of the Fomor, coming to collect rent and taxes from the men of Ireland. The four hardest and cruellest of them were Eine and Eathfaigh and Coron and Compar. The Tuatha de Danaan were in such dread of those four that not one of them would so much as punish his own son or his foster-son without their leave.

The Fomor came up to where the King of Ireland was with the Riders of the Sidhe, and the king and all the Tuatha de Danaan stood up for them.

"Why do you stand up for that surly, slovenly troop," said Lugh of the Long Hand, "when you didn't stand up for us?"

"We have to," said the king. "If there were only a child of ours sitting in front of them, they wouldn't think that too small a reason to kill him."

"By my word," said Lugh, "there's a great desire coming on me to kill them."

"That would bring harm on us," said the king. "We'd meet our own death and destruction through it."

"You have been under this oppression too long," said Lugh.

And with that he started up and went at the Fomor, killing and wounding, until he had made an end of eight nines of them. The last nine he let go, under the protection of Nuada the king.

"I would kill you along with the others," he told them, "but I'd sooner you carried the news to your own country than any of my people, in case they got some ill-treatment there."

So the nine went back until they came to Lochlann, where the men of the Fomor were, and told the story from beginning to end: how a young, well-featured lad had come into Ireland and killed all the tax-gatherers but themselves. "And the reason he let us go," they said, "was so that we could tell you the story ourselves."

"Do you know who this young man is?" said Balor of the Evil Eye.

"I know well," said Ceithlenn, his wife. "He is the son of your daughter and mine. And it was foretold that from the day he came into Ireland, we would never have power there again, for ever."

Then the chief men of the Fomor went into council. There was Eab, son of Neid, and Seanchab, grandson of Neid, and Sital Salmhor, and Liath, son of Lobais; and the nine poets of the Fomor, who had learning and the gift of foreknowledge; and Lobais the Druid; and Balor himself, and his twelve white-mouthed sons; and Ceithlenn of the Crooked Teeth, his queen.

It was just then that Bres and his father Elathan had come to ask the Fomor for help.

"I'll go to Ireland myself," said Bres, "with seven great battalions of the Riders of the Fomor, and I'll give battle to this Ildánach, this master of all arts. I'll strike his head off and bring it back here to you, to the green of Berbhe."

"That would be a fitting thing for you to do," they all said.

"Then let my ships be made ready," said Bres, "and let food and provisions be put in them."

They made no delay. They readied the ships and filled them with food and drink, and the two swift Luaths were sent out to gather the army to Bres. When they were all gathered they made ready their armour and their weapons, and they set out for Ireland.

Balor the king followed them down to the harbour.

"Give battle to that Ildánach," he said, "and strike his head off. Then tie that island they call Ireland to the backs of your ships, and let the destroying water take its place. Put it on the north side of Lochlann. Not one of the Men of Dea will follow it there, to the end of life and time."

Then they pushed out their ships and raised their painted sails, and went out of the harbour onto the untilled country, the ridges of the wide-lying sea. They never turned from their course until they came to the harbour of Eas Dara. From there they sent an army through West Connacht, and destroyed it altogether, through and through.

The King of Connacht at that time was Bodb Dearg, son of the Dagda.

The Sons Of Tuireann



Lugh of the Long Hand was at Teamhair with the King of Ireland when it was shown to him that the Fomor had landed at Eas Dara.

He made ready Manannan's horse, the Aonbharr, in the hour between day and night, and he went to Nuada the king. He told him that the Fomor had landed at Eas Dara and had spoiled Bodb Dearg's country. "And what I want," he said, "is your help to give battle to them."

But Nuada was not minded to avenge a destruction that had been done to Bodb Dearg and not to himself.

Lugh did not like that answer. He rode out of Teamhair, westward.

Presently he saw three armed men coming towards him. They were his own father Cian, and Cian's brothers Cu and Ceithen: the three sons of Cainte. They greeted him.

"What has you up so early?" they said.

"I have good cause," said Lugh. "The Fomor have come into Ireland and robbed Bodb Dearg. What help will you give me against them?"

"Each one of us will keep a hundred off you in the battle," they said.

"That's a good help," said Lugh. "But there's a help I'd sooner have from you than that. Gather the Riders of the Sidhe to me, from every place where they are."

So Cu and Ceithen went south, and Cian went north, and Cian did not stop until he reached the Plain of Muirthemne. As he was crossing the plain he saw three armed men ahead of him. They were the three sons of Tuireann, son of Ogma.

Here is what you need to know. Between the three sons of Tuireann and the three sons of Cainte there was hatred and enmity, and whenever they met there was sure to be fighting.

"If my two brothers were here," Cian said to himself, "we'd make a brave fight of it. Since they're not, it's best for me to fall back."

There was a great herd of pigs near him. He struck himself with a Druid rod, and it put on him the shape of one of the pigs of the herd, and he began rooting up the ground like the rest of them.

"Did you see that armed man walking the plain a while ago?" said Brian, one of the sons of Tuireann, to his brothers.

"We saw him," they said.

"Do you know what took him away?"

"We don't."

"It's a pity you don't keep a better watch over the open country in a time of war," said Brian. "I know well what happened to him. He struck himself with his Druid rod into the shape of one of these pigs, and he's rooting up the ground now like any of them. And whoever he is, he's no friend of ours."

"That's bad for us," said the other two. "The pigs belong to one of the Tuatha de Danaan. Even if we kill every one of them, the Druid pig might still get away from us in the end."

"You got your learning badly in the city of learning," said Brian, "if you can't tell an enchanted beast from a natural one."

And as he said it he struck his two brothers with his own Druid rod, and turned them into two thin, fast hounds, and they began to yelp sharply on the track of the enchanted pig.

It was not long before the pig broke out from among the others. Not one of the others ran, only that one. It made for a wood, and at the edge of the wood Brian threw his spear, and the spear went through its body.

The pig cried out. "That was a bad thing you did, throwing at me when you knew who I was."

"It seems to me you talk like a man," said Brian.

"I was a man indeed," said the pig. "I am Cian, son of Cainte. Give me your protection now."

"I swear by the gods of the air," said Brian, "that if the life came back into you seven times, I would take it from you every time."

"If that's how it is," said Cian, "give me one request. Let me go back into my own shape."

"We'll do that," said Brian. "It's easier for me to kill a man than a pig."

So Cian took his own shape again. "Give me mercy now," he said.

"We will not," said Brian.

"Well, I've got the better of you all the same," said Cian. "If you had killed me in the shape of a pig, there'd only be the blood-price of a pig on me. But since you'll kill me in my own shape, there never was and never will be anyone killed for whose sake a heavier fine will be paid than for me. And the weapons I'm killed with, they will tell the deed to my son."

"Then it's not with weapons you'll be killed," said Brian, "but with the stones lying on the ground."

And they pelted him with stones, fiercely and roughly, until all that was left of him was a poor, miserable, broken heap. They buried him the depth of a man's body in the earth.

The earth would not take that murder from them. It cast the body up again.

Brian said it should go back into the earth, and they put it in a second time, and a second time the earth would not take it. Six times the sons of Tuireann buried the body, and six times it was cast up. The seventh time they put it underground, the earth kept it.

Then they went on to join Lugh of the Long Hand for the battle.

As for Lugh: after he parted from his father he went on from Teamhair, westward. He went to the hills that were called afterwards Gairech and Ilgairech, and to the ford of the Shannon that is called Athluain now, and to Bearnah-Eadargana, the Gap of Separation, and over Magh Luirg, the Plain of Following, and to Corr Slieve na Seaghsa, the Round Mountain of the Poet's Spring, and to the head of Sean-Slieve, and through the place of the

bright-faced Corann, and from there to Magh Mor an Aonaigh, the Great Plain of the Fair. That was where the Fomor were, and the spoils of Connacht with them.

Bres, son of Elathan, stood up and said, "It's a wonder to me that the sun is rising in the west today, when every other day it rises in the east."

"It would be better for us if it were the sun," said the Druids.

"What else is it?"

"It is the shining of the face of Lugh, son of Ethlinn."

Lugh came up to them and greeted them.

"Why do you come to us like a friend?" they said.

"There's good cause for that," he said. "Only half of me is of the Tuatha de Danaan. The other half is yours. Now give me back the milch cows of the men of Ireland."

"May early good luck never come to you," said one of them, angrily, "until you get either a dry cow or a milch cow here."

Lugh stayed near them three days and three nights, and at the end of that time the Riders of the Sidhe came to him. Bodb Dearg, son of the Dagda, came with twenty-nine hundred men.

"Why are you so slow to give battle?" he said.

"I was waiting for you," said Lugh.

Then the kings and chief men of the men of Ireland put on their armour, and raised the points of their spears over their heads, and made close fences of their shields. They attacked their enemies on Magh Mor an Aonaigh, and their enemies answered them. They threw their whining spears at each other, and when the spears were broken they drew their swords from their blue-bordered sheaths and struck at each other, and thickets of brown flame rose above them from the bitterness of their many-edged weapons.

Lugh saw the battle-pen where Bres, son of Elathan, was. He made a fierce attack on him and on the men guarding him, until he had made an end of two hundred of them.

When Bres saw that, he gave himself up to Lugh's protection. "Give me my life this time," he said, "and I'll bring the whole race of the Fomor to fight it out with you in a great battle. I bind myself to that by the sun and the moon, the sea and the land."

So Lugh gave him his life. Then the Druids who were with Bres asked for his protection too.

"By my word," said Lugh, "if the whole race of the Fomor put itself under my protection, I would not destroy them."

So Bres and the Druids set out for their own country.

Now, Lugh and the sons of Tuireann.

After the battle of Magh Mor an Aonaigh, Lugh met two of his kinsmen and asked them whether they had seen his father in the fight.

"We did not," they said.

"Then I'm sure he's not living," said Lugh. "And I give my word that no food or drink will go into my mouth until I know by what death my father died."

He set out, with the Riders of the Sidhe behind him, and came to the place where he and his father had parted, and from there to the place where his father had gone into the shape of a pig when he saw the sons of Tuireann.

When Lugh came to that place, the earth spoke to him.

"Your father was in great danger here, Lugh," it said, "when he saw the sons of Tuireann in front of him. It was into the shape of a pig he had to go. But it was in his own shape they killed him."

Lugh told that to his people. He found the place where his father was buried and told them to dig, so that he would know by what death the sons of Tuireann had made an end of him.

They raised the body out of the grave and looked at it. It was all one bed of wounds.

"It was the death of an enemy the sons of Tuireann gave my dear father," said Lugh.

He kissed him three times.

"I am in a bad way after this death," he said. "I can hear nothing with my ears. I can see nothing with my eyes. There is no living pulse in my heart, for grief after my father. You gods I worship — it's a pity I wasn't here when this was done. And it is a great thing that has been done here: that the people of the gods of Dana have done treachery on one another. They will be at a loss by it for a long time, and weakened by it. And from this out, Ireland will never be free of trouble, east or west."

They put Cian under the earth again. There was keening over his grave, and a stone was raised on it, and his name was written on it in Ogham.

"This hill will take its name from Cian," said Lugh, "though he himself is stripped and broken. It was the sons of Tuireann did this thing, and grief and anguish will fall on them from it, and on their children after them. It's no lying story I'm telling you. And it's a pity the way I am, and my heart is broken in my breast, since Cian, the brave man, is not living."

Then he told his people to go on ahead of him to Teamhair. "But don't tell the story," he said, "until I tell it myself."

When Lugh came to Teamhair he sat in the high seat of the king, and he looked about him, and he saw the three sons of Tuireann.

Those three were beyond everyone else at Teamhair in those days for quickness and skill, for a good hand in battle, for beauty, and for an honourable name.

Lugh told his people to shake the chain of silence. They shook it, and everyone listened.

"What are your minds fixed on at this moment, Men of Dea?" said Lugh.

"On yourself, indeed," they said.

"I have a question for you. What vengeance would each of you take on the man who killed your father?"

They were astonished to hear it. One of the chief men said, "Tell us — was it your own father who was killed?"

"It was indeed," said Lugh. "And I see in this house now the men who killed him, and they know better than I do what way they killed him."

"It's not the death of a single day I'd give the man who killed my father, if I had him in my power," said the king. "I'd cut off one of his limbs from day to day until I'd made an end of him."

All the chief men said the same. So did the sons of Tuireann, with the rest.

"The three men who killed my father are among those making that answer," said Lugh. "Let them pay the fine for him now, since you're all together in the one place. And if they won't, I will not break the protection of the king's house — but they must make no attempt to leave this house until they have settled with me."

"If it were I who had killed your father," said the king, "I'd be well content for you to take a fine from me for him."

"It's at us Lugh is saying all this," said the sons of Tuireann among themselves.

"Let's admit the killing of his father to him," said Iuchar and Iucharba.

"I'm afraid," said Brian, "that he wants us to admit it in front of everyone, and then he won't let us off with a fine afterwards."

"It's best to admit it," said the others. "And you speak it, since you're the eldest."

So Brian, son of Tuireann, said: "It's at us you're speaking, Lugh, because you think we've gone against the sons of Cainte before now. We didn't kill your father. But we'll pay the fine for him the same as if we had."

Notice what Brian did there. He denied it and paid for it in the same breath.

"I'll take a fine from you that you don't expect," said Lugh. "I'll say here what it is, and if it's too much for you, I'll let you off part of it."

"Let's hear it," they said.

"Here it is," said Lugh. "Three apples. And the skin of a pig. And a spear. And two horses, and a chariot. And seven pigs. And a dog's whelp. And a cooking-spit. And three shouts on a hill. That is the fine I'm asking. If it's too much for you, part of it will be taken off you presently. If you don't think it too much, pay it."

"It isn't too much," said Brian. "A hundred times as much wouldn't be too much. And because it's so small, we think it likely you have some treachery hidden behind it."

"I don't think it too little a fine," said Lugh. "And I give you the guarantee of the Tuatha de Danaan that I'll ask nothing else, and that I'll be faithful to you. Now give me the same pledge."

"It's a pity for you to ask that," said Brian. "Our own pledge is as good as any pledge in the world."

"Your own pledge isn't enough," said Lugh. "It's often the like of you promised to pay a fine this way, and tried to back out of it afterwards."

So the sons of Tuireann bound themselves by the King of Ireland, and by Bodb Dearg, son of the Dagda, and by the chief men of the Tuatha de Danaan, that they would pay that fine to Lugh.

"It would be as well now," said Lugh, "to give you a better knowledge of the fine."

"It would indeed," they said.

"This is how it is, then," said Lugh.

"The three apples I asked of you are the three apples from the Garden in the East of the World. No other apples will do. They are the most beautiful apples in the whole world, and there is the most virtue in them. They are the colour of burnt gold, and the size of the head of a child a month old, and they taste of honey. Whoever eats them is left with no pain of wounds and no vexation of sickness. And they never grow less for being eaten."

"The skin I asked of you is the pig-skin of Tuis, King of Greece. It heals all the wounds and all the sickness of the world. Whatever danger a man is in, if the skin can only reach him while there's life in him, it will cure him. This is how it was with that pig: every stream it went through was turned into wine for nine days after, and every wound it touched was healed. The Druids of Greece said the virtue wasn't in the pig but in the skin, so they skinned it, and the skin has been there ever since. And I don't think it will be easy for you to get it, with leave or without."

"And do you know what spear I'm asking for?"

"We don't."

"It is a very deadly spear that belongs to the King of Persia. The Luin, it's called. Every choice deed is done with it. Its head is kept steeped in a vessel of water, so that it won't burn down the place where it is. It will be hard to get.

"And do you know what two horses and what chariot I'm asking for? They are the chariot and the two wonderful horses of Dobar, King of Siogair. The sea is the same as land to them. There are no faster horses, and there's no chariot to equal that one in shape or in strength.

"And do you know what the seven pigs are? They are the pigs of Easal, King of the Golden Pillars. Though they are killed every night, they are found alive again the next day. And no disease and no sickness will come on anyone who eats a share of them.

"The whelp I asked of you is Fail-Inis, the whelp that belongs to the King of Ioruaidh, the Cold Country. All the wild beasts of the world fall down at the sight of her. She is more beautiful than the sun in his fiery wheels. It will be hard to get her.

"The cooking-spit I asked of you is one of the spits of the women of Inis Cenn-fhinne, the Island of Caer of the Fair Hair.

"And the three shouts you're to give on a hill must be given on the Hill of Miochaoín, in the north of Lochlann. Miochaoín and his sons are under bonds not to allow any shout to be given on that hill. It was with them my father got his learning. Even if I forgave you his

death, they would not. If you get through all your other voyages before you reach them, it's my opinion they'll avenge him on you themselves.

"That is the fine I have asked of you," said Lugh.

Silence and darkness came down on the sons of Tuireann when they heard that.

They went to their father and told him the fine that had been put on them.

"That's bad news," said Tuireann. "It's to your death and destruction you'll be going, looking for those things. But even so — if Lugh himself had a mind to help you, you could work out the fine. All the men in the world couldn't do it, except by the power of Manannan, or of Lugh. So go and ask Lugh for the loan of Manannan's horse, the Aonbharr. If he wants the fine, he'll give it to you. If he doesn't, he'll say the horse isn't his, and he won't give the loan of a loan. Then ask him for the loan of Manannan's curragh, the Scuabtuinne, the Sweeper of the Waves. He'll give you that, because he's under bonds not to refuse a second request. And the curragh is better for you than the horse."

So the sons of Tuireann went to Lugh and greeted him, and told him they couldn't bring him the fine without his help, and so it would be well for them to have the loan of the Aonbharr.

"I have that horse only on loan myself," said Lugh. "I won't give the loan of a loan."

"Then give us the loan of Manannan's curragh," said Brian.

"I'll give that," said Lugh.

"Where is it?"

"At Brugh na Boinn."

They went back to Tuireann. Ethne, their sister, was with him. They told him they had got the curragh.

"You won't be much the better for it," said Tuireann. "Lugh would like well to have every piece of this fine that he can use before the battle with the Fomor. But he would like you to come to your deaths looking for it."

They went away, and left Tuireann sorrowing and lamenting. Ethne went with them to where the curragh was.

Brian got into it. "There's only room for one other person with me here," he said, and began to find fault with how narrow it was.

"You shouldn't be faulting the curragh," said Ethne. "And oh, my dear brother, it was a bad thing you did, killing the father of Lugh of the Long Hand. Whatever harm comes to you from it, it's only just."

"Don't say that, Ethne," they said. "We're in good heart, and we'll do brave deeds. We'd sooner be killed a hundred times over than die the death of cowards."

"My grief," said Ethne. "There's nothing more sorrowful than this: to see you driven out of your own country."

The three of them pushed their curragh out from the beautiful clear-bayed shore of Ireland.

"Which way first?" they said.

"We'll go for the apples," said Brian, "since they were the first thing we were told to bring. So we ask you, curragh of Manannan that is under us, to sail to the Garden in the East of the World."

The curragh did not neglect that order. It sailed on over the green-sided waves and the deep places until it came to its harbour in the east of the world.

"How do you want to get into the garden?" Brian asked his brothers. "I think the king's champions and the fighting men of the country are always guarding it, and the king himself is chief over them."

"What else should we do," said his brothers, "but make straight at them and attack them, and bring away the apples or fall ourselves? We can't get out of the dangers ahead of us without meeting our death somewhere."

"It would be better," said Brian, "for the story of our bravery and our craftiness to be told and live after us, than a story of folly and cowardice. Here's what's best. We'll go into the garden in the shape of swift hawks. The watchers have only light spears to throw at us. Take good care to keep out of their reach. When they've thrown them all, make a quick dive at the apples, and each of you bring one away in your claws, and I'll bring the third."

They said that was good advice. Brian struck himself and the others with his Druid rod and changed them into beautiful hawks, and they flew towards the garden.

The watchers saw them. They shouted on every side, and threw showers of spears and darts. But the hawks kept out of reach, as Brian had told them, until all the spears were spent. Then they swept down bravely on the apples and carried them away, without so much as a wound.

The news went through the city and the whole district.

The king had three wise, crafty daughters. They put themselves into the shape of three ospreys and followed the hawks out to sea, and sent flashes of lightning before them and after them, and the lightning scorched them badly.

"We're in a bad way now," said the sons of Tuireann. "We'll be burned through and through with this lightning if we don't get some relief."

"If I can give you relief I will," said Brian.

He struck himself and his brothers with the Druid rod, and they became three swans, and went down quickly into the sea. The ospreys left them then, and the sons of Tuireann got back into their boat.

After that they talked it over and agreed to go to Greece and bring away the skin of the pig, with leave or without it. So they went on until they came near the court of the King of Greece.

"What shape should we put on to go in here?" said Brian.

"What shape but our own?" said the others.

"That's not what I think best," said Brian. "We'll go in looking like poets from Ireland. Then the high people of Greece will hold us in respect and honour."

"That will be hard," they said, "when we have no poem, and we know very little about how to make one."

All the same, they tied their hair in the poet's tie and knocked at the door of the court. The door-keeper asked who was there.

"We are poets of Ireland," said Brian, "and we've come with a poem for the king."

The door-keeper went in and told the king there were poets from Ireland at the door.

"Let them in," said the king. "It was in search of a good man they came so far from their own country." And he ordered everything in the court to be well laid out, so that they would say they had seen no place so grand in all their travels.

So the sons of Tuireann were let in, looking like poets, and they fell to drinking and pleasure without delay. They thought they had never seen, and there was not in the world, a court as good as that one, or so large a household, or a place where they had been better treated.

Then the king's poets got up to give out their poems and songs. Brian, son of Tuireann, told his brothers to say a poem for the king.

"We have no poem," they said. "Don't ask any poem of us except the one we know already, and that's to take what we want by the strength of our hands if we're the strongest, or to fall by those against us if they're the strongest."

"That's not a good way to make a poem," said Brian.

He stood up himself and asked for a hearing. They all listened, and this is what he said:

"O Tuis, we do not hide your fame; we praise you as the oak among kings. The skin of a pig, bounty without hardness — that is the reward I ask for it.

"The war of a neighbour against an ear; the fair ear of his neighbour will be against him. He who gives us what he owns, his court will not be the scarcer for it.

"A raging army and a sudden sea are a danger to whoever goes against them. The skin of a pig, bounty without hardness — that is the reward I ask, O Tuis."

"That's a good poem," said the king. "But I don't understand a word of it."

"I'll tell you what it means," said Brian. "'O Tuis, we do not hide your fame; we praise you as the oak above the kings.' That is: as the oak is beyond the kingly trees of the wood, so you are beyond the kings of the world, for open-handedness and grandeur."

"'The skin of a pig, bounty without hardness.' That is: the pig-skin you own is what I'd like to get from you as a reward for my poem."

"'The war of a neighbour against an ear; the fair ear of his neighbour will be against him.' That is: you and I will be at each other's ears over the skin, unless I get it with your consent."

"That's the meaning of the poem," said Brian.

"I'd praise your poem," said the king, "if there weren't so much about my pig-skin in it. You have no good sense, man of poetry, to be asking me for that. I wouldn't give it to all the poets and the learned men and the great men of the world, since they couldn't take it without my consent. But I'll give you three times the full of the skin in gold, as the price of your poem."

"Good be with you, king," said Brian. "I knew well it was no easy thing I was asking, but I knew I'd get a good ransom for it. And I'm so covetous that I won't be satisfied without seeing the gold measured into the skin myself."

The king sent his servants with them to the treasure-house to measure out the gold.

"Measure out the full of it to my brothers first," said Brian, "and then give good measure to me, since it was I who made the poem."

When the skin was brought out, Brian made a quick, sudden snatch at it with his left hand. He drew his sword and struck at the man nearest him, and made two halves of him. He kept hold of the skin and wrapped it round himself, and the three of them rushed out of the

court, cutting down every armed man in front of them, so that not one escaped death or wounding.

Then Brian went to where the king himself was. The king made no delay in attacking him. They made a hard fight of it, and at the end the King of Greece fell by the hand of Brian, son of Tuireann.

The brothers rested a while after that, and then they said they would go and look for another part of the fine.

"We'll go to Pisear, King of Persia," said Brian, "and ask him for the spear."

So they got into their boat and left the blue streams of the coast of Greece. "We're well off," they said, "now we have the apples and the skin." They stopped nowhere until they reached the borders of Persia.

"Let's go into the court looking like poets," said Brian, "the same as we did with the King of Greece."

"We're content to," said the others, "since everything turned out so well the last time we took to poetry. Not that it's easy to take up a calling that doesn't belong to us."

So they tied their hair in the poet's tie, and they were as well treated as they had been at the other court. When the time came for poems, Brian stood up, and this is what he said:

"It is little any spear looks to Pisear; the battles of enemies are broken; it is not too much for Pisear to wound every one of them.

"A yew, the most beautiful of the wood, it is called a king; it is not bulky. May the spear drive the whole crowd on to their wounds of death."

"That's a good poem," said the king. "But I don't understand why my own spear is brought into it, O Man of Poetry from Ireland."

"Because it's that spear of yours I'd like to get as the reward for my poem," said Brian.

"You have little sense to be asking me that," said the king. "The people of my court never showed more respect for poetry than they're showing now, by not putting you to death on

the spot."

When Brian heard the king talk like that, he thought of the apple in his hand. He made a straight cast and hit the king in the forehead, so that his brains were put out through the back of his head. Then he bared his sword and attacked the people around him, and the other two did the same, and gave him brave help, until they had made an end of everyone of the court they met. Then they found the spear, with its head in a cauldron of water so that it would not set fire to the place.

After a while they said it was time to go and look for the rest of the great fine, and asked each other which way they should go.

"We'll go to the King of the Island of Siogair," said Brian. "It's he who has the two horses and the chariot the Ildánach asked for."

They went on, bringing the spear with them, and the three champions were proud after all they had done. They went on until they came to the court of the King of Siogair.

"Here's what we'll do this time," said Brian. "We'll go in looking like paid soldiers from Ireland, and make friends with the king, so we'll find out where the horses and the chariot are kept."

With that settled, they went on to the lawn in front of the king's house.

The king and his chief men got up and came through the fair that was going on there. The brothers greeted the king, and he asked who they were.

"We're trained fighting men from Ireland," they said, "and we earn our wages from the kings of the world."

"Do you want to stay with me for a while?" said the king.

"That's what we want," they said. So they made an agreement and took service with him.

They stayed in that court a fortnight and a month, and in all that time they never saw the horses.

"This is a bad way to be in," said Brian, "with no more news of the horses now than the first day we came."

"What's best to do now?" said his brothers.

"Let's do this," said Brian. "We'll take our arms and gather our things together and go to the king and tell him we're leaving the country and this part of the world, unless he shows us those horses."

They went to the king that same day. He asked them what they meant by getting ready for a journey.

"You'll hear that, high king," said Brian. "Trained fighting men from Ireland like ourselves always have trust put in them by the kings they guard. We're used to being told the secrets and the whispers of whoever we're with. And that is not how you've treated us since we came to you. You have two horses and a chariot that are the best in the world, so we're told, and we haven't been given a sight of them yet."

"It would be a pity for you to go on that account," said the king, "when I'd have shown them to you the first day if I'd known you wanted to see them. If you want to see them now, you may. I don't think any soldiers ever came here from Ireland that were thought more of, by me and my people, than you."

He sent for the horses, and they were yoked to the chariot. They went as fast as the cold spring wind, and the sea was the same as land to them.

Brian was watching the horses closely. Suddenly he took hold of the chariot, pulled the chariot-driver out and dashed him against the nearest rock, and leapt into his place himself. He threw the Persian spear at the king, and it went through his heart. Then he and his brothers scattered the people in front of them, and brought the chariot away.

"Now we'll go to Easal, the King of the Golden Pillars," said Brian, "for the seven pigs the Ildánach told us to bring him."

They sailed on without delay or drawback to that high country.

The people of that country were watching their harbours for fear of the sons of Tuireann. The story of them had been told everywhere by then: how they had been sent out of Ireland by force, and how they were carrying away all the gifted treasures of the world.

Easal came down to the edge of the harbour to meet them. He asked whether it was true, what he had heard: that the king of every country they had been to had fallen by them.

Brian said it was true, whatever Easal might want to do to them for it.

"What made you do that?" said Easal.

Brian told him it was the oppression and the hard sentence of another that had driven them to it. He told him everything that had happened, and how they had put down everyone who stood against them so far.

"What have you come to this country for now?" said the king.

"For your pigs," said Brian. "Bringing them away is part of the fine."

"And how do you think you'll get them?"

"If we get them with good-will," said Brian, "we're ready to take them thankfully. If we don't, we're ready to do battle with you and your people for them, so that you'll fall by us, and we'll bring away the pigs in spite of you."

"If that's to be the end of it," said the king, "it would be a pity to bring my people into a battle."

"It would be a pity indeed," said Brian.

The king whispered with his people and took their advice, and they agreed to give up the pigs of their own free will to the sons of Tuireann, since they could see that nobody had been able to stand against them up to then.

The sons of Tuireann thanked Easal, and they wondered to have got the pigs like that, when they had had to fight for every other part of the fine. More than that — they had left some of their own blood in every other place.

Easal brought them to his own house that night, and they were given food and drink and good beds and everything they could wish for. In the morning they came before the king, and the pigs were given to them.

"You've done well by us, giving us these pigs," said Brian. "They are the only part of the fine we've got without fighting." And he made a poem for the king, praising him and putting a great name on him for what he had done. It was the only honest poem he made on that whole journey.

"Where are you going next, sons of Tuireann?" said Easal.

"To the country of Ioruaidh," they said, "for a whelp that's there."

"Grant me one request," said Easal. "Bring me with you to the King of Ioruaidh. A daughter of mine is his wife, and I'd like to persuade him to give you the whelp without a battle."

"That will please us well," they said.

So the king's ship was made ready. We have no knowledge of what happened until they came to the delightful, wonderful coast of Ioruaidh. The people and the armies were watching the harbours and landing-places for them, and they knew them at once and shouted at them.

Easal went ashore peaceably, and went to his son-in-law the king, and told him the story of the sons of Tuireann from beginning to end.

"What's brought them to this country?" said the King of Ioruaidh.

"They've come to ask for the hound you have," said Easal.

"You had a bad thought, coming with them to ask it," said the king. "The gods haven't given that much luck to any three champions in the world, that they'd get my hound by force or by good-will."

"It would be better for you to let them have the hound," said Easal, "since they've put down so many of the kings of the world."

But everything he said was idleness to the king. So he went back to the sons of Tuireann and told them the whole of it.

When they heard the king's answer they made no delay. They put quick hands on their weapons, and offered battle to the army of Ioruaidh.

When the armies met there was a brave battle fought on both sides. The sons of Tuireann began to kill and strike at the men of Ioruaidh until they were separated from one another in the fight, so that Iuchar and Iucharba happened to be on one side, and Brian alone on the other. There was a gap of danger and a breaking of ranks in front of Brian on every path he took, until he came to the King of Ioruaidh in his battle-pen. Then those two brave champions began a fierce fight together, and neither of them spared the other.

In the end Brian overcame the king and bound him, and brought him through the middle of the army to the place where Easal was.

"There's your son-in-law for you," he said. "And I swear by my hand of valour, I'd think it easier to kill him three times than to bring him to you once like this."

So the whelp was given to the sons of Tuireann, and the king was unbound, and peace was made between them. And when they had brought all that to an end, they said goodbye to Easal and to all the rest.

Now as to Lugh of the Long Hand.

It was shown to him that the sons of Tuireann had got every one of the things he needed against the battle with the Fomor. So he sent a Druid spell after them, to put forgetfulness on them of the rest of the fine they had not yet got. And he put a great desire and longing on them to go home to Ireland. So they forgot that any part of the fine was still missing, and they turned back towards home.

Lugh was at a gathering of the people, a fair on the green outside Teamhair, and the King of Ireland with him, when it was made known to him that the sons of Tuireann had landed at Brugh na Boinn.

He went into the city of Teamhair and shut the gate behind him. He put on Manannan's smooth armour, and the cloak of the daughters of Flidais, and he took his own weapons in his hand.

The sons of Tuireann came to where the king was, and the king and the Tuatha de Danaan made them welcome. The king asked whether they had got the fine.

"We have," they said. "Where's Lugh, so we can give it to him?"

"He was here a while ago," said the king. The whole fair was searched for him, but he was not found.

"I know where he is," said Brian. "It's been made known to him that we've come to Ireland with these deadly weapons, and he's gone into Teamhair to avoid us."

Messengers were sent to him. His answer was that he would not come, but that the fine should be given to the king.

So the sons of Tuireann gave it to the king. When the king had taken it, they all went to the palace in Teamhair, and Lugh came out onto the lawn, and the fine was given to him.

"There is good payment here," said Lugh, "for anyone that was ever killed, or ever will be. But there's something missing from it yet that it isn't lawful to leave out. Where is the cooking-spit? And where are the three shouts on the hill that you haven't given yet?"

When the sons of Tuireann heard that, clouds of weakness came down on them.

They left that place and went to their father's house that night, and they told him everything they had done, and how Lugh had treated them. Grief and darkness came on Tuireann, and they spent the night together.

In the morning they went to their ship, and Ethne their sister went with them, crying and lamenting. This is what she said:

"It is a pity, Brian of my life, that it is not to Teamhair you are going, after all the troubles you have had before this — even if I could not follow you.

"O Salmon of the dumb Boinn, O Salmon of the Lifé River, since I cannot keep you here I am loath to part from you.

"O Rider of the Wave of Tuaidh, the man who stands best in the fight: if you come back again, I think it will not please your enemy.

"Is there pity with you for the sons of Tuireann, leaning now on their green shields? Their going is a cause for pity; my mind is filled up with it.

"That you should be tonight at Beinn Edair until the heavy coming of the morning — you who have taken forfeits from brave men — it is you have increased our grief.

"It is a pity your journey is away from Teamhair, and from the pleasant plains, and from great Uisnech of Midhe. There is nothing so pitiful as this."

After that lament they went out on the rough waves of the green sea. They were a quarter of a year on the sea without any news of the island.

Then Brian put on his water-dress and leapt over the side. He was a long time walking in the sea looking for the Island of the Fair-Haired Women, and in the end he found it. He went looking for the court, and when he came to it all he found was a troop of women doing needlework and embroidering borders. And among all the other things they had with them was the cooking-spit.

When Brian saw it, he picked it up and started to carry it to the door.

All the women began to laugh when they saw him doing that.

"That's a brave deed you've put your hand to," they said. "Even if your brothers were with you, the least of the three times fifty women of us wouldn't let the spit go with you or with them. But all the same, take a spit of the spits with you, since you had the daring to try and take it in spite of us."

It is the only part of the fine that was ever given out of pity.

Brian said goodbye to them and went to look for the boat. His brothers thought he had been away too long. They were just about to leave the place when they saw him coming to-

wards them, and their courage rose greatly.

He got into the boat, and they went on to look for the Hill of Miochaoín.

When they got there, Miochaoín, the guardian of the hill, came towards them. Brian attacked him the moment he saw him, and the fight of those two champions was like the fight of two lions, until at last Miochaoín fell.

Then Miochaoín's three sons came out to fight the three sons of Tuireann. If anyone ever came from the east of the world to look at a fight, it was to see the fight of these champions he should have come, for the greatness of their blows and the courage of their minds. The sons of Miochaoín were Core and Conn and Aedh. They drove their three spears through the bodies of the sons of Tuireann. That did not discourage the sons of Tuireann at all. They put their own three spears through the bodies of the sons of Miochaoín, so that they fell into the clouds and the faintness of death.

"How are you now, my dear brothers?" said Brian.

"We're near our death," they said.

"Let's get up," he said, "and give three shouts on the hill. I see the signs of death coming on us."

"We can't," they said.

So Brian stood up, and lifted each of them with one hand, bleeding heavily all the while, until they had given the three shouts.

The fine was paid.

Brian brought them with him to the boat, and they were travelling the sea a long time. At last Brian said, "I see Beinn Edair, and our father's dun, and Teamhair of the Kings."

"We'd have our fill of health if we could see that," said the others. "For the love of your good name, brother, raise our heads on your breast until we see Ireland again, and life or death will be the same to us after. And O Brian, Flame of Valour without treachery, we'd

sooner death took us than see you with wounds on your body and no physician to heal you."

They came to Beinn Edair, and from there to their father's house.

"Go, dear father, to Teamhair," Brian said to Tuireann, "and give this spit to Lugh, and bring back the skin that has healing in it, to save us. Ask it of him for friendship's sake, for we are of the one blood. Let him not give hardness for hardness. And oh, dear father, don't be long on your journey, or you won't find us alive."

Tuireann went to Teamhair and found Lugh of the Long Hand there. He gave him the spit, and asked him for the skin to heal his children.

Lugh said he would not give it.

Tuireann came back and told them he had not got the skin.

"Bring me with you to Lugh," said Brian, "to see if I can get it from him."

So they went to Lugh, and Brian asked him for the skin. Lugh said he would not give it. He said that if they gave him the breadth of the earth in gold for it, he would not take it from them — unless he was sure their death would come on them in satisfaction for the deed they had done.

When Brian heard that, he went back to where his two brothers were, and lay down between them. His life went out of him, and out of the other two at the same moment.

Their father cried and lamented over his three beautiful sons, who had the making of a king of Ireland in each of them. His strength left him, and he died.

They were buried together in the one grave.

Lugh had his fine. He had every weapon he needed for the war against the Fomor. And he had seen, standing on the lawn at Teamhair, exactly what the people of the gods of Dana were capable of doing to each other.

CHAPTER III

The Great Battle Of Magh Tuireadh



It was not long after Lugh got the fine from the sons of Tuireann that the Fomor came, and landed at Scetne.



The Morrígan — Goddess of War and Fate

This time the whole host of the Fomor came. Their king came with them, Balor of the Strong Blows and of the Evil Eye. And Bres came, and Indech, son of De Domnann, a king of the Fomor, and Elathan, son of Lobos, and Goll and Ingol, and Octriallach, son of Indech, and Elathan, son of Delbaeth.

Lugh sent the Dagda to spy out the Fomor, and to delay them until the men of Ireland could come to the battle.

So the Dagda went to their camp and asked them for a delay, and they said he could have it.

Then, to make sport of him, the Fomor made him porridge-broth, because he had a great love for broth. They filled the king's cauldron with four times twenty gallons of new milk, and the same of meal and fat. They put in goats and sheep and pigs as well, and boiled it all together. Then they poured the whole of it into a great hole in the ground.

They called him over to it and told him to eat his fill, so that nobody could reproach the Fomor for want of hospitality the way Bres had been reproached.

"And we'll make an end of you," said Indech, son of De Domnann, "if you leave any of it behind."

The Dagda took the ladle. It was big enough for a man and a woman to lie together in the bowl of it. He took up bits with it — half a salted pig to a bit, and a quarter of lard.

"If the broth tastes as good as the bits," he said, "this is good food."

He went on putting the full of the ladle into his mouth until the hole was empty. And when it was all gone he put his hand down and scraped up what was left, among the earth and the gravel.

Sleep came on him then, after the broth, and the Fomor laughed at him, for his belly was the size of the cauldron of a great house.

But after a while he got up, and heavy as he was, he made his way home. His clothes were no way handsome: a cape that came only to the hollow of his elbows, and a brown coat, long in front and short behind, and on his feet brogues of horse-hide with the hair on the

outside. In his hand was a wheeled fork that it would take eight men to carry, and the track it left behind him was deep enough to be the boundary ditch of a province.

That is the Dagda. People laughed at him. People always laughed at him. It never did them any good.

On his way he saw the Battle-Crow, the Morrighu, washing herself in the river Unius of Connacht. One of her feet was at Ullad Echne, to the south of the water, and the other at Loscuinn, to the north of the water, and her hair hung down in nine loosened locks.

She told the Dagda that she would bring the heart's blood of Indech, son of De Domnann — who had threatened him — to the men of Ireland.

While he was away, Lugh had called together the Druids and the smiths and the physicians and the law-makers and the chariot-drivers of Ireland, to make their plans for the battle.

He asked the great magician Mathgen what he could do to help them.

"This is what I can do," said Mathgen. "By my power I can throw down all the mountains of Ireland on the Fomor, until their tops are rolling on the ground. And the twelve chief mountains of Ireland will bring you their help, and will fight for you: Slieve Leag, and Denda Ulad, and Bennai Boirche, and Bri Ruri, and Slieve Bladma, and Slieve Snechtae, and Slieve Mis, and Blai-Slieve, and Nemthann, and Slieve Macca Belgodon, and Segois, and Cruachan Aigle."

Then he asked the cup-bearers what help they could give.

"We'll put a strong thirst on the Fomor," they said, "and then we'll bring the twelve chief lochs of Ireland in front of them, and however great their thirst, they'll find no water in them: Derc-Loch, Loch Luimnech, Loch Orbsen, Loch Righ, Loch Mescdhae, Loch Cuan, Loch Laeig, Loch Echach, Loch Febail, Loch Decket, Loch Riach, Mor-Loch. And we'll go to the twelve chief rivers of Ireland: the Buas, the Boinn, the Banna, the Nem, the Laoi, the Sionnan, the Muaid, the Sligech, the Samair, the Fionn, the Ruirtech, the Siuir. They'll all be hidden from the Fomor, so they won't find a drop in them. But as for the men of Ireland, there'll be drink for them if they're in the battle to the end of seven years."

Figol, son of Mamos, the Druid, was asked what he would do.

"This is what I'll do," he said. "I'll make three showers of fire pour down on the faces of the army of the Fomor. I'll take from them two-thirds of their bravery and their strength, and I'll put sickness on their bodies and on the bodies of their horses. But for the men of Ireland, every breath they draw will be an increase of strength and bravery to them. If they're seven years in the battle, they'll never tire."

Then Lugh asked his two witches, Bechulle and Dianan, "What power can you bring to the battle?"

"That's easy to say," they said. "We'll put enchantment on the trees and the stones and the sods of the earth, until they become an armed host against the Fomor, and put terror on them, and put them to rout."

Then Lugh asked Carpre the poet, son of Etain, what he could do.

"That's not hard to say," said Carpre. "I'll make a satire on them at sunrise, with the wind from the north, and me on a hilltop with my back to a thorn-tree, and a stone and a thorn in my hand. And with that satire I'll put shame on them, and enchantment, so they won't be able to stand against fighting men."

Remember, this was the poet who had brought down Bres with a few lines about dry cakes. Nobody laughed.

Then Lugh asked Goibniu the Smith what he would be able to do.

"This," said Goibniu. "If the men of Ireland stay in the battle to the end of seven years, for every sword that's broken and every spear that's lost from its shaft, I'll put a new one in its place. No spear-point made by my hand will ever miss its mark. And no man it touches will ever taste life again. That's more than Dolb, the smith of the Fomor, can do."

"And you, Credne," Lugh said to his worker in brass, "what help can you give our men in the battle?"

"That's not hard to tell," said Credne. "Rivets for their spears, and hilts for their swords, and bosses and rims for their shields. I'll supply them all."

"And you, Luchta," he said to his carpenter, "what will you do?"

"I'll give them all they want of shields and spear-shafts," said Luchta.

Then he asked Diancecht, the physician, what he would do.

"Every man who's wounded there," said Diancecht, "unless his head is struck off, or his brain or his marrow is cut through, I'll make whole and sound again for the battle of the next day."

Then the Dagda spoke. "All those great things you're boasting you'll do," he said, "I'll do every one of them by myself."

"It's you are the good god!" they said, and they all gave a great shout of laughter.

That is where his name comes from. The Good God. They meant it as a joke. It stuck anyway, the way the true ones do.

Then Lugh spoke to the whole army, and put strength into them, so that each of them had in him the spirit of a king or a great lord.

When the delay was over, the Fomor and the men of Ireland came on towards each other until they reached the plain of Magh Tuireadh. This was not the same Magh Tuireadh where the first battle was fought. It was to the north, near Ess Dara.

Then the two armies threatened each other.

"The men of Ireland are daring enough to offer battle to us," said Bres to Indech, son of De Domnann.

"I give my word," said Indech, "their bones will be in small pieces if they don't give in to us and pay their tribute."

The Men of Dea had decided not to let Lugh go into the battle, because of how great a loss his death would be to them. They left nine of their men to keep watch on him.

On the first day none of the kings or princes went into the battle. Only the common fighting men fought, and they were fierce enough and proud enough.

The battle went on like that from day to day, and neither side had much advantage. But there was one thing the Fomor wondered at.

When their own weapons were broken or blunted in the fight, they lay where they were. When their own men were killed, they showed no sign of life the next day. It was not like that with the Tuatha de Danaan. If their men were killed today, or their weapons broken, they were as good as before tomorrow.

This is how that happened.

The well of Slaine lay west of Magh Tuireadh and east of Loch Arboch. Diancecht, and his son Octruil, and his daughter Airmed, used to sing spells over that well and put herbs into it. Men who had been wounded to death in the battle were brought to the well and put into it, dead men. And they came out of it whole and sound, by the power of the spells. And not only healed: there was such fire put into them that they were quicker in the fight than they had been before.

As for the weapons, this is how they were made new every day.

Goibniu the Smith stayed in the forge making swords and spears. He made a spear-head in three turns. Then Luchta the Carpenter made the shaft in three cuts, and the third cut was the finish, and set it in the ring of the spear. When the spear-heads were stuck in the side of the forge, he threw the shafts and the rings so that they went straight into the spear-heads and needed no more setting. Then Credne the Brazier made the rivets in three turns and cast the rings of the spears to them. And with that they were ready, and set together.

Three turns. Three cuts. Three turns. A spear.

All this went against the Fomor, and they sent one of their young men to spy about the camp and see if he could find out how these things were done. They sent Ruadan, son of Bres and of Brigit, daughter of the Dagda, because he was a son and a grandson of the Tuatha de Danaan. So he went and saw everything that was done, and came back to the Fomor.

When they heard his story, they decided that it was Goibniu the Smith who hindered them most. They sent Ruadan back and told him to make an end of him.

So Ruadan went back to the forge and asked Goibniu whether he would give him a spear-head. Then he asked Credne for rivets, and the carpenter for a shaft, and everything was given to him as he asked. There was a woman there, Cron, mother of Fianlug, grinding the spears.

When the spear was given to Ruadan, he turned and threw it at Goibniu, and wounded him.

Goibniu pulled it out and threw it back at Ruadan. It went through him, and he died. His father Bres and the army of the Fomor saw him die.

Then Brigit came and keened her son, shrieking and crying.

That was the first keening ever heard in Ireland. The whistle for calling through the night was Brigit's, and so was this.

As for Goibniu, he went into the well and was healed.

But after that Octriallach, son of Indech, called to the Fomor and told every man of them to take a stone from the stones of Drinnes and throw it into the well of Slane. They did that until the well was dried up, and there was a cairn raised over it. It is called Octriallach's Cairn.

It was while Goibniu was making spear-heads for the battle of Magh Tuireadh that a charge was brought against his wife. Everyone could see that it was heavy news to him, and that jealousy came on him. There was a spear-shaft in his hand when he heard the story — Nes was its name — and he sang spells over it, so that anyone struck with that spear afterwards would be burned up by it as if by fire.

At last the day of the great battle came.

The Fomor came out of their camp and stood in strong ranks. There was not a leader or a fighting man among them without good armour to his skin, and a helmet on his head, a broad spear in his right hand, a heavy sword in his belt, and a strong shield on his shoulder. To attack the army of the Fomor that day was to beat your head against a rock, or to go up fighting against a fire.

The Men of Dea rose up. They left Lugh with the nine comrades who were guarding him, and went on to the battle. Midhir was with them, and Bodb Dearg, and Diancecht. And Badb and Macha and the Morrighu called out that they would go along with them.

It was a hard battle, and for a while it went against the Tuatha de Danaan.

Nuada of the Silver Hand, their king, fell by Balor, King of the Fomor. So did Macha, daughter of Emmass. Cass-mail fell by Octriallach. And the Dagda got a dreadful wound from a casting spear thrown by Ceithlenn, the wife of Balor.

But while the battle was going on, Lugh broke away from those who were keeping him, and rushed out to the front of the Men of Dea.

Then there was a fierce battle fought. Lugh was heartening the men of Ireland to fight well, so that they would not be in bonds any longer. It was better for them, he said, to die protecting their own country than to live any longer under bonds and under tribute. He sang them a song of courage, and the hosts gave a great shout as they went into battle, and then they met, and each began to attack the other.

There was great slaughter, and laying low in graves, and many comely men fell there in the stall of death. Pride and shame were there side by side, and hardness, and red anger, and there was red blood on the white skin of young fighting men. The dashing of spear against shield and sword against sword, and the shouting of the fighters, and the whistling of casting-spears, and the rattling of scabbards, went through the battle like harsh thunder. Many slipped in the blood underfoot and fell, striking their heads against one another. And the river carried away the bodies of friends and enemies together.

Then Lugh and Balor met in the battle.

Lugh called out insults to him. Balor grew angry, and said to the men beside him, "Lift up my eyelid, so I can see this chatterer who's talking to me."

They raised Balor's eyelid.

But Lugh threw his red spear at him, and it drove the eye out through the back of Balor's head, so that the eye fell facing his own army. Three times nine of the Fomor died when

they looked at it. If Lugh had not put out that eye when he did, the whole of Ireland would have been burned up in one flash.

After that Lugh struck his head off.

So the Druid's prophecy came true, the way prophecies do. Balor had locked his daughter in a tower of glass, and thrown her baby into the sea, and it had not made the smallest difference.

As for Indech, son of De Domnann, he fell and was crushed in the battle, and blood burst from his mouth. He called out for Leat Glas, his poet, as he lay there, but Leat Glas could not help him. Then the Morrighu came into the battle, heartening the Tuatha de Danaan to fight well. As she had promised the Dagda, she took the full of her two hands of Indech's blood and gave it to the armies waiting at the ford of Unius. It was called the Ford of Destruction from that day.

After that it was not a battle any more, but a rout, and the Fomor were beaten back to the sea.

Lugh and his comrades followed them, and they came up with Bres, son of Elathan, and no guard with him.

"It's better for you to spare my life than to kill me," said Bres. "If you spare me now, the cows of Ireland will never go dry."

"I'll ask advice about that from our wise men," said Lugh.

He told Maeltine Mor-Brethach, Maeltine of the Great Judgments, what Bres had said.

"Don't spare him for that," said Maeltine. "He has no power over their calves, though he has power over the cows while they're living."

"If you spare me," said Bres, "the men of Ireland will reap a harvest of corn every quarter."

"The spring is for ploughing and sowing," said Maeltine, "and the beginning of summer for the strength of the corn, and the beginning of autumn for its ripeness, and the winter for using it."

"That doesn't save you," said Lugh to Bres.

But then, to have an excuse for sparing him, Lugh said: "Tell us the best way for the men of Ireland to plough, and to sow, and to reap."

"Let their ploughing be on a Tuesday," said Bres, "and their casting of seed into the field on a Tuesday, and their reaping on a Tuesday."

Lugh said that would do, and let him go free.

It was in this battle that Ogma found Orna, the sword of Tethra, a king of the Fomor. He took it out of its sheath and cleaned it. When the sword was out of its sheath it told all the deeds that had been done by it. There used to be that power in swords. There may be still. We have stopped asking.

Lugh and the Dagda and Ogma went after the Fomor, because the Fomor had carried off the Dagda's harp, that was called Uaitne. They came to a feasting-house, and inside it they found Bres and his father Elathan, and there was the harp hanging on the wall.

The Dagda had bound the music into that harp, so that it would not sound until he called to it. Sometimes it was called Dur-da-Bla, the Oak of Two Blossoms, and sometimes Coir-cethar-chuin, the Four-Angled Music.

When he saw it hanging on the wall, this is what he said: "Come summer, come winter, from the mouth of harps and bags and pipes."

The harp sprang off the wall and came to the Dagda. It killed nine men on its way.

Then he played for them the three things harpers understand: the sleepy tune, and the laughing tune, and the crying tune. When he played the crying tune their women cried tears. Then he played the laughing tune, until their women and children laughed. And then he played the sleepy tune, and all the hosts fell asleep. And through that sleep the three of them walked away, through the Fomor who would have been glad to harm them.

When it was all over, the Dagda brought out the heifer he had taken as his wages from Bres, the time he was building his dun. She called to her calf. And at the sound of her call

all the cattle of Ireland that the Fomor had carried off as tribute were back in their own fields again.

Cé, the Druid of Nuada of the Silver Hand, was wounded in the battle. He went south until he came to Carn Corrslebe, and there he sat down to rest, tired with his wounds, and with the fear that was on him, and with the journey. He saw a smooth plain in front of him, full of flowers, and a great desire came on him to reach that plain. He went on until he came to it, and there he died. When his grave was made there, a lake burst out over it and over the whole plain, and it was given the name of Loch Cé.

There were only four men of the Fomor left in Ireland after the battle. They went about the country spoiling corn and milk and fruit, and whatever came out of the sea, until they were driven out one Samhain night by the Morrighu and by Angus Og, so that the Fomor might never be over Ireland again.

When the battle was won and the bodies were cleared away, the Morrighu gave out the news of the great victory to the hosts, and to the royal heights of Ireland, and to its chief rivers and its river-mouths. This is what she said:

"Peace up to the skies, the skies down to earth, the earth under the skies; strength to every one."

As for the number of men who fell in that battle, it will not be known until we have numbered the stars of the sky, or the flakes of snow, or the dew on the grass, or the grass under the feet of cattle, or the horses of the Son of Lir in a stormy sea.

Lugh was made king over the Men of Dea, and he held his court at Nas.

While he was king, his foster-mother Tailte, daughter of Magh Mor, the Great Plain, died. Before her death she asked her husband Duach the Dark — he who built the Fort of the Hostages in Teamhair — to clear away the wood of Cuan, so that there could be a gathering of the people around her grave. So he called on the men of Ireland to cut down the wood with their wide-bladed knives and bill-hooks and hatchets, and within a month the whole wood was down.

Lugh buried her in the plain of Midhe, and raised a mound over her that can be seen to this day. He ordered fires to be kindled, and keening to be made, and games and sports to be held in the summer of every year out of respect for her. The place where they were held took its name from her. It is Taillten.

And as for Lugh's own mother, tall, beautiful Ethlinn — she who had grown up in a tower of glass and never been told the name of a man — she came to Teamhair after the battle of Magh Tuireadh, and Lugh gave her in marriage to Tadg, son of Nuada.

The children born to them were Muirne, who would be the mother of Finn, the Head of the Fianna of Ireland; and Tuiren, who would be the mother of Bran.

But that was a long way off yet. First the gods would have to lose Ireland.



Book Three: The Coming Of The Gael



The Hidden House Of Lugh



Lugh held the kingship for a long time. Then the Dagda was made king in his place.

Lugh went away out of Ireland.

Some said he died at Uisnech, the place where the five provinces meet. Uisnech was where the first fire was ever kindled in Ireland. Mide, son of Brath, kindled it for the sons of Nemed, and it burned for six years, and every chief fire in Ireland was lit from that fire.

But gods do not die as easily as people say they do. Lugh was seen again in Ireland, at the time when Conchubar and the Men of the Red Branch went following white birds southward to the Boinn, at the time of Cuchulain's birth. And it was Lugh who came and kept watch over Cuchulain in his three days' sleep, at the time of the War for the Bull of Cuailgne.

And after that, he was seen again, by Conn of the Hundred Battles. This is how that happened.

Conn was at Teamhair, and he went up in the early morning to the Rath of the Kings at the rising of the sun. His three Druids were with him, Maol and Bloc and Bhuice, and his three poets, Ethain and Corb and Cesarn. He went up there with them every day, to look out on every side, so that if any men of the Sidhe came into Ireland, they would not come without his knowing it.

On this day he happened to stand on a stone that was in the rath. The stone screamed under his feet. It was heard all over Teamhair, and as far away as Bregia.

Conn asked his chief Druid how the stone came to be there, and what it screamed for. The Druid said he would not answer that until fifty-three days had passed. At the end of that time Conn asked him again, and this is what the Druid said:

"The Lia Fail is the name of that stone. It was brought out of Falias, and it was set up in Teamhair, and in Teamhair it will stay for ever. As long as there's a king in Teamhair, this

will be the gathering-place for games; and if no king comes to the last day of the gathering, there will be hardship in that year. And when the stone screamed under your feet, the number of screams it gave was a foretelling of the number of kings of your race that will come after you. But it is not I who will name them for you."

While they were standing there, a great mist came down around them, and a darkness, so that they could not tell which way they were going. They heard the sound of a rider coming towards them.

"It would be a great grief to us," said Conn, "to be carried off into a strange country."

The rider threw three spears at them, and each came faster than the one before.

"It is the wounding of a king indeed," said the Druids, "for anyone to throw at Conn of Teamhair."

At that the rider stopped throwing his spears. He came up to them and bade Conn welcome, and asked him to come to his house.

They went on until they came to a beautiful plain, and there they saw a king's rath, with a golden tree at its door. Inside the rath was a grand house with a roof of white bronze. They went into the house, and the rider who had come to meet them was there before them, sitting in his royal seat. There had never been a man seen in Teamhair like him for comeliness, or for beauty, or for the wonder of his face.

There was a young woman in the house, with a band of gold on her head. Beside her was a silver vessel with hoops of gold, full of red ale, with a golden bowl on its edge and a golden cup at its mouth.

"Who am I to serve drink to?" she said to the master of the house.

"Serve it to Conn of the Hundred Battles," he said, "for he will win a hundred battles before he dies."

Then he told her to pour out the ale for Art of the Three Shouts, the son of Conn. And after that he went through the names of all the kings of Ireland who would come after Conn, and told the length of each one's life.

The young woman left the vessel with Conn, and the cup and the bowl. And she gave him, along with them, the rib of an ox and the rib of a hog. The ox-rib was twenty-four feet long.

The master of the house told them that the young woman was the Kingship of Ireland, for ever.

"And as for me," he said, "I am Lugh of the Long Hand, son of Ethlinn."

Then the mist lifted, and they were standing on the Rath of the Kings again, in the morning, with a vessel and a cup and a bowl, and nobody to tell them what any of it had cost.

CHAPTER I

The Landing



Nobody knows now how long the Tuatha de Danaan ruled over Ireland. It was probably a long time. But in the end they were put out of it.

This is how it happened.

The sons of Gaedhal of the Shining Armour, the Very Gentle — the ones who were called afterwards the Sons of the Gael — made their first attempt to land in Ireland at Inver Slane, to the north of Leinster. They came to avenge Ith, one of their own race, who had come to Ireland once before and met his death there.

The sons of Miled led them, and they came from the south. Their Druids had told them there was no country for them to settle in until they came to that island in the west. "And if you don't get possession of it yourselves," the Druids said, "your children will."

When the Tuatha de Danaan saw the ships coming, they flocked down to the shore. By their enchantments they threw such a cloud over the whole island that the sons of Miled were confused, and all they could see was some large thing that looked like a pig.

Ireland, from the sea, looked like a pig. That is the kind of magic the gods had then.

Since the enchantments kept them from landing there, they sailed along the coast until at last they managed to land at Inver Sceine, in the west of Munster.

From there they marched in good order as far as Slieve Mis. There they were met by a queen of the Tuatha de Danaan, with a train of beautiful women attending her, and her Druids and wise men following behind. Amergin, one of the sons of Miled, spoke to her and asked her name. She said it was Banba, wife of Mac Cuill, Son of the Hazel.

They went on until they came to Slieve Eibhline, and there another queen of the Tuatha de Danaan met them, with her women and her Druids behind her. They asked her name, and she said it was Fodhla, wife of Mac Cecht, Son of the Plough.

They went on until they came to the hill of Uisnech, and there they saw another woman coming towards them, and they wondered as they watched her. One moment she was a wide-eyed and most beautiful queen. The next she was a sharp-beaked, grey-white crow. She came up to where Eremon, one of the sons of Miled, was standing, and sat down in front of him. He asked her who she was.

"I am Eriu," she said, "wife of Mac Greine, Son of the Sun."

The names of those three queens were often given to Ireland in the time that came after. They still are. Every time someone says Eire, they are saying her name.

After that the Sons of the Gael went on to Teamhair. The three sons of Cermait Honey-Mouth, son of the Dagda, held the kingship between them at that time and kept their court there. And the three were quarrelling with each other over the division of the treasures their father had left, and the quarrel was so hot that it looked as if it would come to a battle in the end.

The Sons of the Gael wondered to see them quarrelling over such things, when they had so fruitful an island — where the air was so wholesome, and the sun not too strong, and the cold not too bitter, and where there was such plenty of honey and acorns, and milk, and fish, and corn, and room enough for everybody.

They lived in great grandeur at the palace of Teamhair, with their Druids around them. Amergin went to them and told them they must give up the kingship there and then, or else leave it to the chance of a battle. He said he asked it in revenge for the death of Ith, of the race of the Gael, who had come to their court before and had been killed by treachery.

When the sons of Cermait Honey-Mouth heard Amergin say such fierce words they were astonished. They said they were not willing to fight just then, for their army was not ready.

"But you make us an offer," they said, "for we can see you have good judgment and knowledge. Only, if you make us an offer that isn't fair, we'll destroy you with our enchantments."

So Amergin told the men with him to go back to Inver Sceine, and to hurry into their ships again with the rest of the Sons of the Gael, and to go out from the shore the length of nine waves.

Then he made his offer to the Tuatha de Danaan. If they could stop his men from landing on their island, he and all his ships would go home to their own country and never try to come again. But if the Sons of the Gael could land on the coast in spite of them, the Tuatha de Danaan must give up the kingship and be under their rule.

The Tuatha de Danaan were well pleased with that offer. They thought that with their enchantments over the winds and the sea, and all their arts, they would easily keep them from ever setting foot in the country again.

So the Sons of the Gael did what Amergin told them. They went back to their ships and drew up their anchors and moved out the length of nine waves from the shore.

The moment the Men of Dea saw they had left the land, they took to their enchantments and their spells. They raised a great wind that scattered the ships of the Gael and drove them apart.

Amergin knew it was not a natural storm. Arranan, son of Miled, knew it too, and he climbed the mast of his ship to look about him. A great blast of wind came at him, and he fell back into the ship and died that moment.

There was great confusion among the Gael. The ships were tossed to and fro and came close to being lost. The ship that Donn, son of Miled, commanded was torn away from the others by the force of the storm and broken to pieces, and he and everyone with him were drowned: four-and-twenty men and women in all. Ir, son of Miled, died the same way. His body was thrown up on the shore, and it was buried on a small island that is called Sceilg Michill now. Ir was a brave man. He led the Sons of the Gael to the front of every battle, and he was their help and their shelter in battle, and his enemies were in dread of his name.

Heremon, another of the sons of Miled, was driven with his share of the ships to the left of the island, and he barely got safe to land. The place where he landed was called Inver Colpa, because Colpa of the Sword, another son of Miled, drowned there trying to get ashore.

Five of the sons of Miled in all were destroyed by the storm and the winds the Men of Dea had raised with their enchantments. Only three were left: Heber, and Heremon, and Amergin.

Before he was swept into the sea, Donn had shouted out: "It's treachery our learned men are doing on us, not putting down this wind!"

"There's no treachery," said Amergin, his brother.

And he stood up in front of them, and whatever enchantment he worked on the winds and the sea, these are the words he said with it:

"That they who are tossing on the great, wide, food-giving sea may reach the land now.

"That they may find a place upon its plains, its mountains, and its valleys; in its forests full of nuts and of all fruits; on its rivers and its streams, on its lakes and its great waters.

"That we may have our gatherings and our races in this land; that there may be a king of our own in Teamhair; that it may be the possession of our many kings.

"That the sons of Miled may be seen in this land, and their ships and their boats find a place there.

"This land that is now under darkness, it is for it we are asking. Let our chief men, let their learned wives, ask that we may come to the noble woman, great Eriu."

When he had said it, the wind dropped, and the sea was quiet again that same moment.

He had not fought the storm. He had asked the land. And the land had answered.

So those who were left of the sons of Miled and of the Sons of the Gael landed at Inver Sceine.

Amergin was the first to put his foot on the land. And when he stood on the shore of Ireland, this is what he said:

"I am the wind on the sea; I am the wave of the sea; I am the bull of seven battles; I am the eagle on the rock; I am a flash from the sun; I am the most beautiful of plants; I am a

strong wild boar; I am a salmon in the water; I am a lake in the plain; I am the word of knowledge; I am the head of the spear in battle; I am the god that puts fire in the head. Who spreads light in the gathering on the hills? Who can tell the ages of the moon? Who can tell the place where the sun rests?"

The gods of Dana heard it. And they understood, perhaps before the Gael did, that a man had come to Ireland who could speak to it the way they spoke to it. That had never happened before.



Book Four: The Ever-Living Living Ones



The Battle Of Tailtin



Three days after the Gael landed, they were attacked by Eriu, wife of Mac Greine, Son of the Sun. She had a good share of men with her. They fought a hard battle, and many were killed on both sides. This was the first battle fought between the Sons of the Gael and the Men of Dea for the kingship of Ireland.

Fais, wife of Un, was killed in that battle, in a valley at the foot of the mountain, and the valley was named after her: the Valley of Fais. And Scots, wife of Miled, got her death in the battle, and she was buried in a valley on the north side of the mountain, near the sea.

But the Sons of the Gael lost no more than three hundred men, and they beat back the Men of Dea and killed a thousand of them.

Eriu was driven back to Tailtin, with as many of her men as she could hold together. When she got there she told the people how she had been worsted in the battle, and how the best of her men had got their death.

The Gael stayed on the battlefield and buried their dead. They gave a great burial to two of their Druids, Aer and Eithis, who had been killed in the fight.

When they had rested a while they went on to Inver Colpa in Leinster, and Heremon and his men joined them there. Then they sent messengers to the three kings of Ireland, the three sons of Cermait Honey-Mouth, and told them to come out and fight a battle that would settle the ownership of the country once and for all.

So they came out to Tailtin, and the best fighters of the Tuatha de Danaan with them.

There the two sides fell on each other. The Sons of the Gael remembered the death of Ith, and a great anger came on them, and they went at the Men of Dea to avenge him, and a fierce battle was fought. For a while neither side got the better of the other. But at last the Gael broke through the army of the Men of Dea and put them to rout, with great slaughter, and drove them out of that place.

Their three kings were killed in the rout. And the three queens of Ireland were killed: Eriu, and Fodhla, and Banba.

When the Tuatha de Danaan saw their leaders dead, they fell back in great disorder, and the Sons of the Gael came after them. In the pursuit the Gael lost two of their best leaders: Cuailgne, son of Breagan, at Slieve Cuailgne, and Fuad, his brother, at Slieve Fuad. They were not daunted by that. They followed the Men of Dea so hard that the Men of Dea were never able to bring their army together again, and had to own themselves beaten, and give up the country to the Gael.

Consider what that means. The gods lost. Not to other gods. To people.

The leaders, the sons of Miled, divided the provinces of Ireland between them. Heber took the two provinces of Munster, and gave a share of it to Amergin. Heremon took Leinster and Connacht for his share. Ulster was divided between Eimhir, son of Ir, son of Miled, and some others of their chief men.

It was from the sons of Eimhir — who were called the Children of Rudraighe, and who lived in Emain Macha for nine hundred years — that some of the best men of Ireland came. Fergus, son of Rogh, was one of them, and Conall Cearnach of the Red Branch of Ulster.

And from the sons of Ith, the first of the Gael to get his death in Ireland, there came in later times Fathadh Canaan, who got the sway over the whole world from the rising to the setting of the sun, and who took hostages of the streams, and of the birds, and of the languages.

This is what the poets of Ireland used to say. Every brave man good at fighting, every man who could do great deeds and not make much talk about them, was of the Sons of the Gael. Every skilled man who had music, and who did enchantments in secret, was of the Tuatha de Danaan.

But they gave a bad name to the Firbolgs, and to the men of Domnand, and to the Gaileoin, for lying and big talk and injustice. For all that, there were good fighters among them. Ferdiad, who made such a good stand against Cuchulain in the war for the Bull of Cuailgne,

was one of them. The Gaileoin fought well in that same war. But the men of Ireland had no great liking for them, and their Druids drove them out of the country afterwards.

As for the Men of Dea, they were beaten, and they had given up the country.

They did not leave it.

CHAPTER I

Bodb Dearg



After they were beaten, the Tuatha de Danaan would not go under the rule of the sons of Miled. They went away by themselves.

Manannan, son of Lir, understood all enchantments, so they left it to him to find places for them where they would be safe from their enemies. He chose the most beautiful of the hills and valleys of Ireland for them to settle in. And he put hidden walls around them, walls no man could see through — though they themselves could see through them, and pass through them.

That is where they went. Into the hills. Behind the walls you cannot see. They are there still.

Manannan made the Feast of Age for them. What they drank at it was the ale of Goibniu the Smith, and whoever tasted it was kept from age, and from sickness, and from death. For food at the feast he gave them his own swine, which, though they were killed and eaten one day, would be alive and fit for eating again the next, and would go on like that for ever.

After a while they said, "It would be better for us to have one king over us, than to be scattered the way we are through the whole of Ireland."

The ones with the best chance of the kingship at that time were Bodb Dearg, son of the Dagda; and Ilbrech of Ess Ruadh; and Lir of Sidhe Fionnachaidh, the Hill of the White Field, on Slieve Fuad; and Midhir the Proud of Bri Leith; and Angus Og, son of the Dagda — though Angus did not want the kingship at all, and would sooner have been left as he was.

All the chief men except those five went into council together. They agreed to give the kingship to Bodb Dearg, for his father's sake, and for his own sake, and because he was the eldest of the children of the Dagda.

Bodb Dearg had his house in Sidhe Femen, and he put great enchantments about it.

Cliach, the Harper of the King of the Three Rosses in Connacht, went there once to ask for one of Bodb's daughters in marriage. He stayed outside the place for the whole length of a year, playing his harp, and he could get no nearer to Bodb or to his daughter. He went on playing until a lake burst up under his feet: the lake on the top of a mountain, Loch Bel Sead.

It was Bodb's swineherd who went to Da Derga's Inn, with his squealing pig along with him, on the night that Conaire, the High King of Ireland, met his death. It was said that whatever feast that swineherd went to, blood would be shed before it was over.

Bodb had three sons: Angus, and Artrach, and Aedh. In the time of the Fianna, later, they often lived among men.

Artrach had a house with seven doors, and a free welcome for everyone who came. The king's son of Ireland and the king's son of Alban used to come to Angus to learn the throwing of spears and darts. And troops of poets from Alban and from Ireland stayed with Aedh, who was the comeliest of Bodb's sons, so that his place was called the Rath of Aedh of the Poets. It was a beautiful rath in those days, with golden-yellow apples in it, and the crimson-pointed nuts of the wood.

But after the passing of the Fianna, the three brothers went back to the Tuatha de Danaan.

Bodb Dearg was not always in his own place. Sometimes he was with Angus at Brugh na Boinn.

Three sons of Lugaidh Menn, King of Ireland, went there once: Eochaid, and Fiacha, and Ruide. Their father had refused them any land until they won it for themselves. When he said that, they rose up together, like one man rising, and went and sat down on the green of Brugh na Boinn, and fasted there against the Tuatha de Danaan, to see whether they could win some good thing from them.

That is a thing you could do, then. You could sit down outside the hill of the gods and refuse to eat until they noticed you. It sometimes worked.

They had not been there long when they saw a young man coming towards them, quiet and pleasant-looking. He wished them good health, and they answered the same way.

"Where have you come from?" they asked him.

"From the rath over there, with the many lights," he said. "I am Bodb Dearg, son of the Dagda. Come in with me now to the rath."

So they went in, and supper was made ready for them, but they did not touch it. Bodb Dearg asked them why they would take nothing.

"Because our father has refused us land," they said. "There are only two races in Ireland, the Sons of the Gael and the Men of Dea. When the one failed us, we came to the other."

The Men of Dea took counsel together. The chief among them was Midhir of the Yellow Hair, and this is what he said: "Let us give a wife to each of these three men. It's from a wife that good or bad fortune comes."

They agreed to that, and Midhir's three daughters, Doirenn and Aife and Aillbhe, were given to them.

Then Midhir asked Bodb to say what marriage portion should go with them.

"I'll tell you," said Bodb. "We are three times fifty sons of kings in this hill. Let every king's son give three times fifty ounces of red gold. And I myself will give them, along with that, three times fifty suits of clothing of all colours."

"I'll give them a gift," said a young man of the Tuatha de Danaan from Rachlainn in the sea. "A horn, and a vat. You have only to fill the vat with pure water and it will turn into mead, fit to drink and strong enough to make you drunk. And you have only to put salt water from the sea into the horn, and it will turn into wine that moment."

"A gift from me," said Lir of Sidhe Fionnachaidh. "Three times fifty swords, and three times fifty well-riveted long spears."

"A gift from me," said Angus Og, son of the Dagda. "A rath, and a good town with high walls, and bright sunny houses, and wide houses, in whatever place they please between Rath Chobtaige and Teamhair."

"A gift from me," said Aine, daughter of Modharn. "A woman-cook I have. There is a geis on her never to refuse food to anyone, and as she serves it out, her store fills itself up again."

"Another gift from me," said Bodb Dearg. "A good musician I have, Fertuinne, son of Trogain. If there were women in the sharpest pains of childbirth, and brave men wounded early in the day, in a place where saws were going through wood, they would all sleep at the sweetness of the music he makes. And whatever house he's in, the people of the whole country round will hear him."

They stayed at Brugh na Boinne three days and three nights. When they left, Angus told them to bring three apple-trees with them from the oak-wood: one in full bloom, one shedding its blossom, and the third covered with ripe fruit.

Then they went to their own dun that had been given to them, and it was a good place. They had a troop of young men there, and great troops of horses and of greyhounds. They had the three kinds of music that comely kings like to listen to: the music of harps, and of lutes, and the chanting of Trogain's son. They had three great sounds: the tramping on the green, and the uproar of racing, and the lowing of cattle. And three other sounds: the grunting of good pigs with the fat thick on them, and the voices of the crowd on the green lawn, and the noise of men drinking inside the house.

It was said of Eochaid that he never took a step backwards in flight, and that his house was never without music or the drinking of ale. It was said of Fiacha that there was no man of his time braver, and that he never said one word too many. And as for Ruide, he never refused anybody anything, and he never asked anything of any man.

When their lifetime was over, they went back to the Tuatha de Danaan, for they belonged to them through their wives. And they have stayed there ever since.

Bodb Dearg had a daughter, Scathniamh, the Flower of Brightness. In the time of the Fianna she gave her love to Caoilte. They were forced apart, and they never met again until Caoilte was old and withered, and one of the last of the Fianna left alive.

She came to him then, out of the cave of Cruachan, and asked him for the bride-price he had promised her, and that she had never been able to come and ask for until then.

Caoilte went to a cairn near by that was filled up with gold. It was wages that Conan Maol had earned and hidden there. And Caoilte gave the gold to Bodb Dearg's daughter.

The people who were there wondered to see the girl so young and comely, and Caoilte so grey and bent and withered.

"There's no wonder in that," said Caoilte. "I am of the sons of Miled, who wither and fade away. She is of the Tuatha de Danaan, who never change, and who never die."

That is the difference between them and us. It is not a difference in power. It is a difference in what time does to you.

CHAPTER II

The Dagda



The Dagda, the Red Man of All Knowledge, had his house at Brugh na Boinne.



Aonghus Óg — God of Love and Youth

The things most worth seeing in it were the Hall of the Morrigu, and the Bed of the Dagda, and the Birthplace of Cermait Honey-Mouth, and the Prison of the Grey of Macha, the horse that would afterwards be Cuchulain's. There was a little hill by the house called the Comb and the Casket of the Dagda's Wife, and another called the Hill of Dabilla, after the little hound that belonged to Boann. And the Valley of the Mata was there — the Mata was a sea-turtle, and it could suck down a man in armour.

It is likely that the Dagda set up his cooking-oven there, the one Druimne, son of Luchair, made for him at Teamhair. This is how it was made. The axle and the wheel were wood, and the body was iron, and there were twice nine wheels on its axle so that it would turn the faster. It turned as quick as a stream runs. There were three times nine spits off it, and three times nine pots. It would lie down low with the cinders, and rise up to the height of the roof with the flame.

The Dagda himself once made a great vat for Ainge, his daughter. She was not well satisfied with it. It would not stop dripping while the sea was in flood, though it never lost a drop during the ebb. So she gathered a bundle of twigs to make a new vat for herself. But Gaible, son of Nuada of the Silver Hand, stole the bundle from her and hurled it away. Where it fell, a beautiful wood grew up, and it was called Gaible's Wood.

The Dagda kept his household at Brugh na Boinne. His steward was Dichu. The smith of the Brugh was Len Linfiachlach. Len lived in the lake, making the bright vessels of Fand, daughter of Flidhais. Every evening when he stopped work he would throw his anvil eastward to Indeoin na Dese, the Anvil of the Dese, as far as the Grave End. It cast three showers as it went: a shower of fire, and a shower of water, and a shower of precious stones of pure purple.

But Tuirbe, father of Goibniu the Smith, could throw better still. He would throw his axe from Tulach na Bela, the Hill of the Axe, into the face of the incoming tide, and put his order on the sea, and the sea would not come past the axe.

Corann was the best of the harpers of the household. He was harper to the Dagda's son, Diancecht. Once he called with his harp to Cailcheir, one of the swine of Debrann. The pig ran northward with all the strength of its legs, and the champions of Connacht ran after it

with all their strength, and their hounds with them, until they got as far as Ceis Corain. There they gave it up — all except Niall, who kept on the pig's track until he found it in the oak-wood of Tarba. Then it made away across the plain of Ai, and through a lake, and Niall and his hound were drowned following it through the lake.

The Dagda gave Corann a great tract of land for harping so well.

However great a house the Dagda had, Angus got it away from him in the end, with the help of Manannan, son of Lir.

Manannan told Angus to ask his father for the Brugh for the length of a day and a night, and said that he would use his art to take away the Dagda's power of refusing. So Angus asked for the Brugh, and his father gave it to him for a day and a night.

When the Dagda asked for it back, Angus said it had been given to him for ever. For the whole of life and time, he said, is made up of a day and a night, one following the other.

It was a trick. It was also true. The best tricks usually are.

When the Dagda heard that, he went away, and his people and his household with him, for Manannan had put an enchantment on them all.

But Dichu the Steward was away at the time, and his wife and his son, gone to get provisions for a feast for Manannan and his friends. When he came back and found his master gone, he took service with Angus.

Angus stayed in Brugh na Boinne. Some say he is there still, behind the hidden walls, drinking Goibniu's ale and eating the pigs that never fail.

As for the Dagda, he took no revenge, though he had the name of being revengeful and quick-tempered. Some say it was at Teamhair he made his home after that. Wherever it was, a great misfortune came on him there.

Corrgenn, a great man of Connacht, came to visit him once, and brought his wife with him. While they were there, Corrgenn got it into his head that something was going on that was not right between his wife and Aedh, one of the sons of the Dagda. A great jealousy and

anger came on him, and he struck at the young man and killed him in front of his father's face.

Everyone thought the Dagda would take Corrgenn's life then and there, in revenge for his son. He would not. He said that if his son was guilty, there was no blame on Corrgenn for doing what he did.

So he spared his life for that time. But Corrgenn did not gain much by it.

The punishment the Dagda put on him was this. He must take the dead body of the young man on his back and never lay it down until he found a stone that was its exact fit in length and in breadth, a stone that would make a gravestone for him. When he found it, he could bury him in the nearest hill.

Corrgenn had no choice but to go. He set out with his load, and he had a long way to travel before he found a stone that would fit. He found it at last on the shore of Loch Feabhail. He left the body up on the nearest hill, and went down and raised the stone and brought it up, and dug a grave, and buried the Dagda's son.

Many an Ochone he gave while he was putting the stone over him. And when he had done it, he was spent, and he dropped dead there and then.

The Dagda brought his two builders, Garbhan and Imheall, to the place, and told them to build a rath around the grave. Garbhan cut the stones and shaped them, and Imheall set them all round the house until the work was finished, and then closed the top of the house with a slab.

The place was called the Hill of Aileac, that is, the Hill of Sighs and of a Stone. For it was tears of blood the Dagda shed for the death of his son.

The gods do not die. It turns out their children can.

CHAPTER III

Angus Og



As for Angus Og, son of the Dagda, sometimes he would come out of Brugh na Boinn and let himself be seen upon the earth.

A long time after the coming of the Gael, he was seen by Cormac, King of Teamhair. This is the account Cormac gave of him.

Cormac was alone one day in his Hall of Judgment. He often sat there reading the laws and thinking how best to carry them out. Suddenly he saw a stranger at the end of the hall, a very comely young man. He knew at once that it was Angus Og. He had often heard his people talk of him — though he himself used to say he did not believe there was any such person at all.

When his people came back into the hall he told them that he had seen Angus himself and talked with him, and that Angus had told him his name, and had foretold what would happen to him.

"He was a beautiful young man," Cormac said, "with high looks, and his appearance was more beautiful than all beauty. There were ornaments of gold on his clothes. In his hand he held a silver harp with strings of red gold, and the sound of its strings was sweeter than all the music under the sky. Over the harp were two birds that seemed to be playing on it. He sat beside me pleasantly and played his sweet music to me. And at the end he foretold things that put drunkenness on my wits."

That is how it goes with gods. You say you do not believe in them. And then one day you look up from your law books.

The birds that went about with Angus were four of his kisses, which had turned into birds. They used to fly about the young men of Ireland, crying after them. "Come, come," two of them would say. "I go, I go," the other two would say. It was hard to get free of them.

Even in his earliest youth Angus was called the Frightener, or the Disturber. The plough-teams of the world, and every kind of beast that men use, would run in terror before him.

Once he appeared in the shape of a landholder to two men, Ribh and Eochó, who were looking for a place to settle. The first place they chose was near Bregia, on a plain that belonged to Angus. He came to them then, leading his horse by the hand, and told them they should not stay there. They said they could not carry their goods away without horses. So he gave them his horse, and told them to load everything they wanted onto it, and the horse would carry it. And it did.

But the next place they chose was Magh Find, the Fine Plain, and that was the playing-ground of Angus and of Midhir. That time Midhir came to them in the same way and gave them a horse to put their goods on, and went on with them as far as Magh Dairbthenn.

Many women loved Angus.

There was one, Enghi, daughter of Elcmair, who loved him though she had never seen him. She went looking for him once, to the gathering for games between Cletech and the Sidhe in Broga. The bright troops of the Sidhe came to that gathering every Samhain evening, bringing a moderate share of food with them — that is, a nut.

The sons of Derc came from the north, out of Sidhe Findabrach, and went round among the young men and women without their knowing it, and carried away Elcmair's daughter. There was great lamenting then, and the place got the name Cnoguba, the Nut Lamentation, from the crying there was at that gathering.

She had gone looking for love. She got taken instead. It happens.

Derbrenn, the daughter of Eochaid Fedlech, was another whom Angus loved. She had six fosterlings, three boys and three girls. But the mother of the boys, Dalb Garb, Dalb the Rough, put a spell on them that she made from a gathering of the nuts of Caill Ochuid, and it turned them into swine.

Angus gave them into the care of Buichet, the Hospitaller of Leinster, and they stayed a year with him. At the end of that year a longing came on Buichet's wife to eat a bit of the flesh of one of them. So she gathered a hundred armed men and a hundred hounds to take them.

The pigs ran. They went to Brugh na Boinn, to Angus, and he made them welcome, and they asked for his help.

He said he could not give it until they had shaken the Tree of Tarbga, and eaten the salmon of Inver Umaill.

So they went to Glascarn and hid there a year with Derbrenn. Then they shook the Tree of Tarbga, and went on towards Inver Umaill.

But Maeve gathered the men of Connacht to hunt them. They all fell but one. Their heads were put in a mound, and the mound got the name of Duma Selga, the Mound of the Hunting.

And it was in the time of Maeve of Cruachan that Angus set his love on Caer Ormaith, of the Province of Connacht, and brought her away to Brugh na Boinn.

Angus loved often. Once, at least, it ended well.

The Morrigu



The Morrigu. The Great Queen. The Crow of Battle.

Nobody knows where she lived after the coming of the Gael. Before that, she lived at Teamhair.

She had a great cooking-spit there that held three kinds of food on it at the one time: a piece of raw meat, and a piece of cooked meat, and a piece of butter. The raw meat cooked, and the cooked meat did not burn, and the butter did not melt, all three of them together on the spit.

Nine outlaws went to her once and asked her to make a spit for them. They carried it away with them. It had nine ribs, and each of the outlaws carried a rib in his hand wherever he went, until they all met again at the close of day. If they wanted the spit to be high, it could be raised to a man's height; at another time it would be no more than a fist's height over the fire. It never broke and it never grew less.

The Morrigu had a son, Mechi, and he was killed by Mac Cecht on Magh Mechi, which until then had been called Magh Fertaige.

Mechi had three hearts, and this is how they were: they had the shapes of three serpents through them. If Mechi had not died, those serpents would have grown, and whatever they left alive in Ireland would have wasted away. Mac Cecht burned the three hearts on Magh Luathad, the Plain of Ashes, and threw the ashes into the stream. The rushing water of the stream stopped, and boiled up, and every creature in it died.

The story does not tell us what the Morrigu said about that. It does not need to. She was the Crow of Battle, and she had lost a son, and she went on.

She was always meddling in Ireland in Cuchulain's time, stirring up wars and quarrels.

It was she who came and roused Cuchulain once, when he was only a boy, and was close to giving in to some enchantment worked against him.

"There's not the making of a hero in you," she said to him, "lying there under the feet of shadows."

With that Cuchulain got up and struck the head off a shadow that was standing over him, with his hurling-stick.

And when Conchubar sent Finched out to rouse the men of Ulster at the time of the war for the Bull of Cuailgne, he told him to go to that terrible fury, the Morrighu, and get help for Cuchulain.

She quarrelled with Cuchulain once, when he met her bringing a cow away from the Hill of Cruachan. Another time she helped Talchinem, a Druid of the household of Conaire Mor, to carry off a bull his wife had set her heart on.

She was much given to meddling with cattle. Once she took a cow from Odras, a woman of the household of the cow-chief of Cormac Hua Cuined, who was following her husband with cattle. The Morrighu brought the cow away with her to the Cave of Cruachan and the Hill of the Sidhe. Odras followed her there, until sleep fell on her in the oak-wood of Falga. The Morrighu woke her, and sang spells over her, and made her into a pool of water, which ran into the river that flows to the west of Slieve Buane.

It is not a good idea to follow the Morrighu home.

In the battle of Magh Rath she fluttered over Congal Claen in the shape of a bird, until he could not tell friend from foe. And again, at the battle of Cluantarbh, she was flying over the head of Murchadh, son of Brian. She had many shapes, and it was often in the shape of a crow that she fought her battles.

If it was not the Morrighu, it was Badb who showed herself in the battle of Dunbolg, where the men of Ireland fought under Aedh, son of Niall. And Brigit was seen in that same battle, on the side of the men of Leinster.

The gods had given up Ireland. They had never given up its wars.

Aine



Some said Aine was a daughter of Manannan. Some said she was the Morrighu herself. Either way, there was a stone that belonged to her, and it was called Cathair Aine.

If you sat on that stone, you were in danger of losing your wits. If you sat on it three times, you lost them for ever.

People whose wits had gone astray would find their way to it. Mad dogs would come from all over the country and gather round it, and then go down into the sea, to Aine's place there.

But those who did cures with herbs said she had power over the whole body. She gave gifts of poetry and of music. She often gave her love to men. They called her the Leanan Sidhe, the Sweetheart of the Sidhe.

It was not safe to offend Aine. She was very revengeful.

Oilioll Oluim, a king of Ireland, killed her brother once. This is what she did about it.

She made a great yew-tree by enchantment beside the river Maigh in Luimnech, and she put a little man in it, playing sweet music on a harp.

Oilioll's son was crossing the river with his step-brother, and they saw the tree and heard the sweet music coming out of it. First they quarrelled over which of them should have the little harper. Then they quarrelled over the tree. They asked Oilioll to judge between them, and he gave judgment for his own son.

The bad feeling over that judgment led to the battle of Magh Mucruimhe. Oilioll and his seven sons were killed there.

So Aine got her revenge. She had not raised a hand. She had only planted a tree, and put music in it, and waited for people to be people.

CHAPTER VI

Aoibhell



Aoibhell was another woman of the Sidhe. She made her home in Craig Liath.

At the time of the battle of Cluantarbh she set her love on a young man of Munster, Dubhlaing ua Artigan. The King of Ireland had sent him away in disgrace. But before the battle he came back, to join Murchadh, the king's son, and to fight for the Gael.

Aoibhell came to stop him. When he would not stay with her, she put a Druid covering around him, so that nobody could see him.

He went to where Murchadh was fighting and made a great attack on the enemies of Ireland, striking them down on every side.

Murchadh looked around. "It seems to me I hear the sound of the blows of Dubhlaing ua Artigan," he said, "but I don't see him."

Then Dubhlaing threw off the Druid covering. "I won't keep this on me," he said, "if you can't see me through it. And come with me now across the plain to where Aoibhell is. She can give us news of the battle."

So they went to her, and she told them both to leave the battle, for they would lose their lives in it.

"I'll tell you a little true story," Murchadh said to her. "Fear for my own body will never make me change my face. If we fall, the strangers will fall with us. Many a man will fall by my own hand, and the Gael will be sharing out their strong places."

"Stay with me, Dubhlaing," she said then, "and you'll have two hundred years of happy life with me."

"I won't give up Murchadh," he said, "or my own good name, for silver or gold."

Two hundred years. Think about that for a moment. That is what he turned down, and he knew exactly what he was turning down.

Anger came on Aoibhell when he said it. "Murchadh will fall," she said, "and you will fall yourself, and your proud blood will be on the plain tomorrow."

They went back into the battle, and got their death there.

It was Aoibhell who gave a golden harp to the son of Meardha, when he was getting his learning at the school of the Sidhe in Connacht and heard that his father had got his death at the hands of the King of Lochlann. Whoever heard that harp played did not live long after. Meardha's son went to where the three sons of the King of Lochlann were, and played his harp for them, and they died.

It was that harp Cuchulain heard when his enemies were gathering against him at Muirthemne. And he knew by it that his life was near its end.

CHAPTER VII

Midhir And Etain



Midhir took a hill for himself. His wife Fuamach lived there with him, and his daughter, Bri.



Manannán mac Lir — God of the Sea and Otherworld — Lord of Tír Tairngire — The Ferryman of Souls

Leith, son of Celtchar of Cualu, was the most beautiful of the young men of the Sidhe of Ireland in those days, and he loved Bri, Midhir's daughter.

Once Bri went out with her young girls to meet him at the Grave of the Daughters, beside Teamhair. Leith came, and his young men with him, as far as the Hill of the After Repentance. They could come no closer to one another than that, because of the slingers on Midhir's hill, who answered one another until their spears were as thick as a swarm of bees on a fine day. Cochlan, Leith's servant, got a sharp wound from them, and died.

Then the girl turned back to Midhir's hill, and her heart broke inside her, and she died.

"Though I'm not let come to this girl," said Leith, "I'll leave my name with her."

And the hill was called Bri Leith from that day.

After a while Midhir took Etain Echraide to be his wife.

Fuamach, the wife he already had, was bitterly jealous when she saw the love Midhir gave to Etain. She called on the Druid Bresal Etarlaim to help her, and he put spells on Etain so that Fuamach was able to drive her away.

When she was driven out of Bri Leith, Angus Og, son of the Dagda, took her into his keeping. When Midhir asked for her back, Angus would not give her up, but carried her with him everywhere he went. Wherever they rested, he made a sunny house for her and filled it with sweet-smelling flowers, and put invisible walls around it, walls no one could see through, and that could not be seen.

When news came to Fuamach of how well Angus was caring for Etain, anger and jealousy came on her again, and she searched her mind for a way to destroy Etain altogether.

This is what she did. She persuaded Midhir and Angus to go out and meet each other and make peace, for there had been a quarrel between them since Etain was sent away. And while Angus was away from Brugh na Boinn, Fuamach went and found Etain there in her sunny house. She turned her with Druid spells into a fly. Then she sent a blast of wind into the house, and it swept Etain out through the window.

Midhir and Angus waited a while for Fuamach to come and join them. When she did not come they grew uneasy, and Angus hurried back to Brugh na Boinn. He found the sunny house empty. He went looking for Fuamach, and he found her with Etarlaim the Druid, and struck her head off there and then.

For seven years Etain was blown to and fro through Ireland in great misery. A fly, on the wind. For seven years.

At last she came to the house of Etar, of Inver Cechmaine, where there was a feast going on. She fell from a beam of the roof into the golden cup that stood beside Etar's wife. Etar's wife drank her down with the wine. And at the end of nine months she was born again, as Etar's daughter.

She had the same name as before: Etain. She was reared as a king's daughter, and fifty young girls, daughters of princes, were brought up with her to keep her company.

One day Etain and the other young girls were bathing in the bay at Inver Cechmaine, and from the water they saw a man of very high looks coming towards them across the plain, riding a bay horse with curled mane and tail. He wore a long green cloak, and a shirt woven with threads of red gold, and a brooch of gold that reached across to his shoulders on either side. On his back was a shield of silver with a rim of gold and a boss of gold, and in his hand a sharp-pointed spear covered with rings of gold from heel to socket. He had fair yellow hair coming over his forehead, bound with a golden band to keep it from loosening.

When he came near them he got down from his horse and sat on the bank, and this is what he said:

"It is here Etain is today, at the Mound of Fair Women. It is among little children her life is, on the strand of Inver Cechmaine.

"It is she healed the eye of the king from the well of Loch da Lig; it is she was swallowed in a heavy drink by the wife of Etar.

"Many great battles will happen for your sake to Echaid of Midhe; destruction will fall upon the Sidhe, and war on thousands of men."

When he had said that, he vanished, and nobody knew where he went. And they did not know that the man who had come to them was Midhir of Bri Leith.

He had waited all that time. He had found her.

When Etain was grown into a beautiful young woman, she was seen by Eochaid Feidlech, High King of Ireland. This is how it happened.

He was crossing the fair green of Bri Leith once, and he saw a woman beside a well. She had a bright comb of gold and silver, and she was washing in a silver basin with four golden birds on it and little bright purple stones set in its rim. She wore a beautiful purple cloak with silver fringes, and a gold brooch, and under it a dress of green silk with a long hood, embroidered in red gold, and wonderful clasps of gold and silver on her breast and at her shoulder. The sunlight was falling on her, so that the gold and the green silk shone out. She had two plaits of hair, with four locks in each plait and a bead at the point of every lock, and the colour of her hair was like yellow flags in summer, or like red gold after it has been rubbed.

There she was, letting down her hair to wash it, with her arms out through the sleeve-holes of her shift. Her soft hands were as white as the snow of a single night. Her eyes were as blue as any blue flower, and her lips as red as rowan-berries, and her body as white as the foam of a wave. There was the bright light of the moon in her face, and the highness of pride in her eyebrows, a dimple of delight in each of her cheeks, the light of wooing in her eyes. And when she walked, she walked with a step as steady and even as a queen's.

Eochaid sent his people to bring her to him, and asked her name. She told him her name was Etain, daughter of Etar, King of the Riders of the Sidhe. Eochaid gave her his love, and paid the bride-price, and brought her home to Teamhair as his wife, and there was a great welcome for her there.

A while after that there was a great feast at Teamhair. All the chief men of Ireland came to it, and it lasted from the fortnight before Samhain to the fortnight after.

King Eochaid's brother Ailell came to that feast — he who was afterwards called Ailell Anglonach, Ailell of the Only Fault. When he saw his brother's wife Etain he fell in love

with her that moment, and all through the feast he could not be content unless he was looking at her.

A woman noticed it: the daughter of Luchta Lamdearg, Luchta of the Red Hand. "What far thing are you looking at, Ailell?" she said. "It's my opinion that looking the way you're looking is a sign of love."

Ailell checked himself, and did not look towards Etain again.

But when the feast was over and the gathering broken up, a great desire and envy came on Ailell, so that he fell sick, and they carried him to a house in Teffia. He stayed there a whole year, wasting away, and he told no one the cause of his sickness.

At the end of the year Eochaid came to visit his brother. He passed his hand over his breast, and Ailell groaned.

"How are you?" said Eochaid. "Are you getting any easier? You mustn't let this illness come to a bad end."

"By my word," said Ailell, "I'm not easier. I'm worse and worse every day and every night."

"What is it ails you? What is it that's coming against you?"

"By my word, I can't tell you that."

"I'll bring someone here who will know the cause of your sickness," said the king.

He sent Fachtna, his own physician, to Ailell. Fachtna passed his hand over Ailell's heart, and at that Ailell groaned again.

"This sickness won't be your death," said Fachtna. "And I know well where it comes from. It's either from the pains of jealousy, or from love you have given and found no way out of."

But Ailell was ashamed, and would not admit to the physician that he was right. So Fachtna went away and left him.

As for King Eochaid, he went off to visit all the provinces of Ireland under his kingship, and left Etain behind.

"Good Etain," he said, "take tender care of Ailell as long as he's living. And if he should die on us, make a sodded grave for him, and raise a pillar-stone over it, and write his name on it in Ogham."

And with that he went away on his journey.

One day Etain went into the house where Ailell lay in his sickness, and they talked together, and then she made a little song for him. This is what she said:

"What is it ails you, young man? It is a long time you are wasted with this sickness, and it is not the hardness of the weather that has stopped your light footstep."

Ailell answered her the same way. "I have good cause for my hurt. The music of my own harp doesn't please me. There's no food that's pleasant to me, and so I'm wasted away."

"Tell me what it is that ails you," said Etain, "for I'm a woman who is wise. Tell me if there's anything that would cure you, so that I can help you to it."

"O kind, beautiful woman," said Ailell, "it isn't good to tell a secret to a woman. But sometimes it may be known through the eyes."

"Though it's bad to tell a secret," said Etain, "it ought to be told now. How else can help be given to you?"

"My blessing on you, fair-haired Etain," said Ailell. "I'm not fit to be spoken to. My wits have been no help to me. My body is a rebel against me. All Ireland knows, O king's wife, there's sickness in my head and in my body."

"If there's a woman among the fair-faced women of Ireland tormenting you like this," said Etain, "she must come to you here, if it pleases you. I'll woo her for you myself."

"Woman," said Ailell, "it would be easy for you yourself to take my sickness from me. My desire is a desire as long as a year. But it's love given to an echo, grief spent on a wave, a lonely fight with a shadow. That is what my love and my desire have been to me."

Then Etain knew what the sickness was that was on him, and it was a heavy trouble to her.

But she came to him every day to tend him, and to make his food ready, and to pour water over his hands. She did everything she could for him, for it grieved her that he should wither away and be lost for her sake.

At last one day she said to him, "Get up, Ailell, son of a king, man of high deeds, and I'll do your healing."

He put his arms around her, and she kissed him.

"Come tomorrow morning at the break of day to the house outside the dun," she said, "and I'll give you all your desire."

That night Ailell lay without sleeping until the morning was nearly there. And at the very moment he should have got up to go to her, sleep settled down on him, and he slept on until the full light of day.

Etain went to the house outside the dun. She had not been there long when she saw a man coming towards her who looked like Ailell, sick and tired and worn. But when he came near and she looked at him closely, she saw it was not Ailell at all. Then he went away, and after she had waited a while she went back into the dun herself.

It was then that Ailell woke. When he knew the morning had gone by, he would sooner have had death than life, and he fretted terribly. Etain came in, and he told her what had happened.

"Come tomorrow to the same place," she said.

But the same thing happened the next day.

And when it happened on the third day, and the same man came to meet her, Etain said to him: "It isn't you at all I come here to meet. Why is it you come to meet me? And as for the one I did come to meet, it isn't for gain or out of lightness I told him to come to me, but to heal him of the sickness he's lying under for my sake."

"It would be more fitting for you to come to meet me than anyone else," said the man. "In the time long ago, I was your first husband, and your first man."

"What are you saying?" she said. "Who are you?"

"That's easy to tell," he said. "I am Midhir of Bri Leith."

"And what parted us, if I was your wife?"

"It was Fuamach's sharp jealousy, and the spells of Bresal Etarlaim the Druid, that parted us. Will you come away with me now?"

"It's not for a man whose kindred is unknown," said Etain, "that I'll give up the High King of Ireland."

She did not remember him. Think of that. He remembered everything, and she remembered nothing, and he had to stand there and be a stranger to her.

"Surely it was I myself put that great desire for you on Ailell," said Midhir. "And it was I kept him from going to meet you, so that you would keep your good name."

When she went back to Ailell's house, she found his sickness gone from him, and his desire with it. She told him everything that had happened.

"It has turned out well for us both," said Ailell. "I'm well of my sickness, and your good name is none the less."

"We give thanks to our gods for that," said Etain. "We are well pleased to have it so."

Just then Eochaid came back from his journey. They told him the whole story, and he was thankful to his wife for the kindness she had shown Ailell.

A good while after that there was a great fair held at Teamhair, and Etain was out on the green watching the games and the races. She saw a rider coming towards her, and nobody could see him but herself. When he came near, she saw he looked the same as the man who had come and spoken to her and her young girls when they were bathing in the sea at Inver Cechmaine. When he came up to her he began to sing words to her that nobody could hear but her. This is what he said:

"O beautiful woman, will you come with me to the wonderful country that is mine? It is pleasant to look at the people there, beautiful people without any blemish. Their hair is the

colour of the flag-flower, their fair bodies are as white as snow, the colour of the foxglove is on every cheek. The young never grow old there. The fields and the flowers are as pleasant to look at as the blackbird's eggs. Warm, sweet streams of mead and of wine flow through that country. There is no care and no sorrow on anyone. We see others, but we ourselves are not seen.

"Though the plains of Ireland are beautiful, you would think little of them after our great plain. Though the ale of Ireland is heady, the ale of the great country is headier. O beautiful woman, if you come to my proud people, it is the flesh of pigs newly killed I will give you for food; it is ale and new milk I will give you to drink; it is feasting you will have with me there; it is a crown of gold you will have upon your hair, O beautiful woman!

"And will you come there with me, Etain?"

Etain said she would not leave Eochaid the High King.

"Will you come," said Midhir, "if Eochaid gives you leave?"

"I will," said Etain.

One day after that, Eochaid the High King was looking out from his palace at Teamhair, and he saw a strange man coming across the plain. He had yellow hair, and eyes blue and shining like the flame of a candle, and a purple dress, and in his hand a five-pronged spear and a shield with gold knobs on it.

He came up to the king, and the king bade him welcome. "Who are you?" he said. "And what have you come for? You're a stranger to me."

"If I'm a stranger to you, you're no stranger to me," said the man. "I've known you a long time."

"What is your name?"

"Nothing very great," he said. "I'm called Midhir of Bri Leith."

"What brings you here?"

"I've come to play a game of chess with you."

"Are you a good player?" said the king.

"A trial will tell you that," said Midhir.

"The chessboard is in the queen's house," said Eochaid, "and she's asleep just now."

"No matter," said Midhir. "I have a chessboard with me as good as your own."

He brought out his chessboard. It was made of silver, with precious stones shining in every corner. Then he brought out the chessmen, made of gold, from a bag woven of shining gold threads.

"Let's play now," said Midhir.

"I won't play without a stake," said the king.

"What stake shall we play for?"

"We can settle that after the game," said the king.

They played, and Midhir was beaten, and the king asked for fifty brown horses. They played a second time, and Midhir was beaten again. This time the king gave him four hard things to do: to make a road over Moin Lamraide, and to clear Midhe of stones, and to cover the district of Tethra with rushes, and the district of Darbrech with trees.

You should be suspicious by now of a stranger who loses at chess. Eochaid was not.

So Midhir brought his people out of Bri Leith to do those things, and it was hard work they had doing them. Eochaid used to go out and watch them, and he noticed that when the men of the Sidhe yoked their oxen, they yoked them by the neck and the shoulder, not by the forehead and the head. After Eochaid taught his own people to yoke them that way, he was given the name Eochaid Airem — Eochaid of the Plough.

When it was all done, Midhir came to Eochaid again, looking thin and wasted enough from the hard work he had been doing, and asked him to play a third game. Eochaid agreed, and it was settled as before: the winner would name the stake.

Midhir won that time. When the king asked him what he wanted, he said, "It's Etain, your wife, I want."

"I won't give her to you," said the king.

"Then all I'll ask," said Midhir, "is to put my arms around her and kiss her once."

"You may do that," said the king, "if you'll wait until the end of a month."

Midhir agreed, and went away for that time.

At the end of the month he came back and stood in the great hall at Teamhair, and nobody had ever seen him look so comely as he looked that night. Eochaid had gathered all his best fighting men in the hall, and when he saw Midhir come in he shut all the doors of the palace, for fear Midhir would try to carry Etain off by force.

"I've come to be paid what's owed to me," said Midhir.

"I haven't been thinking about it up to now," said Eochaid, and there was anger on him.

"You promised me Etain, your wife," said Midhir.

The red of shame came into Etain's face when she heard that.

"Let there be no shame on you, Etain," said Midhir. "For a whole year I've been asking for your love, and offered you every kind of treasure and riches, and you refused to come to me until your husband gave you leave."

"It's true I said that," said Etain. "I'll go, if Eochaid gives me up to you."

"I won't give you up," said Eochaid. "I'll let him do no more than put his arms round you, here in this place, as was promised him."

"I'll do that," said Midhir.

He took his sword in his left hand, and he took Etain in his right arm, and he kissed her.

All the armed men in the house rushed at him then. But he rose up through the roof, taking Etain with him. And when they rushed out of the house to follow, all they could see was

two swans, high up in the air, linked together by a chain of gold.

Eochaid was very angry. He went and searched all through Ireland, but there was no news of them to be had anywhere, for they were in the houses of the Sidhe.

They went first to the Brugh of Angus on the Boinn. After they had stayed there a while they went on to a hill of the Sidhe in Connacht. There was a serving-maid with Etain at that time, Cruachan Croderg by name, and she said to Midhir, "Is this your own place we're in?"

"It isn't," said Midhir. "My own place is nearer the rising of the sun."

She was not well pleased to stay there when she heard that, and to quiet her Midhir said, "Your own name will be put on this place from now on." And the hill has been called the Hill of Cruachan from that day.

Then they went to Bri Leith. Etain's daughter Esa came to them there, bringing a hundred of every kind of cattle with her, and Midhir fostered her for seven years.

All that time Eochaid the High King was searching for them.

At last Codal of the Withered Breast took four rods of yew and wrote Oghams on them, and through them and his enchantments he found out that Etain was with Midhir in Bri Leith.

So Eochaid went there and attacked the place. For nine years he besieged it, and Midhir kept driving him away. Then Eochaid's people began digging into the hill. When they were getting near to where Etain was, Midhir sent out three times twenty beautiful women, every one of them with the appearance of Etain, and told the king to choose her out from among them.

The first one he chose was his own daughter, Esa.

But then Etain called out to him, and he knew her, and brought her home to Teamhair.

Eochaid gave his daughter Esa her choice of a place for herself. She chose it, and built a rath there, and it got the name of Rath Esa. From it she could see three notable places: the Hill of the Sidhe in Broga, and the Hill of the Hostages in Teamhair, and Dun Crimthain on Beinn Edair.

But Midhir and his people were very angry that their hill had been attacked and dug into. It was in revenge for that insult that they brought Conaire, High King of Ireland — the grandson of Eochaid and of Etain — to his death, afterwards, at Da Derga's Inn.

The gods do not forget a hole dug in their hill. They can wait a very long time.

CHAPTER VIII

Manannan



As for Manannan the Proud, son of Lir: when he had made places for the rest of the Tuatha de Danaan to live in, he went away out of Ireland himself.

Some said he was dead. They said he got his death in battle at the hands of Uillenn Faebarderg, Uillenn of the Red Edge. They said the battle was fought at Magh Cuilenn, and that Manannan was buried standing on his feet, and that no sooner was he buried than a great lake burst up under his feet, in a place that had been a red bog until then. The lake got the name of Loch Orbson, from one of Manannan's names. And they said that red Badb was glad at that battle, and many women were sorry.

But he had many places to live, and he was often heard of in Ireland afterwards. Whatever the story says, Manannan was never a god who stayed dead.

It was he who sent a messenger to Etain, the mother of Conaire the High King, when she was hidden in the cowherd's house. It was he who brought up Deirdre's children in Emhain of the Apple Trees, and it was said of that place, "a house of peace is the hill of the Sidhe of Emhain." It was he who taught Diarmuid of the Fianna the use of weapons. It was he who taught Cuchulain the use of the Gae Bulg.

Some say he was Deirdre's father. Some say it was he who brought Conchubar, King of Ulster, to the place where she was hidden, running in the shape of a hare in front of the hounds of the men of Ulster to lead them there.

And this is what they say. When Conchubar had brought the sons of Usnach to Emain Macha, and could not get at them to kill them because of their bravery, it was to Manannan he went for help.

Manannan said he would give him none. He had told Conchubar, at the time he took Deirdre, that she would be the cause of the breaking of his kingdom, and Conchubar had taken her anyway.

But Conchubar asked him to put blindness on the sons of Usnach for a while, or else the whole army would be destroyed by their blows. After a time Manannan consented to that. When the sons of Usnach came out again against the army of Ulster, the blindness came on them, and they struck at one another, not seeing who was near them, and they fell by one another's hands.

But more people say that Manannan had no hand in it, and that it was Cathbad the Druid who put a sea about them and brought them to their death by his enchantments.

Some say Culain the Smith, who gave his name afterwards to Cuchulain, was Manannan himself, for Manannan had many shapes.

Anyway, before Culain came to Ulster he lived in the Island of Falga, which was one of Manannan's places. Once, before Conchubar came into his kingdom, he went to ask a Druid for advice, and the Druid told him to go to the Island of Falga and ask the smith he would find there, Culain, to make weapons for him. Conchubar did that, and the smith promised to make him a sword and a spear and a shield.

While he was at work on them, Conchubar went out early one morning to walk on the strand, and there he saw a sea-woman asleep on the shore. He put bonds on her while she slept, so that she could not escape.

When she woke and saw what had happened, she asked him to set her free.

"I am Tiabhal," she said, "one of the queens of the sea. Tell Culain, who's making your shield, to put my likeness on it and my name around it. Whenever you go into battle with that shield, the strength of your enemies will lessen, and your own strength and the strength of your people will increase."

So Conchubar let her go, and told the smith to do as she had said. And when he went back to Ireland he won the victory wherever he carried that shield.

Then he sent for Culain and offered him a place on the plains of Muirthemne. And whether he was Manannan or not, it is likely he gave Cuchulain good teaching, in the time the boy stayed with him there after killing his great dog.

Manannan had good hounds once. They went hunting after a pig that was destroying the whole country and making a desert of it. They followed it until they came to a lake, and there it turned on them. Not one hound escaped alive. They were all drowned, or maimed. The pig made for an island, that got the name of Muc-inis, the Pig's Island, afterwards. And the lake got the name of Loch Conn, the Lake of the Hounds.

It was through Manannan that the wave of Tuaig, one of the three great waves of Ireland, got its name. This is how that happened.

There was a young girl called Tuag, a fosterling of Conaire the High King. She was reared at Teamhair, and a great company of the daughters of the kings of Ireland were set around her to guard her, so that she would be kept for a king's asking.

But Manannan sent Fer Ferdiad of the Tuatha de Danaan — a pupil of his own, and a Druid — in the shape of a woman of Manannan's household. Fer Ferdiad went to where Tuag was, and sang a sleep-spell over her, and carried her away to Inver Glas. There he laid her down while he went looking for a boat, so that he could carry her away in her sleep to the Land of the Ever-Living Women.

But a wave of the flood-tide came over the girl, and she was drowned.

Manannan killed Fer Ferdiad in his anger. It did not bring back the girl. It never does.

Once Manannan's cows came up out of the sea at Baile Cronin: three of them, a red, and a white, and a black. The people there watched them stand on the strand for a while, as if they were thinking. Then they all walked up together, side by side, away from the strand.

There were no roads in Ireland at that time. The people wondered greatly when they saw a good wide road lying ready in front of the three cows to walk on.

When they were about a mile from the sea, the cows parted. The white cow went north-west, towards Luimnech. The red cow went south-west, and on round the coast of Ireland. The black cow went north-east, towards Lis Mor, in the district of Portlairge. A road opened in front of each of them, and the roads can be seen to this day.

Some say it was Manannan who came to Finn and the Fianna in the shape of the Gilla Decair, the Bad Servant, and carried them off to Land-under-Wave. Anyway, he often went hunting with them on Cnoc Aine, and sometimes he came to their help.

He liked people. That was the strange thing about him. Of all the gods, he liked people best, and he liked to play with them.

Manannan At Play



A long time after that, Manannan went playing tricks through Ireland again. That was the time he got the name of O'Donnell's Kern.

This is how it happened. Aodh Dubh O'Donnell was holding a feast at Bel-atha Senaig, and his people were boasting of the goodness of his house and of his musicians.

While they were talking, they saw a clown coming towards them. He wore old striped clothes. Puddle-water squelched in his shoes. His sword stuck out naked behind him. His ears poked out through the old cloak he had over his head. In his hand he carried three spears of holly-wood, scorched and blackened.

He wished O'Donnell good health, and O'Donnell wished him the same, and asked where he had come from.

"This is where I've been," he said. "I slept last night at Dun Monaidhe, with the King of Alban. I'm a day in Ile, a day in Cionn-tire, a day in Rachlainn, a day in the Watchman's Seat on Slieve Fuad. A pleasant, rambling, wandering man I am. And it's with you I am now, O'Donnell."

"Bring the gate-keeper to me," said O'Donnell.

When the gate-keeper came, O'Donnell asked him if it was he who had let this man in. The gate-keeper said he had not, and had never seen him before.

"Let him off, O'Donnell," said the stranger. "It was as easy for me to come in as it will be for me to go out again."

They all wondered at that: that any man could come into the house without passing the gate.

Then the musicians began to play. All the best musicians of the country were there, and they played very sweet tunes on their harps.

"By my word, O'Donnell," the stranger called out, "there was never a noise of hammers beating iron in any bad place as bad to listen to as this noise your people are making."

With that he took a harp himself, and he made music that would put women in their pains, and wounded men after a battle, into a sweet sleep.

"Since I first heard talk of the music of the Sidhe that's played in the hills and under the earth below us," said O'Donnell, "I never heard better music than yours. You're a very sweet player."

"One day I'm sweet," said the clown, "another day I'm sour."

O'Donnell told his people to bring him up to sit near himself.

"I've no mind to do that," said the clown. "I'd sooner be as I am, an ugly clown making sport for high-up people."

Then O'Donnell sent him down clothes, a hat and a striped shirt and a coat. He would not have them. "I've no mind," he said, "to let high-up people be boasting that they gave them to me."

By now they were afraid he might leave them. They set twenty armed horsemen and twenty men on foot to keep him from leaving the house, and as many again outside at the gate, for they knew he was not a man of this world.

"What are these men for?" said he.

"They're to keep you here," said O'Donnell.

"By my word, it's not with you I'll be eating my supper tomorrow," he said, "but at Cnoc Aine, where Seaghan, Son of the Earl, is, in Desmumain."

"If I find you giving one stir out of yourself between this and morning," said O'Donnell, "I'll knock you into a round lump there on the ground."

At that the stranger took up the harp again, and made the same sweet music as before. While they were all listening to him, he called out to the men outside: "Here I come! Watch me well now, or you'll lose me."

When the men watching the gate heard that, they raised their axes to strike at him. But in their haste they struck at one another instead, until they were all lying stretched in their blood.

Then the clown said to the gate-keeper: "You ask O'Donnell for twenty cows and a hundred of free land, as a fee for bringing his people back to life. And take this herb, and rub it in the mouth of each man of them, and he'll get up whole and well again."

The gate-keeper did that. He got the cows and the land from O'Donnell, and he brought all the people back to life.

Seaghan, Son of the Earl, was holding a gathering on the green in front of his dun at that time, and he saw the same man coming towards him, dressed the same way, and the water squelching in his shoes. When Seaghan asked who he was, he gave himself the name of a very learned man, Duartane O'Duartane. He said he had come by Ess Ruadh, and by Ceiscorainn, and from there to Corrslieve, and to Magh Lorg of the Dagda, and into the district of Hy'Conaill Gabhra — "until I came to you," he said, "by Cruachan of Magh Ai."

So they brought him into the house, and gave him wine to drink and water to wash his feet, and he slept until sunrise the next day.

Then Seaghan, Son of the Earl, came to see him. "That was a long sleep you had," he said, "and no wonder, after so long a journey yesterday. But I've often heard of your learning in books and of your skill on the harp, and I'd like to hear you this morning."

"I'm good at those arts indeed," said the stranger.

They brought him a book, and he could not read a word of it. Then they brought him a harp, and he could not play a single tune.

"It's likely your reading and your music have gone from you," said Seaghan. And he made a little verse mocking him, saying it was a strange thing that Duartane O'Duartane, with such a great name, could not read a line of a book, or even remember one.

When the stranger heard himself being mocked, he took up the book and read it from the top to the bottom of the page, very well, in a sweet-sounding voice. Then he took the harp

and played and sang, the same as he had done in O'Donnell's house the day before.

"You're a very sweet man of learning," said Seaghan.

"One day I'm sweet," said the stranger, "another day I'm sour."

They walked out together on Cnoc Aine. While they were talking there, all in a minute the stranger was gone, and Seaghan, Son of the Earl, could not see where he had gone.

After that he went on, and reached Sligach just as O'Conchubar was setting out with the men of Connacht to avenge the Connacht hag's basket on the hag of Munster. This time he called himself the Gilla Decair, the Bad Servant. He joined the men of Connacht, and they went over the Sionnan westward into Munster. There they hunted and drove every creature that could be made to travel — cattle and horses and flocks — into one place, until they got the hornless bull of the Munster hag and her two speckled cows, and O'Conchubar carried them off to give to the Connacht hag in satisfaction for her basket.

The men of Munster attacked them on the way back. The Gilla Decair asked O'Conchubar whether he would sooner have the cows driven on, or the Munster men held back. O'Conchubar said he would sooner have the Munster men held back. So the Gilla Decair turned on them, and with his bow and twenty-four arrows he kept them off until O'Conchubar and his people were safe out of reach, in Connacht.

But then he took offence, because when they came to O'Conchubar's house O'Conchubar took the first drink himself instead of giving it to him, who had done so much. He took his leave and left them that very moment.

Gods notice who is handed the first cup. They always notice.

After that he went to where Tadg O'Cealaigh was, wearing his old striped clothes and his old shoes as before. When they asked him what art he had, he said, "I'm good at tricks. If you'll give me five marks, I'll show you a trick."

"I'll give that," said Tadg.

The stranger put three rushes on the palm of his hand. "I'll blow away the middle rush now," he said, "and the other two will stay where they are."

They told him to do it. He put the tips of two of his fingers on the two outside rushes, and blew the middle one away.

"There's a trick for you now, Tadg O'Cealaigh," he said.

"By my word, that's not a bad trick," said O'Cealaigh.

But one of O'Cealaigh's men said: "No good luck to the one who did it. Give me half of that money, Tadg, and I'll do the same trick for you myself."

"I'll give you half of what I got, if you'll do it," said the stranger.

So the other man put the rushes on his hand. But when he tried the trick, his two fingertips went through the palm of his hand.

"Ob-ob-ob!" said the stranger. "That's not the way I did the trick. But since you've lost the money, I'll heal you again."

"I could do another trick for you," he said. "I could wag the ear on one side of my head and the ear on the other side would stay still."

"Do it, then," said O'Cealaigh.

So the man of tricks took hold of one of his ears and wagged it up and down.

"That's a good trick indeed," said O'Cealaigh.

"I'll show you another one now," he said.

He took a thread of silk out of his bag and threw it up into the air, so that it caught fast to a cloud. Then he took a hare out of the same bag, and it ran up the thread. Then he took out a little dog and set it after the hare, and it followed, yelping on its track. Then he brought out a little serving-boy and told him to follow the dog and the hare up the thread. Then out of another bag he brought a beautiful, well-dressed young woman, and told her to follow the hound and the boy, and to take care the hare was not torn by the dog.

She went up quickly after them. It was a delight to Tadg O'Cealaigh to watch them, and to listen to the sound of the hunt going on in the air.

Then it was quiet for a long time.

"I'm afraid there's some bad work going on up there," said the man of tricks.

"What's that?" said O'Cealaigh.

"I'm thinking the hound might be eating the hare, and the serving-boy courting the girl."

"That's likely enough," said O'Cealaigh.

The stranger drew in the thread. And this is what he found: the boy making love to the girl, and the hound chewing the bones of the hare.

The man of tricks was very angry when he saw that. He took his sword and struck the boy's head off.

"I don't like a thing of that sort done in my presence," said Tadhg O'Cealaigh.

"If it didn't please you, I can set everything right again," said the stranger. He took up the head and threw it at the body, and it joined on, and the young man stood up — but his face was turned backwards.

"It would be better for him to be dead than living like that," said O'Cealaigh.

When the man of tricks heard that, he took hold of the boy and twisted his head straight, and he was as well as before.

And with that the man of tricks vanished, and nobody saw where he went.

That is how Manannan used to go round Ireland, doing tricks and wonders. Nobody could keep him in any place. If he was hanged on a gallows, he would be found safe in the house afterwards, and some other man on the gallows in his place. But he did no harm, and anyone who was put to death by him he brought back to life again with a herb out of his bag.

All the food he ever ate was a vessel of sour milk and a few crab-apples. And there was never any music sweeter than the music he played.

One day sweet, another day sour. It is as good a description of the sea as any.

His Call To Bran



Some people went to Manannan's country beyond the sea, and gave an account of it afterwards.

Bran, son of Febal, was out by himself one time near his dun, and he heard music behind him. It stayed behind him wherever he went, and at last he fell asleep with the sweetness of it. When he woke, there was a branch of silver lying beside him. It had white blossoms on it, and the whiteness of the silver was the same as the whiteness of the blossoms.

He carried the branch into the royal house. When all his people were gathered with him, they saw a woman in strange clothing standing in the house.

She began to make a song for Bran, and all the people watched her and listened to her. This is what she said:

"I bring a branch of the apple-tree from Emhain, from the far island around which are the shining horses of the Son of Lir. A delight of the eyes is the plain where the hosts hold their games: curragh racing against chariot in the White Silver Plain to the south.

"There are feet of white bronze under it, shining through life and time; a comely level land through the length of the world's age, and many blossoms falling on it.

"There is an old tree there with blossoms, and birds calling from among them. Every colour is shining there; delight is common, and music, in the Gentle-Voiced Plain, in the Silver Cloud Plain to the south.

"Keening is not used there, or treachery, in the tilled, familiar land. There is nothing hard or rough, but sweet music striking on the ear.

"To be without grief, without sorrow, without death, without any sickness, without weakness: that is the sign of Emhain. It is no common wonder.

"There is nothing to liken its mists to. The sea washes the wave against the land. Brightness falls from its hair.

"There are riches, there are treasures of every colour in the Gentle Land, the Bountiful Land. Sweet music to listen to; the best of wine to drink.

"Golden chariots on the Plain of the Sea, rising up to the sun with the tide; silver chariots and bronze chariots on the Plain of Sports.

"Gold-yellow horses on the strand, and crimson horses, and others with wool on their backs, blue like the colour of the sky.

"It is a day of lasting weather; silver is dropping on the land; a pure white cliff on the edge of the sea, getting its warmth from the sun.

"The host races over the Plain of Sports; beautiful, and not weak, is their game. Death will not come to them, nor the ebbing of the tide, in the Many-Coloured Land.

"There will come at sunrise a fair man, lighting up the level lands. He rides upon the plain that is beaten by the waves; he stirs the sea until it is like blood.

"An army will come over the clear sea, rowing to the stone that is in sight, that a hundred sounds of music come from.

"It sings a song to the army; it is not sad through the length of time; it increases music with hundreds singing together. They do not look for death, or for the ebb-tide.

"There are three times fifty far islands in the ocean to the west of us, and every one of them twice or three times the size of Ireland.

"It is not to all of you I am speaking, though I have made all these wonders known. Let Bran listen, out of the crowd of the world, to all the wisdom that has been told him.

"Do not fall upon a bed of sloth. Do not be overcome by drunkenness. Set out on your voyage over the clear sea, and you may chance to come to the Land of Women."

With that the woman left them, and they did not know where she went. She took her branch with her. It leapt out of Bran's hand into hers, and he did not have the strength to hold it.

The next day Bran set out upon the sea, with three companies of nine along with him. One of his foster-brothers and comrades was set over each company of nine.

When they had rowed for two days and two nights, they saw a man coming towards them over the sea in a chariot. The man made himself known to them. He said he was Manannan, son of Lir.

Then Manannan spoke to Bran in a song. This is what he said:

"This is what Bran thinks: he is going in his curragh over the wonderful, beautiful clear sea. But to me, from far off in my chariot, it is a flowery plain he is riding on.

"What is a clear sea to the good boat Bran is in, is a happy plain with many flowers to me in my two-wheeled chariot.

"This is what Bran sees: many waves beating across the clear sea. This is what I myself see: red flowers without any fault.

"The sea-horses are bright in summertime, as far as Bran's eyes can reach. There is a wood of beautiful acorns under the head of your little boat.

"A wood with blossom and with fruit, that has the smell of wine; a wood without fault, without withering, with leaves the colour of gold.

"Let Bran row on steadily. It is not far to the Land of Women. Before the setting of the sun you will reach Emhain, of many-coloured hospitality."

Think about that. The same place. To Bran it was the sea, and to Manannan it was a meadow. Neither of them was wrong.

Bran went on from him, and after a while he saw an island. He rowed around it. There was a crowd of people on it, staring at them and laughing. They were all looking at Bran and at his people, but they would not stop to talk to them. They only went on letting out gusts of laughter.

Bran put one of his men ashore on the island. The man joined the others, and began to stare the same way as the people of the island. Bran went on rowing round the island, and

every time they passed their own man his comrades called to him, but he would not answer. He only stared and wondered at them.

So they went away and left him there, on that island. It is called the Island of Joy.

It was not long after that they reached the Land of Women. They saw the chief of the women at the landing-place, and this is what she said: "Come here to land, Bran, son of Febal. Your coming is welcome."

But Bran did not dare to go ashore.

Then the woman threw a ball of thread straight at him. He caught it in his hand, and it stuck fast to his palm. The woman kept the other end of the thread in her own hand, and she pulled the curragh in to the landing-place.

They went into a grand house where there was a bed for every couple: three times nine beds. The food that was put on every dish never came to an end. They had every kind of food and drink they wished for.

It seemed to them that they were only a year there.

Then the longing for home took hold of one of them, Nechtan, son of Collbrain, and his kinsmen begged and prayed Bran to go back with him to Ireland. The woman said they would be sorry if they went. In spite of that, in the end, they set out. She told them not to touch the land when they came to Ireland. And she told them to call at the Island of Joy on the way, and bring with them the man they had left there.

So they went on towards Ireland, until they came to a place called Srub Bruin. There were people on the strand, and they asked who it was coming over the sea.

"I am Bran, son of Febal," said Bran.

"We know of no such man," the people said. "Though the voyage of Bran is in our very old stories."

Then Nechtan, son of Collbrain, leapt out of the curragh. No sooner did he touch the shore of Ireland than he was a heap of ashes, as if he had been lying in the earth for hundreds of

years.

Then Bran told the people the whole story of his wanderings, from the beginning. And after that he said farewell to them.

Where he went after that is not known. He could not land. He could not go back. The sea was all there was left for him, and to him it was only ever the sea.

His Three Calls To Cormac



Another who went to Manannan's country was Cormac, grandson of Conn, King of Teamhair. This is how it happened.

He was by himself at Teamhair one time, and he saw an armed man coming towards him: quiet, with high looks, and grey-haired. He wore a shirt ribbed with gold thread next to his skin, and broad shoes of white bronze between his feet and the ground. On his shoulder he carried a shining branch with nine apples of red gold on it.

The sound of that branch was a delight. No one on earth would remember any want, or trouble, or tiredness, when that branch was shaken for him. Whatever trouble was on him, he would forget it at the sound.

Cormac and the armed man greeted each other, and Cormac asked where he came from.

"I come from a country where there is nothing but truth," the man said, "and where there is no age, nor withering, nor heaviness, nor sadness, nor jealousy, nor envy, nor pride."

"It isn't like that with us," said Cormac. "I'd be well pleased to have your friendship."

"I'm well pleased to give it," said the stranger.

"Give me your branch along with it," said Cormac.

"I'll give it," said the stranger, "if you'll give me the three gifts I ask in return."

"I'll give them to you indeed," said Cormac.

This is always how it starts. Somebody agrees to give three things before he knows what they are.

The strange man left the branch and went away, and Cormac did not know where he had gone.

Cormac went back into the royal house, and all the people wondered when they saw the branch. He shook it at them, and it put them all to sleep, from that hour of that day to the same hour of the next.

At the end of a year the strange man came back and asked for the first of his three requests.

"You'll get it," said Cormac.

"Then I'll take your daughter, Aille, today," said the stranger.

He took the girl away with him. The women of Ireland gave three loud cries after the king's daughter. But Cormac shook the branch at them until it put sorrow away from them, and put them all to sleep.

A month from that day the stranger came again, and this time he took Cormac's son, Carpre Lifecar, away with him. There was crying and lamenting without end in Teamhair after the boy. That night no one ate or slept, and they were all in grief and very downhearted. But when Cormac shook the branch, their sorrow went from them.

Then the stranger came the third time, and Cormac asked him what he wanted.

"It's your wife, Ethne, I'm asking for this time," he said.

And he went away, taking Ethne the queen with him.

Cormac would not bear that. He went after them, and all his people followed him. But in the middle of the Plain of the Wall a thick mist came down on them. When it lifted, Cormac found himself alone on a great plain.

There was a great dun in the middle of the plain, with a wall of bronze around it. Inside the dun was a house of white silver, half thatched with the white wings of birds. A great troop of the Riders of the Sidhe were all about the house, with their arms full of white birds' wings for thatching. But as soon as they put the thatch on, a blast of wind came and carried it away again.

Then he saw a man kindling a fire. The man would throw a thick oak-tree onto it. By the time he came back with a second tree, the first was burned out.

"I'll look at you no longer," said Cormac, "for there's nobody here to tell me your story. And I think I could find good sense in your meanings, if I understood them."

He went on to another dun, very large and royal, with another wall of bronze around it and four houses inside. He went in, and saw a great king's house with beams of bronze and walls of silver, thatched with the wings of white birds.

On the green he saw a shining well, with five streams flowing out of it, and the armies drinking the water in turn. The nine lasting purple hazels of Buan grew over it. They were dropping their nuts into the water, and the five salmon caught them and sent the husks floating down the streams. The sound of the flowing of those streams is sweeter than any music that men sing.

Then he went into the palace, and there he found a man and a woman waiting for him, very tall, in clothes of many colours. The man was beautiful in his shape, and his face was a wonder to look at. As for the young woman with him, she was the loveliest of all the women of the world. She had yellow hair and a golden helmet.

There was a bath there, with heated stones going in and out of the water of themselves, and Cormac bathed in it.

"Get up, man of the house," the woman said after that. "This is a comely traveller who's come to us. If you have one kind of food better than another, let it be brought in."

The man rose. "I have only seven pigs," he said. "But I could feed the whole world with them. The pig that's killed and eaten today, you'll find it alive again tomorrow."

Another man came into the house then, with an axe in his right hand, and a log in his left hand, and a pig behind him.

"It's time to make ready," said the man of the house. "We have a high guest with us today."

The man struck the pig and killed it, and cut the logs, and made a fire, and put the pig on it in a cauldron.

"It's time for you to turn it," said the master of the house after a while.

"There'd be no use doing that," said the man. "Never and never will the pig be boiled until a truth is told for every quarter of it."

That is the rule in that house. Remember it. Food there is cooked by truth, and by nothing else.

"Then you tell yours first," said the master of the house.

"One day," said the man, "I found another man's cows on my land, and I drove them into a cattle-pound. The owner of the cows followed me, and said he would give me a reward to let them go free. So I gave them back to him, and he gave me an axe. When a pig is to be killed, it's with that axe it's killed. And the log is cut with it, and there's enough wood to boil the pig, and enough for the palace besides. And that's not all: the log is found whole again in the morning. From that time to this, that's the way they are."

"That story is true indeed," said the man of the house.

They turned the pig in the cauldron, and one quarter of it was found to be cooked.

"Let's tell another true story," they said.

"I'll tell one," said the master of the house. "Ploughing time had come. When we had a mind to plough that field outside, this is how we found it: ploughed, and harrowed, and sown with wheat. When we had a mind to reap it, the wheat was found in the haggard, all in one thatched rick. We've been using it from that day to this, and it's no bigger and no smaller."

They turned the pig, and another quarter was found to be done.

"It's my turn now," said the woman. "I have seven cows and seven sheep. The milk of the seven cows would satisfy all the men of the world, if they were in the plain drinking it. It's enough for all the people of the Land of Promise. And it's from the wool of the seven sheep that all the clothes they wear are made."

At that story, the third quarter of the pig was boiled.

"If these stories are true," Cormac said to the man of the house, "you are Manannan, and this is Manannan's wife. For nobody on the whole ridge of the world owns these treasures but him. It was to the Land of Promise he went looking for that woman, and he got those seven cows with her."

They told Cormac it was his turn now. So Cormac told them how his wife and his son and his daughter had been taken away from him, and how he had followed them until he came to that place.

And with that the whole pig was boiled.

They cut it up, and Cormac's share was set in front of him.

"I've never yet eaten a meal," he said, "with only two people in my company."

The man of the house began to sing to him then, and sang him to sleep. And when he woke, he saw fifty armed men, and his son, and his wife, and his daughter with them.

There was great gladness and courage on him then, and ale and food were given out to them all.

A gold cup was put into the hand of the master of the house, and Cormac wondered at it, for the number of shapes on it and the strangeness of the work.

"There's a stranger thing about it yet," said the man. "Let three lying words be spoken under it, and it will break into three. Then let three true words be spoken under it, and it will be as good as before."

He said three lying words under it, and it broke into three pieces.

"It's best to speak truth under it now," he said, "and mend it. And I give you my word, Cormac, that until today neither your wife nor your daughter has seen the face of a man since they were taken from you out of Teamhair, and your son has never seen the face of a woman."

With that, the cup was whole again, that moment.

"Take your wife and your children away with you now," he said, "and this cup with them, so that you'll have it for judging between truth and untruth. And I'll leave the branch with you for music and delight. But on the day of your death they'll be taken from you again.

"And as for me," he said, "I am Manannan, son of Lir, King of the Land of Promise. I brought you here by enchantments, so that you'd be with me tonight in friendship.

"The Riders you saw thatching the house are the men of art, and the poets, and all who go looking for a fortune in Ireland, gathering cattle and riches. When they go out, everything they leave behind them in their houses goes to nothing, and so they go on for ever.

"The man you saw kindling the fire is a young lord who is more generous than he can afford. Everyone else is served while he's getting the feast ready, and everyone else profits by it.

"And the well you saw is the Well of Knowledge, and the streams are the five streams through which all knowledge goes. No one will have knowledge who doesn't drink a draught out of the well itself, or out of the streams. And the people of many arts are the ones who drink from them all."

In the morning, when Cormac got up, he found himself on the green of Teamhair, and his wife and his son and his daughter with him, and he had his branch and his cup.

It was given the name of Cormac's Cup, and it judged between truth and falsehood among the Gael.

But it did not stay in Ireland after the night of Cormac's death. Manannan had told him it would not. Manannan, in that house at least, told the truth.

Clodna's Wave



It was in the time of the Fianna of Ireland that Ciabhan of the Curling Hair, the King of Ulster's son, went to Manannan's country.

Ciabhan was the most beautiful of the young men of the world at that time. He was as far beyond all other kings' sons as the moon is beyond the stars. Finn liked him well. But the rest of the Fianna grew tired of him, because there was not a woman among their women, wed or unwed, who did not give him her love. In the end Finn had to send him away, for he was in dread of the men of the Fianna because of how great their jealousy was.

Being that beautiful is not only a gift. Sometimes it is an exile.

So Ciabhan went on until he came to the Strand of the Cairn, which is called now the Strand of the Strong Man, between Dun Sobairce and the sea. There he saw a curragh with a narrow stern of copper. Ciabhan got into it.

"Is it Ireland you have a mind to leave, Ciabhan?" his people said.

"It is indeed," he said. "In Ireland I get neither shelter nor protection."

He said goodbye to his people then, and left them very sorrowful behind him, for parting with him was like the parting of life from the body.

Ciabhan went on in the curragh, and great white shouting waves rose up around him, every one of them the size of a mountain. The beautiful speckled salmon that stay down in the sand and the shingle rose up to the sides of the curragh, until great dread came on Ciabhan.

"By my word," he said, "if I were on land I could make a better fight for myself."

He was in that danger until he saw a rider coming towards him on a dark grey horse with a golden bridle. The horse would go under the sea for the length of nine waves and rise up with the tenth, and there would be no wet on the rider at all.

"What reward would you give," said the rider, "to whoever would bring you out of this great danger?"

"Is there anything in my hand worth offering you?" said Ciabhan.

"There is," said the rider. "That you'd give your service to whoever gave you his help."

Ciabhan agreed to that, and put his hand into the rider's hand.

With that the rider drew him up onto the horse, and the curragh came along beside them until they reached the shore of Tir Tairngaire, the Land of Promise. They got off the horse there and came to Loch Luchra, the Lake of the Dwarfs, and to Manannan's city. A feast had been made ready there, and comely serving-boys were going round with smooth horns, and playing on sweet-sounding harps until the whole house was filled with music.

Then clowns came in, long-snouted, long-heeled, lean and bald and red, the ones who did tricks in Manannan's house. One of their tricks was this: a man of them would take nine straight willow rods and throw them up to the rafters of the house, and catch them again as they came down — standing on one leg the while, and with only one hand free. They thought nobody could do that trick but themselves, and they used to ask strangers to try it, so they could watch them fail.

So this night, when one of them had done the trick, he came up to Ciabhan — who was beyond all the Men of Dea and all the Sons of the Gael in the house, in shape, and in walk, and in name — and put the nine rods in his hand.

Ciabhan stood up and did the feat in front of them all, as if he had never learned to do anything else.

Now Gebann, who was a chief Druid in Manannan's country, had a daughter, Cliodna of the Fair Hair, and she had never given her love to any man. But when she saw Ciabhan she gave him her love, and she agreed to go away with him the next day.

They went down to the landing-place and got into a curragh, and went on until they came to Teite's Strand, in the southern part of Ireland. The strand got its name from Teite Brec,

Teite the Freckled, who went there once for a wave-game with three times fifty young girls, and they were all drowned in that place.

Ciabhan came ashore and went looking for deer, as was right, under the thick branches of the wood. He left the young girl in the boat on the strand.

But the people of Manannan's house came after them, with forty ships. And Iuchnu, who was in the curragh with Cliodna, did treachery. He played music to her until she lay down in the boat and fell asleep. And then a great wave came up on the strand and swept her away.

The wave got its name from Cliodna of the Fair Hair. It will be long remembered.

Ciabhan had given his service to whoever would help him. He never said what it cost him, coming back from the wood with a deer on his shoulders to an empty strand.

His Call To Connla



It was probably Manannan who sent his messenger for Connla of the Red Hair, the time Connla went away out of Ireland, for it was to Manannan's country that Connla was brought. This is how he got the call.

He was with his father Conn, King of Teamhair, on the Hill of Uisnach one day, and he saw a woman in wonderful clothing coming towards him.

"Where have you come from?" he asked her.

"I come from Tir-nam-Beo," she said, "the Land of the Ever-Living Ones, where no death comes. We have feasts that last for ever, and we do every kind thing without quarrelling. We are called the people of the Sidhe."

"Who are you talking to, boy?" said Conn. For nobody could see the strange woman but Connla.

"He's talking to a high woman that death and old age will never come to," she said. "I'm asking him to come to Magh Mell, the Pleasant Plain, where the triumphant king lives. There he'll be a king for ever, without sorrow or fret. Come with me, Connla of the Red Hair, of the fair freckled neck and the ruddy cheek. Come with me, and your body won't wither from its youth and its comeliness for ever."

They could all hear the woman's words then, though they could not see her.

"Help me, Coran," Conn said to his Druid, "you who sing the spells of the great arts. There's an attack made on me that's beyond my wisdom and beyond my power. I never knew so strong an attack since the first day I was a king. There's an unseen figure fighting with me. She's using her strength against me to take away my beautiful son. The call of a woman is taking him out of the hands of the king."

Then Coran the Druid began to sing spells against the woman of the Sidhe, so that nobody would hear her voice, and Connla could not see her any more. But as she was being driven

away by the Druid's spells, she threw an apple to Connla.

For a whole month after that, Connla ate and drank nothing but that apple, for he thought no other food or drink was worth having. And however much of it he ate, it grew no smaller, but stayed whole the whole time. And there was great trouble on Connla because of the woman he had seen.

At the end of the month Connla was at his father's side in Magh Archomnim, and he saw the same woman coming towards him. This is what she said:

"It's a high place indeed Connla has among dying people, with death ahead of him. But the Ever-Living Living Ones are asking you to take the rule over the people of Tethra. They look at you every day, in the gatherings of your country, among your dear friends."

When Conn the king heard her voice, he said to his people: "Call Coran the Druid to me. I hear the sound of that woman's voice again."

"O Conn, fighter of a hundred," she said, "the wonderful tribes of Traig Mor, the Great Strand, have little love and little respect for Druids. Where its law comes, it scatters the spells on their lips."

Then Conn looked at his son Connla to see what he would say.

"My own people are dearer to me than anything," said Connla. "And yet sorrow has taken hold of me because of this woman."

Then the woman spoke to him again. This is what she said:

"Come now into my shining ship, if you will come to the Plain of Victory. There is another country it would be no worse for you to look for. Though the bright sun is going down, we will reach that country before night. That is the country that delights the mind of everyone who turns to me. There is no living race in it but women and girls only."

When the woman had finished her song, Connla leapt away from his people into the shining boat. They saw him sailing away from them, far off, as if in a mist, as far as their eyes could see.

They went away across the sea. They have never come back. Only the gods know where they went.

Conn had a hundred battles in him, and every one of them he could win. This was the one fight he could not see to fight.

Tadg In Manannan's Islands



Another who went to the Land of the Ever-Living Ones, and who came back again, was Tadg, son of Cian, son of Olioll. This is how that happened.

Tadg was making his round as next heir, into the west of Munster, and his two brothers, Airnelach and Eoghan, were with him.

At that same time Cathmann, son of Tabarn, king of the beautiful country of Fresen, which lay to the south-east of the Great Plain, was searching the sea for whatever he could find, with nine of his ships. They landed at Beire do Bhunadas, in the west of Munster. The country was quiet, and so they slipped ashore, and nobody noticed them until everything was surrounded, men and cattle both.

Tadg's wife Liban, daughter of Conchubar Abratrudh of the Red Brows, was taken by the foreigners, and his two brothers, and a great many of the people of Munster, and they were carried off to the coasts of Fresen.

Cathmann took Liban to be his own wife. He put hardship on Tadg's two brothers. Eoghan he set to work a common ferry across a channel of the coast. Airnelach he set to cut fire-wood and keep the fires going for all the people. All the food they got was barley-seed and muddy water.

As for Tadg, he only escaped by his courage and his sword. There was great grief and discouragement on him, with his wife and his brothers carried away. But he had forty of his fighting men left, each of whom had killed one of the foreigners, and they had brought one of them in alive. This man told them about the country he came from.

When Tadg heard that, he made a plan in his own head. He gave orders for a curragh to be built that would be fit for a long voyage. It was very strong, with forty ox-hides on it of hard red leather that had been soaked in bark. It was well fitted with masts and oars and pitch and everything else that was needed. They put every kind of meat and drink and clothing into it, enough to last them the length of a year.

When all was ready and the curragh was out in the tide, Tadg said to his people, "Let's set out now on the high sea, and look for our own people, who've been away from us this long time."

They set out over the stormy, heavy flood until at last they could see no land ahead of them or behind, only the hillsides of the great sea. Farther on they heard the singing of a great flock of birds they did not know. Pleasant white-bellied salmon leapt around the curragh on every side, and big dark seals came after them, breaking through the shining wash of the oars, and great whales after the seals, so that the young men liked to watch them, for they had never seen anything like them.

They rowed on for twenty days and twenty nights. At the end of that time they sighted a high land with a smooth coast. When they reached it they all landed and pulled up the curragh and lit their fires. Food was given out, and they made short work of it. Then they made beds for themselves on the beautiful green grass, and slept well until sunrise the next day.

Tadg got up and put on his weapons and went out, with thirty of his men, to search the whole island.

They went all through it, and found no living thing on it, man or beast, but flocks of sheep. The size of the sheep was past telling. They were as big as horses, and the whole island was full of their wool. There was one great flock beyond all the others, all very big rams, and one of them was the biggest of all. He had nine horns. He charged Tadg's chief men, attacking them and butting them.

They were angry at that, and went at him, and there was a struggle. At first the ram broke through five of their shields. But Tadg took his spear, the spear there was no escape from, and made a lucky throw at the ram, and killed him.

They brought the ram to the curragh and made it ready for the young men to eat. They stayed three nights on the island, and every night they had a sheep for their food. They gathered up a good share of the wool and put it in the curragh, for the wonder and the beauty of it. They found the bones of very big men on the island too, but whether those men had died of sickness or been killed by the rams, they did not know.

They left that island and went on until they found two strange islands with great flocks of wonderful birds on them. The birds were like blackbirds, but some were the size of eagles or cranes, red with green heads, and their eggs were blue and pure crimson. Some of the men began to eat the eggs, and that moment feathers began to grow out of them. But they went bathing afterwards, and the feathers dropped off them as quickly as they had come.

Up to then it was the foreigner they had with them who had set their course, for he had been on that track before. But now they went on for six weeks and never saw land.

"We're astray on the great ocean that has no boundaries," the foreigner said.

Then the wind began to rise with its sharp voice, and there was a sound like the tramping of feet in the sea, and the sea rose up into great mountains, hard to climb. Tadg's people were terrified, for they had never seen anything like it.

But Tadg began to stir them up and rouse them, and told them to meet the sea like men. "Do bravery, young men of Munster," he said, "and fight for your lives against the waves that are rising up and coming at the sides of the curragh."

Tadg took one side of the curragh and his men took the other, and he was able to pull it round against the whole twenty-nine of them, and bail it out and keep it dry at the same time.

After a while they got a fair wind and put up their sail, so that less water came in. Then the sea went down and lay flat and calm, and there were strange birds of many shapes singing all around them. They saw land ahead of them, with a good coast, and courage and gladness came on them.

When they came nearer they found a beautiful inver, a river's mouth, with green hills about it. Its bed was sandy and as bright as silver, and there were red-speckled salmon in it, and pleasant woods with purple treetops edging the stream.

"This is a beautiful country," said Tadg. "It would be a happy man who'd always be in it. Pull up the ship now and dry it out."

A score of them went on into the country, and a score stayed to mind the curragh. And for all the cold and discouragement and bad weather they had come through, they felt no wish at all for food or for fire. The sweet smell of the crimson branches of that place was enough for them.

They went on through the wood, and after a while they came to an apple-garden with red apples in it, and leafy oak-trees, and hazels yellow with nuts.

"It's a wonder to me," said Tadg, "to find summer here, and it winter in our own country."

It was a delightful place, but they went on into another wood, a very sweet-smelling one, with round purple berries in it, each of them bigger than a man's head. Beautiful shining birds were eating the berries, strange birds with white bodies and purple heads and golden beaks. And while they ate the berries they sang sweet music that would have put sick and wounded men into their sleep.

Tadg and his men went on farther until they came to a great smooth flowery plain with a dew of honey over it. There were three steep hills on the plain, and a very strong dun on each of them.

When they reached the nearest hill they found a white-bodied woman, the best of the women of the whole world.

"Your coming is welcome, Tadg, son of Cian," she said, "and there'll be food and provision for you as you need it."

"I'm glad of that welcome," said Tadg. "Tell me now, woman of sweet words, what is that royal dun on the hill, with walls of white marble round it?"

"That is the dun of the royal line of the kings of Ireland," she said, "from Heremon, son of Miled, to Conn of the Hundred Battles, who was the last to go into it."

"What is the name of this country?"

"It is Inislocha, the Lake Island. There are two kings over it, Rudrach and Dergcroche, sons of Bodb."

And she told Tadg the whole story of Ireland, up to the time of the coming of the Sons of the Gael.

"That's well," said Tadg. "You have good knowledge and learning. And tell me now, who lives in that middle dun, the one that's the colour of gold?"

"It's not I will tell you that," she said. "Go on to it yourself and you'll find out."

And she went away from them into the dun of white marble.

Tadg and his men went on until they came to the middle dun. There they found a queen of beautiful shape, wearing a golden dress.

"Health to you, Tadg," she said.

"I thank you for that," said Tadg.

"Your coming on this journey was foretold a long time ago," she said.

"What is your name?"

"I am Cesair," she said, "the first that ever reached Ireland. But since I and the men who were with me came out of that dark, unquiet land, we live for ever in this country."

Ireland: that dark, unquiet land. It is worth remembering that this is how it looks from the other side.

"Tell me, woman," said Tadg, "who lives in that dun with the wall of gold about it?"

"That's not hard to tell," she said. "Every king, and every chief man, and every noble person who was in a high place among all those who had power in Ireland, it's in that dun beyond they are. Parthalon and Nemed, Firbolgs and Tuatha de Danaan."

"You have good knowledge and learning," said Tadg.

"I have good knowledge of the history of the world, indeed," she said. "And this island is the fourth paradise of the world. As for the others, they are Inis Daleb to the south, and Inis Ercandra to the north, and Adam's Paradise in the east of the world."

"Who lives in that dun with the silver walls?" said Tadg.

"I won't tell you that, though I know," said the woman. "Go to the beautiful hill where it stands, and you'll find out."

They went on to the third hill. On the top of it was a very beautiful resting-place, and two sweethearts in it, a boy and a girl, comely and gentle. They had smooth hair shining like gold, and beautiful green clothes of the one kind, and anyone would have thought they had the same father and mother. They had gold chains round their necks, and bands of gold above the chains.

"O bright, comely children," said Tadg, "it's a pleasant place you have here."

They answered him, and praised his courage and his strength and his wisdom, and gave him their blessing.

The young man had a sweet-smelling apple the colour of gold in his hand. He would eat a third of it, and however much he ate, it was never any less. That was the food that nourished the two of them, and neither age nor sorrow could touch them once they had tasted it.

"Who are you?" Tadg asked him.

"I'm son to Conn of the Hundred Battles," he said.

"Is it Connla you are?" said Tadg.

"I am indeed," said the young man. "And it was this girl of many shapes who brought me here."

"I've given him my love and my affection," said the girl. "It's because of that I brought him to this place, so that we might be looking at one another for ever. And beyond that, we have never gone."

"That's a beautiful thing, and a strange thing," said Tadg, "and a thing to wonder at. And who is in that grand dun with the silver walls?"

"There's no one at all in it," said the girl.

"Why is that?"

"It's for the kings who are yet to rule Ireland," she said. "And there'll be a place in it for you, Tadg. Come now and see it."

The lovers went on to the dun, and the green grass hardly bent under their white feet. Tadg and his people went with them.

They came to the great wonderful house that stood ready for the company of the kings. It was a pleasant house, and anyone would have liked to be in it. It had walls of white bronze, set with crystal and with carbuncles that shone through the night as well as through the day.

Tadg looked out of the house, and he saw on one side of him a great sheltering apple-tree, with blossom and ripe fruit on it together.

"What's that apple-tree over there?" said Tadg.

"The fruit of that tree is food for the host in this house," said the girl. "And it was an apple from that tree that brought Connla here to me. It's a good tree, with its white-blossomed branches, and its golden apples that would satisfy the whole house."

Then Connla and the young girl left them, and they saw a troop of beautiful women coming towards them. One among them was the most beautiful of all.

"A welcome to you, Tadg," she said when she came to them.

"I thank you for that welcome," said Tadg. "And tell me, who are you?"

"I am Cliodna of the Fair Hair," she said, "daughter of Gebann, son of Treon, of the Tuatha de Danaan, a sweetheart of Ciabhan of the Curling Hair. It's from me that Cliodna's wave on the coast of Munster got its name. I've been a long time on this island now, and it's the apples of that tree you saw that we eat."

So the wave did not drown her. It brought her here.

Tadg was well pleased to listen to her talk. But after a while he said, "It's best for us to go on now and look for our people."

"We'd be well pleased if you stayed longer with us," said the woman.

While she was saying it, they saw three beautiful birds coming to them. One was blue with a crimson head, and one was crimson with a green head, and the third was speckled with a head the colour of gold. They lit on the great apple-tree, and each of them ate an apple, and then they sang sweet music that would put sick men to sleep.

"Those birds will go with you," said Cliodna. "They'll guide you on your way, and they'll make music for you, and there'll be neither sorrow nor sadness on you, by land or by sea, until you come to Ireland.

"And take this beautiful green cup away with you. There's power in it. If you only pour water into it, it will turn to wine that moment. Don't let it out of your hand, but keep it with you. For whenever it escapes from you, your death won't be far off.

"And this is where you'll meet your death: in the green valley beside the Boinn. A wandering wild deer will give you a wound, and after that, strangers will put an end to you. I myself will bury your body, and there'll be a hill over it, and the name it will get is Croidhe Essu."

That is the price of a visit to the Land of the Ever-Living. You come home knowing exactly how you will die.

They went out of the shining house, and Cliodna of the Fair Hair went with them to the place where they had left their ship. She gave their comrades a kindly welcome, and asked them how long they had been in that country.

"It seems to us we've been here only one day," they said.

"You've been here the whole length of a year," she said, "and in all that time you had neither food nor drink. But however long you stayed here, cold or hunger would never come on you."

"It would be a good thing to live this way always," said Tadg's people when they heard that.

But Tadg said, "It's best for us to go on and look for our people. We must leave this country, though it's hard for us to leave it."

Then Cliodna and Tadg said farewell to one another, and she gave her blessing to him and to his people.

They set out over the ridges of the sea. They were downhearted after leaving that country, until the birds began to sing for them. Then their courage rose, and they were glad and light-hearted.

When they looked back they could not see the island they had come from, because of a Druid mist that came down on it and hid it from them.

Then, by the leading of the birds, they came to the country of Fresen, and they were in a deep sleep for the whole of that voyage.

They attacked the foreigners and got the better of them, and Tadg killed Cathmann the king after a hard fight. Liban his wife made no delay. She came to meet her husband and her sweetheart, and she was glad to see him.

When they had rested a while they faced the sea again — Tadg, and his wife Liban, and his two brothers, and a great many treasures with them — and they came home safely to Ireland at last.

He had chosen the dark, unquiet land over paradise. He had a green cup in his hand, and he knew he must never let it go.



PART TWO: THE FIANNA

Book One: Finn, Son Of Cumhal



Laegaire In The Happy Plain



Another who went to Magh Mell, the Happy Plain, was Laegaire, son of the King of Connacht, Crimthan Cass.

He was out one day with the king his father near Loch na-n Ean, the Lake of Birds, and the men of Connacht with them, and they saw a man coming towards them through the mist. He had long golden-yellow hair streaming out behind him, a gold-hilted sword at his belt, two five-barbed darts in his hand, a gold-rimmed shield on his back, and a five-folded crimson cloak about his shoulders.

"Give a welcome to the man coming towards you," said Laegaire to his people. He had the best name of all the men of Connacht. And to the stranger he said, "A welcome to the champion we don't know."

"I'm thankful to you all," said the stranger.

"What have you come for, and where are you going?" said Laegaire.

"I've come to look for the help of fighting men," said the stranger. "My name is Fiachna, son of Betach, of the men of the Sidhe. And this is what ails me: my wife was taken from my pillow and carried off by Eochaid, son of Sal. We fought, and I killed him. Now she's gone to a brother's son of his, Goll, son of Dalbh, king of a people of Magh Mell. I've given him seven battles, and all of them went against me. There's another to be fought this very day, and I've come to ask for help. To everyone who deserves it I'll give a good reward of gold and silver."

And this is what he said:

"The most beautiful of plains is the Plain of the Two Mists. It is not far from here. A host of the men of the Sidhe, full of courage, are stirring up pools of blood upon it.

"We have drawn red blood from the bodies of high nobles; many women are keening them with cries and with tears.

"The men of the host go out in good order ahead of their beautiful king; they march among blue spears, white troops of fighters with curled hair.

"They scatter the troops of their enemies; they destroy every country they attack; they are beautiful in battle, a host with high looks, rushing, avenging.

"It is no wonder they have such strength: every one of them is the son of a king and a queen; they have manes of hair the colour of gold.

"Their bodies are smooth and comely; their eyes blue and far-seeing; their teeth bright like crystal within their thin red lips.

"They have white shields in their hands, patterned with white silver; blue shining swords, red horns set with gold.

"They are good at killing men in battle; good at song-making; good at chess-playing.

"The most beautiful of plains is the Plain of the Two Mists; the men of the Sidhe are stirring up pools of blood on it; it is not far from this place."

"It would be a shameful thing not to help this man," said Laegaire.

Then Fiachna, son of Betach, went down into the lake, for it was out of the lake he had come. Laegaire went down into it after him, with fifty fighting men.

They saw a strong place in front of them, and a company of armed men, with Goll, son of Dalbh, at their head.

"That's well," said Laegaire. "I and my fifty will go out against this troop."

"I'll answer you," said Goll, son of Dalbh.

The two fifties fell on each other. Goll fell. Laegaire and his fifty came out of it with their lives, and made such slaughter of their enemies that not one of them escaped.

"Where's the woman now?" said Laegaire.

"She's inside the dun of Magh Mell, with a troop of armed men guarding it," said Fiachna.

"You stay here," said Laegaire, "and I and my fifty will go there."

So he and his men went on to the dun, and Laegaire called out to the men around it: "Your king has got his death. Your chief men have fallen. Let the woman come out, and I'll give you your lives."

The men agreed, and brought the woman out. And when she came out, she made this lament:

"It is a sorrowful day that swords are reddened for the sake of the dear dead body of Goll, son of Dalbh. It was he loved me; it was he I loved. Little does Laegaire Liban care for that.

"Weapons were hacked and split by Goll. It is to Fiachna, son of Betach, I must go. It is Goll, son of Dalbh, I loved."

That lament got the name of The Lament of the Daughter of Eochaid the Dumb.

Nobody had asked her. Two kings and a hero from the world of men had fought over her, and nobody had once asked her.

Laegaire went back with her until he put her hand in Fiachna's hand. That night Fiachna's daughter, Deorgreine, a Tear of the Sun, was given to Laegaire as his wife, and fifty other women were given to his fifty fighting men, and they stayed with them there until the end of a year.

At the end of that time Laegaire said, "Let's go and ask for news of our own country."

"If you have a mind to go," said Fiachna, "take horses with you. But whatever happens, don't get down off them."

So they set out. When they came back to Ireland they found a great gathering of all the men of Connacht, keening them.

When the men of Connacht saw them coming they rose up to meet them and welcome them. But Laegaire called out, "Don't come near us. It's to bid you farewell we're here."

"Don't leave us again," said Crimthan his father. "I'll give you the rule over the three Connachts, their silver and their gold, their horses and their bridles, and their beautiful

women, if you won't leave us."

And this is what Laegaire said:

"In the place we have gone to, the armies move from kingdom to kingdom; they listen to the sweet-sounding music of the Sidhe; they drink from shining cups; we talk with those we love; it is beer that falls instead of rain.

"We have brought from the dun of the Pleasant Plain thirty cauldrons, thirty drinking horns; we have brought the lament that was sung by the Sea, by the daughter of Eochaid the Dumb.

"There is a wife for every man of the fifty; my own wife to me is the Tear of the Sun; I am made master of a blue sword. I would not give, for your whole kingdom, one night of the nights of the Sidhe."

With that Laegaire turned from them and went back to that kingdom. He was made king there along with Fiachna, son of Betach, and his daughter. He has not come out of it yet.

Now, at the time the Tuatha de Danaan chose a king for themselves after the battle of Tailltin, when Lir heard that the kingship had been given to Bodb Dearg, it did not please him. He left the gathering without leave and without a word to anyone, for he thought it was he who had the right to be made king.

But though he went away, Bodb was given the kingship all the same, for not one of the five begrudged it to him except Lir. And the others decided to follow Lir and burn his house down, and attack him with spear and sword, for refusing obedience to the king they had chosen.

"We won't do that," said Bodb Dearg. "That man would defend any place he was in. And besides, I'm none the less king over the Tuatha de Danaan though he doesn't submit to me."

Things went on like that for a good while. But at last a great misfortune came on Lir. His wife died, after a sickness of three nights. It came very hard on him, and there was heavi-

ness on his mind after her. There was great talk of the death of that woman in her own time.

The news of it was told all through Ireland, and it came to the house of Bodb, where the best of the Men of Dea were with him.

"If Lir had a mind for it," said Bodb, "my help and my friendship would be good for him now, since his wife is gone from him. For I have here with me the three young girls of the best shape, and the best appearance, and the best name in all Ireland: Aobh, Aoife, and Ailbhe, the three daughters of Oilell of Aran, my own three nurselings."

The Men of Dea said it was a good thought, and that what he said was true.

So messages and messengers went from Bodb Dearg to where Lir was, to say that if he had a mind to join with the Son of the Dagda and acknowledge his lordship, Bodb would give him one of his foster-children. Lir thought well of the offer. The next day he set out with fifty chariots from Sidhe Fionnachaidh, and went by every short way until he came to Bodb's dwelling-place at Loch Dearg. There was a welcome for him there, and all the people were merry and pleasant to him, and he and his people were well attended that night.

The three daughters of Oilell of Aran were sitting on the one seat with Bodb Dearg's wife, the queen of the Tuatha de Danaan, their foster-mother.

"You may have your choice of the three young girls, Lir," said Bodb.

"I can't say which of them is my choice," said Lir. "But whichever of them is the eldest is the noblest, and it's best for me to take her."

"If that's so," said Bodb, "Aobh is the eldest, and she'll be given to you, if it's your wish."

"It is my wish," he said.

He took Aobh as his wife that night, and stayed there a fortnight, and then he brought her to his own house, to make a great wedding-feast.

In the course of time Aobh gave birth to two children, a daughter and a son, and their names were Fionnuala and Aodh. After a while she was brought to bed again, and this time

she gave birth to two sons, and they called them Fiachra and Conn.

She died at their birth.

That weighed very heavy on Lir, and if his mind had not been set on his four children, he would have come near to dying of grief.

The news came to Bodb Dearg's place, and all the people gave three loud, high cries, keening their nursling. When they had keened her, Bodb Dearg said: "It's a grief to us that our daughter has died, for her own sake and for the sake of the good man we gave her to, for we're thankful for his friendship and his faithfulness. But our friendship won't be broken. I'll give him her sister Aoife for a wife."

When Lir heard that, he came for the girl and married her and brought her home to his house.

At first Aoife had honour and affection for her sister's children. Indeed, nobody at all could see those four children without giving them the heart's love.

Bodb Dearg often came to Lir's house for the sake of those children, and would bring them to his own place for a good while, and then let them go back home again. And the Men of Dea were holding the Feast of Age in each hill of the Sidhe in turn at that time, and when they came to Lir's hill, those four children were their joy and delight for the beauty of their looks. The children slept in beds in sight of their father Lir. He would rise at the break of every morning, and go and lie down among his children.

But this is what came of all that. A fire of jealousy was kindled in Aoife, and she came to dislike her sister's children, and then to hate them.

She pretended to have a sickness, and it lasted nearly a whole year. And at the end of that time she did a deed of jealousy and cruel treachery against the children of Lir.

One day she had her chariot yoked, and took the four children into it, and they set out towards the house of Bodb Dearg. Fionnuala had no wish to go with her. She knew by Aoife that she had some plan for their death or their destruction, and she had seen in a dream

that there was treachery against them in Aoife's mind. But for all that, she could not escape what was ahead of her.

On the way Aoife said to her people: "Kill the four children of Lir now — for whose sake their father has given up my love — and I'll give you your own choice of reward out of all the good things of the world."

"We won't do that indeed," they said. "It's a bad deed you've thought of, and harm will come to you out of it."

When they would not do as she said, she took out a sword herself to put an end to the children. But she was a woman with no good courage, and no great strength in her mind, and she was not able to do it.

They went on west to Loch Dairbhreach, the Lake of the Oaks, and the horses were stopped there. Aoife told the children of Lir to go out and bathe in the lake, and they did as she told them.

As soon as Aoife saw them out in the lake she struck them with a Druid rod, and put on them the shape of four swans, white and beautiful.

And this is what she said: "Out with you, children of the king. Your luck is taken from you for ever. Sorrowful will the story be to your friends. It's with flocks of birds your cries will be heard, for ever."

And Fionnuala said: "Witch, we know your name now. You've struck us down with no hope of relief. But though you drive us from wave to wave, there are times we'll touch the land. We'll get help when we're seen — help, and all that's best for us. Even if we have to sleep on the lake, our minds will be going abroad early."

Then the four children of Lir turned towards Aoife, and Fionnuala said: "It's a bad deed you've done, Aoife, and a bad fulfilling of friendship, to destroy us without cause. Vengeance for it will come on you, and you'll fall in satisfaction for it. Your power to destroy us is not greater than the power of our friends to avenge it on you. Now set some bounds to the time this enchantment is to stay on us."

She is the eldest, and she is a child, and she is a swan, and she is the one who thinks to ask. Remember that.

"I'll do that," said Aoife, "and it's worse for you that you asked it of me. The bounds I set to your time are these: until the Woman from the South and the Man from the North come together. And since you ask to hear it of me: no friends and no power you have will be able to bring you out of these shapes through the length of your lives, until you've been three hundred years on Loch Dairbhreach, and three hundred years on Sruth na Maoile between Ireland and Alban, and three hundred years at Irrus Domnann and Inis Gluaire. Those are to be your journeys from now on."

But then repentance came on Aoife, and she said: "Since there's no other help I can give you now, you may keep your own speech. And you'll sing sweet music of the Sidhe that would put the men of the earth to sleep, and there'll be no music in the world to equal it. And your own sense and your own nobility will stay with you, so it won't weigh so heavy on you to be in the shape of birds.

"And go away out of my sight now, children of Lir, with your white faces and your stammering Irish. It's a great curse on tender lads to be driven out on the rough wind. Nine hundred years to be on the water — it's a long time for anyone to be in pain. It was I put this on you through treachery. It's best for you to do as I tell you now.

"Lir, who got victory with so many a good cast, his heart is a kernel of death in him now. The groaning of the great hero is a sickness to me, though it's I that have well earned his anger."

Then the horses were caught for Aoife, and the chariot yoked for her, and she went on to the palace of Bodb Dearg. The chief people of the place welcomed her. The Son of the Dagda asked her why she had not brought the children of Lir with her.

"I'll tell you that," she said. "It's because Lir has no liking for you, and he won't trust you with his children, for fear you'd keep them from him altogether."

"I wonder at that," said Bodb Dearg, "for those children are dearer to me than my own children."

In his own mind he thought the woman was deceiving him. So he sent messengers north to Sidhe Fionnachaidh. Lir asked them what they had come for.

"For your children," they said.

"Didn't they go to you with Aoife?"

"They didn't," they said. "And Aoife said it was you who wouldn't let them come."

Lir was downhearted and sorrowful at that news, for he understood well that it was Aoife who had destroyed his children, or made an end of them. Early the next morning his horses were caught, and he set out on the road to the south-west.

When he had got as far as the shore of Loch Dairbhreach, the four children saw the horses coming towards them.

"A welcome to the troop of horses I see coming near the lake," said Fionnuala. "The people they carry are strong, and there's sadness on them. It's us they're following, it's us they're looking for. Let's move over to the shore, Aodh, Fiachra, and comely Conn. The ones who are coming can be nobody else in the world but Lir and his household."

Lir came to the edge of the lake, and he saw that the swans had the voices of living people, and he asked them why they had that voice.

"I'll tell you that, Lir," said Fionnuala. "We are your own four children, destroyed by your wife, the sister of our own mother, through the force of her jealousy."

"Is there any way to put you back in your own shapes?" said Lir.

"There's no way," said Fionnuala. "All the men of the world couldn't help us until we've gone through our time. And that won't be until the end of nine hundred years."

When Lir and his people heard that, they gave three great heavy shouts of grief and sorrow and crying.

"Have you a mind to come to us on the land," said Lir, "since you still have your own sense and your memory?"

"We haven't the power to live with any person at all from now on," said Fionnuala. "But we have our own language, the Irish, and we have the power to sing sweet music, and it's enough to satisfy the whole race of men to listen to that music. Stay here tonight, and we'll make music for you."

So Lir and his people stayed there listening to the music of the swans, and they slept quietly there that night.

Lir rose early the next morning and made this lament:

"It is time to go out from this place. I do not sleep, though I am lying down. To be parted from my dear children, it is that is tormenting my heart.

"It was a bad net I put over you, bringing Aoife, daughter of Oilell of Aran, to the house. I would never have followed that advice if I had known what it would bring on me.

"O Fionnuala, and comely Conn, O Aodh, O Fiachra of the beautiful arms; I am not ready to go away from you, from the border of the harbour where you are."

Then Lir went on to the palace of Bodb Dearg, and there was a welcome for him there, and Bodb Dearg reproached him for not bringing his children with him.

"My grief!" said Lir. "It wasn't I who wouldn't bring my children. It was Aoife there beyond, your own foster-child and the sister of their mother, who put them in the shape of four white swans on Loch Dairbhreach, in the sight of all the men of Ireland. But they have their sense still, and their reason, and their voice, and their Irish."

Bodb Dearg gave a great start when he heard that, and he knew what Lir said was true. He gave Aoife a very sharp reproach.

"This treachery will be worse for you in the end, Aoife," he said, "than for the children of Lir. What shape would you think worst to be in?"

"I'd think worst of being a witch of the air," she said.

"That's the shape I'll put you into now," said Bodb.

He struck her with a Druid wand, and she was turned into a witch of the air there and then. She went away on the wind in that shape. She is in it yet, and she will be in it to the end of life and time.

Nine hundred years for the children. For ever, for her. The gods have their own arithmetic.

As for Bodb Dearg and the Tuatha de Danaan, they came to the shore of Loch Dairbhreach and made their camp there, to listen to the music of the swans.

The Sons of the Gael came from every part of Ireland as well as the Men of Dea to hear them, for there never was any music or any delight heard in Ireland to compare with the music of those swans. The swans told stories and talked every day with the men of Ireland, and with their teachers and their fellow-pupils and their friends. Every night they sang very sweet music of the Sidhe, and whoever heard it would sleep sound and quiet, whatever trouble or long sickness was on him. Everyone who heard the music of those birds was happy and contented after it.

Those two gatherings, of the Tuatha de Danaan and of the Sons of the Gael, stayed there around Loch Dairbhreach for three hundred years.

Then Fionnuala said to her brothers, "Do you know that we've spent all we have to spend of our time here, except this one night?"

The sons of Lir were greatly grieved when they heard that. Talking with their friends and companions on Loch Dairbhreach had seemed to them almost the same as being living people again, compared with going out on the cold, fretful sea of the Maoil in the north.

Early the next day they came to speak with their father and their foster-father, and said farewell to them, and Fionnuala made this lament:

"Farewell to you, Bodb Dearg, the man with whom all knowledge is in pledge. And farewell to our father along with you, Lir of the Hill of the White Field.

"The time has come, as I think, for us to part from you, O pleasant company. My grief, it is not on a visit we are going to you.

"From this day out, O friends of our heart, our comrades, it is on the tormented course of the Maoil we will be, without the voice of any person near us.

"Three hundred years there, and three hundred years in the bay of the men of Domnann: it is a pity for the four comely children of Lir, that the salt waves of the sea should be their covering by night.

"O three brothers, with the ruddy faces gone from you, let them all leave the lake now, the great troop that loved us. Sorrowful is our parting."

After that lament they took flight, lightly, airily, until they came to Sruth na Maoile, between Ireland and Alban. That was a grief to the men of Ireland, and they gave out an order that from then on no swan was to be killed anywhere in Ireland, whatever chance there might be of killing one.

Sruth na Maoile was a bad dwelling-place for the children of Lir. When they saw the wide coast around them they were filled with cold and with sorrow, and they thought nothing of all they had been through before, compared with what they went through on that sea.

One night while they were there a great storm came on them.

"My dear brothers," said Fionnuala, "it's a pity we aren't making ready for this night, for it's certain the storm will separate us. Let's settle on some place where we can meet afterwards, if we're driven apart in the night."

"Let's settle to meet at Carraig na Ron, the Rock of the Seals," said the others, "for we all know it."

When midnight came, the wind came with it, and the noise of the waves grew, and lightning flashed, and a rough storm came sweeping down, so that the children of Lir were scattered over the great sea, and the wideness of it set them astray, and none of them could tell which way the others had gone.

After the storm a great quiet came on the sea, and Fionnuala was alone on Sruth na Maoile. When she found her brothers were gone, she lamented them greatly, and made this lament:

"It is a pity for me to be alive in the state I am. My wings are frozen to my sides. It is little that the wind has not broken the heart in my body, with the loss of Aodh.

"To be three hundred years on Loch Dairbhreach without going into my own shape — it is worse to me, the time I am on Sruth na Maoile.

"The three I loved, och, the three I loved, that slept under the shelter of my feathers: until the dead come back to the living I will see them no more for ever.

"It is a pity I should stay after Fiachra, and after Aodh, and after comely Conn, with no account of them. My grief, to be here to face every hardship this night."

She stayed all night on the Rock of the Seals until sunrise, looking out over the sea on every side. At last she saw Conn coming to her, his feathers soaked through and his head hanging, and her heart gave him a great welcome. Then Fiachra came, wet and perished and worn out, and he could not say a word they could understand for the cold and the hardship he had gone through. Fionnuala put him under her wings.

"We'd be well off now," she said, "if only Aodh would come to us."

It was not long after that they saw Aodh coming, his head dry and his feathers beautiful. Fionnuala gave him a great welcome, and put him in under the feathers of her breast, and Fiachra under her right wing, and Conn under her left, so that she could put her feathers over them all.

"And och, my brothers," she said, "this was a bad night for us, and there are many like it ahead of us from now on."

They stayed there a long time after that, suffering cold and misery on the Maoil, until at last a night came on them the like of which they had never known, for frost and snow and wind and cold. They cried and lamented the hardship of their life, and the cold of the night, and the depth of the snow, and the hardness of the wind.

After they had suffered cold to the end of a year, a worse night again came on them, in the middle of winter. They were on Carraig na Ron, and the water froze round them, and as they rested on the rock their feet and their wings and their feathers froze to it, so that they

could not move. They struggled so hard to get away that they left the skin of their feet, and their feathers, and the tips of their wings on the rock behind them.

"My grief, children of Lir," said Fionnuala, "our state is bad now. We can't bear the salt water to touch us, and there are bonds on us not to leave it. If the salt water gets into our sores, we'll get our death."

And she made this lament:

"It is keening we are tonight, without feathers to cover our bodies. Cold are the rough, uneven rocks under our bare feet.

"Bad was our stepmother to us, the time she played enchantments on us, sending us out like swans upon the sea.

"Our washing-place is on the ridge of the bay, in the foam of the flying manes of the sea. Our share of the ale-feast is the salt water of the blue tide.

"One daughter and three sons; it is in the clefts of the rocks we are; it is on the hard rocks we are; it is a pity, the way we are."

All the same they came out onto the course of the Maoil again, and the salt water was sharp and rough and bitter to them, but they could neither avoid it nor find shelter from it. They stayed by the shore in that hardship until their feathers grew again, and their wings, and their sores were entirely healed. After that they used to go every day to the shore of Ireland or of Alban, but they had to come back to Sruth na Maoile every night.

One day they came to the mouth of the Banna, in the north of Ireland, and they saw a troop of riders, beautiful, all of one colour, with well-trained pure white horses under them, travelling straight along the road from the south-west.

"Do you know who those riders are, sons of Lir?" said Fionnuala.

"We don't," they said. "But it's likely they're some troop of the Sons of the Gael, or of the Tuatha de Danaan."

They moved closer to the shore to see who they were, and when the riders saw them they came to meet them, until they could talk together.

The chief men among them were two sons of Bodb Dearg: Aodh Aithfhiosach, Aodh of the Quick Wits, and Fergus Fithchiollach, Fergus of the Chess. A third part of the Riders of the Sidhe were with them. They had been looking for the swans for a long time, and when they came together they gave each other a kind and loving welcome.

The children of Lir asked for news of all the Men of Dea, and above all of Lir, and Bodb Dearg, and their people.

"They're well," they said, "and they're all together in your father's house at Sidhe Fionnachaidh, keeping the Feast of Age pleasantly and happily, with no unease on them except for being without you, and not knowing what happened to you from the day you left Loch Dairbhreach."

"It hasn't been that way with us," said Fionnuala. "We've gone through great hardship and unease and misery on the tides of the sea until this day."

And she made this lament:

"There is delight tonight with the household of Lir! Plenty of ale with them, and of wine — though it is in a cold dwelling-place, this night, are the four children of the king.

"Our bedclothes are without a spot, our bodies covered over with curved feathers. But often we were dressed in purple, drinking pleasant mead.

"This is our food and our drink: the white sand and the bitter water of the sea. Often we drank mead of hazel-nuts from round four-lipped drinking cups.

"These are our beds: bare rocks out of the power of the waves. Often there were spread out for us beds of the breast-feathers of birds.

"Though it is our work now to be swimming through the frost and through the noise of the waves, often a company of the sons of kings rode after us to the Hill of Bodb.

"This is what has wasted my strength: to be going and coming over the current of the Maoil, the way I was never used to, and never to be in the sunshine on the soft grass.

"Fiachra's bed and Conn's bed is under the cover of my wings on the sea. Aodh has his place under the feathers of my breast, the four of us side by side.

"The teaching of Manannan without deceit, the talk of Bodb Dearg on the pleasant ridge, the voice of Angus, his sweet kisses: it is by their side I used to be without grief."

After that the riders went on to Lir's house, and told the chief men of the Tuatha de Danaan all that the birds had gone through, and the state they were in.

"We have no power over them," said the chief men. "But we're glad they're still living, for they'll get help at the end of time."

The gods could do nothing. That is worth saying plainly. All that power, and they could do nothing but be glad.

The children of Lir went back to their old place on the Maoil, and stayed there until the time they had to spend in it was spent.

Then Fionnuala said, "The time has come for us to leave this place. It's to Irrus Domnann we must go now, after our three hundred years here. There'll be no rest for us there, or any standing-ground, or any shelter from the storms. But since it's time to go, let's set out on the cold wind, so we won't go astray."

So they set out, and left Sruth na Maoile behind them, and went to the point of Irrus Domnann, and there they stayed. It was a life of misery and cold they led there. Once the sea froze around them so that they could not move at all, and the brothers were lamenting, and Fionnuala was comforting them, for she knew help would come to them in the end.

They stayed at Irrus Domnann until the time they had to spend there was spent.

Then Fionnuala said, "The time has come for us to go back to Sidhe Fionnachaidh, where our father is, with his household and all our own people."

"It pleases us well to hear that," they said.

So they set out, flying lightly through the air until they came to Sidhe Fionnachaidh.

This is how they found the place: empty in front of them, with nothing in it but green hillocks and thickets of nettles. No house. No fire. No hearthstone.

The four pressed close to one another, and gave three sorrowful cries, and Fionnuala made this lament:

"It is a wonder to me, this place, without a house, without a dwelling-place. To see it the way it is now — ochone! — it is bitterness to my heart.

"Without dogs, without hounds for hunting, without women, without great kings; we never knew it to be like this when our father was in it.

"Without horns, without cups, without drinking in the lighted house; without young men, without riders; the way it is tonight is a foretelling of sorrow.

"The people of the place to be as they are now — ochone! — it is grief to my heart. It is plain to my mind tonight that the lord of the house is not living.

"Och, house where we used to see music and playing and the gathering of people! I think it a great change to see it lonely the way it is tonight.

"The greatness of the hardships we have gone through, going from one wave of the sea to another, we never heard of the like of them coming on any other person.

"It is seldom this place had its share of grass and bushes. The man is not living who would know us. It would be a wonder to him to see us here."

All the same, the children of Lir stayed that night in their father's place and their grandfather's, where they had been reared, and they sang very sweet music of the Sidhe.

They rose early the next morning and went to Inis Gluaire, and all the birds of the country gathered near them on Loch na-n Ean, the Lake of the Birds. They used to go out every day to feed in the far parts of the country, to Inis Geadh, and to Accuill, where Donn, son of Miled, and his people who were drowned were buried, and to all the western islands of Connacht. And they went back to Inis Gluaire every night.

It was about that time that they met a young man of good family named Aibric. He often watched the birds, and their singing was sweet to him, and he loved them greatly, and they loved him. It was this young man who told the whole story of all that had happened to them, and put it in order.

And this is the story he told of what happened to them at the end.

It was after the faith of Christ and blessed Patrick came into Ireland that Saint Mochaomhog came to Inis Gluaire. On the first night he came to the island, the children of Lir heard the sound of his bell ringing near them. The brothers started up in fright when they heard it.

"We don't know what that weak, unpleasing voice is that we hear," they said.

"That's the voice of the bell of Mochaomhog," said Fionnuala. "And it's through that bell you'll be set free from pain and from misery."

They listened to the music of the bell until matins were done, and then they began to sing the low, sweet music of the Sidhe.

Mochaomhog listened to them, and prayed to God to show him who was singing that music, and it was shown to him that it was the children of Lir. The next morning he went to the Lake of the Birds and saw the swans ahead of him on the lake, and he went down to them at the brink of the shore.

"Are you the children of Lir?" he said.

"We are indeed," they said.

"I give thanks to God for that," he said. "It's for your sakes I came to this island above any other island. Come to land now, and put your trust in me, so that you may do good deeds and part from your sins."

They came to land after that, and put their trust in Mochaomhog, and he brought them to his own dwelling-place, and they used to hear Mass with him. He got a good smith and had him make chains of bright silver for them. He put a chain between Aodh and Fionnuala, and a chain between Conn and Fiachra. The four of them lifted his heart and gladdened his

mind, and no danger and no distress that had been on the swans before troubled them now.

The King of Connacht at that time was Lairgnen, son of Colman, son of Cobthach, and his wife was Deoch, daughter of Finghin. And that was the coming together of the Man from the North and the Woman from the South that Aoife had spoken of.

Deoch heard talk of the birds, and a great desire came on her to have them. She told Lairgnen to bring them to her, and he said he would ask Mochaomhog for them.

She gave her word she would not stay another night with him unless he brought them to her, and she set out from the house there and then. Lairgnen sent messengers after her to bring her back, and they did not overtake her until she was at Cill Dun. She went home with them then, and Lairgnen sent messengers to ask Mochaomhog for the birds, and he did not get them.

Lairgnen was very angry. He went himself to where Mochaomhog was, and asked whether it was true he had refused him the birds.

"It's true indeed," said Mochaomhog.

At that Lairgnen got up and took hold of the swans, and pulled them off the altar, two birds in each hand, to carry them off to Deoch.

No sooner had he laid his hands on them than their bird-skins fell away. And what was in their place was three lean, withered old men and a thin, withered old woman, without blood or flesh.

Nine hundred years. They had been children when it started.

Lairgnen gave a great start at that, and went out of the place.

Then Fionnuala said to Mochaomhog: "Come and baptize us now, for it's not long till our death comes. And it's certain you don't think worse of parting with us than we do of parting with you. Make our grave afterwards, and lay Conn at my right side, and Fiachra at my left side, and Aodh in front of my face, between my two arms. And pray to the God of Heaven that you may be able to baptize us."

The children of Lir were baptized then, and they died, and they were buried as Fionnuala had asked: Fiachra and Conn one on each side of her, and Aodh in front of her face. A stone was put over them, and their names were written on it in Ogham, and they were keened there, and heaven was gained for their souls.

That is the fate of the children of Lir, so far.

She had held them under her wings for nine hundred years. She held them there still.

CHAPTER I

The Coming Of Finn



When Finn was born, his father was already dead.



Fionn mac Cumhaill — Leader of the Fianna

His father was Cumhal, of the sons of Baiscne, Head of the Fianna of Ireland, and he had been killed in battle by the sons of Morna, who were fighting him for the leadership. Finn's mother was beautiful long-haired Muirne, daughter of Tadg, son of Nuada of the Tuatha de Danaan, and of Ethlinn, the mother of Lugh of the Long Hand. So there was god-blood in the boy, on his mother's side. It did not keep him safe.

Muirne did not dare to keep him with her. Two women came and took him away to care for him: Bodhmall, the woman Druid, and Liath Luachra.

They took him to the woods of Slieve Bladhma, and nursed him there in secret, because of his father's enemies, the sons of Morna. They kept him there a long time.

Muirne took another husband, who was King of Carraighe. But at the end of six years she came to see Finn, travelling through every lonely place until she came to the wood. There she found the little hunting-cabin, and the boy asleep in it. She lifted him up in her arms and kissed him, and sang him a little sleepy song. Then she said goodbye to the women, and went away again.

That is all she had of him. One song, in a cabin, in a wood.

The two women went on caring for him until he came to sensible years. One day he went out and saw a wild duck on the lake with her clutch, and he made a throw at her that cut off her wings so that she could not fly, and he brought her back to the cabin. That was his first hunt.

They gave him good training in running and leaping and swimming. One of them would run round a tree with a thorn switch, and Finn after her with another switch, each trying to hit the other. They would leave him in a field with hares, and tell him not to let the hares leave the field, but to keep in front of them whichever way they went. And to teach him swimming, they would throw him into the water and let him make his own way out.

After a while he went away with a troop of poets, to hide from the sons of Morna, and they hid him on the mountain of Crotta Cliach. But there was a robber in Leinster then, Fiacuil, son of Codhna, and he came to where the poets were in Fidh Gaible and killed them all. He spared the child, and took him to his own house, which was in a cold marsh. After a while

the two women, Bodhmall and Liath, came looking for him, and Fiacuil gave him up to them, and they brought him back to the same place he had been before.

He grew up there, straight and strong and fair-haired and beautiful.

One day he was out on Slieve Bladhma with the two women, and they saw a herd of the wild deer of the mountain ahead of them.

"It's a pity," said the old women, "that we can't get a deer of those deer."

"I'll get one for you," said Finn.

He went after the herd, and caught two stags, and brought them home to the hunting-cabin. After that he hunted for them every day.

But at last they said to him: "It's best for you to leave us now. The sons of Morna are watching again, to kill you."

So he went off by himself, and did not stop until he came to Magh Lifé. There he saw young lads swimming in a lake, and they called to him to swim against them. He went into the lake, and he beat them at swimming.

"Fair he is, and well shaped," they said, watching him swim. And from that time on he had the name of Finn, which means Fair.

But they grew jealous of his strength, and he went away and left them.

He went on until he came to Loch Lein, and took service there with the King of Finntraigh. There was no hunter like him.

"If Cumhal had left a son," the king said, "you would be that son."

He left that king afterwards and went into Carraighe, and took service there with the king who had taken his mother Muirne to wife. One day they were playing chess together, and Finn won seven games, one after another.

"Who are you at all?" said the king.

"I'm the son of a countryman of the Luigne of Teamhair," said Finn.

"You are not," said the king. "You're the son that Muirne my wife bore to Cumhal. Don't stay here any longer, or you'll be killed while you're under my protection."

From there he went into Connacht, looking for his father's brother, Crimall, son of Trenmor. On his way he heard a lone woman crying. He went to her and looked at her, and there were tears of blood on her face.

"Your face is red with blood, woman," he said.

"I have reason for it," she said. "My only son has just been killed by a great fighting man who came on us."

Finn went after the big champion and fought him and killed him. And the man he killed was the same man who had given Cumhal his first wound in the battle where he got his death, and who had carried off his treasure-bag.

As for that treasure-bag: it was made of a crane's skin. The skin had once been Aoife, the beautiful sweetheart of Ilbrec, son of Manannan, who was put into the shape of a crane through jealousy. The bag used to hang in Manannan's house, and there were treasures kept in it: Manannan's shirt and his knife, and the belt and the smith's hook of Goibniu, and the shears of the King of Alban, and the helmet of the King of Lochlann, and a belt made of the skin of a great fish, and the bones of Asal's pig that had been brought to Ireland by the sons of Tuireann. All those treasures would be in the bag at full tide, but at the ebbing of the tide it would be empty. It passed from Manannan to Lugh, son of Ethlinn, and after that to Cumhal, who was husband to Muirne, Ethlinn's daughter.

Finn took the bag and carried it with him until he found Crimall. Crimall was an old man now, living in a lonely place, and some of the old men of the Fianna were with him, and went hunting for him. Finn gave him the bag, and told him his whole story.

Then he said goodbye to Crimall, and went on to learn poetry from Finegas, a poet who lived by the Boinn. The poets always thought it was on the brink of water that poetry was revealed to them. Finn did not give him his own name. He called himself Deimne.

Finegas had been seven years at the Boinn, watching for the salmon. It was in the prophecy that he would eat the salmon of knowledge that would come there, and after that he would

have all knowledge. When at last the salmon of knowledge came, he brought it to Finn and told him to roast it, but told him not to eat any of it.

After a while Finn brought him the salmon.

"Did you eat any of it at all, boy?" said Finegas.

"I did not," said Finn. "But I burned my thumb pressing down a blister that rose on the skin, and after I did that I put my thumb in my mouth."

"What is your name, boy?" said Finegas.

"Deimne."

"It is not. Your name is Finn. And it's to you, and not to me, the salmon was given in the prophecy."

Seven years of waiting. And he gave the boy the whole of the salmon anyway. That is a better thing than it sounds.

From that time Finn had the knowledge that came from the nuts of the nine hazels of wisdom that grow beside the well below the sea.

Besides the wisdom he got then, a second wisdom came to him at another time, and this is how it happened. There was a well of the moon belonging to Beag, son of Buan, of the Tuatha de Danaan. Whoever drank from it would get wisdom, and after a second drink he would get the gift of foretelling. The three daughters of Beag, son of Buan, had charge of the well, and they would not part with a vessel of its water for anything less than red gold. One day Finn happened to be hunting in the rushes near the well, and the three women ran out to keep him from it. One of them had a vessel of the water in her hand, and she threw it at him to stop him, and some of the water went into his mouth. From then on he had all the knowledge that water could give.

He learned the three ways of poetry. And this is the poem he made to show that he had got his learning well:

"The month of May is the pleasant time; its face is beautiful. The blackbird sings his full song; the living wood is his holding; the cuckoos are singing and ever singing. There is a welcome before the brightness of the summer.

"Summer is lessening the rivers; the swift horses are looking for the pool; the heath spreads out its long hair; the weak white bog-down grows. A wildness comes on the heart of the deer; the sad, restless sea is asleep.

"Bees with their little strength carry a load reaped from the flowers; the cattle go up muddy to the mountains; the ant has a good full feast.

"The harp of the woods is playing music; there is colour on the hills, and a haze on the full lakes, and entire peace upon every sail.

"The corncrake is speaking, a loud-voiced poet; the high lonely waterfall is singing a welcome to the warm pool; the talking of the rushes has begun.

"The light swallows are darting; the loudness of music is around the hill; the fat soft mast is budding; there is grass on the trembling bogs.

"The bog is as dark as the feathers of the raven; the cuckoo makes a loud welcome; the speckled salmon is leaping; as strong is the leaping of the swift fighting man.

"The man is gaining; the girl is in her comely growing power; every wood is without fault from the top to the ground, and every wide good plain.

"Pleasant is the colour of the time; rough winter is gone; every plentiful wood is white; summer is a joyful peace.

"A flock of birds pitches in the meadow; there are sounds in the green fields; there is in them a clear rushing stream.

"There is a hot desire on you for the racing of horses; twisted holly makes a leash for the hound; a bright spear has been shot into the earth, and the flag-flower is golden under it.

"A weak, lasting little bird is singing at the top of his voice; the lark is singing clear tidings; May without fault, of beautiful colours.

"I have another story for you. The ox is lowing; the winter is creeping in; the summer is gone. High and cold the wind, low the sun; cries are about us; the sea is quarrelling.

"The ferns are reddened and their shape is hidden; the cry of the wild goose is heard; the cold has caught the wings of the birds. It is the time of ice-frost, hard, unhappy."

After that, while Finn was still only a young lad, he made himself ready and went up at Samhain to the gathering of the High King at Teamhair.

It was the law of that gathering that nobody should raise a quarrel or bring out any grudge against anyone for the whole time it lasted. The king and his chief men were sitting at a feast in the great house of the Middle Court, and Goll, son of Morna, who was now Head of the Fianna, was with them, and Caoilte, son of Ronan, and Conan, son of Morna, of the sharp words. The young lad came in and took his place among them, and not one of them knew who he was.

The High King looked at him. The horn of meetings was brought to the king, and he put it into the boy's hand and asked him who he was.

"I am Finn, son of Cumhal," he said. "Son of the man who used to be head over the Fianna, and king of Ireland. I've come to get your friendship, and to give you my service."

He said it in a hall full of the men who had killed his father. Under the Samhain peace, nobody could lift a hand.

"You are the son of a friend, boy," said the king, "and the son of a man I trusted."

Then Finn stood up and made his agreement of service and of faithfulness to the king. The king took him by the hand and sat him down beside his own son, and they gave themselves to drinking and pleasure for a while.

Now, every year at Samhain for nine years, a man of the Tuatha de Danaan had come out of Sidhe Finnachaidh in the north and burned Teamhair to the ground. His name was Aillen, son of Midhna. This is how he came. He played music of the Sidhe, and all who heard it fell asleep. When they were all asleep, he let a flame of fire out of his mouth, and blew on the flame until all Teamhair was burned.

After a while the king rose at the feast with his smooth horn in his hand. "If I could find among you, men of Ireland," he said, "any man who would keep Teamhair until the break of day tomorrow without its being burned by Aillen, son of Midhna, I would give him whatever inheritance is right for him to have, whether it be much or little."

The men of Ireland made no answer. They knew well that at the sound of the sweet, pitiful music of that comely man of the Sidhe, even women in their pains and wounded men would fall asleep.

It was then Finn stood up and spoke to the King of Ireland.

"Who will be your sureties that you'll fulfil this?"

"The kings of the provinces of Ireland," said the king, "and Cithruadh with his Druids."

So they gave their pledges, and Finn undertook to keep Teamhair safe until the break of day.

There was a fighting man among the followers of the King of Ireland, Fiacha, son of Conga, whom Cumhal, Finn's father, had been very fond of.

"Well, boy," he said to Finn, "what reward would you give me if I brought you a deadly spear that no false cast was ever made with?"

"What reward are you asking?" said Finn.

"Whatever your right hand wins at any time, a third of it to be mine," said Fiacha. "And a third of your trust and your friendship to be mine."

"I'll give you that," said Finn.

Then Fiacha brought him the spear, without the sons of Morna or anyone else knowing.

"When you hear the music of the Sidhe," he said, "strip the covering off the head of the spear, and put it to your forehead. The power of the spear won't let sleep come on you."

That is the rule of the spear. Hold the blade to your own head. The pain keeps you awake. There are worse ways to stay awake, and very few better.

Then Finn stood up in front of all the men of Ireland and made a round of the whole of Teamhair.

It was not long before he heard the sorrowful music. He stripped the covering off the head of the spear, and held the power of it to his forehead.

Aillen went on playing his little harp until he had put everyone to sleep as he always did. Then he let a flame of fire out of his mouth to burn Teamhair.

Finn held up his fringed crimson cloak against the flame. The flame fell down through the air and went into the ground, and carried the four-folded cloak deep into the earth with it.

When Aillen saw his spells were broken, he went back to Sidhe Finnachaidh on the top of Slieve Fuad. But Finn followed him there, and as Aillen was going in at the door, Finn threw the spear, and it went through his heart. Then Finn struck off his head and brought it back to Teamhair, and fixed it on a crooked pole, and left it there until the sun rose over the heights and the river-mouths of the country.

Aillen's mother came to where his body was lying. There was great grief on her, and she made this lament:

"Ochone! Aillen is fallen, chief of the Sidhe of Beinn Boirche; the slow clouds of death have come on him. Och! he was pleasant; och! he was kind: Aillen, son of Midhna of Slieve Fuad.

"Nine times he burned Teamhair. It is a great name he was always looking for. Ochone, ochone, Aillen!"

He had burned Teamhair nine times, and to his mother he was pleasant and kind. Both things were true.

At the break of day, the king and all the men of Ireland came out onto the lawn at Teamhair, where Finn was.

"King," said Finn, "there is the head of the man who burned Teamhair, and the pipe and the harp that made his music. And it's my opinion that Teamhair and everything in it is saved."

Then they all came together into the place of counsel, and they agreed that the headship of the Fianna of Ireland should be given to Finn.

"Well, Goll," the king said to Goll, son of Morna, "is it your choice to leave Ireland, or to put your hand in Finn's hand?"

"By my word," said Goll, "I'll give Finn my hand."

When the charms that bring good luck had done their work, the chief men of the Fianna stood up and struck their hands into Finn's hand. And Goll, son of Morna, was the first to give him his hand, so that there would be less shame on the rest for doing it.

Goll had killed Finn's father. And he was the first to kneel. That is Goll. Remember him.

Finn kept the headship of the Fianna until the end. The place he lived in was Almhuin of Leinster, where Nuada of the Tuatha de Danaan had built the white dun — as white as if all the lime in Ireland had been put on it. It got its name from a great herd of cattle that died fighting once around the well there, and left their horns behind them, speckled horns and white.

As for Finn himself: he was a king and a seer and a poet, a Druid and a man of knowledge, and everything he said was sweet-sounding to his people. A better fighting man than Finn never struck his hand into a king's hand, and whatever anyone ever said of him, he was three times better.

It was said of his justice that if his enemy and his own son had come before him to be judged, he would have given a fair judgment between them.

It was said of his generosity that he never refused any man anything as long as that man had a mouth to eat with and legs to carry away what he was given. He left no woman without her bride-price, and no man without his pay. He never promised at night what he would not fulfil in the morning, and he never promised in the day what he would not fulfil at night. And he never forsook his right-hand friend.

If he was quiet in peace, he was angry in battle, and Oisín his son and Osgar his son's son followed him in that.

A young man of Ulster came once and claimed kinship with them, saying they were of the one blood.

"If that's so," said Oisín, "it's from the men of Ulster we took the madness and the angry heart we have in battle."

"That is so indeed," said Finn.

Finn's Household



In those days the Fianna of Ireland numbered seven score and ten chief men, and every one of them had three times nine fighting men under him.

Every man of them was bound to three things. To take no cattle by oppression. Not to refuse any man, whether it was cattle or riches he asked for. And never to fall back before nine fighting men.

No man was taken into the Fianna until his tribe and his kindred gave securities for him that, even if they themselves were all killed, he would not look for satisfaction for their deaths. And if he himself did harm to others, that harm was not to be avenged on his people.

No man was taken into the Fianna until he knew the twelve books of poetry.

And these were the tests. Before any man was taken, he was put into a deep hole in the ground up to his middle, with his shield and a hazel rod in his hand. Nine men went off the length of ten furrows from him and threw their spears at him all at the one time. If he got a wound from any of them, he was not thought fit to join the Fianna.

After that his hair was fastened up, and he was set to run through the woods of Ireland, and the Fianna came after him to see whether they could wound him, with only the length of a branch between him and them when they started. If they caught him and wounded him, he was not let join. Nor was he, if his spears had trembled in his hand, or if a branch of a tree had undone the plaiting of his hair, or if he had cracked a dry stick under his foot as he ran.

And they would not take him among them until he had leapt over a stick the height of himself, and stooped under one the height of his knee, and pulled a thorn out of his foot with his nail — all while running his fastest.

If he had done all those things, he was one of Finn's people.

The wages Finn and the Fianna got in those days were good: a townland in every district, and in every house the fostering of a pup or a whelp from Samhain to Beltaine, and a great many other things besides. But however good the pay was, the hardships and dangers they went through for it were greater. They had to keep strangers and robbers from beyond the seas, and every bad thing, from coming into Ireland. They had hard work enough doing it.

Besides the fighting men, Finn had with him his five Druids, the best that ever came into the west. One of them was Cainnelsciath, of the Shining Shield, who used to bring knowledge down out of the clouds in the sky for Finn, and who could foretell battles. He had his five wonderful physicians, four of them from Ireland and one who came over the sea from the east. He had his five high poets, and his twelve musicians, and among them were Daighre, son of Morna, and Suanach, son of Senshenn, Finn's teller of old stories, the sweetest that ever took a harp in his hand in Ireland or in Alban. He had his three cup-bearers and his six door-keepers, and his horn-players, and the stewards of his house, and his huntsman, Comhrag of the five hundred hounds, and his serving-men, who were under Garbhchronan, of the Rough Buzzing. And a great troop of others with them.

Fifty of the best sewing-women in Ireland were gathered together in a rath on Magh Feman, under the charge of a daughter of the King of Britain, and they made clothing for the Fianna the whole year round. Three of them, who were a king's daughters, made music for the rest on a little silver harp. There was a very great candlestick of stone in the middle of the rath, because they would not kindle a fire more than three times in the year, for fear the smoke and the ashes might harm the needlework.

Of all his musicians, the one Finn thought most of was Cnu Deireoil, the Little Nut, who came to him from the Sidhe.

Finn was at Slieve-nam-ban for hunting the time he came. He was sitting on the turf-built grave that is there, and when he looked around him he saw a small little man, about four feet tall, standing on the grass. He had light yellow hair hanging down to his waist, and he was playing music on his harp. There was no fault at all in the music he made, and it was a wonder the whole of the Fianna did not fall asleep with the sweetness of it.

The little man came up and put his hand in Finn's hand.

"Where do you come from, little one," said Finn, "you and your sweet music?"

"I've come out of the place of the Sidhe in Slieve-nam-ban," he said, "where ale is drunk and made. I've come here to be in your company for a while."

"You'll get good rewards from me," said Finn, "and riches, and red gold, and my full friendship. I like you well."

"That's the best luck that ever came to you, Finn," said all the rest of the Fianna, for they were well pleased to have him with them.

They gave him the name of the Little Nut. He was good at speaking, and his memory was so good he never forgot anything he heard, east or west. There was nobody who did not have to stop and listen to his music, and all the Fianna liked him well. Some said he was a son of Lugh Lamh-Fada, of the Long Hand.

The five musicians of the Fianna were brought to him to learn the music of the Sidhe that he had brought from that other place, for there was never any music heard on earth that his was not better than.

These were the three best things Finn ever got: Bran and Sceolan, who were without fault, and the Little Nut from the House of the Sidhe in Slieve-nam-ban.

Two of those three were hounds. That is a story too.

CHAPTER III

Birth Of Bran



This is the story of the birth of Bran.

Finn's mother, Muirne, came once to Almhuin, and brought her sister Tuiren with her.

Iollan Eachtach, a chief man of the Fianna of Ulster, was at Almhuin at the time. He gave his love to Tuiren, and asked for her in marriage, and took her to his own house. But before they went, Finn made him give his word that he would bring her back safe and sound if ever Finn asked for her, and told him to find sureties for himself among the chief men of the Fianna. Iollan did that. The sureties he got were Caoilte and Goll and Lugaidh Lamha, and it was Lugaidh who gave her into the hand of Iollan Eachtach.

But before Iollan made that marriage he had had a sweetheart of the Sidhe, Uchtdealb of the Fair Breast. A great jealousy came on her when she learned he had taken a wife.

She put on the appearance of Finn's woman-messenger and came to the house where Tuiren was.

"Finn sends health and long life to you, queen," she said, "and he bids you make a great feast. And come with me now until I speak a few words with you, for I'm in a hurry."

So Tuiren went out with her. When they were away from the house, the woman of the Sidhe took her dark Druid rod out from under her cloak and struck Tuiren a blow with it that changed her into a hound — the most beautiful hound that was ever seen.

Then she went on, bringing the hound with her, to the house of Fergus Fionnliath, king of the harbour of Gallimh.

Fergus was the most unfriendly man to dogs in the whole world. He would not let one stay in the same house with him.

"Finn wishes you life and health, Fergus," said Uchtdealb, "and he tells you to take good care of his hound until he comes himself. Mind her well, for she's with young. Don't let her go hunting when her time is near, or Finn will be no way thankful to you."

"I wonder at that message," said Fergus, "for Finn knows well there's no man in the world has less liking for dogs than I have. But all the same, I won't refuse Finn the first time he's sent a hound to me."

When he took the hound out to try her, she was the best he had ever known. She never saw a wild creature she did not run down. And Fergus took a great liking to hounds from then on.

When her time came near, they did not let her go hunting any more, and she gave birth to two whelps.

As for Finn: when he heard that his mother's sister was not living with Iollan Eachtach, he called on Iollan to fulfil the pledge he had given the Fianna. Iollan asked for time to go looking for Tuiren, and gave his word that if he did not find her he would give himself up in satisfaction for her.

They agreed to that, and Iollan went to the hill where Uchtdealb was, his sweetheart of the Sidhe, and told her how things stood with him, and the promise he had made to give himself up to the Fianna.

"If that's so," she said, "and if you'll give me your pledge to keep me as your sweetheart to the end of your life, I'll free you from that danger."

So Iollan gave her his promise. She went to the house of Fergus Fionnliath and brought Tuiren away, and put her own shape back on her, and gave her up to Finn. And Finn gave her to Lugaidh Lamha, who asked for her in marriage.

As for the two whelps, they stayed with Finn always. The names he gave them were Bran and Sceolan.

They were his cousins. He never forgot it, and neither, in their way, did they.

Oisín's Mother



Finn and his men were coming back from hunting one time when a beautiful fawn started up in front of them. They followed it, men and dogs, until at last they were all tired and fell back — all but Finn himself, and Bran and Sceolan.

Suddenly, as they were going through a valley, the fawn stopped and lay down on the smooth grass. Bran and Sceolan came up with it. They did not harm it at all. They played about it, licking its neck and its face.

Finn wondered at that. He went on home to Almhuin, and the fawn followed him, playing with the hounds, and came with them into the house.

Late that evening, when Finn was alone, a beautiful young woman in a rich dress came before him. She told him she herself was the fawn he had been hunting that day.

"It was for refusing the love of Fear Doirche, the Dark Druid of the Men of Dea, that I was put into this shape," she said. "For three years I've lived the life of a wild deer in a far part of Ireland, and I'm hunted like a wild deer. A serving-man of the Dark Druid took pity on me. He said that if I were once inside the dun of the Fianna of Ireland, the Druid would have no more power over me. So I ran, and I never stopped the whole length of a day until I came into the district of Almhuin. And I never stopped then until there was no one after me but Bran and Sceolan, who have human wits. I was safe with them, for they knew my nature was like their own."

Then Finn gave her his love, and took her as his wife, and she stayed in Almhuin. Her name was Sadbh.

So great was his love for her that he gave up his hunting and all the things he used to take pleasure in, and gave his mind to nothing else but her.

Finn, who never refused any man. Finn, who was never still. For a while, he was only a husband. It was the happiest he was ever to be.

But at last the men of Lochlann came against Ireland. Their ships came into the bay below Beinn Edair, and they landed there.

Finn and the battalions of the Fianna went out against them and drove them back. At the end of seven days Finn came home. He went quickly over the plain of Almhuin, thinking to see Sadbh his wife looking out from the dun. There was no sign of her.

When he came to the dun, all his people came out to meet him, and they had a very down-cast look.

"Where is the flower of Almhuin?" he asked them. "Where is beautiful, gentle Sadbh?"

And this is what they said.

"While you were away fighting, your likeness, and the likeness of Bran and of Sceolan, appeared in front of the dun, and we thought we heard the sweet call of the Dord Fiann. And Sadbh, who was so good and so beautiful, came out of the house and went out through the gates. She wouldn't listen to us, and we couldn't stop her.

"'Let me go and meet my love,' she said, 'my husband, the father of the child that isn't born.'

"And she went running out towards the shadow of you that was in front of her, with its arms stretched out to her. But no sooner did she touch it than she gave a great cry. And the shadow lifted up a hazel rod, and that moment it was a fawn standing on the grass.

"Three times she turned and made for the gate of the dun. But the two hounds the shadow had with him went after her and took her by the throat and dragged her back to him.

"And by your hand of valour, Finn, we made no delay, but went out on the plain after her. But — our grief — they had all vanished. There was no woman to be seen, nor fawn, nor Druid. But we could hear the quick tread of feet on the hard plain, and the howling of dogs. And if you asked every one of us which quarter he heard those sounds from, each one would tell you a different one."

When Finn heard that, he said no word at all. He struck his breast over and over again with his closed fists. Then he went into his own inner room, and his people did not see him

again that day, or until the sun rose over Magh Lifé the next morning.

For seven years after that, whenever he was not out fighting the enemies of Ireland, he went searching, and searching, in every far corner of the country for beautiful Sadbh. There was great trouble on him the whole time, unless he could throw it off for a while in hunting or in battle. And in all that time he never took any hounds out hunting but the five he trusted most — Bran and Sceolan and Lomaire and Brod and Lomluath — so that there would be no danger to Sadbh if ever he came on her track.

He never found her.

At the end of seven years, Finn and some of his chief men were hunting on the sides of Beinn Gulbain, and they heard a great outcry among the hounds, which had gone into some narrow place. When they followed them in, they saw Finn's five hounds in a ring, keeping the other hounds back. In the middle of the ring was a young boy with high looks, naked, with long hair.

He was not frightened by the noise of the hounds. He did not look at them at all. He was looking at the men who were coming up.

As soon as the fight was stopped, Bran and Sceolan went up to the little lad and whined and licked him, so that anyone would think they had forgotten their master.

Finn and the others came up to him then, and put their hands on his head, and made much of him. They brought him to their own hunting-cabin, and he ate and drank with them, and before long he lost his wildness and was the same as they were. And as for Bran and Sceolan, they never tired of playing about him.

Finn thought there was some look of Sadbh in his face, and that he might be her son, and he kept him always beside him.

Little by little, as the boy learned their speech, he told them all he could remember.

He had lived with a deer, he said, whom he loved very much, and who cared for him and sheltered him. They lived in a wide place with hills and valleys and streams and woods in it, but it was shut in with high cliffs on every side, so that there was no way out. He ate

fruits and roots in the summer, and in the winter there was food left for him in the shelter of a cave.

A dark-looking man used to come to that place. Sometimes he spoke to the deer softly and gently, and sometimes in a loud, angry voice. But whichever way he spoke, she always drew away from him, as if in great dread, and the man would go away in a great rage.

The last time the boy saw the deer, his mother, the dark man talked to her for a long time, from softness to anger. At the end he struck her with a hazel rod. With that she was forced to follow him, and she kept looking back at the child the whole time, crying out after him so that anyone would have pitied her. He tried hard to follow her, and made every attempt, and cried out with grief and rage. But he had no power to move. And when he could hear his mother no more, he fell down on the grass, and his wits went from him.

When he woke, he was on the side of the hill where the hounds found him. He searched a long time for the place where he had been brought up, but he could not find it.

The name the Fianna gave him was Oisín, which means Little Fawn. He was their maker of poems afterwards, and their good fighter.



Oisín — Poet-Warrior of the Fianna

He would outlive them all. But that was a long way off yet.



Book Two: Finn's Helpers



The Best Men Of The Fianna



While Oisín was still in his early youth, Finn had other good men with him, and the best of them were Goll, son of Morna, and Caoilte, son of Ronan, and Lugaidh's Son.

Goll was of Connacht. He was very tall and light-haired, and some say he was the strongest of all the Fianna. Finn made a poem in praise of him once, when some stranger was asking what kind of man he was. He said how hardy Goll was and how brave in battle, as strong as a hound or as the waves; and with all that, how kind and gentle, and open-handed, and sweet-voiced, and faithful to his friends.

This was the man who had killed Finn's father. Finn made a poem for him anyway. That is the kind of thing that was possible, once.

Goll's chessboard was called the Solustairtech, the Shining Thing. Some of the chessmen were made of gold and some of silver, and each of them was as big as the fist of the biggest man of the Fianna. After the death of Goll it was buried in Slieve Baune.

Caoilte was a grey, thin man, and he was the best runner of them all. He did a good many great deeds. He killed a big man of the Fomor once. He killed a five-headed giant in a wheeling door. Another time he made an end of an enchanted boar that nobody else could get near. And he killed a grey stag that had escaped the Fianna for twenty-seven years.

Another time he brought Finn out of Teamhair, where the High King was keeping him by force because of some rebellion the Fianna had stirred up.

When Caoilte heard that Finn had been carried off to Teamhair, he went out to avenge him. The first man he killed was Cuireach, a king of Leinster with a great name, and he carried his head up to the hill above Buadhmaic. After that he made a great rout through Ireland, bringing sorrow into every house for Finn's sake, killing a man in every place, and killing the calves along with the cows. Every door the red wind from the east blew on, he threw open, and went in and destroyed everything in front of him, setting fire to the fields, and giving one man's wife to another.

When he came to Teamhair, he went to the palace and took the clothes off the door-keeper. He left his own sword, worn thin with use, in the king's sheath, and took the king's sword, which had great power in it. Then he went into the palace disguised as a servant, to see how best to free Finn.

When evening came, Caoilte held the candle at the king's feast in the great hall.

After a while the king said, "You'll wonder at what I tell you, Finn. The two eyes of Caoilte are in my candlestick."

"Don't say that," said Finn, "and don't put reproach on my people, even if I myself am your prisoner. As for Caoilte, that's not his way. He has a high mind, and he only does high deeds. He wouldn't stand serving with a candle for all the gold of the whole world."

After that Caoilte was serving drink to the King of Ireland, and as he stood beside him he let out a high, sorrowful lament.

"There's the smell of Caoilte's skin on that lament," said the king.

When Caoilte saw he was known, he spoke out. "Tell me how I can get freedom for my master."

"There's only one way to get freedom for him," said the king, "and it's a thing you can never do. If you can bring me together a pair of every one of the wild creatures of Ireland, I'll give your master up to you then."

When Caoilte heard that, he made no delay. He set out from Teamhair and went through the whole of Ireland to do that work for Finn's sake. He started with the flocks of birds, though they were scattered in every part, and from them he went on to the beasts. And he gathered together two of every kind.

Two ravens from Fiodh da Bheann. Two wild ducks from Loch na Seillein. Two foxes from Slieve Cuilinn. Two wild oxen from Burren. Two swans from blue Dobhran. Two owls from the wood of Faradhruim. Two polecats from the branchy wood on the side of Druim da Raoin, the Ridge of the Victories. Two gulls from the strand of Loch Leith. Four woodpeckers from white Brosna. Two plovers from Carraigh Dhain. Two thrushes from Leith

Lomard. Two wrens from Dun Aoibh. Two herons from Corrain Cleibh. Two eagles from Carraig of the Stones. Two hawks from Fiodh Chonnach. Two sows from Loch Meilghe. Two water-hens from Loch Erne. Two moor-hens from Monadh Maith. Two sparrow-hawks from Dubhloch. Two stonechats from Magh Cuilleán. Two tomtits from Magh Tuallainn. Two swallows from Sean Abhla. Two cormorants from Ath Cliath. Two wolves from Broit Cliathach. Two blackbirds from the Strand of the Two Women. Two roebucks from Luachair Ire. Two pigeons from Ceas Chuir. Two nightingales from Leiter Ruadh. Two starlings from green-sided Teamhair. Two rabbits from Sith Dubh Donn. Two wild pigs from Cluaidh Chuir. Two cuckoos from Drom Daibh. Two lapwings from Leanain na Furraich. Two woodcocks from Craobh Ruadh. Two hawks from the Bright Mountain. Two grey mice from Luimneach. Two otters from the Boinn. Two larks from the Great Bog. Two bats from the Cave of the Nuts. Two badgers from the province of Ulster. Two landrail from the banks of the Sionnan. Two wagtails from Port Lairrge. Two curlews from the harbour of Gallimh. Two hares from Muirthemne. Two deer from Sith Buidhe. Two peacocks from Magh Mell. Two more cormorants from Ath Cliath. Two eels from Duth Dur. Two goldfinches from Slieve na-n Eun. Two birds of slaughter from Magh Bhuilg. Two bright swallows from Granard. Two redbreasts from the Great Wood. Two rock-cod from Cala Chairge. Two sea-pigs from the great sea. Two wrens from Mios an Chuil. Two salmon from Eas Mhic Muirne. Two clean deer from Gleann na Smoil. Two cows from Magh Mor. Two cats from the Cave of Cruachan. Two sheep from bright Sidhe Diobhlain. Two pigs of the pigs of the son of Lir. A ram and a crimson sheep from Innis.

And along with all these he brought ten hounds of the hounds of the Fianna, and a horse and a mare of the beautiful horses of Manannan.

When Caoilte had gathered all of them, he brought them to the one place. But when he tried to keep them together, they scattered away from him in every direction. The raven went off southward, and that vexed him badly, but he caught it again in Gleann da Bheann, beside Loch Lurcan. Then his wild duck went off, and it was not easy to get back. He followed it through every stream as far as grey Accuill, until he took it by the neck and brought it back, and it not at all willing.

For the rest of his life Caoilte remembered well everything he went through that time with the birds, big and little, travelling over hills and ditches and struggling to bring them with him, so that he could set Finn his master free.

When he came to Teamhair he had more to go through yet. The king would not let him bring them in before morning, but gave him a house with nine doors to keep them in for the night. No sooner were they put in than they raised a loud screech all together, for a little ray of light was coming in to them through fifty openings, and they were all trying to escape. If they were not easy inside the house, Caoilte was not easy outside it, watching every door until sunrise.

When he brought his troop out, the people called them Caoilte's Rabble. And no wonder.

But all the profit the King of Ireland got from them was to see them together that one time. For no sooner did Finn get his freedom than the whole of them scattered, and no two of them left Teamhair by the same road.

That was one of the best things Caoilte, son of Ronan, ever did.

Another time he ran from the wave of Cliodna in the south to the wave of Rudraige in the north. Colla his son was a very good runner too. Once he ran a race backwards against the three battalions of the Fianna, for a chessboard. He won the race. But he went backwards over Beinn Edair into the sea.

Caoilte had very good hearing. One time he heard the King of the Luigne of Connacht at his hunting, and Blathmec, who was with him, said: "What hunt is that, Caoilte?"

"A hunt of three packs of hounds," he said, "and three kinds of wild creature in front of them. The first hunt is after stags and large deer. The second hunt is after swift small hares. The third is a furious hunt after heavy boars."

"And what's the fourth hunt, Caoilte?" said Blathmec.

"It's the hunting of heavy-sided, low-bellied badgers."

Then they heard, coming after the hunt, the shouts of the lads, and of the readiest of the men, and of the serving-men who were best at carrying burdens. Blathmec went out to see

the hunting, and it was exactly as Caoilte had told him.

He understood the use of herbs, too. Once he met two women who were very downhearted because their husbands had left them to take other wives. Caoilte gave them Druid herbs, and they put them in the water of a bath and washed in it. The love of their husbands came back to them, and the husbands sent away the new wives they had taken.

As for Lugaidh's Son, he was of Finn's blood, and another of the best men of the Fianna. He was put into Finn's arms as a child, and reared by Duban's daughter, who had reared eight hundred fighting men of the Fianna, until his twelfth year. Then she gave him all he wanted of weapons and armour, and he went to Chorraig Conluain and the mountains of Slieve Bladhma, where Finn and the Fianna were at that time.

Finn gave him a very gentle welcome. The boy struck his hand in Finn's hand and made his agreement of service with him, and stayed a year with the Fianna.

But he was somehow sluggish that whole time, so that under his leadership no more than nine of the Fianna got to kill so much as a boar or a deer. And he used to beat both his servants and his hounds.

At last the three battalions of the Fianna went to Finn at the Point of the Fianna, on the edge of Loch Lein, and made their complaint against Lugaidh's Son.

"Make your choice now," they said. "Will you have us with you, or will you have Lugaidh's Son by himself?"

Then Lugaidh's Son came to Finn, and Finn asked him, "What is it has put the whole of the Fianna against you?"

"By my word," said the lad, "I don't know the reason — unless it's that they don't like me doing my feats and throwing my spears among them."

Then Finn gave him advice. This is what he said:

"If you have a mind to be a good champion, be quiet in a great man's house; be surly in the narrow pass. Don't beat your hound without a cause. Don't bring a charge against your wife without knowledge of her guilt. Don't hurt a fool in fighting, for he's without his wits. Don't

find fault with high-up persons. Don't stand up to take part in a quarrel. Have no dealings with a bad man or a foolish man.

"Let two-thirds of your gentleness be shown to women, and to little children creeping on the floor, and to men of learning who make the poems; and don't be rough with the common people.

"Don't give your reverence to everyone. Don't be ready to share one bed with your companions. Don't threaten or talk big, for it's a shameful thing to speak stiffly unless you can carry it out afterwards.

"Don't forsake your lord as long as you live. Don't give up any man who puts himself under your protection, for all the treasures of the world. Don't speak against others to their lord; that's not work for a good man. Don't be a bearer of lying stories, or a tale-bearer that's always chattering. Don't talk too much. Don't find fault hastily. However brave you are, don't raise factions against you.

"Don't be going to drinking-houses, or finding fault with old men. Don't meddle with low people. This is right conduct I'm telling you.

"Don't refuse to share your meat. Don't have a miser for your friend. Don't force yourself on a great man, or give him occasion to speak against you. Hold fast to your weapons until the hard fight is well ended. Don't give up your opportunity — but with it, follow after gentleness."

That was good advice, and Finn was well able to give it. It was said of him that he had all the wisdom of a little child who is busy about the house, when his mother herself doesn't understand what he's doing — and that's the time she's proudest of him.

As for Lugaidh's Son, that advice stayed with him always, and he changed his ways. After a while he got a great name among the poets of Ireland and of Alban, and whenever they praised Finn in their poems, they praised him too.

Aoife, daughter of the King of Lochlann, who was married to Mal, son of Aiel, King of Alban, heard the great praise the poets were giving Lugaidh's Son, and she set her love on him for the sake of those stories.

One time Mal her husband and his young men went hunting to Slieve-mor-Monaidh, in the north of Alban. While he was gone, Aoife made a plan, in the sunny house where she was, to go over to Ireland, she and her nine foster-sisters. They set out over the manes of the sea until they came to Beinn Edair, and landed there.

It happened that on that day there was a hunt going on from Slieve Bladhma to Beinn Edair. Finn was in his hunting-seat, with his fosterling, brown-haired Duibhruinn, beside him. The little lad was looking about him on every side, and he saw a ship coming in to the strand, and a queen with modest looks in the ship, and nine women with her.

They landed and came up to where Finn was, bringing every kind of present with them, and Aoife sat down beside him. Finn asked her news, and she told him the whole story: how she had given her love to Lugaidh's Son, and had come over the sea looking for him. And Finn made her welcome.

When the hunting was over, the chief men of the Fianna came back to where Finn was, and every one of them asked who the queen with him was. Finn told them her name and what had brought her to Ireland.

"We welcome her who made that journey," they all said. "There's no better man in Ireland or in Alban than the man she's come looking for, unless it's Finn himself."

As for Lugaidh's Son, he had been hunting on the far side of Slieve Bladhma that day, and he was the last to come in. He went into Finn's tent, and when he saw the woman beside him he asked Finn the same as the others had, and Finn told him the whole story.

"And it's to you she's come," he said. "Here she is for you, out of my hand, and all the war and the battles she brings with her. But it won't fall heavier on you than on the rest of the Fianna."

She was with Lugaidh's Son a month and a year without anyone coming to ask for her.

Then one day the three battalions of the Fianna were on the Hill of the Poet in Leinster, and they saw three armed battalions, equal to themselves, coming against them. They asked who was leading them.

"It's Mal, son of Aiel, leading them," said Finn, "to avenge his wife on the Fianna. And it's a good time they've come, when we're all gathered together in the one spot."

Then the two armies went towards each other. Mal, son of Aiel, took hold of his weapons, and three times he broke through the Fianna, and every time a hundred fell by him. In the middle of the battle he and Lugaidh's Son met, and they fought each other with spear and sword. Whether the fight was short or long, it was Mal who fell at the last, by the hand of Lugaidh's Son.

Aoife stood on a hill near by for as long as the battle lasted.

From that day on she belonged to Lugaidh's Son, and was a mother of children to him.

She had crossed the sea for a man she knew only from poems. It is the kind of thing poems do.

CHAPTER I

The Lad Of The Skins



Besides all the men Finn had in his household, there were some who came and joined him from one place or another.

Once a young man wearing a dress of skins came to Finn's house at Almhuin, with his wife, and asked to take service with Finn.

In the morning, as they were going out to hunt, the Lad of the Skins said to Finn: "Let me have no one with me but myself. Let me go into one part of the country alone, and you with all your men go to another."

"Will you go on the dry ridges," said Finn, "or in the deep bogs and marshes, where there's danger of drowning?"

"I'll go in the deep boggy places," he said.

So they all went out from Almhuin, Finn and the Fianna to one part, and the Lad of the Skins to another, and they hunted all day. When they came back at evening, the Lad of the Skins had killed more than Finn and all his men together.

When Finn saw that, he was glad to have so good a servant.

But Conan said to him, "The Lad of the Skins will destroy us and the whole of the Fianna of Ireland, unless you find some way to rid yourself of him."

"I never had a good man with me yet, Conan," said Finn, "but you wanted me to put him away. And how could I put away a man like that?"

"The way to put him away," said Conan, "is to send him to the King of the Floods, to take from him the great cauldron that's never without meat, but always has enough in it to feed the whole world. And let him bring that cauldron back here to Almhuin."

This is Conan. You will get to know him. There is one in every company.

So Finn called the Lad of the Skins and said, "Go from me now to the King of the Floods, and get the great cauldron that's never empty from him, and bring it here to me."

"As long as I'm in your service I must do your work," said the Lad of the Skins.

He set out, leaping over the hills and valleys until he came to the shore of the sea. There he picked up two sticks and laid one across the other, and a great ship rose up out of the two sticks.

The Lad of the Skins went into the ship and put up the sails and set out over the sea. He heard nothing but the whistling of eels in the sea and the calling of gulls in the air until he came to the house of the King of the Floods. There were hundreds of ships waiting near the shore. He left his own ship outside them all, and stepped from ship to ship until he stood on land.

There was a great feast going on in the king's house. The Lad of the Skins went up to the door, but he could get no farther because of the crowd. So he stood outside the door a while, and nobody looked at him, and at last he called out: "This is a hospitable house indeed, and these are mannerly ways, not to ask a stranger if there's hunger on him or thirst."

"That's true," said the king. "Give the cauldron of plenty to this stranger now, until he eats his fill."

His people did that. The moment the Lad of the Skins got hold of the cauldron, he ran off to the ship and put it safe inside.

But when he had done it he said: "There's no use taking the pot by my swiftness if I don't take it by my strength."

So he turned and went back to land. The whole army of the King of the Floods was ready to fight. So was the Lad of the Skins. He went through them and over them all until the whole place was quiet.

Then he went back to his ship and raised the sails and set out again for Ireland, and the ship went rushing back to the place where he had made it. When he got there he gave the

ship a touch of his hand, and there was nothing left of it but the two sticks he had made it from, lying on the strand in front of him, and the cauldron of plenty with them. He took the cauldron up on his back and brought it to Finn, son of Cumhal, at Almuin. And Finn thanked him for the work he had done.

One day Finn was washing himself at the well, and a voice spoke out of the water.

"You must give back the cauldron, Finn, to the King of the Floods," it said, "or you must give him battle in place of it."

Finn told that to the Lad of the Skins. But the answer he got was that the Lad's time was up, and he could not serve on time that was past.

"But if you want me to go with you," he said, "watch my wife through the night. She is Manannan's daughter. In the middle of the night, when she's combing her hair, whatever request you make of her, she can't refuse it. And the request you'll make is that she'll let me go with you to the King of the Floods, to bring the cauldron to his house and bring it back again."

So Finn watched Manannan's daughter through the night. When he saw her combing her hair, he made his request.

"I have no power to refuse you," she said. "But you must promise me one thing: to bring my husband back to me, alive or dead. If he's alive, put up a grey-green flag on the ship coming back. If he's dead, put up a red flag."

Finn promised to do that. And he and the Lad of the Skins set out together for the dun of the King of the Floods, bringing the cauldron with them.

No sooner did the king see them than he told all his armies to make ready. But the Lad of the Skins went at them and overthrew them, and went into the king's dun, and Finn with him, and they overcame the king, and carried off the cauldron that was never empty a second time.

But as they were going back to Ireland they saw a great ship coming towards them.

When the Lad of the Skins looked at it he said, "I think there's an old enemy of mine in that ship, trying to bring me to my death, because of my wife, who refused him her love."

When the ship came alongside, the man in it called out: "I know you well — and it's not by your clothes I know you, son of the King of the Hills."

With that he leapt onto their ship, and the two of them fought a great battle together, and they took every shape. They began young, like two little boys, and fought until they were two old men. They fought from being two young pups until they were two old dogs; from being two young horses until they were two old horses. Then they began to fight in the shape of birds, and it was in that shape they killed each other at the last.

Finn threw the one bird into the water. But the other, which was the Lad of the Skins, he brought with him in the ship. And when he came in sight of Ireland he raised a red flag, as he had promised the woman.

When he came to the strand she was there before him. When she saw Finn, she said, "It's dead you've brought him back to me."

Finn gave her the bird, and she asked if that was what she was to get in place of her husband. She was crying over the bird. She took it into a little boat with her, and told Finn to push the boat out to sea.

He pushed it out. It was driven by wind and waves until at last she saw two birds flying with a dead one between them. The two living birds set the dead one down on an island. It was not long before it rose up alive, and the three went away together.

When Manannan's daughter saw that, she said, "There might be some cure for my man on that island, the way there was for that dead bird."

The sea brought the boat to the island, and she went searching around it, but all she could find was a tree with green leaves.

"It might be in these leaves the cure is," she said.

She took some of the leaves and brought them to where the Lad of the Skins lay, and put them about him. And that moment he stood up, as well and as sound as he had ever been.

Finn had brought him home dead. It was his wife who found the way to bring him back.

They went back to Ireland then, and came to Almhuin at midnight, and the Lad of the Skins knocked at the door.

"Put out my wages to me," he said.

"There's no man living or dead has wages owing from me but the Lad of the Skins," said Finn. "And I'd sooner see him here tonight than the wages of three men."

"If that's so, get up and you'll see him," said he.

So Finn got up and saw him, and gave him a great welcome, and paid him his wages.

After that he went away, and his wife with him, to wherever his own country was. Some said he had gone to the country of his wife's father, Manannan, Son of the Sea.

Black, Brown, And Grey



Finn was hunting one time near Teamhair of the Kings, and he saw three strange men coming towards him, and asked them their names.

"Dubh and Dun and Glasan — Black, Brown, and Grey — are our names," they said. "We've come to find Finn, son of Cumhal, Head of the Fianna, and to take service with him."

So Finn took them into his service. When evening came he said: "Let each of you watch through a third part of the night."

There was a tree-trunk there, and he told them to cut it into three equal parts, and he gave a part to each of the three men.

"When each of you begins his watch," he said, "let him set fire to his own log. As long as the wood burns, let him watch."

That is the rule. The log is the watch. When the log is ash, the watch is over, and not before.

They drew lots, and the lot fell to Dubh to take the first watch. He set fire to his log and went out around the place, and Bran with him.

He went farther and farther until at last he saw a bright light. When he came to the place it was coming from, he saw a large house. He went inside. There was a great company of very strange-looking men in it, all drinking out of a single cup. One of them, who seemed to be the highest, gave the cup to the man nearest him, and when that man had drunk his fill he passed it on to the next, and so on to the last.

While it was going round, the highest one said: "This is the great cup that was taken from Finn, son of Cumhal, a hundred years ago. However many men are together, every one of them can drink his fill from it, of whatever drink he has a mind for."

Dubh was sitting near the door, on the edge of the crowd. When the cup came to him he took a drink from it, and then slipped away in the dark, taking it with him. When he came back to where Finn was, his log had burned out.

Then it was Dun's turn, for the second lot had fallen on him. He set light to his log and went out, and Bran with him.

He walked on through the night until he saw a fire shining out of a large house, and when he went in he saw a crowd of men fighting. A very old man, sitting in a high place above the rest, called out: "Stop fighting now. I have a better gift for you than the one you lost tonight."

With that he drew a knife out of his belt and held it up. "This is the wonderful knife, the small knife of division, that was stolen from Finn, son of Cumhal, a hundred years ago. You have only to cut on a bone with this knife, and you'll get your fill of the best meat in the world."

He gave the knife to the man nearest him, with a bare bone, and the man began to cut, and slices of the best meat in the world came off the bone.

The knife and the bone were passed round from man to man until they came to Dun. As soon as he had the knife in his hand he slipped out unnoticed and hurried back. He had just got to the well where Finn was when his part of the log burned out.

Then Glasan lit his log and went out on his watch, until he came to the house the same way the others had.

He looked in, and he saw the floor covered with dead bodies.

"There must be some great wonder here," he thought. "If I lie down on the floor and pull some of the bodies over me, I'll be able to see everything that happens."

So he lay down and pulled some of the bodies over him. He had not been there long when he saw an old hag come into the house. She had one leg, and one arm, and one upper tooth, and the tooth was long enough to serve her as a crutch.

When she came inside the door she picked up the first dead body she met and threw it aside, for it was lean. As she went on, she took two bites out of every fat body she came to, and threw away every lean one.

She had had her fill of flesh and blood before she reached Glasan. She dropped down on the floor and fell asleep, and Glasan thought every breath she drew would bring the roof down on his head.

He got up then and looked at her, and wondered at the bulk of her body. At last he drew his sword and struck her a slash that killed her. But when he did, three young men leapt out of her body. Glasan struck a blow that killed the first of them, and Bran killed the second. The third escaped.

Glasan made his way back. Just as he got to where Finn was, his log burned out, and the day was beginning to break.

When Finn got up in the morning he asked the three watchers for their news. They gave him the cup and the knife and told him everything they had seen. He gave great praise to Dubh and to Dun. But to Glasan he said:

"It might have been as well for you to have left that old hag alone. I'm afraid the third young man may bring trouble on us all."

Twenty-one years went by.

At the end of twenty-one years, Finn and the Fianna were hunting in the hills, and they saw a Red-Haired Man coming towards them. He spoke to no one, but came and stood in front of Finn.

"What are you looking for?" said Finn.

"I'm looking for a master for the next twenty-one years," he said.

"What wages are you asking?"

"No wages at all. Only, if I die before the twenty-one years are up, to bury me on Inis Caol, the Narrow Island."

"I'll do that for you," said Finn.

So the Red-Haired Man served Finn well for twenty years. But in the twenty-first year he began to waste and wither away, and he died.

When he was dead, the Fianna were not at all inclined to go to Inis Caol to bury him. But Finn said he would break his word for no man, and that he would take the body there himself. He took an old white horse that had been turned loose on the hills — and that had grown younger, not older, since it was put out — and put the Red-Haired Man's body on its back, and let it go its own way. He followed it himself, with twelve men of the Fianna.

When they came to Inis Caol, there was no trace of the horse or of the body. There was an open house on the island, and they went in. There were seats inside for every man of them, and they sat down to rest a while.

When they tried to get up, they could not. There was enchantment on them.

And in that moment they saw the Red-Haired Man standing in front of them.

"The time has come now," he said, "for me to get satisfaction from you for the death of my mother and my two brothers, who were killed by Glasan in the house of the dead bodies."

Twenty-one years he had waited. Twenty years he had served them well, and eaten their bread, and waited.

He began to attack them, and he would have made an end of them all, but Finn got hold of the Dord Fiann and blew a great blast on it.

Before the Red-Haired Man had killed more than three of them, Diarmuid, grandson of Duibhne, who had heard the sound of the Dord Fiann, came into the house and made an end of him, and broke the enchantment.

And Finn came back to Almhuin with the nine that were left of the Fianna.

CHAPTER III

The Hound



One day the three battalions of the Fianna came to Magh Femen, and there they saw three young men waiting for them, with a hound. There was not a colour in the world that was not on that hound, and it was bigger than any other hound.

"Where do you come from, young men?" said Finn.

"Out of the greater Iruath, in the east," they said. "Our names are Dubh, the Dark, and Agh, the Battle, and Ilar, the Eagle."

"What have you come for?"

"To enter your service, and for your friendship."

"What good will it do us to have you with us?" said Finn.

"We are three," they said, "and you can make a different use of each of us."

"What uses are those?"

"I'll do the watching for all the Fianna of Ireland and of Alban," said one of them.

"I'll take the weight of every fight and every battle that comes to them," said the second, "so they can keep themselves in quiet."

"I'll meet every troublesome thing that might come to my master," said the third. "Let all the wants of the world be told to me, and I'll satisfy them. And I have a pipe with me, and all the men of the world would sleep at the sound of it, even in their sickness. As for the hound, as long as there are deer in Ireland he'll get provision for the Fianna every second night. And I myself will get it on the other nights."

"What will you ask of us, to be with us like that?" said Finn.

"We'll ask three things," they said. "That no one comes near the place where we lodge after nightfall. That nothing is given out to us, but we provide for ourselves. And that the worst

places are given to us in the hunting."

"Tell me on your oath," said Finn, "why you won't let anyone see you after nightfall."

"We have a reason," they said. "But don't ask it of us, whether we're a short time or a long time on the one path with you. We'll tell you this much: every third night, one of us three is dead, and the other two are watching over him. And we have no mind for anyone to be looking at us."

Every third night, one of them died. They said it as plainly as that, and asked for privacy, and it was given.

Finn promised it. But some of the Fianna were not well pleased with the ways of those three men, living by themselves as they did, with a wall of fire about them, and they would have made an end of them if Finn had not protected them.

About that time seven men of poetry came from the people of Cithruadh, asking the fee for a poem: three times fifty ounces of gold and the same of silver, to bring back to Cithruadh at Teamhair.

"However we get it, we must find some way to get that," said a man of the Fianna.

"Well, men of learning," said the three young men from Iruath, "would you sooner get the fee for your poem tonight or tomorrow?"

"Tomorrow will be time enough," they said.

The three young men went to the place a little way off from the rath where the hound had its bed. The hound brought up out of its mouth in front of them three times fifty ounces of gold and three times fifty of silver. They gave it to the men of poetry, and the poets went away.

Another time Finn said: "What can the three battalions of the Fianna do tonight, with no water?"

"How many drinking-horns do you have with you?" said one of the men of Iruath.

"Three hundred and twelve," said Caoilte.

"Give me the horns into my hand," said the young man, "and whatever you find in them after that, you may drink."

He filled the horns with beer, and they drank it. He did it a second time and a third, and by the third filling they were talkative and their wits were confused.

"This is a wonderful mending of the feast," said Finn.

And they gave the place where all that happened the name of the Little Rath of Wonders.

Some time after that, three bald red clowns came to Finn, holding three red hounds and three deadly spears. There was poison on their clothes, and on their hands and feet, and on everything they touched. Finn asked who they were.

They said they were the three sons of Uar, son of Indast, of the Tuatha de Danaan. Their father had been killed by a man of the Fianna, Caoilte, son of Ronan, in the battle of the Tuatha de Danaan on Slieve nan Ean, the Mountain of Birds, in the east.

"Let Caoilte, son of Ronan, give us the blood-fine for him now," they said.

"What are your names?" said Finn.

"Aincel and Digbail and Espaid," they said. "Ill-Wishing and Harm and Want. And what answer do you give us now, Finn?"

"Nobody before me ever gave a blood-fine for a man killed in battle," said Finn, "and I won't give it."

"Then we'll do revenge and robbery on you," they said.

"What revenge is that?"

"This is what I'll do," said Aincel. "If I meet with two or three or four of the Fianna, I'll take their feet and their hands from them."

"This is what I'll do," said Digbail. "I won't let a day go by without the loss of a hound, or a serving-boy, or a fighting man to the Fianna of Ireland."

"And I'll always be leaving them in want," said Espaid, "of people, or of a hand, or of an eye."

"Unless we get some help against them," said Caoilte, "there won't be one of us living at the end of a year."

"Well," said Finn, "we'll make a dun and stay here a while. I won't go through Ireland with these men following after me, until I find out who is the stronger, they or we."

So the Fianna made little raths for themselves all about Slieve Mis, and stayed there a month and a quarter and a year. And all that time the three red bald-headed men were doing every kind of hurt and harm to them.

But the three sons of the King of Iruath came to speak with Finn.

"It's our wish, Finn," they said, "to send the hound that's with us to go round you three times every day. However many people are trying to hurt you or rob you, they won't have the power to do it after that. But let there be no fire, and no weapons, and no other dog, in the house he goes into."

"I'll let none of those things into the same house as him," said Finn, "and he'll go safe back to you."

So every day the hound was sent to Finn, with its chain of ridges of red gold around its neck. It went three times round Finn, and three times it put its tongue on him. To the people nearest the hound when it came into the house, it seemed as if a vat of mead was being strained; and to others there came the sweet smell of an apple-garden.

Every harm and sickness the three sons of Uar brought on the Fianna, the three sons of the King of Iruath took off them again with their herbs and their help and their healing.

After a while the High King of Ireland came to Slieve Mis with a great troop of his men, to join Finn and the Fianna. They told the High King the whole story: how the sons of Uar were destroying them, and how the three sons of the King of Iruath were helping them against them.

"Why wouldn't men who can do all that find some good spell to drive the sons of Uar out of Ireland?" said the High King.

With that Caoilte went looking for the three young men from Iruath and brought them to the High King.

"These are comely men," said the High King, "good in their shape and with a good name. Could you find any charm, my sons, that will drive out these three enemies who are destroying the Fianna of Ireland?"

"We'd do that if we could find those men near us," they said. "And this is where they are now: at Daire's Cairn, at the end of the raths."

"Where are Garb-Cronan, the Rough Buzzing One, and Saltran of the Long Heel?" said Finn.

"Here we are, King of the Fianna," they said.

"Go out to those men beyond, and tell them I'll give satisfaction for their father according to the judgment of the King of Ireland."

The messengers went out and brought them in, and they sat down on the bank of the rath.

Then the High King said: "Rise up, Dubh, son of the King of Iruath, and command these sons of Uar with a spell to leave Ireland."

Dubh rose up and said: "Go out through the strength of this spell and this charm, you three enemies of the Fianna — one-eyed, lame-thighed, left-handed, of the bad race. Go out on the deep bitter sea, and let each of you strike a blow of his sword on the head of his brothers. For it's long enough you've been doing harm and destruction on the King of the Fianna, Finn, son of Cumhal."

With that the hound sent a blast of wind under them that carried them out into the fierce green sea. Each of them struck a blow on the heads of the others. And that was the last that was seen of the three destroying sons of Uar, Aincel and Digbail and Espaid.

But after the time of the Fianna there came, three times in the one year, into West Munster, three flocks of birds from the western sea, with beaks of bone and fiery breath, and the wind from their wings was as cold as a wind of spring. The first time they came was at reaping-time, and every one of them carried off an ear of corn from the field. The next time they came they did not leave an apple on a tree, or a nut on a bush, or a berry on the rowan. The third time they spared no living thing they could lift from the ground — young bird, or fawn, or silly little child. And the first day they came was the same day of the year that the three sons of Uar were put out on the sea.

When Caoilte — one of the last of the Fianna, and still living — heard of them, he remembered the sons of Uar. He made a spell that drove them out into the sea again, and they perished there, by one another.

Ill-Wishing and Harm and Want. You can drive them out. They come back, a long time later, with wings.

The three sons of the King of Iruath stayed about a year with Finn.

At the end of that time Donn and Dubhan, two sons of the King of Ulster, came out of the north to Munster. One night they kept watch for the Fianna, and three times they made a round of the camp.

The young men from Iruath always stayed in a place by themselves, apart from the Fianna, with their hound between them, and at nightfall a wall of fire rose around them, so that nobody could look at them.

The third time the sons of the King of Ulster made the round of the camp, they saw the fiery wall.

"It's a wonder," said Donn, "the way those three young men have been a year now, and their hound with them, and nobody allowed to look at them."

With that he and his brother took their weapons in their hands and went inside the wall of fire, and began looking at the three men and at the hound.

The great hound they saw every day at the hunting was no bigger now than a lap-dog that would belong to a queen or a high person. One of the young men was watching over the dog with his sword in his hand. Another was holding a vessel of white silver to the dog's mouth. Whatever drink any of the three asked for, the dog would bring it up out of its mouth into the vessel.

Then one of the young men said to the hound: "Well, noble one, and brave one, and just one, take notice of the treachery that is done to you by Finn."

When the dog heard that it turned to the King of Ulster's sons, and a dark Druid wind rose up and blew the shields from their shoulders and the swords from their sides into the wall of fire. Then the three men came out and made an end of them. When that was done, the dog came and breathed on them, and they turned to ashes that moment, and no blood or flesh or bone of them was ever found afterwards.

The three battalions of the Fianna divided themselves into companies of nine and went searching through every part of Ireland for the King of Ulster's two sons.

As for Finn, he went to Teamhair Luachra, with nobody with him but the serving-lads and the followers of the army. The companies of nine who were looking for the King of Ulster's sons all came back to him there on the one night. They brought no word of them, dead or living.

And as for the three sons of the King of Iruath and the hound that was with them, they were seen no more by Finn and the Fianna.

Finn had given his word. It was broken, and not by him. That did not matter. It never matters, to the ones who leave.



Book Three: The Battle Of The White Strand



CHAPTER IV

Red Ridge



There was another young man who came and served Finn for a while. He came out of Connacht, and he was very daring, and the name they gave him was the Red Ridge.

He nearly left Finn once, because his wages were too long in coming to him. The three battalions of the Fianna came to try to quiet him, but he would not stay for them.

At last Finn himself came. He had a power: if he made only three verses, he could quiet anyone. And this is what he said:

"Daring Red Ridge, good in battle: if you go from me today with your great name, it is a good parting for us. But once, at Rath Cro, I gave you three times fifty ounces in the one day; and at Cam Ruidhe I gave you the full of my cup of silver and of yellow gold. And do you remember the time we were at Rath Ai, when we found the two women, and when we ate the nuts — you and I were there together."

After that the young man said no more about leaving him.

It was not the gold that kept him. It was the nuts, and the two women, and the being there together. Finn knew that. It was why he said it last.

Another helper came to Finn once when he was fighting at a ford, and all his weapons were used up or worn out with the force of the fight. A daughter of Mongan of the Sidhe came to him, bringing a flat stone with a chain of gold on it. He took the stone and did great deeds with it. After the fight the stone fell into the ford, and the ford got the name of Ath Liag Finn, the Ford of Finn's Stone.

That stone will never be found until the Woman of the Waves finds it and brings it to land on a Sunday morning.

And seven years from that day, the world will come to an end.

So if you are ever by that ford, and you see something glinting under the water, leave it where it is.

The Enemies Of Ireland



Of all the great battles the Fianna fought to keep the foreigners out of Ireland, the greatest was the one fought at Finntraigh, the White Strand, in Munster. This is the whole story of it, and of how the Fianna came to have so great a name.

Once the enemies of Ireland gathered together under Daire Donn, High King of the Great World. They meant to take Ireland and put it under tribute.

The King of Greece was among them, and the King of France, and the King of the Eastern World. There was Lughman of the Broad Arms, King of the Saxons, and Fiacha of the Long Hair, King of the Gairean, and Tor, son of Breogan, King of the Great Plain, and Sligech, son of the King of the Men of Cepda. There was Comur of the Crooked Sword, King of the Men of the Dog-Heads, and Caitchenn, King of the Men of the Cat-Heads, and Caisel of the Feathers, King of Lochlann, and Madan of the Bent Neck, son of the King of the Marshes. There were three kings from the rising of the sun in the east. There was Ogarmach, daughter of the King of Greece, the best woman-warrior that ever came into the world. And a great many other kings and great lords.

The whole world, more or less, against one island.

"Who can give me knowledge of the harbours of Ireland?" asked the King of the World.

"I'll do that for you," said Glas, son of Bremen, "and I'll bring you to a good harbour." Finn had put Glas out of Ireland for some treachery he had done.

The armies set out in their ships. They had not gone far when the wind rose, and the waves, and they could hear nothing but the wild playing of the sea-women, and the screams of frightened birds, and the breaking of ropes and of sails. But after a while, when the wind found no weakness in the heroes, it rose up off them and went back to its own high place. Then the sea grew quiet, and the waves grew tame, and the harbours friendly, and they stopped a while at an island called the Green Rock.

"It's not a harbour like this you promised me, Glas, son of Bremen," said the King of the World, "but a shore of white sand, where my armies could hold their fairs and their gatherings when they weren't fighting."

"I know a harbour of that kind in the west of Ireland," said Glas. "The Harbour of the White Strand, in Corca Duibhne."

So they went back into their ships, and went on over the sea towards Ireland.

They were coming to hold fairs on our beach. That is what they thought a war would be.

Cael And Credhe



As for Finn, when it was shown to him that the enemies of Ireland were coming, he called together the seven battalions of the Fianna.

The place where they gathered was the hill called Fionntulach, the White Hill, in Munster. They often stayed on that hill a while, and spear-shafts with spells on them were brought to them there. They had every kind of food: beautiful blackberries, haws of the hawthorn, nuts of the hazels of Cenntire, tender twigs of the bramble-bush, sprigs of wholesome gentian, watercress at the beginning of summer. To their cooking-pots were brought birds out of the oak-woods, and squirrels from Berramain, and speckled eggs from the cliffs, and salmon out of Luimnech, and eels of the Sionnan, and woodcocks of Fidhrinne, and otters from the hidden places of the Doile, and fish from the coasts of Buie and Beare, and dulse from the bays of Cleire.

As they were about to set out southward, they saw one of their young men, Cael, grandson of Nemhnain, coming towards them.

"Where have you come from, Cael?" Finn asked him.

"From Brugh na Boinne," he said.

"What were you asking for there?"

"I was asking to speak with Muirenn, daughter of Derg, who was my own nurse."

"For what cause?"

"It was about a high marriage, and a woman of the Sidhe who was shown to me in a dream. It was Credhe I saw, daughter of the King of Ciarraighe Luachra."

"Do you know this, Cael," said Finn, "that she's the greatest deceiver of all the women of Ireland? There's hardly a precious thing in Ireland but she has coaxed it away to her own great dun."

"Do you know what she asks of every man who comes asking for her?" said Cael.

"I know it," said Finn. "She'll let nobody come unless he can make a poem setting out the report of her bowls and her horns and her cups, her grand vessels and all her palaces."

"I have all that ready," said Cael. "It was given to me by my nurse, Muirenn, daughter of Derg."

The whole world was sailing against Ireland. And the Fianna put off the battle for the time being, and went courting.

They went on over every hilly place and every stony place until they came to Loch Cuire, in the west. They came to the door of the hill of the Sidhe and knocked on it with the shafts of their long gold-socketed spears. Young girls with yellow hair came to the windows of the sunny houses. And Credhe herself came out to speak with them, with three times fifty women.

"We've come to ask you in marriage," said Finn.

"Who is it that's asking for me?" said she.

"It's Cael, the hundred-killer, grandson of Nemhnain, son of the King of Leinster in the east."

"I've heard talk of him, but I've never seen him," said Credhe. "And has he any poem for me?"

"I have that," said Cael. He stood up, and sang his poem:

"A journey I have to make, and no easy journey, to the house of Credhe against the breast of the mountain, at the Paps of Dana. There I must go through hardships for the length of seven days. Pleasant is her house, with men and boys and women, with Druids and musicians, with cup-bearer and door-keeper, with a horse-boy who does not leave his work, with a distributor to share out food; and Credhe of the Fair Hair in command over them all.

"It would be delightful to me in her dun, with coverings and with down, if she has only a mind to listen to me.

"A bowl she has with the juice of berries in it to make her eyebrows black; crystal vats of fermenting grain; beautiful cups and vessels. Her house is the colour of lime; there are rushes for beds, and many silken coverings and blue cloaks; red gold is there, and bright drinking-horns. Her sunny house is beside Loch Cuire, made of silver and yellow gold; its ridge is thatched without any fault with the crimson wings of birds. The doorposts are green; the lintel is of silver taken in battle. Credhe's chair on the left is the delight of delights, covered with gold of Elga; at the foot of the pleasant bed it stands, the bed that was made of precious stones by Tuile in the east. Another bed there is on the right, of gold and silver, made without any fault; it has curtains the colour of the foxglove, hanging on rods of copper.

"The people of her house, they are the ones who have delight. Their cloaks are not faded white, they are not worn smooth; their hair is fair and curling. Wounded men in their blood would sleep, hearing the birds of the Sidhe singing in the eaves of the sunny house.

"If I have any thanks to give to Credhe, for whom the cuckoo calls, she will get better praise than this. If this love-service I have done is pleasing to her, let her not delay; let her say, 'Your coming is welcome to me.'

"A hundred feet there are in her house from one corner to another; twenty feet, fully measured, is the width of her great door. Her roof has its thatch of the wings of blue and yellow birds; the border of her well is of crystals and carbuncles.

"There is a vat there of royal bronze; the juice of pleasant malt is running from it; over the vat is an apple-tree with its heavy fruit. When Credhe's horn is filled from the vat, four apples fall into it together.

"She who owns all these things, both at low water and at flood, Credhe from the Hill of the Three Peaks: she is beyond all the women of Ireland by the length of a spear-cast.

"Here is this song for her. It is no sudden bride-gift, no hurried asking. I bring it to Credhe of the beautiful shape, that my coming may be very bright to her."

Then Credhe took him for her husband. The wedding-feast was made, and the whole of the Fianna stayed there for seven days, drinking and taking their pleasure and having every good thing.

It was a good wedding. Remember it. Remember that they were happy, for seven days, at the foot of the Paps of Dana.

Conn Crither



When Finn turned off his road to go to Credhe's house, he had sent watchmen out to every landing-place, to give warning when the ships of the strangers came in sight. The man keeping watch at the White Strand was Conn Crither, son of Bran, from Teamhair Luachra.

He watched a long time. Then one night, west of the Round Hill of the Fianna that is called Cruachan Adrann, he fell asleep.

While he slept, the ships came.

What woke him was the noise of shields breaking, and the clash of swords and spears, and the cries of women and children, and of dogs and horses under the flames, that the strangers were attacking.

Conn Crither started up when he heard it. "It's great trouble has come on the people through my sleep," he said. "I won't stay living after this for Finn and the Fianna of Ireland to see me. I'll rush into the middle of the strangers, and they'll fall by me until I fall by them."

One man. One sleep. He did not make excuses for it. He did not look for someone to blame. He picked up his weapons.

He put on his battle-suit and ran down towards the strand. On the way he saw three women ahead of him, dressed in battle-clothes, and however fast he ran he could not catch them. He took his spear to throw at the nearest one, but she stopped that moment.

"Hold your hand and don't harm us," she said. "We haven't come to harm you, but to help you."

"Who are you?" said Conn Crither.

"We are three sisters," she said, "and we've come from Tir nan Og, the Country of the Young. All three of us have given you our love, and none of us loves you less than the others, and it's to give you our help we've come."

"How will you help me?"

"We'll give you good help," she said. "We'll make Druid armies around you out of stalks of grass and the tops of the watercress. They'll cry out at the strangers, and strike the weapons out of their hands, and take away their strength and their eyesight. And we'll put a Druid mist around you now, that will hide you from the armies of the strangers, so they won't see you when you attack them. And we have a well of healing at the foot of Slieve Iolair, the Eagle's Mountain. Its waters will cure every wound made in battle. After bathing in that well you'll be as whole and as sound as the day you were born. And bring whatever man you like best with you, and we'll heal him along with you."

Conn Crither thanked them, and hurried on to the strand.

At that time the armies of the King of the Great Plain were taking spoils from Traigh Moduirn in the north to Finntraighe in the south. Conn Crither came on them, with the Druid army at his side. He took their spoils from them, and the Druid army took their sight and their strength from them, and they were routed. They ran to where the King of the Great Plain was, and Conn Crither followed, killing and destroying.

"Stop and stand with me, king-hero," said the King of the Great Plain, "so I can fight you for my people's sake, since there isn't one of them who'll turn and stand against you."

So the two of them set their banners in the earth and went at each other, and fought a good part of the day, until Conn Crither struck off the king's head.

He lifted the head up, boasting of what he had done.

"By my word," he said, "I won't let myself be parted from this body until some of the Fianna, few or many, come to me."

Glas, Son Of Bremen



The King of the World heard that.

"That's a big word that man is saying," he said. "Get up now, Glas, son of Bremen, and see which of the Fianna of Ireland it is that's saying it."

Glas left the ship and went to where Conn Crither was, and asked who he was.

"I am Conn Crither, son of Bran, from Teamhair Luachra," he said.

"If that's so," said Glas, "you're of the one blood with me. I am Glas, son of Bremen, from Teamhair Luachra."

"Then it's not right for you to come fighting against me on the side of those foreigners," said Conn.

"It's a pity indeed," said Glas. "If Finn and the Fianna hadn't driven me out from them, I wouldn't fight against you, or against one of them, for all the treasures of the whole world."

"Don't say that," said Conn. "I swear by my hand of valour: if you had killed Finn's own son, and the sons of his people along with him, you'd have no need to be in dread of him, if only you came under his word and his protection."

That is what Finn's word was worth, in those days. You could stake your life on it. People did.

"I think indeed the day has come for me to fight beside you," said Glas. "I'll go back and tell that to the King of the World."

He went back to the king, and the king asked him which of the men of the Fianna it was.

"It's a kinsman of my own, High King," said Glas. "And my heart is weak at his being alone. I have a great desire to go and help him."

"If you go," said the King of the World, "what I ask of you is to come and tell me every day how many of the Fianna of Ireland have fallen by me. And if a few of my own men should fall, come and tell me who it was they fell by."

"And what I ask of you," said Glas, "is not to let your armies land until the Fianna come to us, but to let only one man at a time come to fight with each of us until then."

So two of the strangers were sent against them that day, and they got their death by Glas and by Conn Crither. Then the two asked to have two men sent against each of them, and that was done, and three times nine fell by them before night.

Conn Crither was covered with wounds by the end of the day.

"Three women came to me from the Country of the Young," he said to Glas, "and they promised to put me in a well of healing for my wounds. You watch the harbour tonight, and I'll go and look for them."

So he went to them, and they bathed him in the well of healing, and he was whole of his wounds.

As for Glas, son of Dremen, he went down to the harbour.

"O King of the World," he called, "there's a friend of mine in the ships, Madan of the Bent Neck, son of the King of the Marshes. He said in the great world in the east that he alone would be enough to take Ireland for you, and would bring it under tribute to you one way or another. I ask you to let him come alone against me tonight, until we see which of us will fight best for Ireland."

So Madan came ashore, and the two went at each other and made a very hard fight. But it was not in the prophecy that Glas would find his death there. It was the son of the King of the Marshes who got his death by him.

Not long after, Conn Crither came back to Glas, and gave him great praise for all he had done.

A traitor had brought the whole world to the White Strand. And now there were two men on it, standing between the whole world and Ireland, and one of them was the traitor.

The Help Of The Men Of Dea



Then Taistellach, one of Finn's messengers, came to the White Strand asking for news. Conn told him to go back to where Finn was and tell him how things stood.

But Taistellach would not go until he had wetted his sword in the blood of one of the enemies of Ireland, as the others had done. He sent a challenge to the ships. Coimhleathan, a very big, tall champion, came and fought with him on the strand, and took him up in his arms to carry him alive back to the High King's ship. But Taistellach struck his head off in the sea, and brought the head back to land.

"Victory and blessing be with you!" said Conn Crither. "Go now, tonight, to the house of Bran, son of Febal, my father, at Teamhair Luachra, and tell him to gather all the Tuatha de Danaan to help us. And go on tomorrow to the Fianna of Ireland."

So Taistellach went on to Bran's house, and told him the whole story, and gave him the message.

Then Bran, son of Febal, went out to gather the Tuatha de Danaan. He went to Dun Sesnain in Ui Conall Gabra, where they were holding a feast. He found three of the best young men of the Tuatha de Danaan there: Ilbrec the Many-Coloured, son of Manannan, and Nemanach the Pearly, son of Angus Og, and Sigmall, grandson of Midhir. They made him welcome and asked him to stay with them.

"There's a greater thing than this for you to do, Men of Dea," said Bran. And he told them the whole story, and how things were with Conn Crither his son.

"Stay with me tonight," said Sesnan, "and my son Dolb will go to Bodb Dearg, son of the Dagda, and gather the Tuatha de Danaan in to us."

So Bran stayed there, and Dolb, son of Sesnan, went to Sidhe Bean Finn above Magh Femen, where Bodb Dearg was at that time, and gave him his message.

"Young man," said Bodb Dearg, "we're in no way bound to help the men of Ireland out of that strait."

"Don't say that," said Dolb. "There isn't a king's son, or a prince, or a leader of the Fianna of Ireland, who doesn't have a wife, or a mother, or a foster-mother, or a sweetheart, of the Tuatha de Danaan. And they've given you good help every time you needed it."

That is the truth of it. The gods had lost Ireland to the Gael. Then they had married them.

"I give my word," said Bodb Dearg, "it's right to give a good answer to so good a messenger."

With that he sent word to the Tuatha de Danaan in every place where they were, and they gathered to him. From there they went on to Dun Sesnain and stayed the night. They rose in the morning and put on their shirts of the costliest silk and their embroidered coats of rejoicing, and took their green shields and their swords and their spears.

Their leaders then, besides Bodb Dearg, were Midhir of Bri Leith, and Lir of Sidhe Finnachaidh, and Abarthach, son of Ildathach, and Ilbrec, son of Manannan, and Fionnbhar of Magh Suil, and Argat Lamh, the Silver Hand, from the Sionnan, and the Man of Sweet Speech from the Boinn.

The whole army of them came into Ciarraighe Luachra, and to red-haired Slieve Mis, and from there to the harbour of the White Strand.

"O Men of Dea," said Abarthach, "let a high mind and high courage rise in you now in the face of the battle. For the doings of every one of you will be told until the end of the world. So fulfil now the big words you've spoken in the drinking-houses."

"Get up, Glas, son of Dremen," said Bodb Dearg, "and tell the King of the World I've come to do battle."

Glas went to the King of the World.

"Are those the Fianna of Ireland I see?" said the king.

"They are not," said Glas. "They're another part of the men of Ireland, who don't dare to be on the face of the earth, but who live in hidden houses under the earth. It's to give warning of battle from them I've come."

"Who will answer the Tuatha de Danaan for me?" said the King of the World.

"We'll go against them," said two of the kings who were with him: Comur Cromchenn, King of the Men of the Dog-Heads, and Caitchenn, King of the Men of the Cat-Heads.

They had five red-armed battalions with them, and they went up the shore like great red waves.

"Who is there to match the King of the Dog-Heads for me?" said Bodb Dearg.

"I'll go against him," said Lir of Sidhe Finnachaidh, "though I've heard there's no man in the world with stronger hands."

"Who'll be a match for the King of the Cat-Heads?"

"I'll be a match for him," said Abarthach, son of Ildathach.

So Lir and the King of the Dog-Heads went at each other and made a hard fight of it. But after a while Lir was getting the worst of it.

"It's a pity, the way Lir is," said Bodb Dearg. "Let some of you get up and help him."

Then Ilbrec, son of Manannan, went to his help, but he got a wound himself and could do nothing. Then Sigmal, grandson of Midhir, went to help him, and after him the five sons of Finnaistucan, and others of the Men of Dea. They were all driven off by the King of the Dog-Heads.

Lir, whose children had been nine hundred years on the water. It is hard to know what he was fighting, that day.

But by then Abarthach had made an end of the King of the Cat-Heads. He rose up on his spear and made a leap, and came down between Lir and his enemy.

"Leave off now, and watch the fight," he said to Lir. "Leave it to me and the foreigner."

He took his sword in his left hand and thrust with his spear in through the king's armour. As the king raised his shield, Abarthach struck at him with the sword in his left hand, and cut off both his legs at the knees. The king let his shield fall then, and Abarthach struck off his head.

With the two kings dead, their people broke and ran. The Men of Dea followed them and made an end of them all. But they lost a good many of their own men doing it.

The gods do not die. Some of them died on the White Strand anyway.

The March Of The Fianna



Finn and the Fianna were still at Credhe's house when they saw Taistellach coming towards them.

It was Finn's custom, when he sent anyone out for news, that the news should be told to him first. That way, if it was bad news, he could pretend not to mind it. And if it was good news, he would have the satisfaction of telling it himself.

That is a thing a leader learns. Bad news is heard alone. Good news is shared.

So Taistellach told him how the foreigners had come to the harbour of the White Strand.

Then Finn turned to his chief men. "Fianna of Ireland," he said, "there never came harm or danger to Ireland to compare with this great danger that has come against us now. You get great tribute and great service from the chief men of Ireland. If you take that from them, it's right for you to defend them now."

The Fianna all said they would not go back one step from the defence of Ireland.

Credhe gave every one of them a battle-dress. They were taking their leave of her when Finn said, "Let the woman come with us, until we know whether the end of this journey is good or bad."

So she came with them, bringing a great herd of cattle. For the whole length of the battle — and it lasted a year and a day — she had new milk for them, and it was to her house that the wounded were brought for healing.

Then the Fianna set out. They went to the borders of Ciarraighe Luachra, and across by the shores of the Bannlid, with Slieve Mis on their left hand, and made shelters for themselves that night and kindled fires.

But Caoilte and Oisín and Lugaidh's Son said to one another that they would go on ahead to the harbour, so that they would have time to redden their hands in the blood of the foreigners before the rest of the Fianna came.

At that time the King of the World was telling some of his chief men to go ashore and bring him back spoils. They went to land and gave a great shout, and the people in the ships gave a great shout at the same time.

"I swear by the oath my people swear by," said Caoilte, "I've gone round the whole world, and I never heard so many voices together in one place."

With that he and Oisín and Lugaidh's Son attacked the strangers and struck great blows at them. When Conn Críther and Glas, son of Bremen, heard the noise of those blows, they knew they were being struck by some of the Fianna of Ireland. They came and joined them, and did great destruction on the strangers, until there was not one left of all that had come to land.

Five men on a beach, now. It was a start.

The First Fighters



In the morning they saw Finn and all his people coming to the rath above the harbour.

"My father Finn," said Oisin, "let's fight the whole of the foreigners now, all together."

"That's not my advice," said Finn. "The number of their armies is too great for us, and we couldn't stand against them. But every day we'll send out some son of a king or of a leader against some king of the kings of the world who's equal in blood to ourselves. And let none of you redden your weapons at first except on a king or a chief man. When a king has fallen, his people are more inclined to give way. Now, who'll give out a challenge of battle for me?"

"I'll do that," said the son of Cuban, leader of the Fianna of Munster.

"Don't go, my son," said Finn. "It isn't shown to me that you'll have good luck in the battle. And I never sent out any man to fight without knowing he'd come back safe to me."

"Don't say that," said Cuban's son. "I wouldn't go back from a fight for the treasure of the whole world because of a bad foretelling. And since it's my own country they did their robbing in first, I'll defend it for you."

"I'm sorrowful for that," said Finn. "For whichever of the kings of the world meets you to-day, you and he will fall together."

This is what it is to be Finn, who drank from the salmon. He knows. He says so. They go anyway.

Glas, son of Dremen, gave out the challenge from Cuban's son, and the King of Greece answered it. The two fought hand to hand. The King of Greece made a great cast of his thick spear at Cuban's son, and it went through his body and broke his back in two. But Cuban's son did not take that blow as a gift. He paid for it with a strong cast of his own golden spear, and it went through the ringed armour of the King of Greece. And those two fell together, sole to sole, and lip to lip.

"There's grief on me that Cuban's son has fallen," said Finn. "No one ever went from his house unsatisfied. A man that I wouldn't keep, or that the High King of Ireland wouldn't keep for a week, he would keep in his house for the length of a year. Let Follamain, his son, be called to me now, and I'll give him his father's name and place."

They stayed there until the next morning.

"Who'll go and fight today?" said Finn.

"I will," said Goll Garb, son of the King of Alban and of the daughter of Goll, son of Morna.

He put on his battle-dress, and there came against him the three kings from the rising of the sun in the east, with their three battalions. Goll Garb rushed in among their men and wounded and maimed and destroyed them, and blinded their eyes for ever, so that their wits went from them, and they called out to him to stop his deadly sword for a while. He did that. And they agreed to take their three kings and hand them over to Goll Garb, so that he would stop the destruction of his sword.

"Who'll go out and fight today?" said Finn, the next morning.

"I'll go," said Oisin, "and the chief men of the sons of Baiscne with me. We get the best share of all the pleasant things of Ireland, and we should be first to defend her."

"I'll answer that challenge," said the King of France. "It's against Finn I came to Ireland, because of my wife that he carried off from me. These men will fall by me now, and Finn himself at the last. When the branches of a tree are cut off, it's not hard to cut down the tree itself."

So the King of France and Oisin met at the eastern end of the strand. They struck their banners of soft silk into the green hill, and bared their swords, and made a quick attack on each other. At one point the king struck such a great blow that he knocked a groan out of Oisin. But he was worsted in the end all the same. A great fear came on him, like the fear of a hundred horses at the sound of thunder. He ran from Oisin, and rose up like a swallow, so that his feet never touched the earth at all, and he never stopped until he came to Gleann na-n Gealt, the Valley of Wild Men.

Ever since then, people who have lost their wits make for that valley. Every mad person in Ireland, if he had his way, would go there within twenty-four hours.

Great cries of lamentation rose from the armies of the World when they saw him go, and the Fianna of Ireland raised great shouts of joy.

When night was coming on, Finn said: "The King of the World is sad and gloomy tonight. It's likely he'll make an attack on us. Which of you will keep watch over the harbour through the night?"

"I will," said Oisín, "with the same number that fought with me today. It's not too much for us to fight for the Fianna of Ireland through a day and a night."

So they went down to the harbour. Just then the King of the World was saying: "It seems to me, men of the World, that our luck of battle wasn't good today. Let a share of you get up now and make an attack on the Fianna of Ireland."

Then the nine sons of Garb, King of the Sea of Icht, got up — they were smiths — and sixteen hundred of their people with them. They all went ashore except Dolar Durba, who was the eldest.

The sons of Baiscne were ready for them, and they fought a great battle until the early light of the next day. And not one man on either side was left alive who could hold a weapon, except Oisín and one of the sons of Garb.

Those two made rushes at each other, and threw their swords out of their hands, and closed their arms round each other and wrestled together, so that it would have been worth coming from the east of the world to the west to see the fight of those two.

Then the foreigner gave Oisín a sudden great fall to bring him into the sea. He was a great swimmer, and he thought he would get the better of him there. And Oisín thought it would not be worthy of him to refuse any man his own place of fighting.

So they went into the water together, and tried to drown each other, until they came to the sand and the gravel of the clear sea-bottom. It was a torment to the heart of the Fianna to see Oisín in that strait.

"Get up, Fergus of the Sweet Lips," said Finn, "and go and praise my son and encourage him."

So Fergus went down to the edge of the sea and called out: "It's a good fight you're making, Oisin, and there are many watching it. The armies of the whole world are looking at you, and the Fianna of Ireland. Show them now your ways and your greatness — for you never went into any place yet but some woman of high beauty, or some king's daughter, set her love on you."

That is a poet's job in a battle. Not to fight. To remind the fighter who he is.

Then Oisin's courage rose, and anger came on him. He locked his hands behind the foreigner's back and put him down on the sand under the sea, face upward, and did not let him rise until the life was gone out of him. Then he brought the body ashore, and struck off the head, and brought it to the Fianna.

But there was great grief and anger on Dolar Durba, the eldest of the sons of Garb, who had stayed in the ship. He swore a great oath that he would have satisfaction for his brothers. He went to the High King and said:

"I'll go alone to the strand, and I'll kill a hundred men every day until I've made an end of the whole of the armies of Ireland. And if any of your own men comes to interfere with me, I'll kill him along with them."

The next morning Finn asked who would lead the battle that day.

"I will," said Dubhan, son of Donn.

"Don't," said Finn. "Let someone else go."

But Dubhan went to the strand, and a hundred men with him. There was nobody there before him but Dolar Durba, and Dolar Durba said he was there to fight the whole of them.

Dubhan's men gave a great shout of laughter when they heard that.

Then Dolar Durba rushed at them, and made an end of the whole hundred, without one of them being able to put a scratch on him.

Then he took a hurling-stick and a ball. He threw up the ball and kept it in the air with the hurl from the west end of the strand to the east, without letting it touch the ground once. Then he put the ball on his right foot and kicked it high into the air, and when it was coming down he gave it a kick with his left foot, and kept it in the air like that, rushing like a blast of March wind from one end of the strand to the other.

When he had done that, he walked up and down the strand making great boasts, and challenging the men of Ireland to do the like of those feats.

And every day he killed a hundred of the men who were sent against him.

The King Of Ulster's Son



It happened at that time that news of the great battle reached the court of the King of Ulster.

The king's son was only twelve years old, and he was the comeliest of all the young men of Ireland.

"Let me go to help Finn, son of Cumhal, and his men," he said to his father.

"You're not old enough or strong enough, boy," said the king. "Your bones are too soft."

When the boy kept on asking, his father shut him up in a closed place, and put twelve young men, his foster-brothers, in charge of him.

A great anger came on the lad then.

"It was through courage and daring that my father won a great name for himself in his own early youth," he said to his foster-brothers. "Why does he keep me from winning a name for myself? Help me now, and I'll be a friend to you for ever."

He went on talking to them and persuading them until he had won them all round, and they agreed to go with him to join Finn and the Fianna. When the king was asleep they went into the house where the weapons were kept, and every lad of them took a shield and a sword and a helmet and two spears and two greyhound whelps.

They went across Ess Ruadh in the north, and through Connacht of many tribes, and through Caille an Chosanma, the Woods of Defence, which were called the choice of every king and the true honour of every poet, and into Ciarraighe, and so on to the White Strand.

When they got there Dolar Durba was on the strand, boasting in front of the men of Ireland.

Oisín was getting up to go against him. He said he would sooner die fighting him than watch the destruction he was doing on his people every day. And all the wise men and the

fighting men and the poets and the musicians of the Fianna gave a great cry of sorrow when they heard Oisín say it.

The King of Ulster's son went to Finn and stood in front of him and greeted him. Finn asked him who he was and where he had come from.

"I am the son of the King of Ulster," he said. "I've come here with my twelve foster-brothers to give you what help we can."

"I give you a welcome," said Finn.

Just then they heard the voice of Dolar Durba, very loud and boastful.

"Who is that I hear?" said the king's son.

"It's a man of the foreigners, asking for a hundred of my men to go and meet him," said Finn.

When the twelve foster-brothers heard that, they said no word. They went down to the strand, without the king's son or Finn knowing.

"You're not a grown man," Conan said to the king's son. "Neither you nor your comrades are fit to face any fighting man at all."

"I never saw the Fianna of Ireland until today," said the young lad. "But I know well that you're Conan Maol, who never says a good word of any man. And you'll see now whether I'm in dread of that man on the strand, or of any man in the world. I'll go out against him by myself."

But Finn held him back and was talking with him. Then Conan began again.

"Dolar Durba has made an end of many men," he said, "and there wasn't a man of all of them who couldn't have killed a hundred of the like of you every day."

When the king's son heard that, a great anger came on him and he leapt up. Just then Dolar Durba gave a great shout on the strand.

"What's he shouting for?" said the king's son.

"He's shouting for more men to come against him," said Conan. "He's just after killing your twelve comrades."

"That's a sorrowful story," said the king's son.

He was twelve. He said it the way a king would say it.

He took hold of his weapons, and nobody could hold him or stop him, and he rushed down to the strand where Dolar Durba was.

All the armies of the strangers gave a great shout of laughter. They thought all Finn's men must be finished, if he was sending a young lad like that against their best champion.

When the boy heard the laughter, his courage grew greater. He fell on Dolar Durba and gave him many wounds before Dolar Durba even knew he was being attacked. They fought a very hard fight together, until their shields and their swords were broken in pieces. That did not stop the battle. They grappled together, and fought and wrestled that way, until the tide came in over them and drowned them both.

When the sea went over them, the armies on both sides gave a great, sorrowful cry.

After the ebb-tide the next day, the two bodies were found, cold and quiet, each held fast by the other. But Dolar Durba was underneath the king's son. So they knew it was the young lad who had been the better, and had won.

They buried him, and put a flagstone over his grave, and keened him there.

Nobody has kept his name. Only that he was the King of Ulster's son, and that he was twelve, and that he was on top.

The High King's Son



Then Finn said he would send out a challenge himself to Daire Donn, the King of the Great World.

But Caoilte asked leave to do that day's fighting himself. Finn said he would agree to it if Caoilte could find enough men to go with him. Finn gave him a hundred men himself, and Oisín did the same, and so on with the rest.

Caoilte gave out his challenge, and it was the son of the King of the Great Plain who answered it.

While they were in the heat of the fight, a fleet of ships came into the harbour. Finn thought they had come to help the foreigners.

But Oisín looked at them. "It's seldom your knowledge fails you, Finn," he said, "but those are friends of our own: Fiachra, son of the King of the Fianna of the Bretons, and Duaban Donn, son of the King of Tuathmumain, with his own people."

When the people in the ships came ashore, they saw Caoilte's banner going down before the son of the King of the Great Plain. They all went hurrying to his help, and between them they made an end of the king's son and of all his people.

"Who'll keep watch tonight?" said Finn then.

"We will," said the nine Garbhs of the Fianna: of Slieve Mis, and Slieve Cua, and Slieve Clair, and Slieve Crot, and Slieve Muice, and Slieve Fuad, and Slieve Atha Moir, and Dun Sobairce, and Dundéalgan.

They had not been long watching when they saw the King of the Men of Dregan coming towards them, and they fought a fierce battle. At the end of the night only three of the Garbhs were left standing, and the King of the Men of Dregan. They fought until their wits were gone from them. And those four fell together, sole against sole, and lip against lip.

The fight went on from day to day and from week to week, with great losses on both sides.

When Fergus of the Sweet Lips saw how many of the Fianna had fallen, he asked nobody's leave but went to Teamhair of the Kings, where the High King of Ireland was, and told him how it was with Finn and his people.

"That's good," said the High King, "Finn being in that strait. There's no labouring man dares touch a pig or a deer or a salmon, even if he finds it lying dead in front of him, because of the Fianna. There's no man but is afraid to go from one place to another without leave from Finn, or to take a wife until he knows whether she has a sweetheart among the Fianna of Ireland. Finn has often given bad judgments against us. It would be better for us if the foreigners won the day than he did."

That is a king, too. Not all of them are Nuada.

Then Fergus went out to the lawn where the High King's son was playing ball.

"It's no good help you're giving to Ireland," said Fergus, "playing a game that brings no lasting profit, while strangers are taking your country away from you."

He went on urging him and blaming him, until great shame came on the young man. He threw away his hurling-stick and went through the people of Teamhair and gathered all the young men who were there — a thousand and twenty of them. They asked no leave and no advice of the High King, but set out, and went on until they came to Finntraigh.

Fergus went to where Finn was and told him the son of the High King of Ireland had come with him. All the Fianna rose up before the young man and welcomed him.

"Young man," said Finn, "we would sooner see you coming at a time when there'd be musicians and singers and poets and high-up women to make pleasure for you, than at a time when we're in the straits of battle the way we are now."

"It's not for playing I've come," said the young man, "but to give you my service in battle."

"I never brought a lad who was new to the work into the breast of battle," said Finn. "Often a lad coming like that finds his death, and I wouldn't wish him to fall through me."

"I give my word," said the young man, "I'll do battle with them on my own account, if I may not do it on yours."

Then Fergus of the Sweet Lips went out to give a challenge of battle from the son of the High King of Ireland to the King of the World.

"Who'll answer the King of Ireland's son for me?" said the King of the World.

"I'll go against him," said Sligech, King of the Men of Cepda.

He went ashore, and his three red battalions with him. The High King's son went against them, with his comrades near him.

"Take a good heart into the fight now," they said to him, "for the Fianna will be no better pleased if it goes well with you than if it goes well with the foreigner."

When the High King's son heard that, he made a rush through the army of the foreigners and began killing and overthrowing them, until their chief men were all made an end of. Then Sligech their king came to meet him, very angry, destroying as he came. They struck at each other and made a great fight. But at the last the King of Ireland's son got the upper hand, and killed the King of the Men of Cepda, and struck off his head.

His father had hoped the Fianna would lose. His son had just made sure they would not. That is how it goes with fathers and sons.

The King Of Lochlann And His Sons



The fighting went on from day to day, and at last Finn said to Fergus of the Sweet Lips: "Go out, Fergus, and see how many of the Fianna are left for the fight today."

Fergus counted them. "There's only one battalion of the Fianna left in good order," he said. "But some men in it are able to fight three, and some are able to fight nine, or thirty, or a hundred."

"If that's so," said Finn, "get up and go to where the King of the World is, and tell him to come out to the great battle."

So Fergus went to the King of the World. He was lying on his bed, listening to the music of harps and pipes.

"King of the World," said Fergus, "it's a long time you're in that sleep. And that's no shame to you, for it'll be your last sleep. The whole of the Fianna have gone out to their place of battle. Go out and answer them."

"In my opinion," said the King of the World, "there's not a man of them able to fight me. How many are left of the Fianna of Ireland?"

"Only one battalion in good order," said Fergus.

"And how many of the armies of the World are left?" said the king. "Thirty battalions came with me to Ireland. Twenty of them have fallen by the Fianna, and what's left is ten red battalions in good order. And there are eight good fighters among them who would put down the men of the whole world if they were against me. That is: myself; and Conmail my son; and Ogarmach, the daughter of the King of Greece, who is the best hand in battle in the whole world after me; and Finnachta of the Teeth, the chief of my household; and the King of Lochlann, Caisel Clumach of the Feathers; and his three sons, Tocha, and Forne of the Broad Shoulders, and Mongach of the Sea."

"I swear by the oath of my people," said the King of Lochlann, "if any man of the armies goes out against the Fianna before me and my three sons, we won't go at all. We wouldn't get the satisfaction we're used to, unless our swords get their fill of blood."

"I'll go out against them alone," said Forne, the youngest son of the King of Lochlann.

He put on his battle-suit and went in among the Fianna of Ireland, with a red-edged sword in each of his hands. He destroyed the young men who were sent against him, and made the strand narrow with their bodies.

Finn saw it, and it was a torment to his heart, and a danger of death and loss of his wits to him. He kept encouraging the men of Ireland against Forne.

And Fergus of the True Lips stood up and said: "Fianna of Ireland, it's a pity the way you are under hardship, defending Ireland. One man is taking her away from you today. You're like nothing but a flock of little birds looking for shelter in a bush from a hawk that's after them. It's into the shelter of Finn and Oisín and Caoilte you're going. Not one of you is better than another, and none of you sets his face against the foreigner."

"By my oath," said Oisín, "all that's true. None of us tries to do better than the rest at keeping him off."

"There's not one of you better than another," said Fergus.

Then Oisín gave a great shout against the King of Lochlann's son. "Stay here with me, king's son," he said, "until I fight you for the Fianna."

"I give my word, the delay will be short," said Forne.

He and Oisín went at each other, and for a while it seemed the battle was going against Oisín.

"By my word, Man of Poetry," said Finn to Fergus of the True Lips, "it's a pity the way you sent my son against the foreigner. Get up and praise him and hearten him now."

So Fergus went down to where the fight was, and called out: "There's great shame on the Fianna, Oisín, seeing you so low in this fight. There's many a foot-messenger and many a

horseman from the daughters of the kings and princes of Ireland watching you now."

Great courage rose in Oisín then, and he drove his spear through the body of Forne, the King of Lochlann's son. And he came back to the Fianna of Ireland.

The armies of the World gave a great cry, keening Forne. There was anger on his brothers, not fear, for they thought it no right thing that he should have fallen by a man of the Fianna.

Tocha, the second son of the King of Lochlann, went ashore to avenge his brother. He went straight into the middle of the Fianna and gave his sword good feeding on their bodies, until they broke away in front of him and made no stand — until Lugaidh's Son turned round against him.

Those two fought a great fight, until their swords were bent and their spears crumbled away and they had lost their golden shields. At last Lugaidh's Son made a stroke of his sword that cut through the foreigner's sword, and then another stroke that cut his heart in two halves. And he came back, high and proud, to the Fianna.

Then the third son of the King of Lochlann, Mongach of the Sea, stood up, and all the armies stood up with him.

"Stay here, Men of the World," he said. "It's not you but I that has to go and ask satisfaction for the bodies of my brothers."

So he went ashore. This is how he was armed. He had a strong iron flail in his hand. It had seven balls of pure iron on it, and fifty iron chains, and fifty apples on every chain, and fifty deadly thorns on every apple.

He rushed through the Fianna to break them up entirely and tear them into strings, and they gave way before him.

Great shame came on Fidach, son of the King of the Bretons. "Come here and praise me, Fergus of the True Lips," he said, "until I go out and fight the foreigner."

"It's easy to praise you, son," said Fergus, and he praised him for a long time.

Then the two of them looked at each other and used fierce, proud words. Mongach of the Sea raised his iron flail and made a great blow at the King of the Bretons' son. But Fidach made a quick leap to one side and gave him a blow of his sword that cut off his two hands at the wrist. He did not stop at that, but struck at his middle and cut him into two halves.

But as Mongach fell, an apple of the flail, with its deadly thorns, went into Fidach's comely mouth and through his brain. And those two fell foot to foot, and lip to lip.

Nobody wins against a weapon like that. At best, you go down together.

The next to come to fight on the strand was the King of Lochlann himself, Caisel of the Feathers.

He came to the battle with his shield on his arm. The smith of the Fomor had made that shield for him. Red flames came out of it, and if it were put under the sea itself, not one of its flames would stop blazing. While he had that shield on his arm, no man could come near him.

There was never such destruction done on the men of Ireland as on that day. The flames he sent out of his shield went through the bodies of men until they blazed up like a splinter of oak that has hung a whole year in the smoke of a chimney. And anyone who touched a man who was burning caught fire himself. Every other harm that had ever come into Ireland before was small beside this.

Then Finn said: "Lift up your hands, Fianna of Ireland, and give three shouts of blessing to whoever will stop this foreigner."

The Fianna gave those three shouts. And the King of Lochlann gave a great laugh when he heard them.

Druimderg, grandson of the Head of the Fianna of Ulster, was near him. He had with him a deadly spear, the Croderg, the Red-Socketed, which had come down from one to another of the sons of Rudraighe.

He looked at the King of Lochlann, and could see no part of him that was not armoured — except his mouth, which was wide open, laughing at the Fianna.

Druimderg threw the Croderg. It hit him in the open mouth, and he fell. His shield fell along with its master, and its flame went out.

Druimderg struck the head from his body, and made great boasts of the things he had done.

He was entitled. It is not every day a man finds the one weak place in a king, and it is his mouth, and he is laughing.

Labran's Journey



Then Fergus of the True Lips set out again, and went through the length of Ireland until he came to the house of Tadg, son of Nuada, who was Finn's grandfather.

There was great grief on Muirne, Finn's mother, and on Labran of the Long Hand, her brother, and on all her people, when they knew the great danger Finn was in.

Tadg asked his wife who she thought would come out alive from the great fighting at the White Strand.

"It's a pity, the way they are there," she said. "If all the living men of the world were on one side, Daire Donn, the King of the World, would put them all down. For there are no weapons in the world that will ever be reddened on him. On the night he was born, the smith of the Fomor made a shield and a sword, and it's in the prophecy that he'll fall by no weapons but those. And he gave them to the King of the Country of the Fair Men to keep, and it's with him they are now."

That is the rule. He cannot be killed. Except by the one sword and the one shield made for him on the night he was born. Remember the rule, because the story does.

"If that's so," said Tadg, "you might be able to get help for Finn, son of Cumhal, the only son of your daughter. Tell Labran Lamfada to go and ask those weapons of him."

"Don't ask me to go against Daire Donn," she said. "He was brought up in my father's house."

But after they had talked a while, they went out onto the lawn, and they sent Labran looking for the weapons in the shape of a great eagle.

He went on from sea to sea until at noon the next day he came to the dun of the King of the Country of the Fair Men. He went into the dun in his own shape and greeted the king. The king made him welcome and asked him to stay a while.

"There's a thing I want more than that," said Labran. "The wife of a champion of the Fianna has given me her love, and I can't get her without fighting for her. It's the loan of that sword and that shield you have in your keeping I've come to ask for."

It was a lie. It was a good lie. It was told for Finn.

There were seven rooms in the king's house, opening one into the next. The first door had one lock, and the second two locks, and so on to the door of the last room, which had seven locks. It was in that room that the sword and the shield made by the smith of the Fomor were kept.

They were brought out and given to Labran, and stalks of luck were put with them, and they were bound together with shield-straps.

Then Labran of the Long Hand went back across the seas, and reached his father's dun between cockcrow and full daylight, and the weakness of death came on him.

"That's a good errand you've done, my son," said Tadg. "No one ever went that far in so short a time."

"It's little profit to me," said Labran, "when I'm not able to bring them to Finn in time for the fight tomorrow."

Just then one of Tadg's people saw Aedh, son of Aebinn. Aedh was as quick as the wind over a plain until the middle of every day; and after midday, there was no man quicker.

"You've come at a good time," said Tadg, and gave him the sword and the shield to bring to Finn for the battle.

So Aedh, son of Aebinn, went with the swiftness of a hare, or a fawn, or a swallow, until at daybreak the next morning he came to the White Strand.

Just then Fergus of the True Lips was rousing up the Fianna for the great fight. "Fianna of Ireland," he was saying, "if there were seven days' length in one day, you'd have work to fill it now. For there never was, and there never will be, a day's work done in Ireland like the work of today."

The Fianna of Ireland stood up, and saw Aedh, son of Aebinn, coming towards them at his quick run, and Finn asked him for news.

"I've come from the dun of Tadg, son of Nuada," he said, "and I'm sent to you, to ask how it is you haven't reddened your weapons yet on the King of the World."

"I swear by the oath of my people," said Finn, "if I don't redden my weapons on him, I'll crush his body inside his armour."

"I have here for you, King of the Fianna," said Aedh, "the deadly weapons that will bring him to his death. It was Labran of the Long Hand who got them for you, by his Druid arts."

He put them in Finn's hand, and Finn took the coverings off them. Flashes of fire rose out of them, and deadly bubbles, and not one of the Fianna could bear to look at them. But it put great courage into them to know that Finn had them.

"Get up now," said Finn to Fergus of the True Lips, "and go to where the King of the World is, and tell him to come out to the place of the great fight."

CHAPTER XII

The Great Fight



Then the King of the World came to the strand, and all his armies with him. All that were left of the Fianna went out against them. They were like two thick woods meeting. They made great strokes, and swords crashed against bones, and bodies were hacked, and eyes were blinded, and many a mother was left without her son, and many a comely wife without her comrade.



Oscar mac Oisín — Grandson of Fionn mac Cumhaill — The Greatest Warrior of the Fianna

Then the creatures of the high air answered the battle, foretelling the destruction that would be done that day. The sea chattered of the losses. The waves gave heavy shouts, keening them. The water-beasts roared to one another. The rough hills creaked with the danger of the battle. The woods trembled, mourning the heroes. The grey stones cried out at their deeds. The wind sobbed, telling them. The earth shook, foretelling the slaughter. And the cries of the grey armies put a blue cloak over the sun, and the clouds were dark. The hounds and the whelps and the crows, and the witches of the valley, and the powers of the air, and the wolves of the forests, howled from every quarter and on every side of the armies, urging them on against each other.

Everything knew. Everything in Ireland knew what that day was.

It was then that Conan, son of Morna, remembered that he and his kindred had done great harm to the sons of Baiscne. He wished to do some good thing for them because of it, and he raised his sword and did great deeds.

Finn was above the battle, encouraging the Fianna, and the King of the World was on the other side, encouraging the foreigners.

"Get up now, Fergus," said Finn, "and praise Conan for me, so his courage will be greater. It's good work he's doing on my enemies."

So Fergus went to where Conan was. Conan was hot with the dust of the fight, and had gone outside it to let the wind get at him.

"It's well you remember the old quarrel between the sons of Morna and the sons of Baiscne, Conan," said Fergus. "You'd be ready to go to your own death if it would bring harm on the sons of Baiscne."

"For the love of your good name, Man of Poetry," said Conan, "don't speak against me without cause. I'll do good work on the foreigners when I get back into the battle."

"By my word," said Fergus, "that would be a good thing for you to do."

Then he sang a verse of praise for him, and Conan went back into the battle, and his deeds were no worse this time than before. And Fergus went back to Finn.

It is hard to praise Conan. Fergus managed it. That is what a poet is for.

"Who's best in the battle now?" said Finn.

"Duban, son of Cas, a champion of your own people," said Fergus. "He never gives more than one stroke to any man, and no man escapes with his life from that stroke. Three times nine and eighty men have fallen by him so far."

Duban Donn, great-grandson of the King of Tuathmumhain, was there listening to him.

"By my oath, Fergus," he said, "all you say is true. There's no son of a king or of a lord better in the battle than Duban, son of Cas. And I'll go to my own death if I don't go beyond him."

With that he went rushing through the battle like flames over a high hill thick with furze. Nine times he made a round of the battle, and he killed nine times nine in every round.

"Who's best in the battle now?" said Finn, after a while.

"It's Duban Donn, who just went from us," said Fergus. "There's been no one ahead of him since he was in his seventh year, and there's no one ahead of him now."

"Get up and praise him, so his courage will be greater," said Finn.

"It's right to praise him," said Fergus, "with the foreigners running from him on every side as they'd run from a heavy drenching of the sea."

So Fergus praised him a while, and then went back to Finn.

"Who's best in the battle now?" said Finn.

"It's Osgar is best in it now," said Fergus. "He's fighting alone against two hundred Franks and two hundred of the men of Gairian, and the King of the Men of Gairian himself. They're all beating at his shield, and not one of them has given him a wound but he's given a wound back for it."

"How is Caoilte, son of Ronan?" said Finn.

"He's in no great strait, after the red slaughter he's made," said Fergus.

"Then go to him," said Finn, "and tell him to keep off a share of the foreigners from Osgar."

So Fergus went to him. "Caoilte," he said, "your friend Osgar is in great danger under the blows of the foreigners. Get up and give him some help."

Caoilte went to where Osgar was, and struck a straight blow of his sword at the man nearest him, and made two halves of him.

Osgar raised his head and looked at him.

"It's likely, Caoilte," he said, "you didn't dare redden your sword on anyone until you struck down a man who was in front of my sword. It's a shame for you — all the men of the great world and the Fianna of Ireland in the one battle, and you not able to make a fight for yourself without coming to take a share of my share of it. I give my oath, I'd be glad to see you put down in your bed of blood for that."

That is Osgar. He would rather die than be helped. He would get his wish, in the end, on another field.

Caoilte's mind changed when he heard that. He turned again to the army of the foreigners with the red of anger on his white face, and eighty fighting men fell in that rout.

"How is the battle now?" said Finn.

"It's a pity," said Fergus, "there never came and there never will come anyone who could tell how it is now. By my word, the treetops of the thickest forest in the whole of the western world aren't closer together than the armies are now, for the bosses of their shields are in each other's hands. There's fire coming off the edges of their swords, and blood raining down like a shower on a day of harvest. And there were never as many leaves torn by the wind from a great forest as there are locks of long golden hair, and of black curled hair, cut off by sharp weapons and blowing up into the clouds at this moment. And nobody could tell one man from another now, unless it might be by their voices."

With that he went into the very middle of the fight to praise and hearten the men of the Fianna.

"Who's first in the battle now, Fergus?" said Finn, when he came back.

"By my oath, it's no friend of yours that's first in it," said Fergus. "It's Daire Donn, the King of the World. It's you he's searching for through the battle, and three times fifty of his own people were with him. Two of the men of your Fianna fell on them — Cairell the Battle-Striker, and Aelchinn of Cruachan — and made an end of them. But they weren't able to wound the King of the World, and the two of them fell together by him."

Then the King of the World came towards Finn. There was nobody near Finn but Arcallach of the Black Axe, the first man who ever brought a wide axe into Ireland.

"I give my word," said Arcallach, "I'd never let Finn go before me into any battle."

He rose up and struck a terrible great blow of his axe at the king. It went through his royal crown to the hair of his head. But it did not take one drop of blood out of him. The edge of the axe turned, and balls of fire went out over the plain from that blow.

And the King of the World struck back at Arcallach, and made two halves of him.

Then Finn and the King of the World turned on each other.

When the king saw the sword and the shield in Finn's hand, he knew those were the weapons that were to bring him to his death. Great dread came on him. His comeliness left him. His fingers shook, and his feet were unsteady, and the sight of his eyes was weakened.

This is what it is to know the rule of your own death, and to see it walking towards you.

Then the two of them fought a great fight, striking at each other like two days of judgment for the possession of the world.

But the king, who had never had a wound before, began to weaken badly in the fight. Finn struck great strokes that broke his shield and his sword, and cut off his left foot. And at the last he struck off his head.

But when he did, Finn himself fell into a faint of weakness from the force of the wounds he had got.

Then Finnachta of the Teeth, the first man of the household of the King of the World, took hold of the king's royal crown, and brought it to Conmail his son, and put it on his head.

"May this bring you success in many battles, my son," he said. And he gave him his father's weapons with it.

The young man went through the battle looking for Finn, and three fifties of the men of the Fianna fell by him. Then Goll Garbh the Rough, son of the King of Alban, saw him and attacked him, and they fought a hard fight. But the King of Alban's son gave him a blow under the shelter of the shield, in his left side, that made an end of him.

Finnachta of the Teeth saw that. He made another rush at the royal crown, and brought it to where Ogarmach was, the daughter of the King of Greece.

"Put on that crown, Ogarmach," he said. "It's in the prophecy that the world will be owned by a woman. And it will never be owned by any woman higher than you."

She went to look for Finn in the battle. Fergus of the True Lips saw her, and he went to where Finn was.

"O King of the Fianna," he said, "bring to mind the good fight you made against the King of the World, and all your victories before that. For a great danger is coming to you now. It's Ogarmach, daughter of the King of Greece."

With that the woman-warrior came towards him.

"O Finn," she said, "you're little satisfaction to me for all the kings and lords who've fallen by you and your people. But for all that, there's nothing better for me to get than yourself, and whatever's left of your people."

"You won't get that," said Finn. "I'll lay your head in its bed of blood the same as I did to every other one."

Then those two went at each other as if there had risen up to smother one another the flooded wave of Cliodna, and the seeking wave of Tuaigh, and the big brave wave of Rudraighe.

The woman-warrior fought for a long time. She was the best hand in battle in the whole world, after the King of the World, and she proved it. But at last a blow from Finn reached her, and cut through the royal crown, and with a second blow he struck her head off.

Then he fell himself in his bed of blood, and was the same as dead — except that he rose again.

The armies of the World and the Fianna of Ireland had fallen side by side there. There were none left fit to stand but Cael, son of Crimthan of the Harbours, and the chief man of the household of the King of the World, Finnachta of the Teeth.

Finnachta went among the dead bodies and lifted up the body of the King of the World and carried it with him to his ship.

"Fianna of Ireland," he said, "bad as this battle was for the armies of the World, it was worse for you. And I'm going back to tell that in the East of the World."

Finn heard him say it, lying on the ground in his blood with the best men of the sons of Baiscne around him.

"It's a pity I didn't find death before I heard the foreigner say those words," he said. "Nothing I've done, or the Fianna of Ireland, is worth anything, since there's a man of the foreigners left alive to go back into the great world and tell that story. Is there anyone left living near me?"

"I am," said Fergus of the True Lips.

"How is the battle now?" said Finn.

"It's a pity, the way it is," said Fergus. "By my word, since the armies met today, no man of the foreigners or of the men of Ireland has taken one step backward from the other, until they all fell foot to foot and sole to sole. There's not so much as a blade of grass or a grain of sand to be seen for the bodies of fighting men stretched on them. And there's no man of the two armies who isn't stretched in that bed of blood, except the chief man of the household of the King of the World, and your own foster-son, Cael, son of Crimthan of the Harbours."

"Get up and go to him," said Finn.

So Fergus went to Cael and asked him how he was.

"It's a pity, the way I am," said Cael. "I swear by my word that if my helmet and my armour were taken off me, there's no part of my body but would fall away from the rest. And by my oath, it's worse to me to see that man over there going away alive than to be the way I am myself. I leave you my blessing, Fergus. Carry me on your back to the sea, so I can swim after the foreigner. I'd be glad for the foreigner to fall by me before the life goes out of my body."

Fergus lifted him up and carried him to the sea, and set him swimming after the foreigner.

Finnachta waited for him to reach the ship, for he thought he was one of his own people.

Cael raised himself up when he came alongside the ship. Finnachta stretched out his hand to him. Cael took it by the wrist, and clasped his fingers round it, and gave a very strong pull that brought Finnachta over the side.

Then their arms locked across each other's bodies, and they went down together to the sand and the gravel of the clear sea.

Nobody went home to the East of the World to tell the story. That is why we are the ones telling it.

And Credhe was waiting, with the cattle, at the edge of the strand.



Book Four: Huntings And Enchantments



Credhe's Lament



Then the women came, and the musicians and the singers and the physicians of the Fianna of Ireland, to search out the kings and princes of the Fianna and to bury them. Everyone who might be healed was carried to a place of healing.

Credhe, wife of Cael, came with the others. She went looking through the bodies for her comely comrade, crying as she went.

As she was searching, she saw a crane of the meadows with her two nestlings, and the cunning beast the fox watching the nestlings. When the crane covered one of the birds to save it, the fox would make a rush at the other, so that she had to stretch herself out over both. She would sooner have got her own death from the fox than let her nestlings be killed by him.

Credhe watched that. "It's no wonder I have such love for my comely sweetheart," she said, "when the bird is in that distress over her nestlings."

Then she heard a stag on Druim Ruighlenn above the harbour, making great lamentation for his hind from place to place. They had been nine years together, and had lived in the wood at the foot of the harbour, Fidh Leis. Finn had killed the hind. The stag had gone nineteen days without tasting grass or water, lamenting after her.

"It's no shame for me," said Credhe, "to die of grief after Cael, when the stag is shortening his life sorrowing after the hind."

Then she met Fergus of the True Lips.

"Have you news of Cael for me, Fergus?" she said.

"I have news," said Fergus. "He and the last man left of the foreigners, Finnachta Fiaclach, have drowned each other in the sea."

By then the waves had put Cael back on the strand. The women and the men of the Fianna who were looking for him lifted him up and carried him to the south end of the White

Strand.

Credhe came to where he was. She keened him and cried over him, and she made this lament:

"The harbour roars, O the harbour roars, over the rushing race of the Headland of the Two Storms: the drowning of the hero of the Lake of the Two Dogs, that is what the waves are keening on the strand.

"Sweet-voiced is the crane, O sweet-voiced is the crane in the marshes of the Ridge of the Two Strong Men. It is she cannot save her nestlings; the wild dog of two colours is taking her little ones.

"Pitiful the cry, pitiful the cry the thrush is making in the Pleasant Ridge; sorrowful is the cry of the blackbird in Leiter Laeig.

"Sorrowful the call, O sorrowful the call of the deer in the Ridge of Two Lights. The doe is lying dead in Druim Silenn; the mighty stag cries after her.

"Sorrowful to me, O sorrowful to me, the death of the hero who lay beside me: the son of the woman of the Wood of the Two Thickets, to be with a bunch of grass under his head.

"Sore to me, O sore to me, that Cael is a dead man beside me, that the waves have gone over his white body. It is his pleasantness that has put my wits astray.

"A woeful shout, O a woeful shout the waves are making on the strand. They that took hold of comely Cael — a pity it is he went to meet them.

"A woeful crash, O a woeful crash the waves are making on the strand to the north, breaking against the smooth rock, crying after Cael now he is gone.

"A sorrowful fight, O a sorrowful fight the sea is making with the strand to the north. My beauty is lessened; the end of my life is measured.

"A song of grief, O a song of grief is made by the waves of Tulcha Leis. All I had is gone since this story came to me. Since the son of Crimthann is drowned I will love no one after him for ever. Many a king fell by his hand; his shield never cried out in the battle."

When she had made that lament, Credhe lay down beside Cael, and died of grief after him.

They were put in the one grave, and it was Caoilte who raised the stone over them.

She had asked him for a poem about her cups and her bowls and her beds. He had given her one. It was the poem that brought him to her door. It is hers that we remember.

After that great battle of the White Strand, which lasted a year and a day, many a sword and shield was left broken, and many a dead body lying on the ground, and many a fighting man left with a foolish smile on his face.

The great name that had been on the armies of the World went from them to the Fianna of Ireland. They took the ships and the gold and the silver and all the spoils of the armies of the World. And from that time on the Fianna had charge of the whole of Ireland, to keep it from the Fomor and from anyone else who might come against it.

They never lost that power, from that time until their last battle: the sorrowful battle of Gabhra.

CHAPTER I

The King Of Britain's Son



Arthur, son of the King of Britain, came once to take service with Finn, with three times nine men.

They went hunting one day on Beinn Edair. Finn took his place on the Cairn of the Fianna, between the hill and the sea, and Arthur took his stand between the hunt and the sea, so that the deer would not escape by swimming.

While Arthur was there he took notice of three of Finn's hounds: Bran, and Sceolan, and Adhnuall. And he made a plan in his mind to go away across the sea with his three nines, and take those three hounds with him.

He did it. He and his men took the hounds and crossed the sea, and the place they landed was Inver Mara Gamiach, on the coast of Britain. After they landed they went to the mountain of Lodan, son of Lir, to hunt on it.

As for the Fianna, when their hunting was done they gathered together on the hill, and, as the custom was, all Finn's hounds were counted. He had three hundred full-grown hounds and two hundred whelps, and the poets used to say that counting them was like counting the branches on a tree.

On this day when they were counted, Bran and Sceolan and Adhnuall were missing, and Finn was told. He told his people to search again through the three battalions of the Fianna. However hard they searched, the hounds were not to be found.

Then Finn sent for a long basin of pale gold with water in it. He put his face in the water, and his hand over his face, and what had happened was shown to him.

"The King of Britain's son has taken the hounds," he said. "Let nine men be chosen to follow them."

So nine men were chosen: Diarmuid, grandson of Duibhne; Goll, son of Morna; Oisin, son of Finn; Faolan, the friend of the hounds, son of a woman who had come over the sea to

give her love to Finn; Ferdoman, son of Bodb Dearg; two sons of Finn, Raighne Wide-Eye and Cainche the Crimson-Red; Glas, son of Enchered Bera; and with them Caoilte and Lugaidh's Son. Those nine put their helmets on their heads and took their long spears in their hands, and they felt sure they were a match for any four hundred men from the east of the world to the west.

They set out, and came to the mountain of Lodan, son of Lir, and they had not been there long when they heard talk of men hunting in that place.

Arthur of Britain and his people were sitting on a hunting-mound just then. The nine men of the Fianna attacked them, and killed them all except Arthur. Goll, son of Morna, put his two arms around Arthur and saved him from death.

Goll, again. The one who holds back the killing stroke.

Then they turned to go back to Ireland, bringing Arthur with them, and the three hounds. As they were going, Goll happened to look round, and he saw a dark-grey horse with a bridle fitted with worked gold. Then he looked to the left and saw a bay mare that was not easy to catch, with a bridle of silver rings and a golden bit. Goll took hold of the two of them and gave them into Oisín's hand, and Oisín gave them on to Diarmuid.

They went back to Finn, bringing his three hounds, and the King of Britain's son as a prisoner. Arthur made bonds with Finn, and was his follower until he died.

As for the horse and the mare, they gave them to Finn. The mare foaled eight times, eight foals at every birth. All the horses of the fair Fianna of the Gael came of that stock, for they had used no horses up to that time.

That was not the only time Finn was robbed of his hounds.

There was a daughter of Roman who was woman-Druid to the Tuatha de Danaan, and she set her love on Finn. But Finn said that as long as there was another woman to be found in the world, he would not marry a witch.

Once, three times fifty of Finn's hounds passed by the hill where she was. She breathed on the hounds and shut them up in the hill, and they never came out again. It was to spite

Finn she did it. And the place got the name of Duma na Conn, the Mound of the Hounds.

Finn could be careless with his words, when it came to women. It cost him, more than once. It was going to cost him more.

As for Adhnuall, one of the hounds Finn thought most of, who was brought back from the King of Britain's son: this is how he came to his death afterwards.

There was a great fight once between the Fianna and Macoon, son of Macnia, somewhere in the province of Leinster, and a great many of the Fianna were killed. The hound Adhnuall went wandering northward from the battle and went astray. Three times he went round the whole of Ireland. Then he came back to the place of the battle, to a hill where three young men of the Fianna who had fallen there were buried, and three daughters of a King of Alban who had died for love of them.

When Adhnuall came to that hill, he gave three loud howls, and stretched himself out, and died.

Three times round Ireland, looking. And then home, to the grave.

The Cave Of Ceiscoran



Finn called for a great hunt once, on the plains of Magh Chonaill and in the forest parts of Cairbre of the Nuts. He himself went up to the top of Ceiscoran, with his two dogs, Bran and Sceolan.

The Fianna were shouting through the whole country where they hunted, so that the deer were roused in their wild places, and the badgers in their holes, and the foxes in their wanderings, and the birds on the wing.

Conaran, son of Imidd, of the Tuatha de Danaan, ruled in Ceiscoran at that time. When he heard the shouting and the cry of the hounds all around, he told his three daughters — who had a great share of enchantments — to take vengeance on Finn for his hunting.

The three women went to the opening of a cave in the hills and sat down there together. They put three strong enchanted hanks of yarn on crooked holly-sticks, and began to reel them off outside the cave.

They had not been there long when Finn and Conan came towards them, and saw the three ugly old hags at their work: their coarse hair tossed, their eyes red and bleary, their teeth sharp and crooked, their arms very long, their nails like the tips of cows' horns, and the three spindles in their hands.

Finn and Conan passed through the hanks of yarn, to get a better look at the hags.

The moment they did it, a deadly trembling came on them, and a weakness. And the bold hags took hold of them and bound them tight.

That is the rule of the yarn. Walk through it, and your strength is gone. It does not matter who you are.

Two other men of the Fianna came up then, with the sons of Menhann, and went through the spindles to where Finn and Conan were. Their strength went from them the same way, and the hags tied them fast and carried them into the cave.

They had not been there long when Caoilte and Lugaidh's Son came to the place, and with them the best men of the sons of Baiscne. The sons of Morna came too. The moment they saw the hanks, their strength and their bravery went out of them, the same as it had gone from the others.

In the end the whole number of them, gentle and simple, were put in bonds by the hags, and carried into the cave.

And there began at the mouth of the cave a great outcry of hounds, calling for the masters who had left them there. And lying on the hillside was a great heap of deer and wild pigs and hares and badgers, dead and torn, that the hunters now tied up in the cave had brought as far as that.

Then the three women came in with swords in their hands, to the place where the Fianna lay, to make an end of them. But first they looked out, to see whether there was any other man of the Fianna left to bring in and make an end of with the rest.

They saw a very tall man coming towards them. It was Goll, son of Morna, the Flame of Battle.

When the three hags saw him they went out to meet him, and they fought a hard battle with him. A great anger came on Goll, and he struck great strokes at the witches, and at last he raised his sword and with one blow cut the two nearest him through and through.

Then the eldest of the three women wound her arms round Goll, and he turned to face her, and they wrestled together, until at last Goll gave her a great twist and threw her on the ground. He tied her fast with the straps of a shield, and took his sword to make an end of her.

"O champion who was never worsted," said the hag, "strong man who never went back in battle, I put my body and my life under the protection of your bravery. It's better for you to get Finn and the Fianna back safe and whole than to have my blood. And I swear by the gods my people swear by, I'll give them back to you."

With that Goll set her free, and they went together into the hill where the Fianna were lying.

"Loose the fastenings first from Fergus of the True Lips, and from the other learned men of the Fianna," said Goll. "After that, from Finn, and Oisín, and the twenty-nine sons of Morna, and from all the rest."

The poets first. Then his old enemy. Then his own kin. That is Goll's order of things, and it is a good one.

She took off the fastenings, and the Fianna made no delay, but got up and went out and sat down on the side of the hill. And Fergus of the Sweet Lips looked at Goll, son of Morna, and made great praises of him, and of all that he had done.

Every man of the Fianna had walked through the yarn. Goll alone had come too late to be caught. Sometimes that is what saves a people: one man, late.

Donn Son Of Midhir



Once the Fianna were hunting on the island of Toraig, north of Ireland, and they roused a fawn that was very wild and beautiful. It made for the coast, and Finn and six of his men followed it through the whole country, until they came to Slieve-nam-Ban. There the fawn put down its head and vanished into the earth, and none of them knew where it had gone.

Then a heavy snow began to fall, bending the tops of the trees like willow-rods, and the courage and strength went out of the Fianna with the force of the bad weather.

"Is there anywhere we can find shelter tonight?" Finn said to Caoilte.

Caoilte made himself supple, and went over the elbow of the hill southward. When he looked around him he saw a house full of light, with cups and horns and bowls of different kinds in it.

He stood a good while in front of the door of the house, which he knew was a house of the Sidhe, wondering whether it would be best to go in and find out about it, or to go back to Finn and the few men with him. He made up his mind to go in. He sat down on a shining chair in the middle of the floor, and looked around.

On one side he saw eight-and-twenty armed men, each with a well-shaped woman beside him. On the other side he saw six nice young girls, yellow-haired, in shaggy gowns from their shoulders. And in the middle was another young girl sitting in a chair with a harp in her hand, playing and singing. Every time she stopped, one of the men would give her a horn to drink from, and she would give it back to him, and they were all making merry around her.

She spoke to Caoilte. "Caoilte, my life," she said, "give us leave to attend on you now."

"Don't," said Caoilte. "There's a better man than me outside, Finn, son of Cumhal, and he has a mind to eat in this house tonight."

"Get up, Caoilte, and go for Finn," said a man of the house. "He never refused any man in his own house, and he'll get no refusal from us."

Caoilte went back to Finn. "You were a long time away from us, Caoilte," said Finn when he saw him. "Since the day I first took weapons in my hands, I never had a night that put so much hardship on me as this one."

The six of them went into the lighted house, with their shields and their weapons. They sat down on the edge of a seat, and a girl with yellow hair came and brought them to a shining seat in the middle of the house. The newest of every food and the oldest of every drink were put in front of them.

When the sharpness of their hunger and thirst was eased, Finn said: "Which of you may I question?"

"Question whoever you like," said the tallest of the men near him.

"Who are you yourself, then?" said Finn. "I didn't think there were so many champions in Ireland I didn't know."

"Those eight-and-twenty armed men you see over there," said the tall man, "had the one father and mother with me. We're the sons of Midhir of the Yellow Hair, and our mother is Fionnchaem, the fair, beautiful daughter of the King of the Sidhe of Monaid in the east.

"At one time the Tuatha de Danaan held a gathering and gave the kingship to Bodb Dearg, son of the Dagda, at his bright, hospitable place. He began asking hostages of me and my brothers. We said we wouldn't give them until all the rest of the Men of Dea had given theirs. Then Bodb Dearg said to our father, 'Unless you put away your sons, we'll wall up your dwelling-place on you.'

"So the eight-and-twenty brothers of us came out to look for a place for ourselves. We searched all Ireland until we found this secret hidden place, and we've been here ever since. My own name is Donn, son of Midhir. Every one of us had ten hundred armed men of his own, but they're all worn away now, and only the eight-and-twenty of us are left."

"What is it that's wearing you away?" said Finn.

"The Men of Dea," said Donn, "who come three times every year to give battle to us on the green outside."

So the gods fight the gods. They never stopped. They only stopped doing it where we could see.

"What's the long new grave we saw on the green outside?" said Finn.

"It's the grave of Diangalach, a man of enchantments of the Men of Dea," said Donn. "That was the greatest loss that's come on them yet. It was I who killed him."

"What was the next loss after that?"

"All the Tuatha de Danaan had of jewels and riches and treasures, horns and vessels and cups of pale gold, we took from them at the one time."

"And the third greatest loss they had?"

"It was Fethnaid, daughter of Feclach, the woman-harper of the Tuatha de Danaan, their music and the delight of their minds," said Donn.

"And tomorrow," he said, "they'll be coming to attack us, and there's no one left but me and my brothers. We knew we'd be in danger, and that we could make no stand against them. So we sent that bare-headed girl over there to Toraig in the north, in the shape of a foolish fawn, and you followed her here. It's that girl washing herself, with the green cloak around her, who went looking for you.

"And the empty side of the house belonged to our people that the Men of Dea have killed."

They spent that night drinking and taking their pleasure. When they got up the next morning Donn, son of Midhir, said to Finn: "Come out with me now on the lawn and see the place where we fight the battles every year."

They went out and looked at the graves and the flagstones.

"It's as far as this the Men of Dea come to meet us," said Donn.

"Which of them come here?" said Finn.

"Bodb Dearg with his seven sons," said Donn. "And Angus Og, son of the Dagda, with his seven sons. And Finnbharr of Cnoc Medha with his seventeen sons. Lir of Sidhe Fionnachaidh with his twenty-seven sons and their sons. Tadg, son of Nuada, out of the beautiful hill of Almhuin. Donn of the Island and Donn of the Vat. The two called Glas, from the district of Osraige. Dobhran Dubthaire from the hill of Liamhain of the Smooth Shirt. Aedh of the Island of Rachrainn in the north. Ferai and Aillinn and Lir and Fainnle, sons of Eogabal, from Cnoc Aine in Munster. Cian and Coban and Conn, three sons of the King of Sidhe Monaid in Alban. Aedh Minbhreac of Ess Ruadh with his seven sons. The children of the Morrighu, the Great Queen, her six-and-twenty women-warriors. The two Luaths from Magh Life. Derg and Dreacan out of the hill of Beinn Edair in the east. And Bodb Dearg himself with his great household, ten hundred, ten score and ten. Those are the chief leaders of the Tuatha de Danaan who come to destroy our hill every year."

Tadg, son of Nuada, was on that list. Finn's own grandfather. Finn heard it, and said nothing about it.

Finn went back into the hill and told all that to his people.

"My people," he said, "the sons of Midhir are in great need and under great oppression, and we've come into great danger ourselves. Unless we make a good fight now, it's likely we'll never see the Fianna again."

"Good Finn," every one of them said, "did you ever see any drawing back in any of us, that you give us that warning?"

"I give my word," said Finn, "if I went through the whole world with only this many of the Fianna of Ireland with me, I'd know neither fear nor fright. Good Donn, is it by day or by night the Men of Dea come against you?"

"It's at nightfall they come," said Donn, "so they can do us the most harm."

So they waited until night came on. Then Finn said: "Let one of you go out on the green now and keep watch, so the Men of Dea won't come on us without word or warning."

The man they set to watch had not gone far when he saw five strong battalions of the Men of Dea coming towards him. He went back to the hill and said: "It's my opinion the troops

that have come against us this time, and are standing now around the grave of the Man of Enchantments, are a match for any fighting men."

Finn called to his people. "These are good fighters come against you, with strong red spears," he said. "Let you all do well in the battle now. And what you have to do is keep the little troop of brothers, the sons of Midhir, safe in the fight. It would be treachery to friendship if any harm came on them, after our joining them. Caoilte and I are the oldest among you. Leave the rest of the battle to us."

Then from the covering-time of evening to the edge of the morning they fought the battle. The loss of the Tuatha de Danaan was no less than ten hundred, ten score and ten men.

Then Bodb Dearg and Midhir and Fionnbhar said to each other: "What are we to do with all these? Let Lir of Sidhe Fionnachaidh give us advice, since he's the oldest of us."

"This is what I advise," said Lir. "Let every one carry away his friends and his fosterlings, his sons and his brothers, to his own place. And as for those of us who stay here, let a wall of fire be made around us on one side, and a wall of water on the other."

Then the Men of Dea raised a great heap of stones, and carried away their dead. And of all the great slaughter that Finn and his men and the sons of Midhir had made, not enough was left for a crow to perch on.

As for Finn and his men, they went back into the hill, hurt and wounded and worn out.

They stayed in the hill with the sons of Midhir for a whole year, and three times in the year the Men of Dea attacked the hill, and a battle was fought.

Conn, son of Midhir, was killed in one of those battles. As for the Fianna, there were so many wounds on them that their clothing had to be held off their bodies with bent hazel sticks as they lay in their beds, and two of them were near to dying.

Finn and Caoilte and Lugaidh's Son went out on the green.

"It was a bad journey we made coming to this hill," said Caoilte, "to leave two of our comrades behind us."

"It's a pity for whoever will face the Fianna of Ireland," said Lugaidh's Son, "after leaving his comrades behind."

"Whoever goes back and leaves them, it won't be me," said Finn.

Then Donn, son of Midhir, came to them.

"Good Donn," said Finn, "do you know of any physician who can cure our men?"

"I only know one physician who could do that," said Donn, "a physician the Tuatha de Danaan have with them. Unless a wounded man has the marrow of his back cut through, he'll get relief from that physician, so that he'll be sound at the end of nine days."

"How can we bring that man here," said Finn, "when the people he's with are no good friends of ours?"

"He goes out every morning at break of day," said Donn, "to gather healing herbs while the dew is on them."

"Find someone, Donn, to show me that physician," said Caoilte, "and living or dead, I'll bring him back with me."

Then Aedh and Flann, two of the sons of Midhir, stood up. "Come with us, Caoilte," they said.

They went ahead of him to a green lawn with the dew on it. When they got there they saw a strong young man, armed, with a cloak made of the wool of the seven sheep of the Land of Promise. The cloak was full of herbs of healing he had been gathering for the Men of Dea who had been wounded in the battle.

"Who's that man?" said Caoilte.

"That's the man we came looking for," said Aedh. "Mind him well now, so he doesn't get away from us back to his own people."

They ran at him together, and Caoilte took him by the shoulders, and they carried him away with them to the ford of the Slaine in the great plain of Leinster, where most of the Fianna were at that time. A Druid mist rose about them so that they could not be seen.

They went up on a little hill above the ford, and saw in front of them four young men in crimson fringed cloaks, with gold-hilted swords, and four good hunting hounds with them. The physician could not see them because of the mist. But Caoilte saw that they were his own two sons, Colla and Faolan, and two other young men of the Fianna. He could hear them talking together, saying it was a year now since Finn, son of Cumhal, had gone from them.

"What will the Fianna of Ireland do from now on," said one of them, "without their lord and their leader?"

"There's nothing for them to do," said another, "but go to Teamhair and break up there, or find another leader for themselves."

There was heavy sorrow on them for the loss of their lord. It was a grief to Caoilte to be watching them, his own sons, and not able to say a word.

He and the two sons of Midhir went back by the Lake of the Two Birds to Slieve-nam-Ban, and went into the hill.

Finn and Donn gave a great welcome to Luibra the physician, and showed him their two comrades lying in their wounds.

"Those men are brothers to me," said Donn. "Tell me how they can be cured."

Luibra looked at their wounds. "They can be cured," he said, "if I get a good reward."

"You'll get that indeed," said Caoilte. "Tell me now, how long will it take to cure them?"

"It will take nine days."

"It's a good reward you'll get," said Caoilte, "and this is what it is: your own life left to you. But if these young men aren't healed, it's my own hand will strike off your head."

Within nine days the physician had cured them, and they were as well and as sound as before.

It was after that time that the High King sent a messenger to bring the Fianna to the Feast of Teamhair. They all gathered to it, men and women, boys and heroes and musicians.

Goll, son of Morna, was sitting at the feast beside the king.

"It's a great loss you've had, Fianna of Ireland," said the king, "losing your lord and your leader, Finn, son of Cumhal."

"It's a great loss indeed," said Goll.

"There's been no greater loss fallen on Ireland since the loss of Lugh, son of Ethne," said the king.

"What orders will you give the Fianna now, king?" said Goll.

"To you, Goll," said the king, "I'll give the right of hunting over all Ireland, until we know whether the loss of Finn is lasting."

"I won't take Finn's place," said Goll, "until he's been missing from us for three years, and until no one in Ireland has any hope of seeing him again."

The place he had once held himself, that Finn had taken from him. He would not take it back. Not yet. Not while there was hope.

Then Ailbe of the Freckled Face said to the king: "What should the seventeen queens of Finn's household do?"

"Let a safe, secret, sunny house be given to every one of them," said the king. "Let her stay there with her women, and let provision be given her for a month and a quarter and a year, until we know whether Finn is alive or dead."

Then the king stood up with a smooth drinking-horn in his hand.

"It would be a good thing, men of Ireland," he said, "if any one of you could get us news of Finn — in hills, or in secret places, or in rivers or river-mouths, or in any house of the Sidhe in Ireland or in Alban."

With that Berngal, the cow-owner from the borders of Slieve Fuad, who was divider to the King of Ireland, spoke.

"The day Finn came out of the north following a deer of the Sidhe, with his five comrades, he put a sharp spear with a shining head into my hand, and a hound's collar with it, and told me to keep them until he met me again in the same place."

Berngal showed the spear and the collar to the king and to Goll. They looked at them, and the king said: "The man who owned this collar and this spear is a great loss to the men of Ireland. Were his hounds with him?"

"They were," said Berngal. "Bran and Sceolan were with Finn, and Breac and Lainbhui with Caoilte, and Conuall and Comrith with Lugaidh's Son."

The High King called for Fergus of the True Lips.

"Do you know how long Finn has been away from us?"

"I know that well," said Fergus. "It's a month and a quarter and a year since we lost him. And indeed he's a great loss to the Fianna of Ireland, himself and the men who were with him."

"It's a great loss indeed," said the king. "And I have no hope at all of finding those six, who were the best men of Ireland or of Alban."

Then he called to Cithruadh the Druid. "Finn gave you many riches and many treasures," he said. "Tell us now: is he living, or is he dead?"

"He's living," said Cithruadh. "But as to where he is, I'll give no news of that, for he himself wouldn't want me to."

There was great joy among them when they heard that, for everything Cithruadh had ever foretold had come true.

"Tell us when he'll come back," said the king.

"Before the Feast of Teamhair is over," said the Druid, "you'll see the Leader of the Fianna drinking at it."

As for Finn and his men, they stayed in the House of the Two Birds until they had taken hostages from the Tuatha de Danaan on behalf of Donn, son of Midhir. And on the last day

of the Feast of Teamhair, they came back to their people.

And from that time on, the Fianna of Ireland had no more dealings with the people who live in houses than they had with the People of the Gods of Dana.

They had been inside the hill. You do not come all the way back from that.

The Hospitality Of Cuanna's House



One day Finn and Oisin and Caoilte and Diarmuid and Lugaidh's Son went up to the top of Cairn Feargall, with their five hounds: Bran and Sceolan, Sear Dubh, Luath Luachar, and Adhnuall.

They had not been there long when they saw a giant coming towards them, very tall and rough, with an iron fork on his back and a squealing pig between the prongs of the fork. Behind the giant was a beautiful, eager young girl, shoving him along in front of her.

"Let someone go and speak with those people," said Finn.

So Diarmuid went towards them, but they turned away before he reached them. Then Finn and the rest got up and went after them. But before they reached the giant and the girl, a dark Druid mist rose up and hid the road.

When the mist cleared, Finn and the rest looked about them and saw a good, light-roofed house at the edge of a ford close by. They went to the house. There was a green lawn in front of it, and on the lawn two wells. On the edge of one well was a rough iron vessel, and on the edge of the other a copper vessel.

They went into the house. There they found a very old, white-haired man standing to the right of the door, and the beautiful young girl they had seen before, sitting near him, and the great rough giant beside the fire, boiling a pig. On the other side of the fire was an old countryman with dark-grey hair and twelve eyes in his head, and his twelve eyes were twelve sons of battle. There was a ram in the house with a white belly and a very black head and dark-blue horns and green feet. And there was a hag at the end of the house in a worn grey gown. There was nobody else in the house.

The man at the door gave them a welcome, and the five of them sat down on the floor of the house, with their hounds.

"Let great respect be shown to Finn, son of Cumhal, and to his people," said the man at the door.

"It's the way I am," said the giant, "always to be asking and getting nothing." But all the same he got up and showed respect to Finn.

Presently a great thirst came on Finn. Nobody noticed it but Caoilte, and he began to complain loudly about it.

"Why are you complaining, Caoilte?" said the man at the door. "You have only to go out and get a drink for Finn at whichever of the wells you choose."

So Caoilte went out and brought the full of the copper vessel to Finn. Finn drank from it. There was the taste of honey on it while he was drinking, and the taste of gall on it afterwards, so that fierce windy pains and the signs of death came on him, and his looks changed so that he could hardly be known.

Caoilte complained louder than before at the state he was in, until the man at the door told him to go out and bring him a drink from the other well. Caoilte did that, and brought in the full of the iron vessel.

Finn never went through such hardship in any battle as he did drinking that draught, from the bitterness of it. But no sooner had he drunk it than his own colour and looks came back to him, and he was as well as before, and his people were very glad to see it.

Then the man of the house asked whether the pig in the cauldron was ready.

"It's ready," said the giant, "and leave the dividing of it to me."

"How will you divide it?" said the man of the house.

"I'll give one hind-quarter to Finn and his dogs," said the giant, "and the other hind-quarter to Finn's four comrades, and the fore-quarter to myself, and the chine and the rump to the old man there by the fire and the hag in the corner, and the entrails to yourself and the young girl beside you."

"I give my word," said the man of the house, "you've shared it well."

"I give my word," said the ram, "it's a bad division for me, for you've forgotten my share."

With that the ram took hold of the quarter that was in front of the Fianna, and carried it off into a corner and began to eat it.

The four of them attacked him with their swords. But with all the hard strokes they gave him they could not harm him at all. The swords slid off his back as they would off a rock.

"On my word, it's a pity for anyone who has the like of you for comrades," said the man with the twelve eyes, "letting a sheep take your food from you."

With that he went up to the ram and took him by the feet and threw him out through the door, so that he fell on his back, and they saw him no more.

Not long after that, the hag got up and threw her pale grey gown over Finn's four comrades. They turned into four old men, weak and withered, their heads hanging.

When Finn saw that a great dread came on him. The man at the door saw it, and told him to come over to him and put his head on his breast and sleep. Finn did that. And the hag took her covering off the four men, so that when Finn woke they were in their own shape again, and he was well pleased to see it.

"Do you wonder, Finn," said the man at the door, "at the ways of this house?"

"I never wondered more at anything I ever saw," said Finn.

"Then I'll tell you what they mean," said the man.

"The giant you saw first, with the squealing pig in the prongs of his fork — Sluggishness is his name. And the girl here beside me who was shoving him along is Liveliness. For liveliness pushes sluggishness on, and liveliness goes farther in the winking of an eye than the foot can travel in a year.

"The old man over there with the twelve bright eyes stands for the World. He's stronger than anyone, and he showed it when he made nothing of the ram.

"The ram you saw stands for the Desires of Men.

"The hag is Old Age, and her gown withered up your four comrades.

"And the two wells you drank the two draughts from stand for Lying and Truth. For it's sweet to people to tell a lie, but it's bitter in the end.

"And as for me, my name is Cuanna from Innistuill. It's not here I usually am. But I took a very great love for you, Finn, because of your wisdom and your great name, and so I put these things in your way, so that I might see you. The Hospitality of Cuanna's House to Finn will be the name of this story to the end of the world. Now come together, you and your men, and sleep till morning."

So they did that. And when they woke in the morning they were on the top of Cairn Feargall, with their dogs and their weapons beside them.

Swords could not touch the ram. Only the World could throw it out of doors. And even the Fianna could not stand up against Old Age; the best they could do was sleep, and be let wake again. There is no other story in this book that is so plainly about everyone.

Cat-Heads And Dog-Heads



Nine of the Fianna set out once looking for a pup they wanted, and they searched through many places before they found it.

They searched all through Magh Leine, and through the Valley of the Swords, and through the storm of Druim Cleibh — and pleasant the Plain of the Life looked after it — but not a pup could they find. Then they went searching through Durlass of the generous men, and great Teamhair, and Dun Dobhran, and Ceanntsaile, men and dogs searching the whole of Ireland, and not a pup could they find.

While they were going from place to place, with their people, they saw the three armies of the sons of the King of Ruadhleath coming towards them. One army was Cat-Headed, and the one beside it was Dog-Headed, and the men of the third army were White-Backed.

When the Fianna saw them coming, Finn held up his shining spear, and light-hearted Caoilte let out a great shout that was heard in Almuin, and in Magh Leine, and in Teamhair, and in Dun Reithlein. And that shout was answered by Goll, son of Morna, and by Faolan, Finn's son, who was with him, and by the Stutterers from Burren, and by the two sons of Maith Breac, and by Iolunn of the Sharp Edge, and by Cael of the Sharp Sword, who never gave his ear to tale-bearers.

Pleasant was the sound then of the spears and the armies, and of the silken banners raised up in the gusty wind of the morning.

These were the banners.

Finn's banner was the Dealb-Greine, the Sun-Shape, and it had the likeness of the sun on it.

Goll's banner was the Fulang Duaraidh, and it was the first to move in a battle and the last.

Faolan's banner was the Coinneal Catha, the Candle of Battle.

Oisín's banner was the Donn Nimhe, the Dark Deadly One.

Caoilte's was the Lamh Dearg, the Red Hand.

Osgar's was the Sguab Gabhaidh. It had a Broom of rowan branches on it, and when the fight was at its hottest, the only thing anyone asked was: where is the Broom?

Merry Diarmuid's banner was the Liath Loinneach, the Shining Grey.

The Craobh Fuileach, the Bloody Branch, was the banner of Lugaidh's Son.

And as for Conan, he had a briar on his banner, because he was always for quarrels and for trouble. It used to be said of him that he never saw a man frown without striking him, or a door left open without going in through it.

When the Fianna had raised their banners they attacked the three armies. First they killed the whole of the Cat-Heads. Then they took the Dog-Heads in hand and made an end of them, and of the White-Backs along with them.

After that they went to a little hill to the south with a double dun on it, and it was there they found a hound they were able to get a pup from.

By that time they had searched the whole of Ireland, and they had not found in the whole of it a hundred men who could match their nine.

As well as their banners, some of the Fianna had swords that had names. Mac an Luin, Son of the Waves, belonged to Finn. Ceard-nan Gallan, the Smith of the Branches, was Oisín's. Caoilte had Cruadh-Chosgarach, the Hard Destroying One. Diarmuid had Liomhadoir, the Burnisher. And Osgar had Cosgarach Mhor, the Great Triumphant One.

This is how they got those swords.

There came one time to where Finn and Caoilte and some others of the Fianna were, a young man, very big and ugly, with only one foot and one eye. He had a cloak of black skins over his shoulders, and in his hand a blunt ploughshare that was turning red. He told them he was Lon, son of Liobhan, one of the three smiths of the King of Lochlann.

Whether he meant to get away from the Fianna, or to lead them to his smithy, he started running, and they followed him all through Ireland: to Slieve-na-Righ, and to Luimnech,

and to Ath Luain, and by the right side of Cruachan of Connacht, and to Ess Ruadh and to Beinn Edair, and so to the sea.

Wherever it was they found the smithy, they went into it. Inside there were four smiths working, and every one of them had seven hands. Finn and Caoilte and the rest stayed there watching them until the swords were made. Then they took them away with them, and they made good use of them afterwards.

Besides his sword Mac an Luin, Finn had a shield called the Sgiath Gailbhinn, the Storm Shield. When it called out, it could be heard all through Ireland.

And whether or not it was the Storm Shield, Finn had a wonderful shield that he did great deeds with, and this is its story.

At the time of the Great Battle of Magh Tuireadh, after Lugh had struck the head off Balor of the Evil Eye, he hung it in the fork of a hazel-tree. The tree split, and the leaves fell off it, with the force of the poison that dripped from the head. For fifty years that tree was a dwelling-place of crows and ravens.

At the end of that time Manannan, son of Lir, was passing by, and he noticed the tree, split and withered, and told his men to dig it up. When they began to dig, a mist of poison rose up out of the roots. Nine of the men got their death from it, and another nine after them, and the third nine were blinded.

Luchtaine the Carpenter made a shield out of the wood of that hazel, for Manannan. After a while Manannan gave it, and a set of chessmen with it, to Tadg, son of Nuada. And from him it came to his grandson, Finn, son of Muirne and of Cumhal.

So Finn carried Balor's death on his arm. Balor, his great-great-grandfather. It is a small country, Ireland, and the dead in it are never very far away.

Lomna's Head



Finn took a wife once from the Luigne of Midhe. At the same time there was a fool in his household, named Lomna.

Finn went into Tethra, hunting with the Fianna, but Lomna stayed at the house. After a while he saw Coirpre, a man of the Luigne, go secretly in to where Finn's wife was.

When the woman knew he had seen it, she begged and prayed Lomna to hide it from Finn. Lomna agreed. But it preyed on him to have a hand in treachery against Finn.

After a while he took a four-sided rod and wrote an Ogham on it. These are the words he wrote:

"An alder stake in a paling of silver; deadly nightshade in a bunch of cresses; a husband of a lewd woman; a fool among the well-taught Fianna; heather on bare Ualann of Luigne."

He had promised not to tell. He did not tell. He wrote it down in riddles, and left it where it would be found. That is how a fool keeps a promise.

Finn saw the message, and there was anger on him against the woman. She knew well it was from Lomna he had heard the story, and she sent a message to Coirpre telling him to come and kill the fool.

So Coirpre came and struck his head off, and took the head away with him.

When Finn came back in the evening he saw the body without a head.

"Let's find out whose body this is," said the Fianna.

Then Finn did the divination of rhymes, and this is what he said: "It is the body of Lomna. It is not by a wild boar he was killed. It is not by a fall he was killed. It is not in his bed he died. It is by his enemies he died. It is no secret to the Luigne the way he died. Now let the hounds out on their track."

So they let the hounds out and put them on Coirpre's track, and Finn followed them. They came to a house with Coirpre in it, and three times nine of his men, cooking fish on a spit. Lomna's head was on a spike beside the fire.

Coirpre divided the first fish that was cooked among his men, but he put no bite into the mouth of the head. Then he made a second division in the same way.

That was against the law of the Fianna. Everyone at the fire gets a share. Everyone.

And the head spoke. "A speckled, white-bellied salmon that grows from a small fish under the sea," it said. "You have shared a share that is not right. The Fianna will avenge it upon you, Coirpre."

"Put the head outside," said Coirpre. "That's an evil word for us."

Then the head spoke from outside: "It is in many pieces you will be. It is great fires will be lighted by Finn in Luigne."

And as it said that, Finn came in. And he made an end of Coirpre and of his men.

Nobody tells us what became of the wife. The head of the fool, at least, got the last word.

Ilbrec Of Ess Ruadh



Caoilte was hunting once on Beinn Gulbain, and he went on to Ess Ruadh.

When he came near the hill of the Sidhe that is there, he saw a young man waiting for him. He wore a crimson fringed cloak, with a silver brooch on his breast. He had a white shield worked with linked beasts of red gold. His hair was rolled into a ball at the back and covered with a golden cup. He carried heavy green weapons, and he held two hounds on a silver chain.

When Caoilte came up to him the young man gave him three loving kisses and sat down beside him on the grass.

"Who are you, young champion?" said Caoilte.

"I'm Derg, son of Eoghan, of the people of Usnach," he said, "and your own foster-brother."

Then Caoilte knew him. "And what's your life like with your mother's people, the Tuatha de Danaan, in Sidhe Aedha?"

"There's nothing wanting to us there of food or clothing," said the young man. "But for all that, I'd sooner live the life of the worst-treated of the serving-boys of the Fianna than the life I'm living in the hill of the Sidhe."

Food and clothing and no age and no death. And he would give it all to carry water for the Fianna.

"Lonely as you are at your hunting today," said Caoilte, "I often saw you coming to the Valley of the Three Waters in the south, where the Siuir and the Beoir and the Berba come together, with a great company around you: fifteen hundred young men, fifteen hundred serving-boys, and fifteen hundred women."

"That was so," said Derg. "And though my gentle hound and I are living in the hill of the Sidhe, my mind is always on the Fianna. I remember well the time you won the race

against Finn's lasting black horse. Come into the hill now, for the dark of the night is coming on."

So he brought Caoilte into the hill with him, and they were set in their right places.

At that time there was great war between Lir of Sidhe Fionnachaidh and Ilbrec of Ess Ruadh. A bird with an iron beak and a tail of fire used to come every evening to a golden window of Ilbrec's house, and shake itself there, until there was not a sword left on a pillow, or a shield on a peg, or a spear in a rack — they would all come down on the heads of the people of the house. And whatever they threw at the bird fell on the heads of some of themselves.

On the night Caoilte came in, the hall was made ready for a feast, and the bird came in again and did the same destruction as before, and nothing they threw at it touched it at all.

"Has the bird been doing this long?" said Caoilte.

"For a whole year now," said Derg, "since we went to war with Sidhe Fionnachaidh."

Then Caoilte put his hand inside the rim of his shield and took out a copper rod he kept there. He threw it at the bird, and it brought the bird down on the floor of the hall.

"Did anyone ever make a better cast than that?" said Ilbrec.

"By my word," said Caoilte, "there's no one of us in the Fianna has any right to boast against another."

Then Ilbrec took down from its place a sharp spear with thirty rivets of gold in it. "That's the Spear of Fiacha, son of Congha," he said. "It was with that Finn made an end of Aillen, son of Midhna, who used to burn Teamhair. Keep it beside you now, Caoilte, until we see whether Lir will come to avenge his bird on us."

So the spear that saved Teamhair had ended up in a hill of the Sidhe. Weapons wander. The good ones always come back to the hand that needs them.

Then they took up their horns and their cups and were at drinking and pleasure.

"Well, Caoilte," said Ilbrec, "if Lir comes to avenge his bird on us, who will you put in command of the battle?"

"I'll give the command to Derg over there," said Caoilte.

"Will you take it in hand, Derg?" said the people of the hill.

"I'll take it," said Derg, "with its loss and its gain."

That is how they spent the night. It was not long into the morning before they heard the blowing of horns, and the rattling of chariots, and the clashing of shields, and the uproar of a great army coming all round the hill. They sent some of their people out to see how many there were, and they saw three brave armies of one size.

"It would be a great vexation to me," said Aedh Nimbrec, the Speckled, "for us to get our death and Lir's people to take the hill."

"Did you never hear, Aedh," said Caoilte, "that the wild boar sometimes escapes both hounds and wolves, and the stag in the same way gets away from the hounds with a sudden start? What man are you most in dread of in the battle?"

"The man who is the best fighter of all the Men of Dea," they all said. "Lir of Sidhe Fionnachaidh."

"The thing I've done in every battle I won't give up today," said Caoilte: "to meet the best man in it hand to hand."

"The two next to him in fighting," they said, "are Donn and Dubh."

"I'll put down those two," said Derg.

Then the host of the Sidhe went out to the battle, and the armies went at each other with wide green spears and little casting-spears and great stones, and the fight went on from the rising of the day until midday.

Then Caoilte and Lir met, and made a very fierce fight of it, and at the last Lir of Sidhe Fionnachaidh fell by the hand of Caoilte.

Lir. The father of Fionnuala and Aodh and Fiachra and Conn. So he died, or went wherever the gods go, in a quarrel over a bird, at the hands of a man.

Then the two good champions Dubh and Donn, sons of Eirrge, decided to go on with the battle. This is how they fought: Dubh at the front of the whole army, and Donn behind all of it, guarding the rear. Derg saw that. He put his finger into the thong of his spear and threw at the one nearest him. It broke his back and went on into the body of the other, so that the one cast made an end of the two.

That ended the battle, and all that was left of the great army of Lir went wearing away to the north. There was great rejoicing in the hill at Ess Ruadh. Ilbrec took the spoils of the beaten army for his people, and to Caoilte he gave the enchanted spear of Fiacha, with nine rich cloaks, and nine long swords with hilts and guards of gold, and nine hounds for hunting.

They said farewell to each other. Caoilte left his blessing with the people of the hill, and took their thanks away with him. And hard as the battle had been, it was harder for Derg to part from his comrade. The day he was parted from Finn and from all the Fianna was no sadder to him than that day.

It was a long time after that Caoilte went again to the hill of Ilbrec at Ess Ruadh, and this is how it happened.

In a battle at Beinn Edair, in the east, Mane, son of the King of Lochlann, threw a deadly spear at him in the middle of the fighting. He heard the whistling of the spear rushing at him, and lifted his shield to protect his head and his body. That did not save him. It struck into his thigh and left its poison there, so that he had to go looking for healing.

This is where he went: to the hill of the Sidhe at Ess Ruadh, to ask the help of Bebind, daughter of Elcmar of Brugh na Boinne, who had the drink of healing of the Tuatha de Danaan, and all that was left of the ale of Goibniu, which she used to give out to them.

Caoilte called Cascorach the Musician, son of Caincenn, and told him to bring his harp and come with him. They stayed a night in the hill of the Sidhe of Druim Nemed, in Luigne of Connacht. From there they went on by Ess Dara, the Fall of the Oaks, and Druim Dearg na

Feinne, the Red Ridge of the Fianna, and Ath Daim Glas, the Ford of the Grey Stag, and to Beinn Gulbain, and northward into the plain of Ceitne, where the Men of Dea used to pay their tribute to the Fomor; and up to the Footstep of Ess Ruadh, and the High Place of the Boys, where the boys of the Tuatha de Danaan used to play their hurling.

Aedh of Ess Ruadh and Ilbrec of Ess Ruadh were at the door of the hill, and they gave Caoilte a true welcome.

"I'm glad of that welcome," said Caoilte.

Then Bebind, daughter of Elcmar of Brugh na Boinne, came out with three times fifty comely women around her. She sat down on the green grass and gave three loving kisses to each of the three — to Caoilte, and to Cascorach, and to Fermaise, who had come with them out of the hill of the Sidhe in Luigne of Connacht.

All the people of the hill welcomed them. "Your friendship would be worth little," they said, "if you wouldn't come to help us when we're in need of help."

"It wasn't for bravery I was asked to come," said Cascorach. "But when the right time comes, I'll make music for you, if you've a mind to hear it."

"It's not for deeds of bravery we've come," said Fermaise. "But we'll give you our help if you need it."

Then Caoilte told them why he had come.

"We'll heal you well," they said.

Then they all went into the hill, and stayed there three days and three nights at drinking and pleasure.

It was good help Caoilte and Cascorach gave them after that.

There was a woman-warrior who used to come every year with the ships of the men of Lochlann to attack the Tuatha de Danaan. She had been reared by a woman who knew all enchantments, and there was no precious thing in all the hills of the Sidhe that she did not know of, and carry off. Just at this time a messenger came to the door of the hill with news

that the harbour was full of ships, and a great army had landed, and the woman-warrior with it.

It was Cascorach the Musician who went out against her, with a shield he had borrowed from Donn, son of Midhir. She used high words when she saw so young a man coming to fight her, and alone. But he made an end of her for all her high talk, and left her lying on the strand with the sea-foam washing up to her.

The harper. Not the hero. The harper went.

As for Caoilte, he went out in a chariot belonging to Midhir of the Yellow Hair, son of the Dagda, and a spear was given to him that was called Ben-badhb, the War-Woman. He threw it, and it struck the King of Lochlann, so that he fell in the middle of his army and the life went from him.

Fermaise went looking for the king's brother, Eolus, who was the comeliest of all the men of the world. He knew him by the band of gold around his head, and his green armour, and his red shield, and he killed him with a cast of a five-pronged spear.

When the men of Lochlann saw their three leaders were gone, they went into their ships and back to their own country. There was great joy through the whole country, among both the men of Ireland and the Tuatha de Danaan, that the men of Lochlann had been driven away by the deeds of Caoilte and Fermaise and Cascorach.

That was not all they did. At that time three flocks of beautiful red birds came from Slieve Fuad in the north and began eating the green grass in front of the hill of the Sidhe.

"What birds are those?" said Caoilte.

"They're three flocks that come and destroy the green every year," said Ilbrec, "eating it down to the bare flagstones, until they leave us no place for our races."

Caoilte and his comrades took up three stones and threw them at the flocks and drove them away.

"Power and blessings to you," said the people of the Sidhe. "That's good work you've done. And there's another thing you can do for us. Three ravens come to us every year out of the

north, and when the young lads of the hill are playing their hurling, each of the ravens carries off a boy. And it's tomorrow the hurling will be."

When the full light of day came the next morning, the whole of the Tuatha de Danaan went out to watch the hurling. Every six men of them were given a chessboard, and every five a board for some other game, and every ten men a little harp, and every hundred men a harp, and every nine men pipes that were sharp and powerful.

Then they saw the three ravens from the north coming over the sea. The ravens settled on the great tree of power that stood on the green, and gave three gloomy screeches — screeches that, if such a thing were possible, would have brought the dead up out of the earth, or the hair off the heads of the listeners. As it was, they took the courage out of the whole gathering.

Then Cascorach, son of Caincenn, took one of the chessmen and threw it at one of the ravens. It struck the bird in the beak and the throat and made an end of it. Fermaise killed the second, and Caoilte the third, the same way.

"Let my cure be done now," said Caoilte. "I've paid my fee for it, and it's time."

"You've paid it indeed," said Ilbrec. "Where is Bebind, daughter of Elcmar?"

"I'm here," she said.

"Bring Caoilte, son of Ronan, with you into some hidden place," he said, "and do his cure, and let him be well served, for he's driven every danger away from the Men of Dea and from the Sons of the Gael. Let Cascorach make music for him, and let Fermaise, son of Eogabil, watch him and guard him and attend him."

So Elcmar's daughter went to the House of Arms, and her two sons with her, and a bed of healing was made ready for Caoilte. A bowl of pale gold was brought to her, full of water. She took a crystal vessel and put herbs into it, and bruised them and put them in the water, and gave the bowl to Caoilte. He drank a great drink of it, and it made him throw up the poison of the spear that was in him. He took five drinks of it, and after that she gave him new milk to drink. But with the force of the retching he was left without strength for three days and three nights.

"Caoilte, my life," she said then, "in my opinion you've got relief."

"I've got it indeed," he said, "except that the weakness of my head is troubling me."

"The washing of Flann, daughter of Flidais, will be done for you now," she said. "The head that washing is done for will never be troubled with pain, or baldness, or weakness of sight."

So that cure was done for him for a while. And the people of the hill divided themselves into three parts — one part of their best men and great nobles, another of their young men, and another of their women and poets — to visit him and make mirth with him as long as he was on his bed of healing. Everything that was best from their hunting, it was to him they brought it.

One day, when Elcmar's daughter and her two sons and Cascorach and Fermaise were with Caoilte, they heard a sound of music coming towards them from the waters of Ess Ruadh. Anyone would leave the music of the whole world for that music. They put their harps on the corners of the pillars and went out, and Caoilte wondered that they had left him.

He noticed that his strength, and the strength of his hands, had not come back to him yet.

"I went into many a rough battle and many a hard fight," he said, "and now there isn't strength enough in me even to go out with the rest."

And he cried.

Caoilte, the runner. The one who ran from the wave of Cliodna to the wave of Rudraige. He could not get out of his bed to hear the music, and he lay there and cried, and the story does not look away from it.

The others came back to him, and he asked them for news.

"What was that sound of music we heard?"

"It was Uaine, out of the hill of the Sidhe at the Wave of Cliodna in the south," they said, "and with her the birds of the Land of Promise. She's musician to the whole of that country. Every year she goes to visit one of the hills of the Sidhe, and this time it's our turn."

Then the woman from the Land of Promise came into the house, and the birds came in with her and settled on the pillars and the beams. Thirty of them came in to where Caoilte was, and began singing together. And Cascorach took his harp, and whatever he played, the birds sang to it.

"I've heard much music," said Caoilte, "but I never heard music as good as that before."

After that Caoilte asked to have the healing of his thigh done, and the daughter of Elcmar gave herself to that. Everything bad was sucked out of the wound by her serving-people until it was healed. Caoilte stayed where he was for three nights after that.

Then the people of the hill got up and went into the stream to swim.

"What's to stop me going to swim now," said Caoilte, "since my health has come back to me?"

And he went into the water.

Afterwards they went back into the hill, and a great feast was made that night.

After that Caoilte said farewell to them, and so did Cascorach, but Fermaise stayed with them a while. The people of the hill gave good gifts to Caoilte: a fringed crimson cloak of the wool of the seven sheep of the Land of Promise; and a fish-hook called Aicil mac Mogha, that could not be set in any river or river-mouth without taking fish; and along with those, a drink of remembrance. After that drink there would be no place he ever saw, and no battle or fight he was ever in, but it would stay in his memory.

"That's a good help from kinsmen and from friends," said Caoilte.

Then Caoilte and Cascorach went out of the hill, and the people of it made a great lamentation after them.

He had been given the gift of never forgetting. He would live long enough to learn what that gift cost.

The Cave Of Cruachan



Caoilte was at Cruachan of Connacht once, with Cascorach. There he saw a man sitting on a heap of stones, with very rough grey hair, in a dark brown cloak fastened with a pin of bronze, and a long stick of white hazel in his hand. There was a herd of cattle in front of him in a fenced field.

Caoilte asked him for news.

"I'm steward to the King of Ireland," said the old man, "and it's from him I hold this land. We have great troubles on us in this district."

"What troubles are those?" said Caoilte.

"I have many herds of cattle," he said, "and every year at Samhain a woman comes out of the hill of the Sidhe of Cruachan and takes away nine of the best out of every herd. As for my name, I'm Bairnech, son of Carbh of Collamair of Bregia."

"Who was the best man that ever came out of Collamair?" said Caoilte.

"I know, and the men of Ireland and of Alban know," said he. "It was Caoilte, son of Ronan. And do you know where that man is now?"

"I am that man myself," said Caoilte, "and your own kinsman."

When Bairnech heard that he gave him a great welcome, and Caoilte gave him three kisses.

"It seems to me that tonight is Samhain night," said Caoilte.

"If that's so," said Bairnech, "it's tonight the woman will come to rob us."

"Let me go tonight to the door of the hill of the Sidhe," said Cascorach.

"You may do that," said Caoilte, "and bring your weapons with you."

So Cascorach went, and it was not long before he saw the girl come out past him from the hill of Cruachan. She had a beautiful cloak of one colour about her, and a gown of yellow

silk tied up with a knot between her thighs, and two spears in her hands, and she was in dread of nothing in front of her or behind her.

Cascorach blew a blast against her. Then he put his finger into the thong of his spear and threw it at the girl, and it went through her. That is how she was made an end of by Cascorach of the Music.

Then Bairnech said to Caoilte: "Caoilte, do you know the other oppression that's on me in this place?"

"What oppression is that?"

"Three she-wolves that come out of the Cave of Cruachan every year and destroy our sheep and our wethers. We can do nothing against them, and they go back into the cave again. It'll be a good friend who rids us of them."

"Well, Cascorach," said Caoilte, "do you know what the three wolves are that are robbing this man?"

"I know well," said Cascorach. "They're the three daughters of Airtach, of the last of the people of oppression of the Cave of Cruachan. It's easier for them to do their robbing as wolves than as women."

"And will they come near anyone?"

"They'll come near only one kind," said Cascorach. "If they see men of the world with harps for music, they'll come near them. What if I went tomorrow to the cairn over there, and brought my harp with me?"

So in the morning he got up and went to the cairn and stayed on it, playing his harp until the mists of evening came. While he was there he saw the three wolves coming towards him. They lay down in front of him, listening to the music. But Cascorach found no way to attack them, and at the end of the day they went back into the cave.

Cascorach went back to Caoilte and told him what had happened.

"Go up tomorrow to the same place," said Caoilte, "and tell them it would be better for them to be in the shape of women for listening to music, than in the shape of wolves."

So the next day Cascorach went out to the same cairn and set his people around it, and the wolves came there and stretched themselves out to listen to the music.

"If you were ever women," Cascorach said to them, "it would be better for you to listen to the music as women than as wolves."

They heard that. And they threw off the dark trailing coverings that were around them, for they liked the sweet music of the Sidhe very much.

When Caoilte saw them there side by side, elbow to elbow, he threw his spear. It went through the three women, so that they were like a skein of thread drawn together on the spear.

That is how he made an end of the strange, unknown three. And the place got the name of the Valley of the Shapes of the Wolves.

They had come out of their wolf-skins to hear the music better. It is the one tender thing we are told about them, and it was the thing that killed them.

The Wedding At Ceann Slieve



Finn and the Fianna made a great hunt once on the hill of Torc, above Loch Lein and Feara Mor.

They went on hunting until they came to pleasant green Slieve Echtge, and from there it spread over other green-topped hills, and through thick tangled woods, and rough red-headed hills, and over the wide plains of the country. Every chief man among them chose the place he liked, and the gap of danger he was used to. The shouts they gave at the turns of the hunt were heard in the woods all around, so that they started the deer in the wood, and sent the foxes wandering, and the little red beasts climbing the rocks, and the badgers out of their holes, and the birds flying, and the fawns running their best. Then they let out their angry, small-headed hounds and set them hunting. Red were the hands of the Fianna that day, and proud they were of their hounds, torn and wounded before evening.

It happened that day that nobody stayed with Finn but Diorraing, son of Domhar.

"Well, Diorraing," said Finn, "you watch for me while I sleep. I rose early today — and it's an early rising a man makes when he can't see the shadow of his five fingers between himself and the light of day, or tell the leaves of the hazel from the leaves of the oak."

With that he fell into a quiet sleep that lasted until the yellow light of evening. And the rest of the Fianna, not knowing where he had gone, gave up the hunt.

The time was long to Diorraing while Finn slept, and he woke him and told him the Fianna must have given up the hunt, for he could not hear a cry or a whistle from them.

"The end of the day has come," said Finn, "and we won't follow them tonight. Go to the wood now and bring timber and dead branches for a shelter, and I'll go looking for food for the night."

So Diorraing went to the wood. He had not gone far when he saw a fine, well-lighted house of the Sidhe in front of him, on the edge of the wood close by. He went back to Finn with the news.

"Let's go to it," said Finn. "We shouldn't be working in this place, with people living so near."

They went to the door of the house and knocked, and the door-keeper came.

"Whose house is this?" said Diorraing.

"It belongs to Conan of Ceann Slieve," said the door-keeper.

"Tell him there are two of the Fianna of the Gael at the door."

The door-keeper went in and told Conan there were two men of the Fianna at the door.

"One of them," he said, "is young and strong, quiet and fair-haired, and more beautiful than the rest of the men of the world. He has in his hand a small-headed, white-breasted hound, with a collar of rubbed gold and a chain of old silver. The other is brown and ruddy and white-toothed, and he's leading a yellow-spotted hound on a chain of bright bronze."

"You've made a good report of them," said Conan, "and I know them by it. The man you spoke of first is Finn, son of Cumhal, Head of the Fianna of Ireland, with Bran in his hand. And the other is Diorraing, with Sceolan. Go quickly now and let them in."

So Finn and Diorraing were brought in and well attended to. Their weapons were taken from them, and a grand feast was made ready that pleased them well. Conan's wife sat on one side of Finn, and his daughter Finndealbh, of the Fair Shape, on the other. They talked a great deal together. At last, seeing her so beautiful, with the colour of gold on her curled hair and her eyes as blue as flowers, and a soft four-cornered cloak fastened at her breast with a silver pin, Finn asked Conan for her as his wife.

"Leave off asking that, Finn," said Conan. "Your own courage isn't greater than the courage of the man she's promised to."

"Who's that?" said Finn.

"He's Fatha, son of the King of Ess Ruadh," said Conan.

"Your wounds and your danger on yourself," said Diorraing. "It would be right for that stammering tongue that gave out those words to be tied and shortened for ever, and a

drink of death to be given to you. For if the whole of the Men of Dea could be put into the one body, Finn would be better than all of them."

"Leave off, Diorraing," said Finn. "It's not fighting I'm here for, but asking for a wife. And I'll get her, whether the Men of Dea think well or badly of it."

A girl is promised to a man of the Sidhe, and Finn wants her, and says so, and means it. He has done this before. It has never once gone well.

"I won't quarrel with you," said Conan. "But I put you under bonds, as a true hero, to answer everything I'm going to ask you."

"I'll do that," said Finn.

So Conan questioned Finn about his birth and his rearing, and the deeds he had done since he came to the Fianna, and Finn gave full answers to them all.

At last Finn said: "Let's go on with this no longer. If you have musicians with you, let them be brought to us now. It's not my custom to go a single night without music."

"Tell me this first," said Conan. "Who made the Dord Fiann, the Mutterer of the Fianna, and when was it made?"

"I'll tell you the truth of that," said Finn. "It was made in Ireland by the three sons of Cearmait Honey-Mouth. Nine men used to sound it, and since it came to me I have fifty men sounding it."

"And tell me this," said Conan. "What music pleased you best of all you ever heard?"

"I'll tell you that," said Finn. "When the seven battalions of the Fianna are gathered in the one place, and raise their spear-shafts over their heads, and the sharp whining of the clear cold wind goes through them — that's very sweet to me. And when the drinking-hall is set out in Almhuin, and the cup-bearers give out the bright cups to the chief men of the Fianna, that's very sweet to me. And it's sweet to me to listen to the voice of the sea-gull and the heron, and the noise of the waves of Traig Liath, the song of the three sons of Meardha, the whistle of Lugaidh's Son, and the voice of the cuckoo at the beginning of

summer, and the grunting of the pigs on the Plain of Eithne, and the shouting of laughter in Doire."

And this is what he said:

"The Dord in the green-topped woods; the lasting wash of the waves against the shore; the noise of the waves at Traig Liath meeting with the river of the White Trout; the three men that came to the Fianna, a man of them gentle and a man of them rough, another man of them ploughing the clouds — they were sweeter than any other thing.

"The grey mane of the sea, when a man cannot follow its track; the swell that brings the fish to the land; it is sleep-music, its sound is sweet.

"Feargall, son of Fionn, a man who was ready-handed, long was his leap, well marked is his track; he never gave a story that did not do away with secrets; it is his voice was the music of sleep to me."

When Finn had answered all the questions so well, Conan said he would give him his daughter, and that he would have a wedding-feast ready at the end of a month.

They spent the rest of the night in sleep. But Finn saw a dreadful vision in his sleep that made him start up from his bed three times.

"What makes you start from your bed, Finn?" said Diorraing.

"It was the Tuatha de Danaan I saw," he said, "taking up a quarrel against me, and making a great slaughter of the Fianna."

As for the Fianna, they rested at Fotharladh of Moghna that night, and they were down-hearted, having no news of Finn. Early the next morning two of them, Bran Beag and Bran Mor, got up and went to Mac-an-Reith, son of the Ram, who had the gift of true knowledge, and asked him where Finn had spent the night. Mac-an-Reith was somehow unwilling to tell them, but at last he said it was at the house of Conan of Ceann Slieve.

The two Brans went on to Conan's house, and Finn made them welcome. But they blamed him when they heard he was taking a wife with none of his people with him.

"Tell all the Fianna to come to the feast at the end of a month," said Conan.

So Finn and Diorraing and the two Brans went back to where the Fianna were and told them all that had happened, and they went on to Almhuin.

That night, when they were in the drinking-hall at Almhuin, they saw the son of the King of Ireland coming to where they were.

"It's a pity the king's son has come," said Finn. "He won't be satisfied without ordering everything in the hall his own way."

"We won't take his orders," said Oisin. "We'll leave half the hall to him and keep the other half ourselves."

So they did that. But it happened that in the half of the house given up to the King of Ireland's son there were sitting two of the Men of Dea, Failbhe Mor and Failbhe Beag. And they said it was because they were sitting on that side of the hall that it was given up.

"It's a pity," said Failbhe Beag, "that this shame and this great insult have been put on us tonight. And it's likely Finn has a mind to do more than that to us again. He's going to carry off the woman who's promised to the third best man of the Tuatha de Danaan, against the will of her father and mother."

This is how wars start. A seat in a hall. A girl. Two men sitting on the wrong side of a room, who were never asked where they would like to sit.

Those two went away early in the morning to Fionnbhar of Magh Feabhail, and told him of the insults Finn and the Fianna of Ireland meant to put on the Tuatha de Danaan.

When Fionnbhar, who was king over the Tuatha de Danaan, heard that, he sent messengers through the length of Ireland to gather them all to him. Six good battalions came to him on the edge of Loch Derg Dheirc at the end of a month. It was the same day Conan had the wedding-feast made ready for Finn and his people.

Finn was at Teamhair Luachra at that time. When he heard the feast was ready he set out to go to it. It happened that most of the men he had with him were of the sons of Morna.

On the way Finn said to Goll: "O Goll, I never felt any fear going to a feast until now. There are only a few of my people with me. I know there's no good thing ahead of me, but that the Men of Dea are going to raise a quarrel against me and kill my people."

"I'll defend you against anything they may do," said Goll.

Goll, again. He always says it the same way.

They went on to Conan's house, and there was a welcome for them. They were brought into the drinking-hall, and Finn was put in the place beside the door, with Goll on his right and Finndeilb, of the Fair Shape, on his left, and all the rest in the places they were used to.

As for Fionnbhar of Magh Feabhail and the Tuatha de Danaan, they put a Druid mist about themselves and went on, hidden and armed, in sixteen battalions, to the lawn in front of Conan's house.

"There's little profit in our being here," they said, "with Goll beside Finn against us."

"Goll won't protect him this time," said Ethne, the woman-Druid. "I'll entice Finn out of the house, however well he's watched."

She went to the house and took her stand outside, in front of Finn.

"Who is that in front of me?" she said.

"It's I," said Finn.

"I put you under the bonds a true hero never broke," she said, "to come out to me here."

When Finn heard that he made no delay but went out to her. For all the people in the house, not one of them noticed him going except Caoilte, and he followed him out.

That is the trouble with being a true hero. Anyone who knows the words can call you out of a lit room into the dark.

At the same time the Tuatha de Danaan let loose a flock of blackbirds with fiery beaks. They settled on the breasts of all the people in the house, and burned them and destroyed

them, until the young lads and the women and children of the place ran out on every side. And the woman of the house, Conan's wife, was drowned in the river outside the dun.

As for Ethne, the woman-Druid, she asked Finn whether he would race her.

"It's to run a race against you I called you out," she said.

"What length of race?" said Finn.

"From Doire da Torc, the Wood of the Two Boars, to Ath Mor, the Great Ford."

So they set out, and Finn got over the ford first. Caoilte was following after them, and Finn was urging him on.

"You should be ashamed of your running, Caoilte," he said, "with a woman going past you."

At that Caoilte made a leap forward, and when he was ahead of the witch he turned and gave her a blow of his sword that made two equal halves of her.

"Power and good luck to you, Caoilte!" said Finn. "Many a good blow you've struck, but you never struck a better one than this."

They went back to the lawn in front of Conan's dun, and there they found the whole company of the Tuatha de Danaan, who had put the Druid mist off them.

"It seems to me, Caoilte," said Finn, "that we've come into the middle of our enemies."

With that they stood back to back, and they were attacked on all sides, until groans of weakness from the unequal fight were forced out of Finn.

When Goll, inside the house, heard that, he said: "It's a pity the Tuatha de Danaan have enticed Finn and Caoilte away from us. Let's go to their help, and make no delay."

He rushed out, and all the Fianna who were there with him, and Conan of Ceann Slieve and his sons. A great anger came on Goll, so that he looked like a tall mountain under his grey shield in the battle. He broke through the Tuatha de Danaan until he reached Fionnbhar, their leader, and they went at each other, cutting and wounding, until at last Fionnbhar of Magh Feabhail fell by the strokes of Goll.

A great many others fell in that battle, and there was never a harder battle fought in Ireland. No man on either side had a mind to go back one step before whoever he was fighting. They were the two hardest-fighting troops to be found in the four parts of the world: the strong, hardy Fianna of the Gael, and the beautiful Men of Dea. And they came near to being all destroyed in that battle.

But after a while they saw the rest of the Fianna, who had not been in the battle, coming from all parts of Ireland. When the Tuatha de Danaan saw them coming they put the Druid mist about themselves again and went away.

Clouds of weakness came on Finn himself, and on those with him, from the force of the fight. Many men of the Fianna were lost in that battle. As for the rest, they stayed a long time in Almhuin of Leinster, until their wounds were entirely healed.

The story does not say whether Finn ever married Finndealbh of the Fair Shape. It does not say what became of her at all. Her mother was drowned on her wedding-day, and after that nobody mentions her again.

The Shadowy One



Finn had no great luck, going to look for a wife that time. And he had no better luck another time he asked for a wife from among the Sidhe. This is how that happened.

He was hunting on the mountain of Bearnas Mor, and a great wild pig turned on the hounds of the Fianna and killed most of them. Then Bran attacked it and got the better of it.

The pig began to scream. With that a very tall man came out of the hill and asked Finn to let the pig go free. When Finn agreed, the man brought them into the hill of the Sidhe at Glandeirgdeis. When they came to the door of the house he struck the pig with his Druid rod, and that moment it changed into a beautiful young woman. The name he called her by was Scathach, the Shadowy One.

He made a great feast for the Fianna. Finn asked for the young girl in marriage, and the tall man, her father, said he would give her to him that very night.

But when night came on, Scathach asked for the loan of a harp, and it was brought to her.

It had three strings. One was of iron, and one of bronze, and one of silver.

When the iron string was played, it set all the hosts of the world crying, and crying without end.

When the bright bronze string was played, it set them all laughing, from one day to the same hour the next.

When the silver string was played, all the men of the whole world fell into a long sleep.

It was the sleepy silver string the Shadowy One played, until Finn and Bran and all his people were in their heavy sleep.

When they woke at sunrise the next morning, they were outside on the mountain of Bearnas, where they had first seen the wild pig.

She had not said no. She had not had to. She had only chosen which string to play.

Finn's Madness



Finn and the Fianna came once to a ford of the Slaine, and sat down there for a while.

As they sat there they saw, on the round rock above the ford, a young woman in a dress of silk, with a green cloak about her and a golden brooch in the cloak, and on her head the golden crown that is the sign of a queen.

"Fianna of Ireland," she said, "let one of you come and speak with me now."

Sciathbreac, of the Speckled Shield, went towards her. "Who is it you want?" he said.

"Finn, son of Cumhal," she said.

Finn went over to talk with her. "Who are you?" he said. "And what is it you want?"

"I am Daireann, daughter of Bodb Dearg, son of the Dagda," she said. "I've come to be your wife, if you'll give me the bride-gift I ask."

"What bride-gift is that?"

"Your promise," she said, "that I'll be your only wife for the length of a year, and have half your time after that."

"I won't give that promise to any woman of the world," said Finn, "and I won't give it to you."

At that the young woman took a cup of white silver from under a covering and filled it with strong drink, and gave it to Finn.

"What's this?" said Finn.

"It's very strong mead," she said.

Now there were bonds on Finn not to refuse anything that belonged to a feast. So he took the cup, and drank what was in it.

That was the rule, and she knew the rule. It is always the rules they use against you, the ones who know you best.

That moment he was like a man gone mad. He turned his face towards the Fianna, and every harm and every fault and every misfortune in battle that he knew of against any one of them, he sprang it on them, through the mad drunkenness the young woman had put on him.

Then the chief men of the Fianna of Ireland got up and left the place to him, every one of them setting out for his own country, until there was nobody left on the hill but Finn and Caoilte.

Caoilte got up and followed after them.

"Fianna of Ireland," he said, "don't leave your lord and your leader because of the arts and the tricks of a woman of the Sidhe."

Thirteen times he went after them, bringing them back to the hill like that.

With the end of the day and the fall of night, the bitterness went out of Finn's tongue. By the time Caoilte had brought back the whole of the Fianna, his sense and his memory had come back to him. And he would sooner have fallen on his sword and got his death than have stayed living.

Think of it. To wake from a drunkenness and know every word you said, and to whom, and that every word was true.

That was the hardest day's work Caoilte ever did — unless it was the day he brought the flock of beasts and birds to Teamhair, to ransom Finn from the High King of Ireland.

Another time Maer, wife of Bersa of Berramain, fell in love with Finn. She made nine nuts of Segair with love-charms in them, and sent them to Finn, and told him to eat them.

"I won't," said Finn. "They're not nuts of knowledge, but nuts of ignorance. And there's no knowing what they are, unless they're an enchantment for drinking love."

So he buried them a foot deep in the earth.

He had learned something, then. It had only cost him one very long day.

The Red Woman



The Fianna were at Almuin once with no great work to do. There came a very misty morning, and Finn was afraid sluggishness would come on his men. He got up and said, "Make yourselves ready, and we'll go hunting to Gleann-na-Smol."

They all said the day was too misty for hunting. But there was no use talking. They had to do as Finn told them. So they made themselves ready and went on towards Gleann-na-Smol. They had not gone far when the mist lifted and the sun came out.

When they were on the edge of a little wood, they saw a strange beast coming towards them with the quickness of the wind, and a Red Woman on its track. The beast had narrow feet, and a head like the head of a boar, with long horns on it. But the rest of it was like a deer, and there was a shining moon on each of its sides.

Finn stopped. "Fianna of Ireland," he said, "did you ever see a beast like that one before?"

"We never did indeed," they said. "It would be right for us to let the hounds out after it."

"Wait a while," said Finn, "until I speak with the Red Woman. But don't let the beast get past you."

They tried to hold the beast back by going in front of it, but they could hardly hinder it at all, and it went away through them.

When the Red Woman came up to them, Finn asked her the name of the beast she was following.

"I don't know that," she said, "though I've been on its track since I left the borders of Loch Dearg a month ago, and I've never lost sight of it since. The two moons on its two sides shine over the country all round at night. And I must follow it until it falls, or I'll lose my own life and the lives of my three sons, who are the best fighting men in the whole world."

"We'll take the beast for you, if you like," said Finn.

"Don't try to do that," she said. "I'm swifter than you are myself, and I can't come up with it."

"We won't let it go until we know what kind of beast it is," said Finn.

"If you or your share of men go after it," she said, "I'll bind you hand and foot."

"That's stiff talk," said Finn. "Don't you know I'm Finn, son of Cumhal? And there are fourscore fighting men with me who were never beaten yet."

"I give little heed to you or your share of men," said the Red Woman. "And if my three sons were here, they'd stand up against you."

"It will be a bad day indeed," said Finn, "when the threat of a woman puts fear on me or on the Fianna of Ireland."

With that he sounded his horn. "Let us all follow now, men and dogs, after that beast we saw."

No sooner had he said it than the woman made a great water-worm of herself and attacked Finn. She would have killed him then and there if Bran had not been with him.

Bran took a grip of the worm and shook it. Then it wound itself round Bran's body, and would have crushed the life out of her, but Finn thrust his sharp sword into its throat.

"Hold back your hand," said the worm, "and you won't have the curse of a lonely woman on you."

"It's my opinion," said Finn, "that you wouldn't leave me my life if you could take it. But go out of my sight now, and let me never see you again."

Then she made herself into a Red Woman again and went away into the wood.

While Finn was talking and fighting with the Red Woman, all the Fianna had gone off on the beast's track, and he did not know where they were. He went after them, he and Bran. It was late in the evening when he caught up with a share of them, still on the track of the beast.

The dark of the night was coming on, but the two moons on the sides of the beast gave a bright light, and they never lost sight of it. They kept following it. About midnight they were pressing close on it, and it began to scatter blood behind it, and before long Finn and his men were red from head to foot. That did not stop them. They followed it on until they saw it going in at the foot of Cnoc-na-righ at the break of day.

When they came to the foot of the hill, the Red Woman was standing there in front of them.

"You didn't take the beast," she said.

"We didn't take it," said Finn, "but we know where it is."

She took a Druid rod and struck a blow on the side of the hill, and that moment a great door opened, and they heard sweet music coming from inside.

"Come in now," said the Red Woman, "and see the wonderful beast."

"Our clothes aren't clean," said Finn, "and we wouldn't like to go in among a company the way we are."

Covered in blood from head to foot, and his worry was whether he was fit to go to a party. That is Finn too.

She put a horn to her mouth and blew it, and that moment ten young men came to her.

"Bring water for washing," she said, "and four times twenty suits of clothes, and a beautiful suit and a crown of shining stones for Finn, son of Cumhal."

The young men went away and came back at the end of a minute with water and with clothing.

When the Fianna were washed and dressed, the Red Woman brought them into a great hall where there was the brightness of the sun and of the moon on every side. From there she brought them into another great room. Finn and his men had seen many grand things up to that time, but they had never seen anything as grand as what they saw there.

There was a king sitting in a golden chair, in clothes of gold and of green, and his chief people were sitting around him, and his musicians were playing. Nobody could say what colour the musicians' clothes were, for every colour of the rainbow was in them. There was a great table in the middle of the room with every kind of thing on it, each better than the last.

The king rose and welcomed Finn and his men, and told them to sit down at the table. They ate and drank their fill, and they needed it after the hunt they had made.

Then the Red Woman stood up. "King of the Hill," she said, "if it's your will, Finn and his men have a mind to see the wonderful beast. They spent a long time following it, and that's what brought them here."

The king struck a blow on his golden chair, and a door opened behind him, and the beast came through and stood before the king. It bowed down before him and spoke.

"I'm going on towards my own country now," it said. "There's no runner in the world as good as me, and the sea is the same to me as the land. Let whoever can catch me come now, for I'm going."

With that the beast went out of the hill as quick as a blast of wind, and all the people who were in the hill went after it. It was not long before Finn and his men were ahead of the rest, at the front of the hunt, gaining on the beast.

About midday Bran made the beast turn, and then she forced it to turn a second time. It began to cry out, and before long its strength began to flag. At last, just at sunset, it fell dead, and Bran was at its side when it fell.

Then Finn and his men came up. But instead of a beast, it was a tall man they saw lying dead in front of them.

The Red Woman came up at the same time.

"High King of the Fianna," she said, "that's the King of the Firbolgs you've killed. His people will put great troubles on this country in the time to come, when you, Finn, and your

people are under the sod. And I'm going now to the Country of the Young, and I'll bring you with me if you like."

"We thank you for that," said Finn. "But we wouldn't give up our own country if we were to get the whole world as an estate, and the Country of the Young along with it."

Remember that he said this. Remember that it was Finn who said it, with the whole of his life in front of him. Someone else would be asked the same question, later, and answer differently.

"That's well," said the Red Woman. "But you're going home empty after your hunt."

"It's likely we'll find a deer in Gleann-na-Smol," said Finn.

"There's a fine deer at the foot of that tree over there," said the Red Woman, "and I'll rouse it for you."

With that she gave a cry, and the deer started out and away, and Finn and his men after it. It never stopped until it came to Gleann-na-Smol, and they could not catch it.

Then the Red Woman came to them. "I think you're tired now with following the deer," she said. "Call off your hounds, and I'll let out my own little dog after it."

So Finn sounded a little horn he had at his side, and that moment the hounds came back to him. Then the Red Woman brought out a little hound as white as the snow of the mountains and set it after the deer. It was not long before it had caught the deer and killed it. Then it came back and leapt in under the Red Woman's cloak.

Finn wondered greatly at that. But before he could ask the Red Woman a question, she was gone out of sight.

As for the deer, Finn knew there was enchantment on it, and he left it lying there.

Tired and empty were the Fianna, going back to Almhuin that night.

Finn And The Phantoms



Finn went to a gathering once at Aonach Clochair, and a great many of the men of Munster crowded to it. The horses of the Fianna were brought there, and the horses of the men of Munster, and they raced against each other.

Fiachu, son of Eoghan, was there. When the games were over he gave good presents to Finn: a lasting black horse that won the three prizes of the gathering, and a chariot, and a horse for the chariot-driver, and a spear with a deadly spell on it, and weapons of silver, and three comely hounds — Feirne and Derchaem and Dialath — with collars of yellow gold and chains of white bronze.

Finn stood up and thanked Fiachu, son of Eoghan. Then he and his people set out for the house of Cacher at Cluain-da-loch. They stayed three days feasting in Cacher's house, and then Finn gave him the price of his feast and his ale: fifty rings, and fifty horses, and fifty cows.

He and the Fianna went on from there over Luachair to the strand at Berramain. Finn was trying out his black horse on the strand, and Caoilte and Oisín raced against him. But it was only folly for them to do it. He gave his horse a blow and away with him, to Traigh Liath, and over the Plain of Health to the Old Yew of the Old Valley, and to the mouth of the Flesc and the mouth of the Lemain to Loch Lein, until he came to the hill of Bairnech, with Caoilte and Oisín after him.

"Night's coming on us," said Finn. "Go and look for some place where we can sleep."

He looked round at the rocks on his left hand and saw a house, and a fire shining out from it in the valley below.

"I never knew of a house in this valley," he said.

"It's best for us to go and see it," said Caoilte. "There are many things we don't know about."

The three of them went on to the house, and they heard screams and crying coming from it. When they came to the house, the people in it were very fierce and rough. A big grey man took hold of their horses and brought them in, and shut the door of the house with iron hooks.

"My welcome to you, Finn of the great name," he said. "You were a long time coming here."

They sat down on the hard boards of a bed. The grey man kindled a fire and threw logs of elder-wood on it, until they were nearly smothered with the smoke.

Then they saw a hag in the house with three heads on her lean neck. And on the other side there was a man without a head, with one eye, and the eye was in his breast.

"Get up, you that are in the house," said the grey man, "and make music for the King of the Fianna."

With that nine bodies rose up out of the corner nearest the Fianna, and nine heads rose up on the other side of the bed, and they gave nine harsh screeches together that nobody would want to listen to. Then the hag answered them, and the headless man answered. And harsh as all that music was, there was none of it you would not rather hear than the music of the one-eyed man. The music that was sung came near to breaking the bones of their heads. It was no sweet music.

Then the big grey man got up and took the axe that was for cutting logs, and began striking at the horses, flaying them and destroying them. Fifty pointed spits of the rowan-tree were brought, and he put a piece of the horses' flesh on each spit and set them on the hearth. But when he took the spits from the fire and put them in front of Finn, the flesh on them was still raw.

"Take your food away," said Finn. "I've never eaten meat that was raw, and I never will, just for being a day without food."

"If you've come into our house to refuse our food," said the grey man, "we'll surely go against you, Finn and Caoilte and Oisín."

With that everyone in the house attacked the three. They were driven back into the corner, and the fire was put out, and the fight went on through the whole night in the dark. And but for Finn and the way he fought, they would have been put down.

When the sun rose and lit up the house the next morning, a mist came into the head of each of the three, so that they fell down as if dead on the floor.

After a while they got up again. There was nothing to be seen of the house, or of the people of the house. They had all vanished. But their horses were there, and they took them and went on, very weak and tired, for a long way, until they came to the strand of Berramain.

The ones who had fought them were the three Shapes out of the Valley of the Yew Tree, who had come to avenge their sister, Cuillen of the Wide Mouth.

As for Cuillen: she was a daughter of the King of Munster, and her husband was the King of Ulster's son. They had a son who was called Fear Og, the Young Man, and there was hardly a man in Ireland as good as he was in shape and courage and spear-casting.

Once he joined a game with the Fianna, and did better than all of them, and Finn gave him a great reward. After that he went out on a hunt they made, and it was by him, and by none of the Fianna, that the first blood was drawn of pig or of deer.

When they came back, a heavy sickness fell on the young man, through the eyes and the envy of the Fianna. It left him without life at the end of nine days.

He was buried under a green hill, and the shining stone he used to hold in his hand while he did his feats was put over his head.

His mother, Cuillen, came to his grave keening him every day for the length of a year. And one day she died there, of grief after her son, and they put her into the same green hill.

The Fianna had killed him by looking at him too hard. Nobody lifted a hand. Envy is a weapon too, and the story is honest enough to say whose it was.

As for Finn, he was afraid of no earthly thing. He killed many great serpents in Loch Cuilinn and Loch Neathach and at Beinn Edair; and Shadow-Shapes at Loch Lein and Drom Cleib and Loch Liath; and a serpent and a cat in Ath Cliath.

The Pigs Of Angus



Angus Og, son of the Dagda, made a feast once at Brugh na Boinne for Finn and the Fianna of the Gael. There were ten hundred of them there, wearing green clothes and crimson cloaks. As for the people of Angus's house, their clothes were of red silk.

Finn sat beside Angus in the beautiful house, and it is a long time since the like of those two were seen in Ireland. Any stranger would have wondered to see the way the golden cups went from hand to hand.

Then Angus said, in a loud voice that everyone could hear: "This is a better life than hunting."

Anger came on Finn. "It's a worse life than hunting," he said, "to be here — without hounds, without horses, without battalions, without the shouting of armies."

"Why are you talking like that, Finn?" said Angus. "As for the hounds you have, they wouldn't kill so much as one pig."

"Neither you nor the whole host of the Tuatha de Danaan," said Finn, "has a pig that ever went on dry land that Bran and Sceolan wouldn't kill."

"I'll send you a pig," said Angus, "that will get away from you and your hounds, and that will kill them in the end."

This is how it goes with gods and heroes, at a feast, with drink in them. Nobody means it. Everybody means it.

The steward of the house called out in a loud voice: "Let everyone go to his bed now, before the lightness of drunkenness comes on you."

But Finn said to his people: "Let's make ready and leave this place. We're only a few among the Men of Dea."

So they set out and went westward until they came to Slieve Fuad, where the Fianna were at that time.

For the whole length of a year after that, the Tuatha de Danaan boasted of how they would get the better of the Fianna, and the Fianna thought about how they could do best in the hunt.

At the end of that time Angus sent messengers to Finn, asking him with great respect whether he was ready to keep his word. Finn said he was.

The hounds were brought out. Finn himself held Bran and Sceolan, one in each hand. Caoilte had Adhnuall, and Oisín had Ablach, and merry Bran Beag had Lonn, and Diarmuid held Eachtach, and Osgar held Mac an Truim. Garraidh was held by Faolan, and Rith Fada, of the Long Run, by hungry Conan.

They had not been there long with their hounds when they saw a terrible herd of great pigs on the plain to the east, every one of them the height of a deer. One pig, out in front of the rest, was blacker than a smith's coal, and the bristles on its head were like a thicket of thorn-trees.

Then Caoilte let Adhnuall go, and she was the first to kill a pig of the herd. Then Bran broke away from the leash Finn was holding. The pigs ran their best, but she caught up with them and took hold of a pig.

At that Angus said: "O Bran, fosterling of fair-haired Fergus, it's not a right thing you're doing, killing my own son."

When Bran heard that, her ways changed, and it was like an enemy she took hold of the pig. She did not let it go. She held her breath and kept it for the Fianna.

She had been told it was her own foster-brother. She held on anyway. For Finn. There is nothing more to say about Bran than that, and nothing less.

The hunt went over Slieve Cua and Slieve Crot, and from Magh Cobha to Cruachan, and to Fionnabraic and to Finnias. At evening, when the hunt was over, there was not one pig of the whole herd without a hurt, and there were only a hundred and ten pigs left living. But if

the hunt brought destruction on Angus, it brought losses on the Fianna too. Ten hundred of their men were missing, besides serving-lads and dogs.

"Let's go to Brugh na Boinne and get satisfaction for our people," said Oisin.

"That's the advice of a man without sense," said Finn. "If we leave these pigs the way they are, they'll come to life again. Let's burn them, and throw their ashes into the sea."

That is the rule of the pigs of the Sidhe. Killed today, alive tomorrow. Unless they are burned.

So the seven battalions of the Fianna made seven fires to every battalion. But for all they could do, they could not set fire to one pig.

Then Bran, who had great sense and knowledge, went away. She came back bringing three logs with her, and no one knows what wood they came from. When the logs were put on the fire they lit up like a candle, and it was with them the pigs were burned. And after that their ashes were thrown into the sea.

Then Oisin said again: "Let's go now to Brugh na Boinne and avenge the death of our people."

So the whole of the Fianna set out for Brugh na Boinne, and every step they took could surely be heard through the whole of the skies.

Angus sent messengers out to where Finn was, offering him any one thing if he would spare his people.

"I'll take no gift at all from you, Angus of the slender body," said Finn, "as long as there's a room left in your house, north or east, without being burned."

"Though you think it bad, the loss of the fine people you rule," said Angus, "yet, O Finn, father of Oisin, the loss of my own good son is sorrowful to me. For the black pig that came before you on the plain was no common pig, but my own son. And along with him there fell the son of the King of the Narrow Sea, and the son of the King of the Sea of Gulls, and the son of Ilbhrec, son of Manannan, and seven score of the comely sons of kings and queens.

And what destroyed my strength and my honour entirely was that they were burned away from me in a far place.

"And it's a pity for you, sweet, daring Bran, fosterling of Fergus of the thirty woods and plains, that you didn't do something worth praise before killing your own foster-brother. I'll put a curse on you, Bran, beyond every hound in Ireland: that you'll never see with your eyes any deer you ever kill."

Anger came on Finn when he heard that. "If you put a curse on Bran, Angus," he said, "there won't be a room left, east or west, in the whole of your great house without being burned."

"If you do that," said Angus, "I'll put trees and stones in front of you in every battle. And I'll know the number of men you have in your armies by looking at them through my ring."

Then Oisín, who was wise, said: "It's best for you to agree between yourselves now. Let's be helpful to one another, and pay whatever fines are due."

So they agreed to that and made peace, and gave children to be fostered by each other: a son of Finn's to Angus, and a son of Angus Og to the Fianna.

But for all that, Angus was not very friendly to Finn afterwards, at the time Finn was following Diarmuid and Grania through the whole length of Ireland.

That story is coming. It is the longest in the book, and the saddest. Angus had not forgotten the black pig. Gods never do.



Book Six: Diarmuid



CHAPTER XV

The Hunt Of Slieve Cuilinn



Finn was out on the green of Almhuin once, and he saw what looked like a grey fawn running across the plain.



Diarmuid Ua Duibhne — Champion of the Fianna

He called and whistled for his hounds. Neither hound nor man heard him or came to him — only Bran and Sceolan. He set them after the fawn. Close as they kept to her, he kept closer to them, until at last they came to Slieve Cuilinn, in the province of Ulster.

No sooner were they at the hill than the fawn vanished from them, and they did not know where she had gone. Finn went looking for her eastward, and the two hounds went west.

It was not long before Finn came to a lake. Sitting on the brink of it was a young girl, the most beautiful he had ever seen, with hair the colour of gold and skin as white as lime, and eyes like the stars in a time of frost. But she seemed somehow sorrowful and downhearted.

Finn asked her whether she had seen his hounds pass that way.

"I didn't see them," she said. "And it's little I'm thinking of your hounds or your hunting, but of the cause of my own trouble."

"What ails you, woman of the white hands?" said Finn. "Is there any help I can give you?"

"What I'm fretting after," she said, "is a ring of red gold I lost off my finger in the lake. And I put you under bonds, Finn of the Fianna, to bring it back to me out of the lake."

Bonds again. Finn never learned to walk past a beautiful woman at the edge of water.

With that Finn stripped off his clothes and went into the lake at the woman's bidding. He went three times round the whole lake, and left no part of it unsearched, until he brought back the ring. He handed it up to her out of the water. And no sooner had he done it than she gave a leap into the water and vanished.

When Finn came up on the bank of the lake he could not even reach the place where his clothes were. For in that moment he — the head and the leader of the Fianna of Ireland — was nothing but a grey old man, weak and withered.

Bran and Sceolan came up to him then. They did not know him. They went on round the lake, searching for their master.

At Almhuin, when he was missed, Caoilte began asking after him.

"Where is Finn," he said, "of the gentle rule and of the spears?"

But nobody knew where he had gone, and there was grief on the Fianna when they could not find him.

But this is what Conan said: "I never heard music that pleased me better than to hear that the son of Cumhal is missing. May he stay missing the whole year, and I'll be king over you all."

Downhearted as they were, they could hardly keep from laughing when they heard Conan say it.

Then Caoilte and the rest of the chief men of the Fianna set out looking for Finn, and they got word of him, and at last they came to Slieve Cuilinn. There they saw a withered old man sitting beside the lake, and they took him for a fisherman.

"Tell us, old man," said Caoilte, "did you see a fawn go by, and two hounds after her, and a tall fair-faced man with them?"

"I did see them," he said, "and it's not long since they left me."

"Tell us where they are now."

But Finn made no answer. He did not have the courage to tell them that he himself was Finn, their leader, being what he was: an ailing, downhearted old man, without leaping, without running, without a walk, grey and sorrowful.

This is the most frightening thing in any story about Finn. Not a giant, not a war. A man who cannot bear to be seen by his friends.

Caoilte drew his sword from its sheath. "It won't be long before you know what death is," he said, "unless you tell us what happened to those three."

Then Finn told them the whole story. And when the seven battalions of the Fianna heard him, and knew that it was Finn, they gave three loud, sorrowful cries. And they gave the lake the name of Loch Doghra, the Lake of Sorrow.

But Conan of the sharp tongue began abusing Finn and all the Fianna in turn.

"You never gave me right praise for my deeds, Finn, son of Cumhal," he said, "and you were always the enemy of the sons of Morna. But we're living in spite of you. And I have only the one fault to find with your shape, and that's that it wasn't put on the whole of the Fianna the same as on you."

Caoilte went at him. "Bald, senseless Conan," he said, "I'll break your mouth to the bone."

But Conan ran in among the rest of the Fianna and asked for their protection, and peace was made again.

As for Finn, they asked him whether there was any cure to be found for him.

"There is," he said. "I know well the enchantment was put on me by a woman of the Sidhe, Miluchradh, daughter of Cuilinn, through jealousy of her sister Aine. Bring me to the hill that belongs to Cuilinn of Cuailgne. He's the only one who can give me my shape again."

They gathered round him and lifted him gently on their shields, and carried him on their shoulders to the hill of the Sidhe in Cuailgne. But nobody came out to meet them.

Then the seven battalions began digging and rooting up the whole hill, and they went on digging for three nights and three days.

At the end of that time Cuilinn of Cuailgne — some say he was Manannan, son of Lir — came out of the hill, holding a vessel of red gold in his hand. He gave the vessel into Finn's hand.

No sooner had Finn drunk what was in the vessel than his own shape and his looks came back to him.

Only his hair, which used to be so fair and so beautiful, like a woman's hair, never got its own colour back. The lake Cuilinn's daughter had made for Finn would have turned every man in the world grey if they had gone into it.

When Finn had drunk all that was in the vessel, it slipped from his hand into the earth, which was loosened with the digging, and he never saw it again. But in the place where it went into the earth a tree grew up. Anyone who looked at the branches of that tree in the morning, fasting, would know everything that was going to happen that day.

That is how Finn came by his grey hair: through the jealousy of Miluchradh of the Sidhe, because he had not given his love to her, but to her sister Aine.

He had been an old man for a few days. He never quite stopped being one after.

As for Oisín, who was so brave and so comely, who could overtake a deer at its greatest speed and see a thistle-thorn on the darkest night: the wife he took was Eibhir of the plaited yellow hair, who had been the foreign sweetheart of the High King of Ireland.

She lived beyond the sea, in a very sunny place. Her father's name was Iunsa. Her sunny house was thatched with the feathers of birds, and the doorposts were of gold, and the doors of ribbed grass. Oisín went there looking for her, and he fought for her against the High King, and against an army of the Firbolgs the High King had helping him. He got the better of them all, and brought Eibhir of the yellow hair away to Ireland.

He had a daughter, and she married the son of Oilíol, son of Eoghan and of Beara, daughter of the King of Spain.

That Eoghan was driven out of Ireland once, and it was to Spain he went for safety. Beara, the daughter of the King of Spain, was very shining and beautiful, and her father wanted to know who her husband would be. He sent for his Druid and asked him.

"I can tell you that," said the Druid. "The man who is to be her husband will come to land in Spain this very night. Let your daughter go eastward to the river Eibhear. She'll find a crimson-spotted salmon in that river, with shining clothing on him from head to tail. Let her strip that clothing off him and make a shining shirt out of it for her husband."

So Beara went to the river Eibhear, and found the golden salmon as the Druid had said, and stripped him of his crimson clothing, and made a shining shirt of it.

As for Eoghan, the waves of the shore put a welcome in front of him, and he came to the king's house that same night. The king gave him a friendly welcome. Everyone said there was never a comelier man seen than Eoghan, or a more beautiful woman than Beara, and that it was fitting for them to come together. Eoghan's own people said they would not be sorry to have been sent out of Ireland, if only Eoghan could get her for his wife.

After a while the king sent his Druid to ask Eoghan why he did not ask for Beara.

"I'll tell you that," said Eoghan. "It wouldn't be fitting for me to be refused a wife. I'm only an exile in this country, and I've brought no treasures or goods with me out of Ireland to give to learned men and poets. But for all that, the king's daughter is dear to me, and I think I have the king's friendship."

The Druid went back with that message.

"That's the answer of a king," said the King of Spain. "Tell my daughter to sit at Eoghan's right hand, and I'll give her to him this very night."

When Beara, the king's daughter, heard that, she sent her serving-maid to bring the shirt she had made for Eoghan. He put it on over his armour, and its shining was seen in every place. It was from wearing that shirt that he got the name of Eoghan the Bright.

Oiliol was the first son they had. It was he who had his ear bitten off by Aine of the Sidhe in revenge for her brother. And it was his son who married Oisin's daughter afterwards.

As for Osgar, Oisin's son: of all the young men of the Fianna he was the best in battle.

When he was only a young child the whole of the Fianna made much of him. It was for him they kept the marrow-bones, and they did not like to put any hardship on him. He grew up tall and idle, and nobody thought he would turn out as strong as he did.

One day a troop of the Fianna was attacked, and everyone in it went out to fight, and they left Osgar behind. When he knew the fight was going on, he took a log of wood, the first thing he could find, and attacked the enemy and made a great slaughter, and they gave way and ran before him. From then on there was no battle he did not go into. He was said to be the strongest of all the Fianna, though the people of Connacht said that Goll was the strongest.

He and Diarmuid, grandson of Duibhne, were comrades and dear friends. It was Diarmuid who taught him feats of arms and of skill, and chess-playing. Oisin his father took great pride in him, and so did his grandfather Finn.

Once Finn was holding a feast at Almuin, and he asked the chief men of the Fianna there what music they thought was best.

"Playing at games," said Conan. "That's the best music I ever heard." For though Conan was a good hand against an enemy, there never was a man with less sense.

"The music I like best is talking with a woman," said Diarmuid.

"My music is the outcry of my hounds when they're putting a deer to its last stand," said Lugaidh's Son.

"The music of the woods is best to me," said Oisin. "The sound of the wind, and of the cuckoo and the blackbird, and the sweet silence of the crane."

Then Osgar was asked.

"The best music," he said, "is the striking of swords in a battle."

It is likely he took after Finn in that. For in spite of all the sweet sounds Finn gave an account of, the time he was at Conan's house at Ceann Slieve, the Fianna used to say that the music Finn liked best was the music of what happens.

Of all the answers, it is the one that has lasted.

This is how Osgar met his wife.

Finn and his men came once to Slieve Crot, and they saw a woman waiting for them there, with a crimson fringed cloak, and a gold brooch in it, and a band of yellow gold on her forehead. Finn asked her name and where she came from.

"Etain of the Fair Hair is my name," she said, "daughter of Aedh of the White Breast, of the hill of the Sidhe at Beinn Edair, son of Angus Og."

"What brought you here, girl?" said Finn.

"To ask a man of the Fianna of Ireland to run a race with me."

"What kind of runner are you?" said Diarmuid.

"I'm a good runner," said the girl. "It's all the same to me whether the ground under my feet is long or short."

All of the Fianna who were there set out to run with her. They ran to the height over Badhamair, and on to Ath Cliath, and from there on to the hill of the Sidhe at Beinn Edair.

There was a good welcome for them there. Meat was brought to them, and wine to drink, and water to wash their feet. After a while they saw a nice fair-haired girl in front of the vats, with a cup of white silver in her hand, giving out drink to everyone.

"It seems to me that's the girl who came asking the Fianna to race her at Slieve Crot," said Finn.

"It is not," said Aedh of the White Breast. "That's the slowest woman there is among us."

"Who was it, then?"

"It was Be-mannair, daughter of Ainceol, the woman-messenger of the Tuatha de Danaan. She's the one who changes herself into every shape. She'll take the shape of a fly, or of a true lover, and everyone leaves their secret with her. It was she outran you coming from the east, and not this other girl, who was drinking and making merry here in the hall."

"What's her name?" said Finn.

"Etain of the Fair Hair," he said. "A daughter of my own, and a darling of the Tuatha de Danaan. And the way it is with her, she has a lover among the men of the Fianna."

"That's well," said Finn. "And who is that lover?"

"It's Osgar, son of Oisin," said Aedh. "It was she herself sent her messenger for you, in her own shape, to Slieve Crot in the south. The son of the High King of Ireland has offered a great bride-price to the Men of Dea for her: three hundreds of the land nearest to Bregia and to Midhe, and to put himself and his weight in gold into a balance, and give it all to her. But we didn't take it, since she had no mind or wish for it herself. So we made no bargain or agreement about her."

"Well," said Finn, "and what conditions will you ask of Osgar?"

"Never to leave me for anything at all but my own fault," said the girl.

"I'll make that agreement with you indeed," said Osgar.

"Give me sureties for it," she said. "Give me the surety of Goll for the sons of Morna, and of Finn, son of Cumhal, for the Fianna of Ireland."

So they gave those sureties, and the wedding-feast was made, and they stayed there twenty nights. At the end of that time Osgar asked Finn where he should bring his wife.

"Bring her to wide Almhuin for the first seven years," said Finn.

But some time after that, in a great battle at Beinn Edair, Osgar got so heavy a wound that Finn and the Fianna were as if they had lost their wits.

When Etain of the Fair Hair came to the bed where Osgar lay, and saw the way he was, and that the great king-like shape he had was gone from him, greyness and darkness came over her. She raised pitiful cries, and went to her bed, and her heart broke in her like a nut. And she died of grief for her husband and her first love.

But it was not then that Osgar got his death. That was afterwards, in the battle of Gabhra.

She did not live to see it. She was spared that much.

Birth Of Diarmuid



Diarmuid was the son of Donn, son of Duibhne, of the Fianna. His mother was Crochnuit, who was near in blood to Finn. At the time he was born, Donn had been banished from the Fianna because of some quarrel, and Angus Og took the child from him to rear him at Brugh na Boinne.

After a while Crochnuit bore another son, to Roc Diocain, who was Head Steward to Angus. Roc Diocain went to Donn and asked whether he would rear his son for him, the way Angus was rearing Donn's son. But Donn said he would not take the son of a common man into his house, and it would be best for Angus to take him. So Angus took that child into Brugh na Boinne too, and he and Diarmuid were reared together.

Two boys. Half-brothers. Same mother, same house, same god for a foster-father.

One day Finn was on the great Hill at Almhuin of Leinster, with nobody but Donn and a few of the poets and learned men of the Fianna, and their hounds and dogs. Bran Beag came in and asked whether he remembered that there were bonds on him not to stay in Almhuin for ten nights together. So Finn asked the people around him where he should go to be entertained that night.

"I'll bring you to the house of Angus, son of the Dagda," said Donn, "where my young son is being reared."

So they went together to the house of Angus at Brugh na Boinne. The child Diarmuid was there, and Angus had great love for him. The Steward's son was with him that night, and the people of the household made as much of him as Angus made of Diarmuid. And there was great vexation on Donn when he saw that.

After a while a great fight broke out between two of Finn's hounds over some broken meat that was thrown to them. The women and the common people of the place ran from them, and the others got up to part them. In running away, the Steward's child ran between

Donn's knees. And Donn gave the child a strong squeeze between his two knees that killed him that moment. Then he threw him under the feet of the hounds.

There is no reason given. There is only a man who did not like to see another man's son loved as much as his own.

When the Steward came after that and found his son dead, he gave a long, very pitiful cry.

"There isn't a man in the house tonight has suffered more from this uproar than I have," he said to Finn. "I had only one son, and he's been killed. What satisfaction will I get from you for that, Finn?"

"See if you can find the mark of a tooth or of a nail of one of the hounds on him," said Finn. "If you can, I'll give you satisfaction for him."

So they looked at the child, and there was no scratch on him and no mark of a tooth at all.

Then the Steward put Finn under the destroying bonds of the Druid cave of Cruachan to tell him who it was that had killed his son. Finn asked for a chessboard, and for water to be brought to him in a basin of pale gold, and he searched, and it was shown to him truly that it was Donn who had killed the Steward's son between his two knees.

When Finn knew that, he said he would take the fine on himself. But the Steward would not consent to it, and forced him to say who had done him the wrong.

When he knew it was Donn who had killed the child, he said: "There's no man in the house it's easier to get satisfaction from than him. His own son is here. I have only to put him between my two knees. And if I let him go from me safe, I'll forgive the death of my son."

Angus was vexed at what the Steward said. As for Donn, he meant to strike the Steward's head off, until Finn pushed him back.

Then the Steward came again, with a Druid rod in his hand. He struck his own dead son with the rod, and made him into a wild boar, without bristle or ear or tail.

"I put you under bonds," he said, "to bring Diarmuid, grandson of Duibhne, to his death. And your own life will be no longer than his."

With that the wild boar got up and ran out through the open door. He was called afterwards the Boar of Slieve Guillion. And it was by him Diarmuid came to his death at the last.

That is the rule of the boar. It will kill Diarmuid. And when Diarmuid dies, it dies. The two lives are knotted together, one brother's to the other's, and there is no untying them.

When Diarmuid came to his full strength he was given a place among the Fianna of Ireland. All women loved him. He did many great deeds, fighting the enemies of the Fianna and of Ireland. Once he fought a wild ox for seven days and seven nights on the top of the Mountain of Happiness.

Somewhere in the woods of Ireland, a boar without ears was growing old, and waiting.

How Diarmuid Got His Love-Spot



Diarmuid and Conan and Goll and Osgar went hunting one day, and they went so far that they could not get home in the evening. They spent the first part of the night walking through the woods, pulling berries and eating them.

About midnight they saw a light. They went towards it and found a little house in front of them, with the light shining out of it. They went in. There was an old man there, and he welcomed them and called each of them by his name. They saw nobody else in the house but the old man, and a young girl, and a cat.

The old man told the girl to make food ready for the Fianna of Ireland, for there was great hunger on them.

When the food was ready and on the table, a great wether that was tied up at the back of the house broke loose and got up on the table where they were eating. When they saw that they looked at one another.

"Get up, Conan," said Goll, "and tie that wether where it was before."

Conan got up and took hold of it. But the wether gave itself a shake that threw Conan down under one of its feet.

The rest were watching that. "Get up, Diarmuid," said Goll, "and tie up the wether."

So Diarmuid got up and took hold of it. It gave itself a shake the same as before, and when Diarmuid was down, it put one of its feet on him.

Goll and Osgar looked at each other, and shame came on them that a wether should have done so much.

Osgar got up. The wether put him down under one of its feet, so that it had the three men under it now.

Then Goll got up and took hold of it and threw it down. But it got up again in spite of him, and put Goll under its fourth foot.

"It's a great shame," said the old man, "for such a thing to be done to the Fianna of Ireland. Get up now, cat, and tie the wether in the place where it was."

The cat got up and took hold of the wether, and brought it over, and tied it in its place at the end of the house.

The men got up then. But they had no mind to go on eating, for there was shame on them at what the wether had done to them.

"You may go on eating," said the old man, "and when you're done, I'll show you that you are now the bravest men in the world."

So they ate their fill, and then the old man spoke to them.

"Goll," he said, "you are the bravest of all the men of the world. For you have wrestled with the world, and you threw it down. The strength of the world is in the wether. But death will come to the world itself. And that is death," he said, and he showed them the cat.

A cat. Death is a cat, sitting by the fire in a small house in the woods. It gets up when it is asked. It is never in a hurry.

They talked together then, and when they had eaten their food, the old man said their beds were ready and they could go to sleep. The four of them went into the one room. When they were in their beds, the young girl came to sleep in the same room with them. The light of her beauty was shining on the walls as if it were the light of a candle.

When Conan saw her he went over to the side of the bed where she was.

Now, the young girl was Youth.

When she saw Conan coming to her she said, "Go back to your bed, Conan. I belonged to you once, and I'll never belong to you again."

Conan went back to his bed. Then Osgar had a mind to go over to her.

"Where are you going?" she said.

"I'm going over to you for a while," he said.

"Go back again, Osgar," she said. "I belonged to you once, and I'll never belong to you again."

Then Diarmuid got up to go to her.

"Where are you going, Diarmuid?" she said.

"I'm going over to you for a while," he said.

"O Diarmuid," she said, "that can't be. I belonged to you once, and I can never belong to you again. But come over here to me, Diarmuid, and I'll put a love-spot on you, so that no woman will ever see it without giving you her love."

So Diarmuid went over to her. She put her hand on his forehead and left the love-spot there. And no woman who ever saw him after that was able to refuse him her love.

It sounds like a gift. So does most of what the Sidhe give you.

The Daughter Of King Under-Wave



One snowy night of winter the Fianna had come into the house after their hunting. About midnight they heard a knocking at the door, and a woman came in, very wild and ugly, with her hair hanging down to her heels.

She went to where Finn was lying and asked him to let her in under the edge of his covering. When he saw how strange she was, and how ugly and wild-looking, he would not let her in.

She gave a great cry, and went to where Oisín was, and asked him to let her shelter under the edge of his covering. Oisín refused her the same way.

Then she gave another great scream and went over to where Diarmuid was.

"Let me in," she said, "under the edge of your covering."

Diarmuid looked at her. "You're strange-looking and wild and ugly," he said, "and your hair is down to your heels. But come in for all that."

So she came in under the edge of his covering.

"O Diarmuid," she said, "I've been travelling over sea and ocean for seven years, and in all that time I never got shelter any night until this night. Let me come to the warmth of the fire now."

So Diarmuid brought her over to the fire. All the Fianna who were sitting there went away from it, seeing her so ugly and so dreadful to look at.

She had not been long at the fire when she said, "Let me under the warmth of the covering with you now."

"You're asking too much," said Diarmuid. "First it was to come under the edge you asked, and then to come to the fire, and now it's under the bedclothes with me you want to be. But for all that, you may come."

So she came in under the covering, and he turned a fold of it between them.

It was not long before he looked at her. What he saw was a beautiful young woman beside him, asleep.

He called the others to come over. "Isn't this the most beautiful woman that ever was seen?" he said.

"She is that," they said. And they covered her up and did not wake her.

The same woman. They had turned her away. It is worth remembering that they were the ones who turned her away.

After a while she stirred. "Are you awake, Diarmuid?" she said.

"I'm awake," he said.

"Where would you like to see the best house that ever was built?"

"Up there on the hillside, if I had my choice," he said. And with that he fell asleep.

In the morning two men of the Fianna came in and said they had just seen a great house up on the hill, where there had never been a house before.

"Get up, Diarmuid," said the strange woman. "Don't lie there any longer. Go up to your house. Look out now and see it."

So he looked out and saw the great house, standing ready.

"I'll go to it," he said, "if you'll come with me."

"I'll do that," she said, "if you'll make me a promise: not to say to me three times how I was when I came to you."

"I'll never say it to you, for ever," said Diarmuid.

That is the rule. Three times, and she is gone. You have heard rules like it before. You know how they go.

They went up to the house, and it was ready for them, with food and servants, and they had everything they could wish for. They stayed there three days. When the three days were over, she said: "You're getting sorrowful because you're away from your comrades of the Fianna."

"I'm not sorrowful indeed," said Diarmuid.

"It will be best for you to go to them," she said. "And your food and your drink will be no worse when you come back than they are now."

"Who'll take care of my greyhound bitch and her three pups if I go?" said Diarmuid.

"There's no fear for them," she said.

When he heard that he took leave of her and went back to the Fianna, and there was a great welcome for him. But all the same they were not well pleased. They were somehow envious that Diarmuid had got that grand house, and her love, from the woman they themselves had turned away.

As for the woman, she was outside the house for a while after Diarmuid went away, and she saw Finn, son of Cumhal, coming towards her. She bade him welcome.

"You're vexed with me, Queen?" he said.

"I'm not indeed," she said. "Come in now and take a drink of wine from me."

"I'll go in if I get my request," said Finn.

"What request is there that you wouldn't get?"

"What I'm asking is one of the pups of Diarmuid's greyhound bitch."

"That's no great thing to ask," she said. "Whichever of them you choose, you may take it away."

So he got the pup, and took it away with him.

At nightfall Diarmuid came back to the house. The greyhound met him at the door and gave a yell when she saw him. He looked for the pups, and one of them was gone.

Anger came on him, and he said to the woman: "If you'd remembered the way you were when I let you in, with your hair hanging, you wouldn't have let the pup be taken from me."

That was once.

"You ought not to say that, Diarmuid," she said.

"I ask your pardon for saying it," said Diarmuid.

They forgave each other, and he spent the night in the house.

The next day Diarmuid went back to his comrades, and the woman stayed at the house. After a while she saw Oisín coming towards her. She welcomed him and asked him into the house. He said he would come if he got his request. And what he asked for was another of the greyhound's pups.

She gave it to him, and he went away with it. When Diarmuid came back that night the greyhound met him and cried out twice. He knew that another pup was gone. And he said to the greyhound, with the woman standing there: "If she'd remembered the way she was when she came to me, she wouldn't have let the pup be taken."

That was twice.

The next day he went back to the Fianna again. When he was gone the woman saw Caoilte coming towards her, and he would not come in to take a drink from her until he had got the promise of one of the pups, the same as the others.

When Diarmuid came back that night the greyhound met him and gave three yells, the most terrible that were ever heard. There was great anger on him when he saw all the pups were gone.

And he said it the third time: "If this woman remembered the way she was when I found her, with her hair down to her heels, she wouldn't have let the pup go."

"O Diarmuid," she said, "what is it you've said?"

He asked her forgiveness then. He went to go into the house. But the house was gone, and the woman was gone, that moment. And it was on the bare ground he woke the next

morning.

The three pups went to Finn and Oisín and Caoilte. His friends. They had turned her away themselves, and then they came, one after another, and took what was his.

There was great sorrow on him, and he said he would search every place until he found her again.

He set out through the lonely valleys. The first thing he saw was the greyhound lying dead. He put her on his shoulder and would not leave her, because of the love he had for her.

After a while he met a cowherd and asked him whether he had seen a woman going that way.

"I saw a woman early in the morning yesterday, walking hard," said the cowherd.

"Which way was she going?"

"Down that path there to the strand. I saw her no more after that."

So he followed the path she had taken down to the strand, until he could go no farther. Then he saw a ship. He leaned on the handle of his spear and made a light leap onto the ship, and it went on until it came to land. He got out and lay down on the side of a hill and fell asleep. When he woke there was no ship to be seen.

"It's a pity for me to be here," he said. "I see no way of getting away again."

After a while he saw a boat coming, with a man in it rowing. He went down and got into the boat and brought the greyhound with him. The boat went out over the sea, and then down under it. And Diarmuid, when he went down, found himself on a plain.

He walked along it, and before long he came on a drop of blood. He picked it up and put it in a napkin. "The greyhound lost this," he said. After a while he came on another drop of blood, and then a third, and he put them in the napkin.

After that he saw a woman gathering rushes as if she had lost her wits. He went towards her and asked her what news she had.

"I can't tell it till I've gathered the rushes," she said.

"Tell it while you're gathering them," said Diarmuid.

"There's great haste on me," she said.

"What is this place we're in?" said Diarmuid.

"It's Land-under-Wave," she said.

"And what use have you for the rushes when they're gathered?"

"The daughter of King Under-Wave has come home," she said. "She was seven years under enchantment. There's sickness on her now, and all the physicians are gathered, and none of them can do her any good. A bed of rushes is what she finds wholesomest."

"Will you show me where the king's daughter is?" said Diarmuid.

"I'll do that," said the woman. "I'll put you in the sheaf of rushes, and put the rushes under you and over you, and carry you to her on my back."

"That's a thing you can't do," said Diarmuid.

But she put the rushes around him and lifted him onto her back. When she got to the room she let the bundle down.

"O come here to me," said the daughter of King Under-Wave.

Diarmuid went over to her, and they took each other's hands, and they were very joyful at that meeting.

"Three parts of my sickness are gone from me now," she said. "But I'm not well yet, and I never will be. For every time I thought of you on my journey, Diarmuid, I lost a drop of the blood of my heart."

Not the greyhound's blood. Hers. Every time she thought of him.

"I have those three drops here in this napkin," said Diarmuid. "Take them now in a drink, and you'll be healed of your sickness."

"They'd do nothing for me," she said, "since I haven't got the one thing in the world I want. And that's the thing I'll never get."

"What thing is that?"

"It's the thing you'll never get, nor any man in the world," she said. "They've failed a long time to get it."

"If it's anywhere on the whole ridge of the world," said Diarmuid, "I'll get it."

"It's three draughts from the cup of the King of Magh an Ionganaidh, the Plain of Wonder," she said. "No man ever got it, and no man ever will."

"Tell me where that cup is to be found," said Diarmuid, "for there aren't as many men on the whole ridge of the world as will keep it from me."

"That country isn't far from the boundary of my father's country," she said. "But there's a little river between. You'd be sailing on that river in a ship, with the wind behind it, for a year and a day before you'd reach the Plain of Wonder."

Diarmuid set out. He came to the little river, and walked beside it a good while, and saw no way to cross it.

At last he saw a low-sized, reddish man standing in the middle of the river.

"You're in straits, Diarmuid, grandson of Duibhne," he said. "Come here and put your foot in the palm of my hand, and I'll bring you through."

Diarmuid did as he told him and put his foot in the red man's palm, and the red man carried him across the river.

"It's to the King of the Plain of Wonder you're going," he said, "to bring away his cup from him. I'll go with you myself."

They went on until they came to the king's dun. Diarmuid called out that the cup should be sent out to him, or else champions to fight him.

It was not the cup that was sent out, but twice eight hundred fighting men. In three hours there was not one of them left to stand against him. Then twice nine hundred better fighters were sent out against him, and within four hours there was not one of them left to stand against him.

Then the king himself came out and stood in the great door.

"Where did the man come from who has brought destruction on my whole kingdom?" he said.

"I'll tell you that," said he. "I'm Diarmuid, a man of the Fianna of Ireland."

"It's a pity you didn't send a messenger telling me that," said the king, "and I wouldn't have wasted my men on you. For seven years before you were born, it was in the prophecy that you would come and destroy them. What is it you're asking for now?"

"It's the cup of healing from your own hand I'm asking for," said Diarmuid.

"No man ever got that cup from me but you," said the king. "But it's easy for me to give it to you, whether there's healing in it or not."

So the King of the Plain of Wonder gave Diarmuid the cup, and they parted. Diarmuid went on until he came to the river. It was only then he thought of the red man, whom he had given no thought to while he was at the king's house. But the red man was there before him. He took Diarmuid's foot in the palm of his hand and carried him over the river.

"I know where you're going, Diarmuid," he said. "It's to heal the daughter of King Under-Wave, whom you've given your love to. I'll give you the signs of a well. Go to it, and bring a share of the water of that well with you. When you come to where the woman is, this is what you have to do: put that water in the cup, and one of the drops of blood in it, and she'll drink it. Then the same with the second drop, and the third. And her sickness will be gone from her from that time on.

"But there's another thing will go along with it," he said, "and that's the love you have for her."

That is the rule of the cure. It heals her. It takes his love away. Both. There is no having one without the other.

"That won't go from me," said Diarmuid.

"It will go from you," said the man. "And it will be best for you to make no secret of it, for she'll know, and the king will know, that you think no more of her then than of any other woman. King Under-Wave will come to you and offer you great riches for healing his daughter. But take nothing from him. Ask only for a ship to bring you home to Ireland. And do you know who I am?"

"I don't know," said Diarmuid.

"I'm the messenger from beyond the world," he said. "And I came to your help because your own heart is hot to come to the help of another."

So Diarmuid did as he told him. He brought the water and the cup and the drops of blood to the woman, and she drank them, and at the third draught she was healed.

And no sooner was she healed than the love he had for her was gone, and he turned away from her.

"O Diarmuid," she said, "your love is gone from me."

"O, it's gone indeed," he said.

Then there was music made through the whole place, and the lamenting stopped, because the king's daughter was healed. As for Diarmuid, he would take no reward and he would not stay there, but asked for a ship to bring him home to Ireland, to Finn and the Fianna.

When he came to where they were, there was a joyful welcome for him.

He had gone to the bottom of the sea for her, and brought back the one cup that could save her, knowing what it would cost. It is the kindest thing Diarmuid ever did. It is the thing to remember about him, later, when the story is less kind.

The Hard Servant



The Fianna went hunting once in the two proud provinces of Munster.

They went out from Almhuin by the nearest paths until they came to the Brosna river in Slieve Bladhma, and from there to the twelve mountains of Eiblinne, and on to Aine Cliach, the harp of Aine.

Then they scattered themselves and hunted through the borders of the forest called Magh Breogain, through blind, trackless places and through broken lands, over beautiful level plains and the high hills of Desmumum, under pleasant Slieve Crot and smooth Slieve na Muc, along the level banks of the blue Siuir, and over the green plain of Feman and the rough plain of Eithne, and the dark woods of Belach Gabrain.

Finn was on the side of a hill with the chief men of the Fianna, watching the hunting. They liked to listen to the outcry of the hounds, and the hurried cries of the boys, and the noise and the whistling and the shouts of the strong men.

Finn asked which of the men with him would go and keep watch on the side of the hill where they were. Finnbane, son of Bresel, said he would go. He went up to the top of the hill, where he could see about him on every side.

He had not been there long when he saw coming from the east a very big man, ugly and gloomy and deformed. This is how he was. He had a dark-coloured shield on his back, and a wide sword on his crooked left thigh, and two spears on his shoulder, and a torn, loose cloak over his limbs, which were as black as a quenched coal.

He had a sulky horse with him that had no good look about it: bony and thin in the body and weak in the legs. He was leading it by a rough iron halter. It was a great wonder that the horse's head was not pulled off its body, or its owner's arms pulled out of him, with the sudden stands and stops and jerks it made. The big man was beating the horse with an iron cudgel, to try to knock some going into it, and the sound of the blows was like the breaking of strong waves.

When Finnbane saw all that, he thought it would not be right to let a stranger like that come up to Finn and the Fianna unannounced. He ran back in haste to where they were and told them everything he had seen.

When he had told his story, they saw the big man coming towards them. But short as the distance was, he was a long time coming, from the badness of his walk and his going.

When he came into Finn's presence he greeted him, and bowed his head and bent his knee, making signs of humility.

Finn raised his hand over his head and asked him for news, and whether he was of the noble or of the mean blood of the great world.

He answered that he did not know whom he came from, only that he was a man of the Fomor, travelling in search of wages from the kings of the earth. "And I heard," he said, "that Finn never refused wages to any man."

"I never did indeed," said Finn, "and I won't refuse you. But why are you without a boy to mind your horse?"

"I have a good reason for that," said the big man. "There's nothing in the world worse to me than a boy being with me. It takes a hundred men's share of food to serve me for one day, and I think it little enough, and I'd begrudge a boy sharing it with me."

"What name do you have?" said Finn.

"The name I have is the Gilla Decair, the Hard Servant."

"Why did you get that name?"

"There's a good reason for that," said the big man. "There's nothing in the world harder for me than to do anything at all for my master, or for whoever I'm with. And tell me this, Conan, son of Morna: who gets the best wages, a horseman or a man on foot?"

"A horseman gets twice as much," said Conan.

"Then I call you to witness, Conan, that I'm a horseman, and that it was as a horseman I came to the Fianna. Now give me your guarantee, Finn, son of Cumhal, and the guarantee

of the Fianna, and I'll turn my horse out with your horses."

"Let him out, then," said Finn.

The big man pulled the iron halter off his horse. It went off as hard as it could go until it came to where the horses of the Fianna were, and began to tear and kick and bite at them, killing and maiming.

"Take your horse out of that, big man," said Conan. "By the earth and the sky, if it weren't on the guarantee of Finn and the Fianna you took the halter off him, I'd let his brains out through the windows of his head. Many a bad prize Finn has found in Ireland, but he never got one as bad as you."

"And I swear by earth and sky as well as you," said the big man, "I'll never bring him out of that. I've no serving-boy to do it for me, and it's not work for me to be leading my horse by the hand."

So Conan, son of Morna, got up and took the halter and put it on the horse, and led it back to where Finn was, and held it with his hand.

"You'd never have done a horse-boy's service for any one of the Fianna, Conan," said Finn, "however far above this Fomor he might be. If you'll take my advice, you'll get up on the horse now and search out every hill and hollow and flowery plain of Ireland with him, until his heart is broken in his body, as payment for the way he destroyed the horses of the Fianna."

Conan leapt onto the horse and struck his heels hard into it. For all that, the horse would not stir.

"I know what ails him," said Finn. "He won't stir until he has the same weight of horsemen on him as the weight of the big man."

At that thirteen men of the Fianna got up behind Conan. The horse lay down with them, and got up again.

"I think you're mocking my horse and me," said the big man. "It's a pity for me to spend the rest of the year with you, after all the humbugging I've seen in you today, Finn. I know well

now that everything I heard about you was nothing but lies, and there was no cause for the great name you have through the world. I'll leave you now, Finn."

With that he went away from them, slow and weak, dragging himself along until he had put a little hill between himself and the Fianna. As soon as he was on the other side of it, he tucked his cloak up to his waist and away with him, as quick as a swallow or a deer, and the rush of his going was like a blast of loud wind going over plains and mountains in springtime.

When the horse saw his master going from him, he could not bear it. Great as his load was, he set out at full gallop after him.

When Finn and the Fianna saw the thirteen men behind Conan, son of Morna, on the horse, and the horse starting off, they shouted with mocking laughter.

When Conan found he could not get down off the horse, he screeched and shouted to them not to let him be carried off by the big man they knew nothing about, and he began abusing and reproaching them.

"A cloud of death over water on you, Finn," he said, "and may some son of a slave or a robber of the bad blood — someone who's a worse son of a father and mother even than you — take everything that might protect your life, and your head along with it, unless you follow us to whatever place or island the big man carries us to, and bring us back to Ireland again."

Finn and the Fianna got up then and followed the Gilla Decair over every bald hill and through every valley and every river, on to pleasant Slieve Luachra, into the borders of Corca Duibhne. The big man, who was up on the horse now with Conan and the rest, turned towards the deep sea.

Liagan Luath of Luachra took hold of the horse's tail with his two hands, thinking to drag it back by the hair of it. But the horse gave a great tug, and away with him over the sea, and Liagan along with him, holding on to his tail.

It was a heavy care to Finn that those fourteen men of his people had been carried away from him, and he himself under bonds to bring them back.

"What can we do now?" Oisín asked him.

"What should we do," said Finn, "but follow our people to whatever place or island the big man has brought them, and, whatever way we do it, bring them back to Ireland?"

"What can we do, having neither a ship nor any kind of boat?" said Oisín.

"We have this," said Finn. "The Tuatha de Danaan left it as a gift to the children of the Gael: that whoever had to leave Ireland for a while had only to go to Beinn Edair, and however many went with him, they'd find a ship that would hold them all."

Then Finn looked towards the sea, and saw two strong armed men coming towards him. The first had a shield on his back, ribbed and many-coloured, engraved with the shapes of strange, wonderful beasts; a heavy sword at his side, and two thick spears on his shoulders; a cloak of lasting crimson about him, with a gold brooch on the breast; a band of white bronze on his head, and gold under each of his feet. The other was dressed the same way.

They made no delay until they came to where Finn was. They bowed their heads and bent their knees before him, and Finn raised his hand over their heads and told them to give an account of themselves.

"We are sons of the King of the Eastern World," they said, "and we've come to Ireland asking to be taken into Finn's service. We heard there wasn't a man in all Ireland better than you to judge the skill we have."

"What are your names, and what skill is that?" said Finn.

"My name is Feradach, the Very Brave," said one. "I have a carpenter's axe and a sling. If there were as many as thirty hundred of the men of Ireland with me in one spot, with three blows of the axe on the sling-stick I could get a ship that would hold them all. And I'd ask no more help of them than to bow down their heads while I was striking those three blows."

"That's a good art," said Finn. "And what can the other man do?"

"I can do this," said the other. "I can follow the track of the teal over nine ridges and nine furrows until I come on her in her bed. And it's all the same to me whether I do it on sea or

on land."

"That's a good art," said Finn, "and it would be a great help to us if you'd come following a track with us now."

"What's gone from you?" said one of the men. And Finn told them the whole story of the Hard Servant.

Then Feradach, the Very Brave, struck three blows on his sling-stick with his axe. The whole of the Fianna bowed their heads. And that moment the whole bay and the harbour were filled with ships and fast boats.

"What'll we do with that many ships?" said Finn.

"We'll do away with all you don't use," he said.

Caoilte got up then and let out three great shouts, and all the Fianna of Ireland, wherever they were, heard them, and thought Finn and his people must be in some kind of danger from men from beyond the sea.

They came in small companies, as they happened to be, until they reached the stepping-stones of the Cat's Head in the western part of Corca Duibhne. They asked Finn what had happened that he had called them away from their hunting, and Finn told them all of it.

Then Finn and Oisín took counsel together, and this is what they agreed. Since only fifteen of his people had been carried off from Finn, he would go on their track with fifteen others. And Oisín would be left at the head of the Fianna to guard Ireland.

They said farewell to one another. A grand ship was made ready for Finn and his people, with food put in it for eating and gold for giving away. The young men and the heroes took their seats and took hold of the oars, and they set out over the restless hills and the dark valleys of the great sea.

The sea rose up and bellowed, and there was madness on the broken green waters. But to Finn and his people the roaring and crooning that went on for ever about the sides of the ship was a call in the morning and a lullaby at night.

They went on like that for three days and three nights, and saw no country and no island. At the end of that time one of them went up into the head of the ship and saw ahead of them a great, rough, grey cliff. They went on towards it. On the edge of the cliff they saw a high rock, round-shaped, with sides more slippery than an eel's back. And they found the track of the Hard Servant as far as the foot of the rock.

Then Fergus of the True Lips said to Diarmuid: "It's no brave thing you're doing, Diarmuid, grandson of Duibhne, holding back like this. It was with Manannan the Powerful, son of Lir, you were reared and got your learning, in the Land of Promise and on the coasts of the harbours, and with Angus Og, the Dagda's son. Are you without any share of their skill and their daring now, that would bring Finn and his people up this rock?"

Diarmuid's face reddened when he heard those words. He took hold of Manannan's staves of power, which he had with him, and reddened again. Then he rose on the staves and gave a leap, and got a standing-place for his two feet on the overhanging rock.

He looked down from there at Finn and his people. But however much he wished to bring them up to where he was, he was not able to do it.

He left the rock behind him, and he had not gone far when he saw a wild, tangled place in front of him, with thick woods. Of all the woods he had ever walked in, it was the leafiest, and the fullest of the sounds of wind and streams and birds, and the humming of bees.

He went walking on over the plain, and as he was looking about him he saw a great tree with many twigs and branches, and a rock beside it, and a smooth-pointed drinking-horn on the rock, and a beautiful fresh well at its foot. There was a great thirst on Diarmuid after the sea-journey, and he had a mind to drink a hornful of the water. But when he stooped to it he heard a great noise coming towards him, and he knew there was enchantment in the water.

"I'll drink my fill of it all the same," he said.

It was not long after that that he saw a Man of Enchantments coming towards him, armed, with no friendly look. And it was in no friendly way he spoke to Diarmuid when he came up to him, but abused him greatly.

"It's no right thing," he said, "to be walking through my thickets and drinking up my share of water."

With that they faced each other angrily, and they fought until the end of the day.

Then the Enchanter thought it best to leave off fighting, and he made a leap into the bottom of the well, away from him. And Diarmuid was vexed to be left like that.

He looked around him and saw a herd of deer coming through the scrub. He went towards them and threw a spear that went through the nearest stag and drove the bowels out of it. He kindled a fire and cut thin bits of the flesh and put them on spits of white hazel. That night he had his fill of meat and of the water of the well.

He got up early the next morning, and found the Enchanter at the well before him.

"It seems to me, Grandson of Duibhne," he said, "it's not enough for you to be walking my scrub and my woods, without killing my deer as well."

With that they started again, blow for blow and thrust for thrust and wound for wound, until the end of the day came on them. Diarmuid killed another great deer that night, and in the morning the fight began again. But in the evening, when the Enchanter was making his leap into the well, Diarmuid threw his arms round his neck, thinking to stop him. And this is what happened: he fell in himself. And when he was at the bottom of the well, the Enchanter left him.

Diarmuid went after the Enchanter. He found in front of him a beautiful, wide, flowery plain, and a comely royal city on the plain, and on the green in front of the dun a great army. When they saw Diarmuid following the Enchanter, they left a way open, a royal road, for the Enchanter to pass through until he got inside the dun. Then they shut the gates, and the whole army turned on Diarmuid.

That put no fear or cowardice on him. He went through them and over them as a hawk goes through little birds, or a wild dog through a flock of sheep, killing everything in front of him, until some of them ran off to the woods and the wastes, and another share of them in through the gates of the dun, and they shut the gates of the dun and the gates of the city behind them.

Diarmuid, full of hurts and wounds after the hard fight, lay down on the plain.

Then a very strong, daring champion came and kicked at him from behind. At that Diarmuid roused himself and put out his brave, ready hand for his weapons.

"Wait a while, Grandson of Duibhne," said the champion. "It's not to do you any hurt or harm I've come, but to tell you it's a bad sleeping-place you have, on your ill-wisher's lawn. Come with me now and I'll give you a better resting-place."

Diarmuid followed him, and they went a long, long way from there, until they came to a high-topped city. There were three times fifty brave champions in it, and three times fifty modest women, and another young woman on a bench, with blushes in her cheeks and delicate hands, and a silken cloak about her, and a dress sewn with gold threads, and on her head the flowing veil of a queen.

There was a good welcome for Diarmuid, for his own sake and for his people's. He was put in a house of healing in the city, and good herbs were put on his hurts until he was smooth and sound again.

Then a feast was made. The tables and the benches were set, and no high person was put in the place of the low, or low in the place of the high, but every one in his own place, according to his nobility, or his descent, or his art. Plenty of good food was brought to them, and well-tasting strong drinks. They spent the first part of the night in drinking, and the second part in music and delight and rejoicing of the mind, and the third part in sound sleep that lasted until the sun rose over the heavy-sodded earth the next day.

Diarmuid stayed three days and three nights in that city, and the best feast he ever found was given to him the whole time. At the end of that time he asked what place he was in, and who was the head of it.

The champion who had brought him there told him it was Land-Under-Wave, and that the man who had fought with him was its king.

"And he's an enemy of the Red Hand to me," he said. "As for me, I was once taking wages from Finn, son of Cumhal, in Ireland, and I never put a year over me that pleased me better. Now tell me, what's the journey or the work in front of you?"

And Diarmuid told him the story of the Hard Servant from beginning to end.

As for Finn and his people, when they thought Diarmuid had been away from them too long, they made ladders of the ship's ropes and put them against the rock, and went looking for him.

After a while they found the leavings of the meat he had eaten. For Diarmuid never ate meat without leaving some behind him.

That is a small thing to tell about a man, and it tells you everything. He always left some for whoever came after.

Finn looked about him on every side, and saw a rider coming towards him over the plain on a dark, beautiful horse with a bridle of red gold. Finn greeted him when he came up, and the rider bowed his head and gave Finn three kisses, and asked him to come with him. They went on a long way until they came to a wide, large dwelling-place full of weapons, with a great troop of armed men on the green in front of the fort. Finn and his people stayed three nights and three days in the dun, and the best feast they ever had was served out to them.

At the end of that time Finn asked what country he was in. The man who had brought him there told him it was the land of Sorchu, and that he himself was its king.

"And I was with you once, Finn, son of Cumhal," he said, "taking your wages for the length of a year in Ireland."

Then Finn and the King of Sorchu called a great gathering of the people, and a great meeting. While it was going on they saw a woman-messenger coming towards them through the crowd, and the king asked her for news.

"I have news indeed," she said. "The whole of the bay and the harbour is full of ships and boats, and there are armies all through the country robbing everything in front of them."

"I know well," said the king, "it's the High King of Greece. He has a mind to put the entire world under him, and to get hold of this country like every other."

The King of Sorchu looked at Finn, and Finn understood it was help he was asking for.

"I take the protection of this country on myself," Finn said, "as long as I'm in it."

He and his people got up then, and the King of Sorchu with them, and they went looking for the strange army. When they came up with it they made great slaughter of its champions. Those they did not kill ran before them and made no better stand than a flock of frightened birds, until there were hardly enough of them left to tell the story.

Then the High King spoke. "Who has done this great slaughter of my people?" he said. "I never heard any talk before of the courage or the doings of the men of Ireland, either now or in the old times. But from now on I'll banish the Sons of the Gael for ever to the very ends of the earth."

But Finn and the King of Sorchu raised a green tent in view of the ships of the Greeks.

Then the King of the Greeks called for help against Finn and the King of Sorchu, to get satisfaction for the shame that had been put on his people. The sons of kings of the eastern and southern world came to his help. But they could make no stand against Finn and Osgar and Oisín and Goll, son of Morna. And at last the King of Greece brought all his people back home, so that no more of them would be made an end of.

Then Finn and the King of Sorchu called another great gathering. While it was going on, they saw a great troop of champions coming towards them, bearing flags of many-coloured silk, with grey swords at their sides and high spears raised over their heads. And at the front of them was Diarmuid, grandson of Duibhne.

When Finn saw him, he sent Fergus of the True Lips to ask him for news, and they told each other everything that had happened.

It would take too long to tell, and it would tire the hearers, how Finn made the Hard Servant bring home the fifteen men he had carried off. When the Hard Servant had brought them back to Ireland, the whole of the Fianna were watching to see him ride away again, he and his long-legged horse. But while they were watching him, he vanished from them. All they could see was a mist, stretching out towards the sea.

That is the story of the Hard Servant, and of Diarmuid's adventures on the island Under-Wave.

Some say the Hard Servant was Manannan himself. If so, he had got what he wanted: a long look at the Fianna, and at Diarmuid, whom he had reared, going over a rock that no one else could climb.



Book Seven: Diarmuid And Grania



CHAPTER V

The House Of The Quicken Trees



The Fianna would often have been badly off without Diarmuid's help. It was he who came to their help the time Miodac, the son of the King of Lochlann, brought them into the enchanted House of the Quicken Trees.



Gráinne — Daughter of the High King of Ireland

He brought them in by treachery. He gave himself out to be a poet, and made poems for Finn to find the meaning of.

He made a verse about a great army he had seen riding over the plains to victory, robbing everything in front of it, and the riders had no horses but plants and branches.

"I understand that," said Finn. "It was an army of bees you saw, gathering riches from the flowers as it went."

Another verse Miodac made was about a woman in Ireland who was swifter than the swiftest horse.

"I know that," said Finn. "That woman is the River Boinn. Slow as she goes, she's swifter in the end than the swiftest horse, for her going never stops."

He made other verses about Angus's house at Brugh na Boinn. Finn made them all out.

After that Miodac said he had a feast ready for them, and told them to go into his House of the Quicken Trees until he brought it. They did that, and went in. It was a beautiful house, with walls of every colour, and foreign coverings of every colour on the floor, and a fire that gave out a very pleasant smoke. They sat down there.

After a while Finn said, "It's a wonder, such a beautiful house to be here."

"There's a greater wonder than that," said Goll. "That fire that was so pleasant when we came in is giving out the worst stench in the world now."

"There's a greater wonder than that," said Glas. "The walls that were every colour are only rough boards joined together now."

"There's a greater wonder than that," said Fiacha. "Where there were seven high doors to the house, there's only one little door now, and it shut."

"There's a more wonderful thing than that, indeed," said Conan. "We sat down on beautiful coverings, and now there's nothing between us and the bare ground, and it as cold as the snow of one night."

He tried to get up. He could not stir, and neither could any of the rest of them. There was an enchantment holding them where they were.

That is how a trap works, in the old stories. Everything gets slowly worse, and you notice one thing at a time, and by the time you have noticed enough, you cannot stand.

It was the treachery of Miodac, and the spells of the Three Kings of the Island of the Floods, that had brought them into that danger. Finn knew by his divination that their enemies were gathering to make an end of them. He told his people there was no use in complaining, but to sound the music of the Dord Fiann.

Some of the Fianna who were waiting for him not far off heard that sorrowful music, and came fighting against Miodac and his armies. They fought well, but they could not stand against them.

At last it was Diarmuid, grandson of Duibhne, who made an end of Miodac, who was so treacherous, and of the Three Kings of the Island of the Floods. And he took the enchantment off the floor of the House of the Rowan Trees with their blood.

While he was freeing the Fianna, Conan called out, asking him to bring him a share of the feast Miodac had made ready for his own friends, for there was hunger on him.

When Diarmuid took no notice of him, he said: "If it was a comely woman speaking to you, Diarmuid, you wouldn't refuse to listen."

For if many women loved Diarmuid, there were many he gave his own love to. He was often called Diarmuid the Brave, or the Hardy, or the Comely, or the Hawk of Ess Ruadh. And he was often called as well the friend and the coxer of women: Diarmuid-na-man.

Conan meant it as an insult. Conan usually did. But he was not wrong, and the next story is the proof of it.

The Flight From Teamhair



Finn rose early one morning at Almhuin of Leinster, and sat out alone on the green lawn, without a boy or a servant with him.

Oisín followed him out, and Diorraing the Druid.

"What's the cause of your early rising, Finn?" said Oisín.

"It's not without cause I rise early," said Finn. "I'm without a wife or a companion since Maighneis, daughter of Black Garraidh, died from me. Quiet sleep doesn't come to a man who's without a fitting wife."

He was grey. He was lonely. He was the greatest man in Ireland. All three were true, and it is the first that matters in what follows.

"Why should you be like that?" said Oisín. "There isn't a woman in all green Ireland you'd throw a look at but we'd bring her to you, willing or unwilling."

"I could find a wife myself who'd be fitting for you," said Diorraing.

"Who's that?" said Finn.

"It's Grania, daughter of the High King of Ireland," said Diorraing. "She's the woman of the best make and shape and the best speech of all the women of the whole world."

"By my word, Diorraing," said Finn, "there's been strife and disagreement between the High King and me this long time, and it wouldn't be pleasing to me to get a refusal from him. It's best for you two to go together and ask his daughter in marriage for me. That way, if he gives a refusal, it'll be to you and not to me he gives it."

"We'll go," said Oisín, "even if we get little profit by it. And let nobody at all know of our going until we've come back."

So the two of them said farewell to Finn and set out, and nothing is told of what they did until they came to Teamhair.

The King of Ireland was holding a gathering on the green of Teamhair at that time, and the chief nobles of his people were with him. Oisín and Diarraing were given a friendly welcome. The king put off the gathering until the next day, for he was sure it was some pressing thing that had brought these two men of the Fianna to Teamhair. Oisín went aside with him and told him they had come from Finn, Head of the Fianna of Ireland, to ask for his daughter Grania in marriage.

This is what the king said: "There isn't a son of a king or of a great prince, there isn't a champion in Ireland, that my daughter hasn't given a refusal to. And it's on me they all lay the blame for it. I'll give you no answer at all until you go to her yourselves. It's better for you to get her own answer than to be displeased with me."

So they went together to the sunny house of the women. The king sat down at the head of the high seat beside Grania.

"Here, Grania," he said, "are two of the people of Finn, son of Cumhal, come to ask you as a wife for him. What answer have you a mind to give them?"

And this is what Grania said: "If he's a fitting son-in-law for you, why wouldn't he be a fitting husband for me?"

Listen to what she said. She did not say yes. She said he was fit for her father. They heard what they wanted to hear.

They were satisfied, and a feast was made for them that night in Grania's sunny house, and the king set a meeting a fortnight from then between himself and Finn at Teamhair.

So Oisín and Diarraing went back to Almhuin and told Finn their story from beginning to end. And as everything wears away, so did that time of waiting.

Then Finn gathered the seven battalions of the Fianna from every part where they were to Almhuin, and they set out in great bands and troops until they came to Teamhair.

The king was out on the green in front of them, with the great people of the men of Ireland, and there was a great welcome for Finn and the Fianna.

But when Grania saw grey-haired Finn, she said: "It's a great wonder it wasn't for Oisín Finn asked me. He'd be more fitting for me than a man who's older than my father."

But they talked together for a while, and Finn put questions to Grania, for she had the name of being very quick with answers.

"What's whiter than snow?" he said.

"The truth," said Grania.

"What's the best colour?"

"The colour of childhood."

"What's hotter than fire?"

"The face of a hospitable man when he sees a stranger coming in, and the house empty."

"What has a taste more bitter than poison?"

"The reproach of an enemy."

"What's best for a champion?"

"His doings to be high, and his pride to be low."

"What's the best of jewels?"

"A knife."

"What's sharper than a sword?"

"The wit of a woman between two men."

"What's quicker than the wind?" said Finn.

"A woman's mind," said Grania.

She was telling no lie when she said it.

And for all their talk together, she had no liking for Finn. She felt the blood in her heart rising against him.

She had answered every question he asked. He had not once asked the one that mattered.

Then the wedding-feast was made ready, and they all went into the king's feasting-house in the Middle Court. The king sat down to take his share of drinking and pleasure, with his wife at his left side and Grania beside her; and Finn, son of Cumhal, at the king's right hand, and Oisín on the other side of Finn, and everyone else according to his nobility and his birth.

Then Daire of the Poems stood up in front of Grania and sang her the songs and the good poems of her fathers. Sitting near Grania was a knowledgeable man, a Druid of Finn's people, and it was not long before they began to talk together.

"Tell me now," said Grania, "who's that man on the right hand of Oisín?"

"That's Goll, son of Morna," said the Druid, "the ready fighter."

"Who's that beside Goll?"

"Osgar, son of Oisín."

"And who's that thin-legged man beside Osgar?"

"That's Caoilte, son of Ronan."

"Who's that proud, hasty man beside Caoilte?"

"Lugaidh's Son of the Strong Hand."

"Who's that sweet-worded man," she said, "with the dark hair, and cheeks like the rowan-berry, on the left side of Oisín, son of Finn?"

"That's Diarmuid, grandson of Duibhne," said the Druid. "The best lover of women in the whole world."

"That's a good company," said Grania.

After the feast had gone on a while, the dogs outside were given their own feast. They began to fight one another, and the noise was heard in the hall, and the chief men of the Fianna went out to drive them apart.

Now, Diarmuid always kept his cap over the love-spot the woman had left on his forehead, for no woman could see that spot without giving him her love.

It happened, while he was driving the dogs apart, that the cap fell off him. Grania was looking out at him as it fell. And a great love for him came on her there and then.

That is the rule of the love-spot. She saw it. That is all. Whatever came after, remember that she did not choose it, and neither did he.

She called her serving-maid and told her to bring the great golden cup from the sunny house, the one that held drink for nine times nine men. When the serving-maid brought the cup, Grania filled it with wine that had enchantment in it.

"Give the cup to Finn first," she said, "and tell him to take a drink from it, and tell him it was I myself sent it to him."

The serving-maid did that. Finn took the cup and drank from it, and no sooner had he drunk than he fell into a deep sleep. Then the cup was given to the king, and the queen, and the sons of kings, and the whole company — all but Oisín and Osgar and Caoilte and Diarmuid, and Diorraing the Druid. And everyone who drank from it fell into the same heavy sleep.

When they were all asleep, Grania rose up softly from her seat and turned her face to Diarmuid.

"Will you take my love, Diarmuid, son of Duibhne," she said, "and will you bring me away out of this house tonight?"

"I won't," said Diarmuid. "I won't meddle with the woman who's promised to Finn."

"If that's so," said Grania, "I put you under Druid bonds to bring me out of this house tonight, before Finn and the King of Ireland wake from their sleep."

"It's under bad bonds you're putting me, Grania," said Diarmuid. "And why is it you put them on me more than on the great men and sons of kings who are in the Middle Court tonight? There isn't one of them but is as well worthy of a woman's love as I am."

"By my hand, Diarmuid, it's not without cause I laid those bonds on you," said Grania. "I was at the door a while ago when you were parting the dogs, and my eyes fell on you, and I gave you there and then the love I never gave to any other, and never will give, for ever."

"It's a wonder you should give that love to me and not to Finn," said Diarmuid. "There isn't a man in Ireland is a better lover of a woman than he is. And do you know this, Grania: the night Finn is in Teamhair, it's he himself is the keeper of its gates. So we can't leave the town."

"There's a side door of escape at my sunny house," said Grania, "and we'll go out by it."

"It's a thing I'll never do," said Diarmuid, "go out by any side door of escape at all."

"That may be so," said Grania. "But I've heard it said that every fighting man has leave to pass over the walls of any dun or any strong place at all by the shafts of his spears. I'll go out through the door, and you follow me like that."

With that she went out.

Diarmuid spoke to his people. "O Oisín, son of Finn," he said, "what must I do with these bonds that are laid on me?"

"You're not guilty if the bonds were laid on you," said Oisín. "I tell you to follow Grania, and keep yourself well out of Finn's hands."

Finn's own son. That is what he said.

"Osgar, son of Oisín," said Diarmuid, "what must I do with these bonds that are put on me?"

"I tell you to follow Grania," said Osgar. "It's a pitiful man who'd break his bonds."

"What advice do you give me, Caoilte?"

"This is what I say," said Caoilte. "I have a fitting wife myself. And it would be better to me than all the riches of the world for Grania to have given me that love."

"What advice do you give me, Diorraing?"

"I tell you to follow Grania," said Diorraing, "though you'll get your death by it, and that's bad to me."

"Is that the advice you all give me?" said Diarmuid.

"It is," said Oisin, and all the rest with him.

With that Diarmuid stood up and stretched out his hand for his weapons. He said farewell to Oisin and the others, and every tear he shed was the size of a mountain berry.

He went out to the wall of the dun and put the shafts of his two spears under him, and rose with a light leap, and came down on the grassy earth outside. Grania met him there.

"It's a bad journey you've come on, Grania," said Diarmuid. "It would be better for you to have Finn, son of Cumhal, as a lover than me. I don't know any part or any western corner of Ireland that will hide you. And if I do bring you with me, it's not as a wife I'll bring you. I'll keep my faith to Finn. Turn back now to the town, and Finn will never get news of what you've done."

"It's certain I won't turn back," said Grania. "And I'll never part from you until death parts us."

"If that's so, let's go on, Grania," said Diarmuid.

They went on. They had not gone far out from the town when Grania said, "I'm getting tired, indeed."

"It's a good time to be tired," said Diarmuid. "Go back again to your own house now. For I swear by the word of a true champion, I'll never carry you or any other woman, to the end of life and time."

"That's not what you have to do," said Grania. "My father's horses are in a grass field by themselves, and chariots with them. Turn back now and bring two horses of them, and I'll

wait in this place until you come to me again."

So Diarmuid went back for the horses. We have no knowledge of their journey until they reached the ford on the Sionnan that is called Ath-luain now.

"It's easier for Finn to follow our track," said Diarmuid, "with the horses along with us."

"If that's so," said Grania, "leave the horses here, and I'll go on foot from now on."

Diarmuid went down to the river and brought one horse over the ford with him, and left the other horse on the far side of the river. He and Grania went a good way westward with the stream, and came to land on the side of the province of Connacht.

And wherever they went, Diarmuid left unbroken bread behind him, as a sign to Finn that he had kept faith with him.

That is the rule of the bread. A whole loaf, left at every camp. It means: I have not touched her. It means: I am still your man. Finn would find every one of those loaves. You can decide for yourself what he thought, each time.

From there they went on to Doire-da-Bhoth, the Wood of the Two Huts. Diarmuid cut down the wood round about them, and made a fence with seven doors of woven twigs. And he set out a bed of soft rushes and the tops of the birch-tree for Grania in the very middle of the wood.

The Pursuit



And now, Finn, son of Cumhal. I will tell his part of it.

Everyone in Teamhair rose early the next morning, and they found Diarmuid and Grania gone. A scorching jealousy came on Finn, and a weakness.

He sent his trackers out on the plain and told them to follow Diarmuid and Grania. They followed the track as far as the ford on the Sionnan, and Finn and the Fianna followed after them. But they could not carry the track across the ford. And Finn gave them his word that unless they found the track again without delay, he would hang them on either side of the ford.

That is Finn now. The man who never refused anyone. The judge who would give fair judgment between his enemy and his own son. He was going to hang his own trackers at a river because they had lost a trail.

Then the sons of Neamhuin went up against the stream and found a horse on each side of it. Then they went westward with the stream and found the track going along the side of the province of Connacht, and Finn and the Fianna of Ireland followed it on.

"I know well where we'll find Diarmuid and Grania now," said Finn. "It's in Doire-da-Bhoth they are."

Oisín and Osgar and Caoilte and Diorraing were listening when Finn said that.

"There's a danger they might be there," Oisín said to the others, "and it would be right for us to give them some warning. Look now, Osgar — where's Bran the hound? Finn himself is no dearer to her than Diarmuid is. Tell her to go now with a warning to him."

So Osgar told Bran, and Bran understood him well. She went to the rear of the whole troop so that Finn would not see her, and followed the track of Diarmuid and Grania until she came to Doire-da-Bhoth. And she put her head into Diarmuid's bosom as he slept.

Diarmuid started up out of his sleep and woke Grania. "Here's Bran, Finn's hound," he said, "come with a warning to tell us that Finn himself is coming."

"Let's take that warning, then," said Grania, "and make your escape."

"I won't take it," said Diarmuid. "If I can't escape Finn, I'd as soon he took me now as any other time."

When Grania heard that, great fear came on her.

Bran went away from them. When Oisín saw her coming back, he said: "I'm afraid Bran found no chance to get to Diarmuid, and we should send him some other warning. Look — where's Fearghoin, Caoilte's serving-man?"

Every shout Fearghoin gave could be heard in the three nearest hundreds. So they made him give three shouts, so that Diarmuid would hear him.

Diarmuid heard him. "I hear Caoilte's serving-man," he said to Grania. "He's with Caoilte, and Caoilte is with Finn. Those shouts were sent as a warning to me."

"Take that warning," said Grania.

"I won't take it," said Diarmuid. "Finn and the Fianna will come up with us before we leave the wood."

Fear and great dread came on Grania when she heard him say that.

As for Finn, he did not leave off following the track until he came to Doire-da-Bhoth. He sent the sons of Neamhuin to search through the wood, and they saw Diarmuid, and the woman with him. They came back to Finn, and he asked them whether Diarmuid and Grania were in the wood.

"Diarmuid's in it," they said, "and there's some woman with him. We know Diarmuid, but we don't know Grania."

"May no good come to the friends of Diarmuid for his sake," said Finn. "He won't leave that wood until he's given me satisfaction for everything he's done to me."

"It's jealousy has put you astray, Finn," said Oisin, "to think Diarmuid would stay here on the plain of Maen Mhagh, with no close place in it but Doire-da-Bhoth, and you following after him."

"Saying that will do you no good," said Finn. "I knew well when I heard the three shouts Caoilte's serving-man gave that it was you sent them to Diarmuid as a warning. And another thing: it was you sent my own hound Bran to him. But none of those things you've done will serve you. He won't leave Doire-da-Bhoth until he gives me satisfaction for everything he's done to me, and every disgrace he's put on me."

"It's great foolishness for you, Finn," said Osgar, "to think Diarmuid would stay in the middle of this plain with you waiting here to strike the head off him."

"Who but himself cut the wood this way," said Finn, "and made this close, sheltered place, with seven woven narrow doors to it? O Diarmuid," he called out, "which of us is telling the truth, myself or Oisin?"

"You never failed in your good judgment, Finn," said Diarmuid. "Indeed, Grania and I are here."

He would not lie to Finn. Even now. Especially now.

Then Finn called on his men to surround Diarmuid and Grania and take them.

At that time it was shown to Angus Og at Brugh na Boinne what great danger Diarmuid was in — his pupil once, and his dear foster-son. He set out on the clear cold wind and did not stop anywhere until he came to Doire-da-Bhoth. He went, unknown to Finn or the Fianna, into the place where Diarmuid and Grania were, and he spoke kind words to Diarmuid.

"What is this thing you've done, grandson of Duibhne?"

"The daughter of the King of Ireland has made her escape with me from her father and from Finn," said Diarmuid. "And it's not by my will she came."

"Let each of you come under an edge of my cloak, then," said Angus, "and I'll bring you out of here without the knowledge of Finn or his people."

"Take Grania with you," said Diarmuid. "But I'll never go with you. If I'm alive, I'll follow you before long. And if I'm not, give Grania to her father, and let him do well or badly by her."

With that Angus put Grania under the edge of his cloak and brought her out, unknown to Finn or the Fianna. No news is told of them until they came to Ros-da-Shoileach, the Headland of the Two Sallows.

As for Diarmuid, when Angus and Grania had gone, he stood up as straight as a pillar and put on his armour and took up his weapons. Then he went to one of the seven doors he had made, and asked who was at it.

"There's no enemy to you here," they said. "Oisin and Osgar are here, and the best men of the sons of Baiscne with us. Come out to us now, and nobody will dare do you any harm or hurt."

"I won't go out to you," said Diarmuid, "until I see at which door Finn himself is."

He went to another of the seven doors and asked who was at it.

"Caoilte, son of Ronan, and the rest of the sons of Ronan with him. Come out to us now, and we'll give ourselves for your sake."

"I won't go out to you," said Diarmuid. "I won't put you under Finn's anger for any good you do me."

He went on to another door and asked who was at it.

"Conan, son of Morna, is here, and the rest of the sons of Morna with him. We're enemies to Finn, and you're a great deal more to us than he is. Come out, and nobody will dare lay a hand on you."

"I won't indeed," said Diarmuid. "Finn would be better pleased to see the death of every one of you than to let me escape."

He went to another door and asked who was at it.

"A friend and a comrade of your own: Fionn, son of Cuadan, head of the Fianna of Munster, and his men with him. We're of the one country and the one soil, and we'll give our bodies and our lives for your sake."

"I won't go out to you," said Diarmuid. "I wouldn't like Finn to have a grudge against you for any good you did me."

He went to another door and asked who was at it.

"Fionn, son of Glor, head of the Fianna of Ulster, and his men with him. Come out to us now, and nobody will dare hurt or harm you."

"I won't go out to you," said Diarmuid. "You're a friend to me, and your father with you, and I wouldn't like Finn's unfriendliness to be put on you for my sake."

He went to another door and asked who was at it.

"There's no friend of yours here," they said. "Here are Aodh Beag the Little from Eamhuin, and Aodh Fada the Long from Eamhuin, and Caol Crodha the Fierce, and Goineach the Wounder, and Gothan the White-Fingered, and Aoife his daughter, and Cuadan the Tracker from Eamhuin. We're unfriendly people to you. If you come out to us we won't spare you at all, but we'll make an end of you."

"It's a bad troop that's in it," said Diarmuid, "you of the lies, and of the tracking, and of the one shoe. It's not fear of your hands that's on me. But because I'm your enemy, I won't go out."

He went to the last of the seven doors and asked who was at it.

"No friend of yours," they said. "It's Finn, son of Cumhal, and four hundred paid fighting men with him. If you come out to us we'll make opened marrow of you."

"I give you my word, Finn," said Diarmuid, "that the door you're at yourself is the first door I'll pass out of."

Seven doors. At six of them, his friends and his enemies. He would not go out through a friend's door, because it would cost the friend. He would not go out through an enemy's

door, because it would look like fear. So there was only one door left, and it was Finn's.

When Finn heard that, he warned his battalions, on pain of lasting death, not to let Diarmuid past them without their knowing. But when Diarmuid heard him, he rose on the shafts of his spears and went with a very high, light leap far beyond Finn and his people, without their knowledge.

He looked back at them and called out that he had gone past them. Then he put his shield on his back and went straight on towards the west, and before long he was out of sight of Finn and the Fianna.

When he saw nobody coming after him, he turned back to where he had seen Angus and Grania leaving the wood, and he followed their track until he came to Ros-da-Shoileach.

He found Angus and Grania there in a sheltered, well-lighted cabin, with a great blazing fire kindled in it, and half a wild boar on spits. Diarmuid greeted them, and the life nearly went out of Grania with joy at the sight of him.

Diarmuid told them his news from beginning to end. They ate their share that night and slept until the coming of the day and the full light the next morning.

Angus got up early and said to Diarmuid: "I'm going from you now, grandson of Duibhne. And I leave you this advice.

"Don't go into a tree with one trunk when you're fleeing from Finn.

"Don't go into a cave of the earth that has only one door.

"Don't go to an island of the sea that has only one harbour.

"And wherever you cook your food, don't eat it there. And wherever you eat it, don't lie down there. And wherever you lie down, don't get up there in the morning."

That is the law of the hunted, and Angus gave it to him whole. It is how you live when the greatest man in Ireland wants you dead. You never sleep where you eat. You never wake where you sleep.

He said farewell to them after that, and went his way.

The Green Champions



Then Diarmuid and Grania went westward along the right bank of the Sionnan until they came to Garbh-abha-na-Fiann, the Rough River of the Fianna. Diarmuid killed a salmon on the brink of the river and put it to the fire on a spit. Then he and Grania crossed the stream to eat it, as Angus had told them. And then they went on westward to sleep.

They rose early the next morning and travelled straight west until they came to the marsh of Finnliath.

On the marsh they met a young man of good shape and appearance, but without fitting clothes or weapons. Diarmuid greeted the young man and asked him for his news.

"I'm a fighting lad looking for a master," he said, "and Muadhan is my name."

"What would you do for me, young man?" said Diarmuid.

"I'd be a servant to you in the day, and watch for you in the night," he said.

"I tell you to keep that young man," said Grania. "You can't be always without people."

So they made an agreement with him and bound one another, and went on together westward until they reached the Carrthach river. Then Muadhan told Diarmuid and Grania to get up on his back until he carried them over the stream.

"That would be a big load for you," said Grania.

But he put them on his back and carried them over. Then they went on until they came to the Beith, and Muadhan brought them over on his back the same way.

They went into a cave at the side of Currach Cinn Adhmuid, the Woody Headland of the Bog, above Tonn Toime. Muadhan made ready beds of soft rushes and birch-tops for them at the far end of the cave. Then he went into the scrub near by and took a long straight rod of a quicken-tree. He put a hair and a hook on the rod, and a holly berry on the hook, and went up the stream, and took a salmon with the first cast. He put on a second berry and

killed another fish, and a third berry and killed the third fish. Then he put the hook and the hair under his belt, and struck the rod into the earth, and brought the three salmon to where Diarmuid and Grania were, and put them on spits.

When they were done, Muadhan said: "I give the dividing of the fish to you, Diarmuid."

"I'd sooner you divided it than me," said Diarmuid.

"Then I'll give the dividing of the fish to you, Grania," said he.

"I'm better satisfied for you to divide it," said Grania.

"If it was you divided the fish, Diarmuid," said Muadhan, "you'd have given the best share to Grania. And if it was Grania divided it, she'd have given you the best share. And since it's I who am dividing it, you have the biggest fish, Diarmuid, and let Grania have the second biggest, and I'll have the smallest."

Three fish on a hook of holly. And a servant who could see into both their hearts and set the table accordingly.

They spent the night there. Diarmuid and Grania slept at the far end of the cave, and Muadhan kept watch for them until the rising of the day and the full light of the next morning.

Diarmuid rose early and told Grania to keep watch for Muadhan while he went and took a walk around the country. He went out and up a hill that was near, and looked about him, east and west, north and south.

He had not been there long when he saw a great fleet of ships coming from the west, straight towards the bottom of the hill where he stood. When they came to land, nine times nine of the chief men of the ships came ashore. Diarmuid went down and greeted them, and asked them for news, and what country they belonged to.

"We are three kings of the Green Champions of Muir-na-locht," they said. "Finn, son of Cumhal, sent for us because of a thief of the woods, an enemy of his, who has gone into hiding from him. It's to stop him we've come. We are twenty hundred good fighting men, and every one of us a match for a hundred. And besides that, we have three deadly hounds

with us. Fire won't burn them, and water won't drown them, and weapons won't redden on them. We'll lay them on his track, and it won't be long before we have news of him. Tell us who you are, and have you any word of the grandson of Duibhne?"

That is the rule of the hounds. Fire, water, weapons: nothing ordinary. Remember it. Diarmuid did.

"I saw him yesterday," said Diarmuid. "And as for me, I'm only a fighting man, walking the world by the strength of my hand and the hardness of my sword. And by my word, you'll know Diarmuid's hand when you meet it."

"Well, we've found nobody up to now," they said.

"What are your own names?" said Diarmuid.

"Dubh-chosach, the Black-footed; Fionn-chosach, the Fair-footed; and Treun-chosach, the Strong-footed," they said.

"Is there wine in your ships?" said Diarmuid.

"There is," they said.

"If you have a mind to bring out a tun of wine," said Diarmuid, "I'll do a trick for you."

They sent men to get the tun. When it came, Diarmuid took it between his two hands and drank a drink out of it, and the others drank what was left. Then Diarmuid took the tun up to the top of the hill, and got up on it himself, and let it roll down the steep of the hill to the bottom. Then he brought it up the hill again, riding it coming and going, and he did that trick three times in front of the strangers.

But they said that a man who called that a trick had never seen a good trick. One of them got up on the tun. But Diarmuid gave a push of his foot at it, and the young man fell off before it began to move, and it rolled over him and crushed him, so that he died. Another man got on it, and another after him, until fifty of them had been killed trying to do Diarmuid's trick. And as many as were not killed went back to their ships that night.

Diarmuid went back to where he had left Grania. Muadhan put the hair and the hook on the rod until he had killed three salmon, and they ate their meal that night, and he kept watch for them the same way as before.

Diarmuid went out to the hill again early the next day. It was not long before he saw the three strangers coming towards him, and he asked them whether they would like to see any more tricks. They said they would sooner have news of the grandson of Duibhne.

"I saw a man who saw him yesterday," said Diarmuid.

With that he took off his weapons and his clothes, all but the shirt next his skin, and he struck the Crann Buidhe, the spear of Manannan, into the earth with the point upwards. Then he rose with a leap and landed on the point of the spear, as light as a bird, and came down off it again without a wound on him.

"It's a man who's never seen feats who'd call that a feat," said a young man of the Green Champions. He took off his clothes and made a leap, and he came down heavily on the point of the spear, and it went through his heart, and he fell to the ground.

The next day Diarmuid came again. He brought two forked poles out of the wood and stood them upright on the hill, and put the sword of Angus Og, the Mor-alltach, the Big Fierce One, between the two forks, on its edge. Then he rose lightly over it and walked on the sword three times, from the hilt to the point, and came down and asked whether there was a man of them could do that feat.

"That's a foolish question," said one of them. "There was never any feat done in Ireland but a man of our own would do it."

And with that he rose up to walk on the sword. This is what happened: he came down heavily on it, and he was cut into two halves.

The rest of the champions told him to take his sword away then, before any more of their people fell by it, and asked him whether he had any word of the grandson of Duibhne.

"I saw a man who saw him today," said Diarmuid, "and I'll go and ask him for news tonight."

Every day, a truth, and they never heard it.

He went back to where Grania was, and Muadhan killed three salmon for their supper and kept watch for them through the night.

Diarmuid rose at the early break of day. He put on his battle-clothes, that no weapon could go through. He took the sword of Angus, which left no leavings after it, at his left side, and his two thick-handled spears, the Gae Buidhe and the Gae Dearg, the Yellow and the Red, which gave wounds there was no healing for. Then he woke Grania and told her to keep watch for Muadhan, and said he would go out and take a look around.

When Grania saw him looking so brave, dressed in his clothes of anger and of battle, great fear took hold of her, and she asked him what he was going to do.

"It's for fear of meeting my enemies I'm like this," he said.

That quieted Grania. Then Diarmuid went out to meet the Green Champions.

They came to land and asked whether he had news of the grandson of Duibhne.

"I saw him not long ago," said Diarmuid.

"If that's so, tell us where he is," they said, "so we can bring his head to Finn, son of Cumhal."

"I'd be keeping bad watch for him if I did that," said Diarmuid. "His life and his body are under the protection of my valour, and because of that I'll do no treachery on him."

"Is that true?" they said.

"It's true indeed," said Diarmuid.

"Then leave this place yourself," they said, "or we'll bring your head to Finn, since you're an enemy of his."

"I'd be in bonds," said Diarmuid, "the day I'd leave my head with you."

With that he drew his sword, the Mor-alltach, out of its sheath and made a fierce blow at the head nearest him that put it in two halves. Then he attacked the whole host of the

Green Champions and began to destroy them, cutting through the beautiful shining armour of the men of Muir-na-locht, until there was hardly a man of them who did not get the shortening of his life and the sorrow of death, or who could go back to give news of the fight — only the three kings and a few of their people, who escaped back to their ships.

Diarmuid turned back then, without wound or hurt on him, and went to where Grania and Muadhan were. They welcomed him, and Grania asked him whether he had heard any news of Finn and the Fianna of Ireland. He said he had not. And they ate their food and spent the night there.

He rose again with the early light of the next morning and went back to the hill, and when he got there he struck a great blow on his shield that set the strand shaking with the sound.

Dubh-chosach heard it, and said he himself would go and fight Diarmuid, and he came ashore there and then.

He and Diarmuid threw the weapons out of their hands and rushed at each other like wrestlers, straining their arms and their sinews, knotting their hands on each other's backs, fighting like bulls in madness, or like two daring hawks on the edge of a cliff. But at last Diarmuid raised Dubh-chosach up on his shoulder and threw him to the ground, and bound him fast and firm on the spot.

Then Fionn-chosach and Treun-chosach came one after the other to fight him, and he put the same binding on them.

He said he would strike their heads off, except that he thought it a worse punishment to leave them in those bonds. "For there's no one can free you," he said.

And he left them there, worn out and sorrowful.

That is the rule of Diarmuid's binding. No man in Ireland can loosen it but four. Keep that in mind as well.

The next morning Diarmuid told Grania the whole story of the strangers from beginning to end, and all he had done to them, and how on the fifth day he had put their kings in bonds.

"And they have three fierce hounds on a chain, ready to hunt me," he said.

"Did you take the heads off those three kings?" said Grania.

"I didn't," said Diarmuid. "There's no man of the heroes of Ireland can loosen those bonds but four only: Oisín, son of Finn; and Osgar, son of Oisín; and Lugaidh's Son of the Strong Hand; and Conan, son of Morna. And I know well none of those four will do it. But all the same, it won't be long before Finn gets news of them, and it's best for us to leave this cave, or Finn and the three hounds might come on us."

So they left the cave and went on until they came to the bog of Finnliath. Grania began to fall behind them, and Muadhan put her on his back and carried her until they came to great Slieve Luachra.

Then Diarmuid sat down on the brink of the stream that flows through the heart of the mountain. Grania was washing her hands, and she asked him for his knife to cut her nails with.

As for the strangers, as many of them as were still alive came to the hill where their three leaders were bound, and tried to loose them. But the way those bonds were, all their meddling only drew them tighter.

They had not been there long when they saw a woman coming towards them with the quickness of a swallow, or a weasel, or a blast of wind over bare mountain-tops. She asked them who had done that great slaughter on them.

"Who are you that's asking?" they said.

"I'm the Woman of the Black Mountain, the woman-messenger of Finn, son of Cumhal," she said. "It's looking for you Finn sent me."

"Indeed, we don't know who did this slaughter," they said. "But we'll tell you what he looked like. He was a young man with dark curling hair and ruddy cheeks. And it's worse again to us that our three leaders are bound like this, and we can't loose them."

"Which way did that young man go from you?" said the woman.

"It was late last night he left us," they said, "and we don't know where he's gone."

"I give you my word," she said, "it was Diarmuid himself. Take your hounds now and lay them on his track, and I'll send Finn and the Fianna of Ireland to you."

They left a woman-Druid attending on the three champions who were bound. They brought their three hounds out of the ship and laid them on Diarmuid's track, and followed them until they came to the mouth of the cave. They went into the far end of it and found the beds where Diarmuid and Grania had slept. Then they went on westward until they came to the Carrthach river, and to the bog of Finnliath, and so on to great Slieve Luachra.

Diarmuid did not know they were after him until he saw them coming, with their banners of soft silk, and their three wicked hounds at the front of the troop, and three strong champions holding them on chains. When he saw them coming like that, a great hatred of them filled him.

One of them, in a well-coloured green cloak, came out far ahead of the others.

Grania gave the knife back to Diarmuid.

"I think you haven't much love for that young man in the green cloak, Grania," said Diarmuid.

"I haven't indeed," said Grania. "And it would be better if I'd never given love to any man at all to this day."

It is the only time in the whole long story that she says it. She is tired, and hunted, and cutting her nails by a stream in the mountains, and she says it once.

Diarmuid put the knife in its sheath and went on. Muadhan put Grania on his back and carried her on into the mountain.

It was not long before one of the three hounds was loosed after Diarmuid.

Muadhan told him to go after Grania, and said he himself would check the hound. Then Muadhan turned back. He took a whelp out of his belt and put it on the flat of his hand. When the whelp saw the hound rushing towards it with its jaws open, it rose up and leapt from Muadhan's hand into the throat of the hound, and came out through its side, bringing

the heart with it. Then it leapt back into Muadhan's hand, and left the hound dead behind it.

Fire would not burn those hounds, nor water drown them, nor weapons redden on them. Nobody had said anything about a whelp.

Muadhan went on after Diarmuid and Grania, and he took Grania up again and carried her a bit of the way into the mountain.

Then another hound was loosed after them.

"I've often heard," Diarmuid said to Muadhan, "that nothing can stand against weapons of Druid wounding, and the throat of no beast can be made safe from them. Will you stand now, while I put the Gae Dearg, the Red Spear, through that hound?"

Muadhan and Grania stopped to watch the cast. Diarmuid threw at the hound, and the spear went through its body and brought out its bowels. He took up the spear again, and they went on.

It was not long after that the third hound was loosed.

"This is the fiercest of them," said Grania, "and there's great fear on me. Mind yourself now, Diarmuid."

It was not long before the hound overtook them. The place it overtook them was Lic Dhubhain, the Flagstone of Dubhan, on Slieve Luachra. It rose with a light leap over Diarmuid, as if it meant to seize Grania. But Diarmuid took it by the two hind legs and struck its carcase against the side of the nearest rock, until he had let out its brains through the openings of its head and its ears.

Then Diarmuid took up his weapons and his battle-clothes, and put his narrow-topped finger into the silken string of the Gae Dearg, and made a good cast at the young man in the green cloak at the head of the troop, and killed him. Then he made another cast at the second man and killed him, and the third man the same way. And since it is not the custom to stand when the leaders have fallen, the strangers, when they saw what had happened, took to flight.

Diarmuid followed them, killing and scattering, so that unless some man of them got away over the forests, or into the green earth, or under the waters, there was not a man or a messenger of them left to tell the news — except the Woman-Messenger of the Black Mountain, who kept moving round about while Diarmuid was putting down the strangers.

It was not long before Finn saw her coming towards him where he was, her legs failing, her tongue muttering, her eyes drooping, and he asked her for news.

"It's very bad news I have to tell you," she said. "And it's my opinion I'm a person without a lord now."

Then she told Finn the whole story from beginning to end: of the destruction Diarmuid had done, and how the three deadly hounds had fallen by him.

"And it was hardly I got away myself," she said.

"Where did the grandson of Duibhne go?" said Finn.

"I don't know that," she said.

When Finn heard of the Kings of the Green Champions that Diarmuid had bound, he called his men to him, and they went by every short way and every straight path until they reached the hill. It was a torment to Finn's heart to see the state they were in.

"Oisin," he said, "loosen those three kings for me."

"I won't loosen them," said Oisin. "Diarmuid put bonds on me not to loosen any man he'd bind."

"Loosen them, Osgar," said Finn.

"I give my word," said Osgar, "I'd sooner put more bonds on them than loosen them."

Neither would Conan help them, nor Lugaidh's Son.

Four men in Ireland could have loosed them. Finn's son, and Finn's grandson, and his old enemy, and his own kinsman. Not one of them would lift a finger. That is how Finn learned where the Fianna's hearts were.

And in any case, they had not been talking about it long before the three kings died under the hardness of the bonds that were on them.

Then Finn made three wide-sodded graves for them. A flagstone was put over them, and another stone raised over that again, and their names were written in branching Ogham. And Finn was tired and heavy-hearted after that. He and his people went back to Almhuin of Leinster.

The Wood Of Dubhros



As for Diarmuid and Grania and Muadhan, they went on through Ui Chonaill Gabhra, and by left-hand ways to Ros-da-Shoileach. Diarmuid killed a wild deer that night, and they had their fill of meat and of pure water, and slept until the next morning.

Muadhan rose early and spoke to Diarmuid. He said he was going away.

"It's not right for you to do that," said Diarmuid. "Everything I promised you, I fulfilled without any dispute."

But he could not stop him. Muadhan said farewell to them and left them there and then. And Diarmuid and Grania were sorrowful and downhearted after him.

He had come from nowhere, and carried them over rivers, and fed them from a hook of holly, and killed a hound with a whelp from his belt. And he left. The story never tells us who he was. Some things that help you are not meant to be understood.

After that they travelled straight north to Slieve Echtge, and from there to the hundred of Ui Fiachrach. When they got there Grania was tired out, but she took courage and went on walking beside Diarmuid until they came to the wood of Dubhros.

There was a wonderful quicken-tree in that wood, and this is how it came to be there.

A dispute rose once between two women of the Tuatha de Danaan, Aine and Aoife, daughters of Manannan, son of Lir. Aoife had given her love to Lugaidh's Son, and Aine had given her love to a man of her own race, and each said her own man was the better hurler. Out of that dispute came a great hurling-match, set between the Men of Dea and the Fianna of Ireland, and the place it was to be played was a beautiful plain near Loch Lein.

They all came together there. The highest and most daring men of the Tuatha de Danaan were there: the three Garbhs of Slieve Mis, and the three Mases of Slieve Luachra, and the three yellow-haired Murchadhs, and the three Eochaidhs of Aine, and the three Fionns of the White House, and the three Sgals of Brugh na Boinne, and the three Ronans of Ath na

Riogh, and the Suirgheach Suairc, the Pleasant Wooer from Lionan, and the Man of Sweet Speech from the Boinn, and Ilbrec the Many-Coloured, son of Manannan, and Neamhanach, son of Angus Og, and Bodb Dearg, son of the Dagda, and Manannan, son of Lir.

They and the Fianna played the match for three days and three nights, from Leamhain to the valley of the Fleisg, which is called the Crooked Valley of the Fianna, and neither side scored a goal. When the Tuatha de Danaan watching the game on either side of Leamhain saw how hard it was for their hurlers to win a goal against the Fianna, they thought it just as well to go away again without playing the game out.

The provisions the Men of Dea had brought with them from the Land of Promise were crimson nuts, and apples, and sweet-smelling rowan-berries. As they were passing through the district of Ui Fiachrach by the Muaidh, one of the rowan-berries fell from them, and a tree grew up from it.

There was virtue in its berries. No sickness or disease would ever come on anyone who ate them. Those who ate them would feel the liveliness of wine and the satisfaction of mead in them. Any old person of a hundred years who ate them would go back to being young again. And any young girl who ate them would grow into a flower of beauty.

After the tree had grown, it happened that some messengers of the Tuatha de Danaan were going through the wood of Dubhros. They heard a great noise of birds and bees, and went to where the noise was, and saw the beautiful Druid tree. They went back and told what they had seen. When all the chief men of the Tuatha de Danaan heard it, they knew the tree must have grown from a berry of the Land of the Ever-Living Living Ones. They asked among all their people until they found it was a young man of theirs, a musician, who had dropped the berry.

They agreed to send him in search of a man of Lochlann who would guard the tree by day and sleep in it by night. The women of the Sidhe were very downhearted to see him going from them, for there was no harper who could play half as sweetly on his harp as he could play on an ivy leaf.

He went on until he came to Lochlann. He sat down on a bank and sleep came on him, and he slept until sunrise the next day. When he woke, he saw a very big man coming towards him, who asked him who he was.

"I'm a messenger from the Men of Dea," he said. "I've come looking for some very strong man who'd be willing to guard a Druid tree in the wood of Dubhros. And here are some of the berries he'll be eating from morning to night."

When the big man had tasted the berries, he said: "I'll go and guard all the trees of the wood to get those berries."

His name was the Searbhan Lochlannach, the Surly One of Lochlann. He was very black and ugly, with crooked teeth and only one eye, in the middle of his forehead. He had a thick collar of iron around his body. And it was in the prophecy that he would never die until three strokes of his own iron club were struck upon him.

That is the rule of the Surly One. Nothing kills him but his own club. Three strokes of it. No fewer.

He slept in the tree by night and stayed near it in the daytime, and he made a wilderness of the whole district around him, and none of the Fianna dared go hunting there, for dread of him.

But when Diarmuid came to the wood of Dubhros, he went into it to where the Surly One was, and made a bond of agreement with him, and got leave from him to hunt in the wood, as long as he did not touch the berries of the tree. Then he made a cabin in the wood for himself and for Grania.

As for Finn and his people, they had not been long at Almhuin when they saw fifty armed men coming towards them, with two at the front who were taller and handsomer than the rest. Finn asked whether any of his people knew them.

"We don't know them," they said, "but maybe you know them yourself, Finn."

"I don't," he said. "But it seems to me they're enemies of mine."

The troop of armed men came up and greeted him, and Finn asked them for news, and what country they came from.

"I'm Aonghus, son of Art Og, of the children of Morna," said one of them, "and this is Aodh, son of Andela. We're enemies of yours. Our fathers were at the killing of your father, and they died themselves for that deed. It's to ask for peace we've come to you now."

"Where were you when my father was killed?" said Finn.

"In our mothers' wombs," they said. "And our mothers were two women of the Tuatha de Danaan. It's time for us now to get our fathers' place among the Fianna."

"I'll give you that," said Finn, "but I must put a fine on you first, in satisfaction for my father's death."

"We have neither gold nor silver nor goods nor cattle to give you, Finn," they said.

"Don't put a fine on them, Finn," said Oisin, "beyond the death of their fathers for your father."

"It's my opinion," said Finn, "that if anyone killed me, Oisin, it would be easy to pay the fine you'd ask. No one comes among the Fianna without giving what I ask in satisfaction for my father's death."

"What is it you're asking of us?" said Aonghus, son of Art Og.

"I'm asking only the head of a champion," said Finn, "or the full of a fist of the berries of the quicken-tree at Dubhros."

Once, Lugh asked a fine that sounded small, of men who had killed his father. You remember how that went. Finn remembered too. He had Lugh's blood in him.

"I'll give you good advice, children of Morna," said Oisin. "Go back to the place you were reared, and don't ask Finn for peace for the length of your lives. It's no easy thing Finn is asking of you. Do you know whose head he's asking you to bring him?"

"We don't," they said.

"The head of Diarmuid, grandson of Duibhne, is the head he's asking of you. And if you were twenty hundred men in your full strength, Diarmuid wouldn't let you take that head."

"And what are the berries Finn is asking of us?" they said.

"There's nothing harder for you to get than those berries," said Oisin.

Then he told them the whole story of the tree, and of the Searbhan, the Surly One of Lochlann, who had been set to mind it by the Tuatha de Danaan.

But Aodh, son of Andela, said he would sooner get his death looking for those berries than go home again to his mother's country. He asked Oisin to look after his people until he came back, and if anything should happen to him and his brother on their journey, to send them back to the Land of Promise.

The two of them said farewell to Oisin and to the chief men of the Fianna, and went on until they reached Dubhros. They went along the wood until they found a track, and followed it to the door of the hunting-cabin where Diarmuid and Grania were.

Diarmuid heard them coming, and put his hand on his weapons and asked who was at the door.

"We're of the children of Morna," they said. "Aodh, son of Andela, and Aonghus, son of Art Og."

"What brings you to this wood?" said Diarmuid.

"Finn, son of Cumhal, has set us looking for your head, if you're Diarmuid, grandson of Duibhne," they said.

"I am indeed," said Diarmuid.

"If that's so," they said, "Finn will take nothing from us but your head, or a fistful of the berries of the quicken-tree of Dubhros, as satisfaction for the death of his father."

"It's not easy for you to get either of those things," said Diarmuid. "And it's a pity for anyone to be under that man's power. Besides, I know it was he himself made an end of your

fathers, and that was satisfaction enough for him to get. And if you do bring him what he asks, it's likely he won't make peace with you in the end."

"Isn't it enough for you," said Aodh, "to have taken his wife away from Finn, without speaking ill of him?"

"It's not for the sake of speaking ill of him I said that," said Diarmuid, "but to save you from the danger he's sent you into."

"What are those berries Finn is asking for," said Grania, "that they can't be got for him?"

Diarmuid told her the whole story of the berry the Tuatha de Danaan had lost, and the tree that had sprung up from it, and the man of Lochlann who was keeping the tree.

"When Finn sent me hiding here and became my enemy," he said, "I got leave from the Surly One to hunt. But he told me never to meddle with the berries. And now, sons of Morna, there's your choice: to fight me for my head, or to go and ask the Surly One for the berries."

"I swear by the blood of my people," said each of them, "I'll fight you first."

With that the two young men made ready for the fight. They chose to fight with the strength of their hands alone. And Diarmuid put them down and bound the two of them there and then.

"That's a good fight you made," said Grania. "But by my word, though the children of Morna don't go looking for those berries, I won't lie in a bed ever again until I get a share of them. And I won't live if I don't get them."

She had never asked him for anything, in all that long hunt. This was the one thing. It was the one thing he could not give without breaking his word.

"Don't make me break my peace with the Surly One," said Diarmuid. "He won't let me take them."

"Loose these bindings off us," said the two young men, "and we'll go with you, and give ourselves for your sake."

"You mustn't come with me," said Diarmuid. "If you got the full of your eyes of that terrible one, you'd be more likely to die than to live."

"Well, do us this kindness, then," they said. "Loosen these bonds on us, and let us go by ourselves and see the fight, before you strike off our heads."

So Diarmuid did that for them.

Then Diarmuid went to the Surly One. He happened to be asleep. Diarmuid gave him a push with his foot, so that he lifted his head and looked up at him.

"Have you a mind to break our peace, Grandson of Duibhne?" he said.

"That's not what I want," said Diarmuid. "But Grania, daughter of the High King, has a desire to taste those berries, and it's to ask a handful of them I've come."

"I give my word," said the Surly One, "if she's to die for it, she'll never taste a berry of those berries."

"I wouldn't do treachery on you," said Diarmuid. "So I'm telling you: willing or unwilling, I'll take those berries from you."

Even here. He warned him first. He would not take so much as a berry by surprise.

When the Surly One heard that he got up on his feet, and lifted his club, and struck three great blows on Diarmuid that gave him some small hurt in spite of his shield. But when Diarmuid saw him not minding himself, he threw down his own weapons and made a great leap and took hold of the club with his two hands. And when he had hold of the club, he struck the Surly One three great blows with it that put his brains out through his head.

Three strokes of his own club. The prophecy was kept.

The two young men of the sons of Morna had watched the whole fight, and when they saw the Surly One was killed, they came out.

Diarmuid sat down, for he was spent with the force of the fight. He told the young men to bury the body under the thickets of the wood, so that Grania would not see it. "And after that," he said, "go back to her and bring her here."

So they dragged the body away and buried it, and then went for Grania and brought her to Diarmuid.

"There are the berries you were asking for, Grania," he said. "You may take what you like of them now."

"I give my word," said Grania, "I won't taste a berry of those berries except the one your own hand plucks, Diarmuid."

Diarmuid got up and plucked the berries for Grania, and for the children of Morna, and they ate their fill.

"Take all you can of these berries," he said to the young men, "and bring them with you to Finn, and tell him it was you made an end of the Surly One of Lochlann."

"We give you our word," they said, "we begrudge giving any of them to Finn."

But Diarmuid plucked a load of the berries for them, and they thanked him greatly for all he had done, and went back to where Finn was with the Fianna.

Diarmuid and Grania went up into the top of the tree, where the Surly One's bed was. The berries below were only bitter berries beside the ones above, in the tree.

When the two young men came to Finn, he asked them for their news.

"We've killed the Surly One of Lochlann," they said, "and we've brought you berries from the quicken-tree of Dubhros in satisfaction for your father, so that we may get peace from you."

They gave the berries into Finn's hand. He knew them.

"I give you my word," he said to the young men, "it was Diarmuid himself plucked those berries, for I know the smell of his hand on them. I know well it was he killed the Surly One. I'll go now and see whether he himself is alive at the quicken-tree."

He knew the smell of Diarmuid's hand. That is how close they had been. That is what makes the rest of this so hard.

After that he called for the seven battalions of the Fianna, and set out and went forward to Dubhros. They followed Diarmuid's track to the foot of the quicken-tree, and found the berries without anyone to guard them, and ate their fill of them.

The great heat of the day came on them, and Finn said they would stay where they were until the heat was past. "For I know well," he said, "that Diarmuid is up in the quicken-tree."

"It's a great sign of jealousy in you, Finn," said Oisín, "to think Diarmuid would stay up there in the quicken-tree when he knows you want to kill him."

Finn asked for a chessboard after that. "I'll play a game with you now on this," he said to Oisín.

They sat down, Oisín and Osgar and Lugaidh's Son and Diorraing on one side of the board, and Finn on the other.

They played that game with great skill and knowledge. Finn pressed Oisín so hard that he had no move left but one.

"There's one move would win the game for you, Oisín," said Finn, "and I defy all who are with you to show you that move."

Then Diarmuid said, up in the tree where he was, so that no one heard him but Grania: "It's a pity you're in straits, and me not there to show you that move."

"You're worse off yourself," said Grania, "in the bed of the Surly One of Lochlann at the top of the quicken-tree, with the seven battalions of the Fianna all round it to take your life."

But Diarmuid took a berry from the tree, and aimed it at the chessman that ought to be moved. Oisín moved it, and turned the game against Finn with that move.

It was not long before the game was going against Oisín a second time. When Diarmuid saw that he threw another berry at the chessman it was right to move, and Oisín moved it and turned the game against Finn the same way.

The third time Finn was getting the game from Oisín, Diarmuid threw the third berry on the man that would give Oisín the game. And the Fianna gave a great shout when the game was won.

He could not help himself. It was his friend, losing, and he knew the move.

Then Finn spoke. "It's no wonder you win the game, Oisín," he said, "with the help of Osgar, and the watchfulness of Diorraing, and the skill of Lugaidh's Son, and the teaching of the grandson of Duibhne with you."

"That's a great sign of jealousy in you, Finn," said Osgar, "to think Diarmuid would stay in this tree with you so near him."

"Which of us has the truth, Diarmuid, grandson of Duibhne," Finn called out, "myself or Osgar?"

"You never lost your good judgment, Finn," said Diarmuid. "Grania and I are here, in the bed of the Surly One of Lochlann."

Then Diarmuid stood up and gave Grania three kisses, in the sight of Finn and the Fianna.

A scorching jealousy and a weakness came on Finn when he saw it.

"It was worse to me, Diarmuid," he said, "that the seven battalions of the Fianna saw what you did at Teamhair, taking Grania away the night you were yourself my guard. But for all that, you'll give your head for the sake of those three kisses."

With that Finn called on the four hundred paid fighting men he had with him to make an end of Diarmuid. He put their hands into one another's hands in a ring around that quicken-tree, and told them that if they wanted to keep their lives, they must not let Diarmuid pass out through them. And he said that to whatever man took Diarmuid he would give his weapons and his armour, and a place among the Fianna of Ireland.

Then one of the Fianna, Garbh of Slieve Cua, said it was Diarmuid had killed his own father, and he would avenge him now. And he went up the quicken-tree to make an end of him.

About that time it was made known to Angus Og in Brugh na Boinne what danger Diarmuid was in, and he came to his help, unknown to the Fianna. When Garbh of Slieve Cua was coming up the tree, Diarmuid gave him a kick of his foot, and he fell down among the hired men. And they struck his head off, for Angus Og had put the appearance of Diarmuid on him. After he was killed his own shape came back on him, and the Fianna knew it was Garbh who had been killed.

Then Garbh of Slieve Crot said it was Diarmuid who had killed his father, and he went up to avenge him, and the same thing happened. And in the end all nine Garbhs — of Slieve Cua, and Slieve Crot, and Slieve Guaire, and Slieve Muice, and Slieve Mor, and Slieve Lugh, and Ath Fraoch, and Slieve Mis, and Drom-mor — went up trying to take Diarmuid's life, and lost their own. Every one of them had the shape and appearance of Diarmuid when he died.

Nine times, Finn watched Diarmuid die. Nine times, it was someone else.

Finn was very sorry and discouraged when he saw that these nine men had come to their death.

Then Angus said he would take Grania away with him.

"Do," said Diarmuid. "And if I'm living at evening, I'll follow you."

Angus said farewell to Diarmuid, and put his Druid cloak about Grania and about himself, and they went away in the safety of the cloak, unknown to Finn and the Fianna, until they came to Brugh na Boinne.

Then Diarmuid, grandson of Duibhne, spoke.

"I'll come down to you, Finn, and to the Fianna," he said. "And I'll do death and destruction on you and on your people. I'm certain your mind is made up to give me no rest, but to bring me to my death in some place. And I have nowhere to go from this danger. I have no friend or comrade under whose protection I could go, in any far part of the great world, for I've often fought against the men of the great world for love of you. There never came battle or fight, danger or trouble on you, but I'd go into it for your sake and the sake of the

Fianna. And not only that, but I'd fight in front of you and behind you. And I give my word, Finn, you'll pay hard for me. You won't get me as a free gift."

"It's the truth Diarmuid is speaking," said Osgar. "Give him forgiveness now, and peace."

"I won't do that," said Finn, "to the end of life and time. He'll never get peace or rest until I get satisfaction from him for every reproach he's put on me."

"It's a great shame and a great sign of jealousy for you to say that," said Osgar. "And I give the word of a true champion: unless the skies come down on me, or the earth opens under my feet, I won't let you or any one of the Fianna of Ireland give him cut or wound. I take his body and his life under the protection of my valour, and I'll keep him safe against all the men of Ireland."

Osgar, who would rather die than be helped, putting his whole life between his friend and his grandfather.

"Those are big words you have, Osgar," said Goll, "to say you'd bring a man away in spite of all the men of Ireland."

"It's not you will raise them up against me, Goll," said Osgar. "None of them would mind what you'd say."

"If that's what you're saying, you champion of great fights," said Goll, "let's see now what you can do."

"You'll have to go through with the fight you've taken on yourself," said Corrioll, son of Goll, in a loud voice.

And Osgar answered him fiercely: "If I do, I'll shorten your bones, and your father's bones along with them. Come down now, Diarmuid, since Finn has no mind to leave you in peace, and I promise on my body and my life no harm will be done to you today."

Then Diarmuid stood up on a high bough of the tree, and rose with a light leap by the shaft of his spear, and landed on the grass far beyond Finn and the Fianna. He and Osgar went towards each other, in spite of the Fianna who came between them. Diarmuid struck down those who were in his way. As for Osgar, the throwing of his spears as he scattered the

Fianna was like the sound of the wind going through a valley, or water falling over flagstones.

And Conan, who was always bitter, said: "Let the sons of Baiscne go on killing one another."

But when Finn saw that Diarmuid was gone from him, he told them to put up their weapons and turn back again to Almhuin.

He sent those of his men who could be healed to places of healing. The nine Garbhs, and the others of his men who had been killed, he put into wide-sodded graves. He was tired and downhearted and sorrowful after that. And he swore an oath that he would take no great rest until he had avenged on Diarmuid everything he had done.

The Quarrel



As for Osgar and Diarmuid, they went on, without cut or wound on them, to where Angus and Grania were at Brugh na Boinne. There was a good welcome for them, and Diarmuid told them the whole story from beginning to end. It was a wonder Grania did not die there and then, hearing all he had gone through.

Then she and Diarmuid set out again, and they went and stayed a while in a cave near the sea.

One night while they were there a great storm came on, so that they went into the far part of the cave. Bad as the night was, a man of the Fomor came over the western ocean in a currach with two oars, and drew it into the cave for shelter. Ciach, the Fierce One, was his name.

Diarmuid made him welcome, and they sat down to play chess together. Ciach got the best of the game. What he asked for his winnings was Grania, to be his wife. And he put his arms around her, as if to carry her away.

"I've been this long time going with the third best man of the Fianna," said Grania, "and he never came as near to me as that."

She said it in front of both of them. It was not a thing that could be taken back.

Diarmuid took his sword to kill Ciach. There was anger on Grania when she saw that. She had a knife in her hand, and she struck it into Diarmuid's thigh.

Diarmuid made an end of the Fomor. He said no word to Grania, but ran out and away through the storm.

Grania went after him, calling to him. But there was great anger on him, and he would not answer her.

At last, at the break of day, she caught up with him. After a while they heard the cry of a heron, and she asked him what had made the heron cry out.

"Tell me that," she said, "Grandson of Duibhne, to whom I gave my love."

"O Grania, daughter of the High King," said Diarmuid, "woman who never took a step right: it's because she was frozen to the rocks she gave that cry."

Grania was asking his forgiveness, and he was reproaching her, and this is what he said:

"O Grania of the beautiful hair, though you are more beautiful than the green tree in blossom, your love passes away as quickly as the cold cloud at break of day. You are asking a hard thing of me now. And it is a pity, what you said to me, Grania, for it was you brought me away from the house of my lord, so that I am banished from it to this day; and now I am troubled through the night, fretting after its delight in every place.

"I am like a wild deer, or a beast gone astray, going ever and always through the long valleys; there is great longing on me to see one of my kindred from the host.

"I left my own people, who were brighter than lime or snow. Their heart was full of generosity to me, like the sun that is high above us. But now they follow me angrily, to every harbour and every strand.

"I lost my people by you, and my lord, and my large bright ships on every sea. I lost my treasure and my gold. It is hunger you gave me, through your love.

"I lost my country and my kindred, my men who used to serve me. I lost quietness and affection. I lost the men of Ireland and the Fianna entirely.

"I lost delight and music. I lost my own right-doing and my honour. I lost the Fianna of Ireland, my great kinsmen, for the sake of the love you gave me.

"O Grania, white as snow, it would have been a better choice for you to have given hatred to me, or gentleness to the Head of the Fianna."

It is all true. Every word of it. And she did not choose the love-spot any more than he did.

And Grania said:

"O Diarmuid of the face like snow, or like the down of the mountains, the sound of your voice was dearer to me than all the riches of the leader of the Fianna.

"Your blue eye is dearer to me than his strength, and his gold and his great hall. The love-spot on your forehead is better to me than honey in streams. The time I first looked on it, it was more to me than the whole host of the King of Ireland.

"My heart fell down there and then before your high beauty. When you came beside me, it was like the whole of life in one day.

"O Diarmuid of the beautiful hands, take me now the same as before. It was with me the fault was, entirely. Give me your promise not to leave me."

But Diarmuid said:

"How can I take you again? You are a woman too fond of words. One day you give up the Head of the Fianna, and the next day me — and no lie in it.

"It is you parted me from Finn, so that I fell under sorrow and grief. And then you left me yourself, when I was full of affection."

And Grania said: "Don't leave me this way now, with my love for you ever growing, like the fresh branches of the tree in the kind long heat of the day."

But Diarmuid would not give in to her. "You're a woman full of words," he said, "and it's you have put me under sorrow. I took you with me, and you struck at me for the sake of the man of the Fomor."

They came then to a place where there was a cave, with water running by it, and they stopped to rest.

"Have you a mind to eat bread and meat now, Diarmuid?" said Grania.

"I'd eat it indeed if I had it," said Diarmuid.

"Give me a knife, then," she said, "so I can cut it."

"Look for the knife in the sheath where you put it yourself," said Diarmuid.

Then she saw that the knife was still in his thigh, where she had struck it. He would not draw it out himself.

All night, running through a storm with her knife in him. And he would not pull it out, so that she would have to.

So she drew it out. And that was the greatest shame that ever came on her.

They stayed then in the cave.

And the next day, when they went on again, Diarmuid did not leave unbroken bread behind him, as he had left every other day as a sign to Finn that he had kept faith with him.

It was broken bread he left behind him.

Somewhere behind them, Finn found it, and knew.

The Wanderers



They went on wandering after that all through Ireland, hiding from Finn in every place, sleeping under the cromlechs, or with no shelter at all. There was no place they dared stay long in.

Wherever they went, Finn followed them, for he knew by his divination where they went. But once he made out that they were on a mountain, for he saw them with heather under them. In fact they were beside the sea, asleep on heather that Diarmuid had brought down from the hills for their bed. So Finn went searching the hills, and did not find them.

That is why, in Ireland, the old stones are called the Beds of Diarmuid and Grania. There are a great many of them. They moved a great deal.

Grania would watch over Diarmuid while he slept, and she would make a sleepy song for him. This is what she would say:

"Sleep a little, a little little, for there is nothing at all to fear, Diarmuid, grandson of Duibhne. Sleep here soundly, soundly, Diarmuid, to whom I have given my love.

"It is I will keep watch for you, grandchild of shapely Duibhne. Sleep a little, a blessing on you, beside the well of the strong field; my lamb from above the lake, from the banks of the strong streams.

"Let your sleep be like the sleep in the South of Dedidach of the high poets, the time he took away old Morann's daughter, for all Conall could do against him.

"Let your sleep be like the sleep in the North of fair, comely Fionnchadh of Ess Ruadh, the time he took Slaine with bravery, as we think, in spite of Failbhe of the Hard Head.

"Let your sleep be like the sleep in the West of Aine, daughter of Gailian, the time she went on a journey in the night with Dubhthach from Doirinis, by the light of torches.

"Let your sleep be like the sleep in the East of Deaghadh the proud, the brave fighter, the time he took Coincheann, daughter of Binn, in spite of fierce Decheall of Duibhreann.

"O heart of the valour of the lands to the west of Greece, my heart will go near to breaking if I do not see you every day. The parting of us two will be the parting of two children of the one house; it will be the parting of life from the body, Diarmuid, hero of the bright lake of Carman."

Then, to rouse him, she would make another song, and this is what she would say:

"Caoinche will be loosed on your track; it is not slow the running of Caoilte will be. Do not let death reach you; do not give yourself to sleep for ever.

"The stag to the east is not asleep; he does not stop from bellowing. Though he is in the woods of the blackbirds, sleep is not in his mind. The hornless doe is not asleep, crying after her speckled fawn; she is going over the bushes; she does not sleep in her home.

"The cuckoo is not asleep; the thrush is not asleep; the tops of the trees are a noisy place. The duck is not asleep; she is made ready for good swimming. The bog lark is not asleep tonight on the high stormy bogs; the sound of her clear voice is sweet; she is not sleeping between the streams."

Two songs. One to put him to sleep, and one to wake him. She was the one who kept the watch. She was the one who knew what it cost to sleep.

Once they were in a cave of Beinn Edair, and there was an old woman befriending them, helping them keep watch. One day she happened to go up to the top of Beinn Edair, and she saw an armed man coming towards her. She did not know he was Finn. When he came near, she asked what he was looking for.

"I've come looking for a woman," he said, "and for a woman's love. Will you do everything I ask you?"

"I'll do that," she said. For she thought it was her own love he was asking for.

"Tell me, then," he said, "where is Diarmuid, grandson of Duibhne?"

So she told him where he was hiding. And he told her to keep Diarmuid in the cave until he came back with his men.

It was a cruel trick, and it was Finn who played it. He had become a man who would play it.

The old woman went back. This is what she did: she dipped her cloak in the sea-water before she went into the cave.

Diarmuid asked her why her cloak was so wet.

"Because I never saw or heard of the like of this day for cold and for storms," she said.

"There's frost on every hillside. There isn't a smooth plain in all Elga without a long rushing river between every two ridges. There isn't a deer or a crow in the whole of Ireland that can find shelter anywhere."

She was shaking the wet off her cloak and complaining of the cold, and this is what she said:

"Cold, cold, cold tonight is the wide plain of Lurg; the snow is higher than the mountains; the deer cannot get at their share of food.

"Cold for ever; the storm is spread over all. Every furrow on the hillside is a river, every ford is a full pool, every full loch is a great sea, every pool is a full loch. Horses cannot go through the ford of Ross, any more than a man on his two feet.

"The fishes of Inisfail are going astray; there is no strand and no pen against the waves; there are no dwellings in the country; there is no bell heard; no crane is calling.

"The hounds of the wood of Cuan find no rest and no sleep in their dwelling-place; the little wren cannot find shelter in her nest on the slope of Lon.

"A sharp wind and cold ice have come on the little company of birds; the blackbird cannot get a ridge to her liking, or shelter for her side, in the woods of Cuan.

"Steady our great pot hangs from its hook; broken is the cabin on the slope of Lon; the snow has made the woods smooth; it is hard to climb to the ridge of Bennait Bo.

"The ancient bird of Glen Ride gets grief from the bitter wind; great is her misery and her pain; the ice will be in her mouth.

"Mind well not to rise up from coverings and from down. Mind this well; there would be no good sense in it. Ice is heaped up in every ford. It is for that I am saying, and ever saying, 'Cold.'"

It was a beautiful poem. Treachery often is.

The old woman went out after that. When she was gone, Grania took hold of the cloak she had left behind and put her tongue to it, and found the taste of salt water on it.

"My grief, Diarmuid," she said. "The old woman has betrayed us. Get up now and put on your fighting-suit."

Grania. Again. She is the one who notices.

So Diarmuid did that, and went out, and Grania with him. No sooner were they outside than they saw Finn and the Fianna of Ireland coming towards them.

Diarmuid looked about him and saw a little boat close by, in the shelter of the harbour, and he and Grania got into it. There was a man in the boat ahead of them, with beautiful clothes on him, and a wide, embroidered, golden-yellow cloak over his shoulders behind. They knew it was Angus, who had come again to help them escape from Finn.

They went back with him for a while to Brugh na Boinne. And Osgar came to them there.

Fighting And Peace



After a while Finn told his people to make his ship ready and put a store of food and drink in it. They did that, and he and a thousand of his men went into the ship. They were nine days, between sailing and rowing, before they came to harbour in the north of Alban.

They tied the ship to the posts of the harbour, and Finn and five of his people went to the dun of the King of Alban. Finn struck a blow with the hand-wood on the door. The door-keeper asked who was there, and they told him it was Finn, son of Cumhal.

"Let him in," said the king.

Finn and his people went in, and the king made them welcome and told Finn to sit in his own place, and they were given strong, pleasant drinks. And the king sent for the rest of Finn's people and made them welcome to the dun.

Then Finn told what had brought him there: that he had come to ask for help and advice against the grandson of Duibhne.

"And you have a right to give me your help," he said, "for it was he killed your father and your two brothers, and many of your best men along with them."

"That's true," said the king. "I'll give you my own two sons, and a thousand men with each of them."

Finn was glad to hear that. He and his men took their leave of the king and his household, and left wishes for life and health with them, and the king did the same by them.

It was near Brugh na Boinne that Finn and his people came to land. Finn sent messengers to the house of Angus to give out a challenge of battle against Diarmuid, grandson of Duibhne.

"What should I do about this, Osgar?" said Diarmuid.

"We'll both go out and make a stand against them," said Osgar, "and we won't let a serving-man of them escape. We'll make an end of them all."

So they rose the next morning and put their battle-suits on their comely bodies. It would be a pity for anyone, many or few, who met those two men with their anger on them. They bound the rims of their shields together, so that they would not be parted from each other in the fight.

The sons of the King of Alban said they and their people would go first to meet them. They came ashore and made a rush at Diarmuid and Osgar. But the two fought so well that they beat them back and scattered them, and made a great slaughter, and put great terror on them, until at last there was not a man left to stand against them.

Two men, with their shields tied together. Two thousand, and the king's two sons. It was not close.

After that Finn went out on the sea again with his people, and there is no word of them until they came to the Land of Promise, where Finn's nurse was.

When she saw Finn coming she was very joyful. Finn told her the whole story from beginning to end, and the cause of his quarrel with Diarmuid. He said he had come to ask her advice, and that it was not possible to put Diarmuid down by the strength of any army, unless enchantment put him down.

"I'll go with you," said the old woman, "and I'll do enchantment on him."

Finn was very glad to hear that. He stayed there that night, and they set out for Ireland in the morning.

When they came to Brugh na Boinne, the nurse put a Druid mist around Finn and the Fianna, so that nobody would know they were there.

The day before, Osgar had parted from Diarmuid, and Diarmuid was out hunting by himself. That was shown to the hag. She took a water-lily leaf with a hole in it, like the eye of a millstone, and rose up on it by her enchantments on a blast of Druid wind, above Diarmuid. And she began to aim deadly spears at him through the hole, until she had done

him great harm, for all his weapons and his armour. He could not get away, he was so hard pressed. Every danger he had ever been in was small beside that danger.

And he thought: unless I can strike the old woman through the hole in that leaf, she'll give me my death here and now.

He lay down on his back with the Gae Dearg, the Red Spear, in his hand, and made a great cast of the spear. It went through the hole, and the hag fell dead on the spot.

A hole the size of a millstone's eye, in a leaf, on the wind. That is a cast to remember.

He struck off her head and brought it back with him to Angus Og.

Early the next morning Angus got up and went to where Finn was, and asked him whether he would make peace with Diarmuid, and Finn said he would. Then Angus went to the King of Ireland to ask peace for Diarmuid, and the king said he would agree to it.

Then he went back to where Diarmuid and Grania were, and asked Diarmuid whether he would make peace with the High King and with Finn.

"I'm willing," said Diarmuid, "if they'll give the conditions I ask."

"What conditions are those?" said Angus.

"The district my father had," said Diarmuid, "that is, the district of Ui Duibhne, without right of hunting to Finn, and without rent or tribute to the King of Ireland. And with that, the district of Dumhais in Leinster, for they're the best in Ireland. And the district of Ceis Corainn from the King of Ireland, as a marriage-portion with his daughter. Those are the conditions on which I'll make peace with them."

"Would you be peaceable if you got those conditions?" said Angus.

"It would go easier with me to make peace if I got them," said Diarmuid.

Angus went with that news to where the King of Ireland was with Finn. They gave him every one of those conditions. And they forgave him all he had done through the whole time he had been in hiding, which was sixteen years.

Sixteen years. Think of it. Sixteen years of never sleeping where you ate.

The place Diarmuid and Grania settled in was Rath Grania, in the district of Ceis Corainn, far away from Finn and from Teamhair. Grania bore him children there, four sons and one daughter. They lived there in peace. And people used to say there was not a man living in his time who was richer in gold and silver, in cattle and in sheep, than Diarmuid.

It was a good peace, and it lasted a long time. It was not the end of the story. But for a while it was allowed to feel like one.



Book Eight: Cnoc-An-Air



The Boar Of Beinn Gulbain



But at last, one day, Grania spoke to Diarmuid.

She said it was a shame on them, with all the people and the household they had, and all their riches, that the two best men in Ireland had never come to their house: the High King, her father, and Finn, son of Cumhal.

"Why do you say that, Grania," said Diarmuid, "when they're enemies of mine?"

"What I'd wish," said Grania, "is to give them a feast, so that you'd get their affection."

"I give leave for that," said Diarmuid.

She wanted her father at her table. She wanted Finn at peace. She wanted, perhaps, to be forgiven. There is nothing wrong in any of that. It is how the end began.

So Grania spent the length of a year making ready a great feast. Messengers were sent for the High King of Ireland, and for Finn and the seven battalions of the Fianna, and they came, and they were at the feast from day to day for the length of a year.

On the last night of the year Diarmuid was asleep at Rath Grania. In the night, through his sleep, he heard the voice of hounds. He started up. Grania caught him and put her two arms around him and asked what had startled him.

"It was the voice of a hound I heard," he said. "And it's a wonder to me to hear that in the night."

"Safe keeping on you," said Grania. "It's the Tuatha de Danaan doing that to you, on account of Angus of Brugh na Boinn. Lie down on the bed again."

But for all that, no sleep came to him. He heard the voice of the hound again, and started up a second time to go after it. Grania caught hold of him the second time and told him to lie down, and said it was no fitting thing to go after the voice of a hound in the night.

So he lay down again and fell asleep. But the voice of the hound woke him a third time. The day had come with its full light by then.

"I'll go after the voice of the hound now," he said, "since the day is here."

"If that's so," said Grania, "bring the Mor-alltach, the Great Fierce One, the sword of Manannan, with you, and the Gae Dearg."

"I won't," he said. "I'll take the Beag-alltach, the Little Fierce One, and the Gae Buidhe in one hand, and the hound Mac an Chuill, the Son of the Hazel, in the other."

Remember what she told him to take. Remember what he took instead.

Then Diarmuid went out of Rath Grania and made no delay until he came to the top of Beinn Gulbain. He found Finn there before him, with nobody at all in his company.

Diarmuid gave him no greeting, but asked him whether it was he who was making that hunt.

Finn said it was not a hunt he was making. He and some of the Fianna had gone out after midnight. "And one of our hounds that was loose beside us came on the track of a wild boar," he said, "and they haven't been able to bring him back yet. There's no use following that boar he's after. The Fianna have hunted him many a time, and he's got away from them every time until now, and he's killed thirty of them this morning. He's coming up the mountain towards us. Let's leave this hill to him now."

"I won't leave the hill for fear of him," said Diarmuid.

"It would be best for you, Diarmuid," said Finn. "It's the earless Green Boar of Beinn Gulbain that's in it. It's by him you'll come to your death. And Angus knew that well when he put bonds on you not to go hunting pigs."

"I never knew of those bonds," said Diarmuid. "But however it is, I won't leave here for fear of him. And leave Bran with me now, along with Mac an Chuill."

"I won't," said Finn. "She's often met this boar before, and could do nothing against him."

He went away then, and left Diarmuid alone on the top of the hill.

"I give my word," said Diarmuid, "you made this hunt for my death, Finn. And if it's here I'm to find my death, there's no use in my going aside from it now."

The earless boar. The Steward's son. His own half-brother, with a bond on him to kill Diarmuid, and a life no longer than Diarmuid's life. It had been waiting since before Diarmuid could walk.

The boar came up the face of the mountain then, with the Fianna after him.

Diarmuid loosed Mac an Chuill from his leash. That did not serve him. The hound did not wait for the boar, but ran from him.

"It's a pity not to follow the advice of a good woman," said Diarmuid. "Grania told me this morning to bring the Mor-alltach and the Gae Dearg with me."

Then he put his finger into the silken string of the Gae Buidhe, and took a straight aim at the boar, and hit him full in the face. The spear did not give him so much as a scratch.

Diarmuid was discouraged by that. But he drew the Beag-alltach and made a full stroke at the boar's back. That did not wound him either. It broke the sword in two.

The Yellow Spear, and the Little Fierce One. The lesser weapons. The Red Spear and the Great Fierce One were hanging on the wall at Rath Grania.

Then the boar made a brave charge at Diarmuid that cut the sod from under his feet and brought him down. But Diarmuid caught hold of the boar as he rose, and held on to him, with a leg on each side of him and his face to the boar's hindquarters. The boar went head-long down the hill, but could not rid himself of Diarmuid. He went on to Ess Ruadh, and when he came to the red stream he gave three high leaps over it, backwards and forwards, but he could not put Diarmuid off his back. And he went back by the same path until he was up on the height of the mountain again.

At last, on the top of the mountain, he freed himself, and Diarmuid fell on the ground. Then the boar made a rush at him and ripped him open, so that his bowels came out about his feet.

But Diarmuid, with the hilt of the broken sword still in his hand, made a cast at him that dashed out his brains, so that he fell dead there and then.

And Rath na h-Amhrann, the Rath of the Sword-Hilt, is the name of that place to this day.

Two brothers, on a mountain, dying of each other.

It was not long before Finn and the Fianna of Ireland came to the place, and the pains of death were coming on Diarmuid.

"I'm well pleased to see you that way, Diarmuid," said Finn. "And it's a pity all the women of Ireland aren't looking at you now. For your great beauty is turned to ugliness, and your comely shape to uncomeliness."

"For all that, you have the power to heal me, Finn," said Diarmuid, "if you had a mind to."

"How could I heal you?" said Finn.

"Easily enough," said Diarmuid. "When you were given the great gift of knowledge at the Boinn, you got this gift with it: that anyone you gave a drink to out of the palms of your hands would be young and well again from any sickness after it."

That is the rule of Finn's hands. Water carried in them heals. It is the one power in this whole story that could have ended it well.

"You don't deserve that drink from me," said Finn.

"That's not true," said Diarmuid. "It's well I deserve it from you. The time you went to the house of Dearc, son of Donnarthadh, with your chief men, for a feast, your enemies came round the house and gave three great shouts against you, and threw fire and firebrands into it. You got up and would have gone out. But I told you to stay there at your drinking and pleasure, for I'd go out myself and put them down. And I went out, and put out the flames, and made three red rushes round the house, and killed fifty in every rush, and came in again without a wound. And you were glad and merry and in good courage that night, Finn. If it was that night I'd asked you for a drink, you'd have given it. And it would be right for you to give it to me now."

"That's not so," said Finn. "It's badly you've earned a drink or any good thing from me. The night you went to Teamhair with me, you took Grania away from me in the presence of all the men of Ireland, and you my own guard over her that night."

"Don't blame me for that, Finn," said Diarmuid. "What did I ever do against you, east or west, but that one thing? And you know well Grania put bonds on me, and I wouldn't fail in my bonds for the gold of the whole world."

"And you'll know I've well earned a drink from you, if you bring to mind the night the feast was made in the House of the Quicken Tree, and how you and all your men were bound there until I heard of it, and came fighting and joyful, and loosed you with my own blood and with the blood of the Three Kings of the Island of the Floods. If I'd asked you for a drink that night, Finn, you wouldn't have refused it."

"And I was with you at the smiting of Lon, son of Liobhan. You're the man who should not forsake me beyond any other man. Many is the strait that has overtaken you and the Fianna of Ireland since I came among you, and I was ready every time to put my body and my life in danger for your sake. You ought not to do this unkindness on me now."

"And besides that, many a good champion has fallen through the things you yourself have done, and there's no end of them yet. Great misfortunes will soon come on the Fianna, and few of their seed will be left after them. And it's not for you I'm fretting, Finn, but for Oisín and Osgar and the rest of my dear comrades. And as for you, Oisín, you'll be left lamenting after the Fianna."

"You'll feel the want of me greatly yet, Finn. And if the women of the Fianna knew I was lying in my wounds on this ridge, their faces would be sorrowful at this time."

Then Osgar said: "Though I'm nearer in blood to you, Finn, than to Diarmuid, grandson of Duibhne, I won't let you refuse him this drink. And by my word, if any prince in the world did the same unkindness to Diarmuid that you've done, it's only whichever of us had the strongest hand would come away alive. Give him a drink now, without delay."

"I don't know of any well at all on this mountain," said Finn.

"That's not so," said Diarmuid. "There's not nine footsteps from you the well with the best fresh water that can be found in the world."

Then Finn went to the well and took the full of his two hands of the water.

But when he was no more than halfway back, the thought of Grania came on him, and he let the water slip through his hands. And he said he was not able to bring it.

"I give my word," said Diarmuid, "it was of your own will you let it go."

Then Finn went back a second time for the water. But coming back, at the thought of Grania, he let it through his hands again.

Diarmuid gave a pitiful sigh of anguish when he saw that.

"I swear by my sword and by my spear," said Osgar, "if you don't bring the water without any more delay, Finn, there won't leave this hill but you or me."

Finn went back a third time to the well, after what Osgar said, and brought the water to Diarmuid.

As he reached him, the life went out of Diarmuid's body.

Nine footsteps. Three times. He could have walked it in the time it takes to say so. And he walked it, in the end. And he was late.

Then the whole company of the Fianna who were there gave three great, heavy shouts, keening for Diarmuid.

Osgar looked very fiercely at Finn, and said it was a greater pity that Diarmuid was dead than if he himself had died, and that the Fianna of Ireland had lost their yoke of battle by him.

"Let's leave this hill," said Finn, "before Angus and the Tuatha de Danaan come on us. Though we have no share in the death of Diarmuid, he wouldn't believe the truth from us."

"I give my word," said Osgar, "if I'd thought it was against Diarmuid you made the hunt of Beinn Gulbain, you'd never have made it."

Then Finn and the Fianna went away from the hill, with Finn leading Diarmuid's hound, Mac an Chuill. But Oisín and Osgar and Caoilte and Lugaidh's Son turned back again and put their four cloaks over Diarmuid. Then they went after the rest of the Fianna.

When they came to the Rath, Grania was out on the wall looking for news of Diarmuid, and she saw Finn and the Fianna of Ireland coming towards her.

"If Diarmuid were living," she said, "it's not led by Finn that Mac an Chuill would be coming home."

She was heavy with child at that time. Her strength went from her, and she fell down from the wall.

When Oisín saw the state she was in, he told Finn and the others to go on and leave her. But she lifted up her head and asked Finn to leave Mac an Chuill with her. Finn said he would not. He said he did not think it too much, to inherit that from Diarmuid, grandson of Duibhne.

When Oisín heard that, he snatched the hound out of Finn's hand and gave it to Grania. Then he followed after his people.

When Grania was certain of Diarmuid's death she gave a long, very pitiful cry that was heard through the whole place. Her women and her people came to her and asked what ailed her, to give a cry like that. She told them how Diarmuid had come to his death by the Boar of Beinn Gulbain in the hunt Finn had made.

"And there's grief in my very heart," she said, "that I can't fight Finn myself. I wouldn't have let him leave this place safe."

When her people heard of Diarmuid's death they gave three great heavy cries in the same way, that were heard in the clouds and the waste places of the sky. Then Grania told the five hundred she had for her household to go to Beinn Gulbain for Diarmuid's body.

When they were bringing it back, she went out to meet them. They put down the body of Diarmuid, and this is what she said:

"I am your wife, beautiful Diarmuid, the man I would do no hurt to. It is sorrowful I am after you tonight.

"I am looking at the hawk and the hound my secret love used to hunt with. She that loved the three, let her be put in the grave with Diarmuid.

"Let us be glad tonight; let us make all welcome tonight; let us be open-handed tonight, since we are sitting by the body of a king.

"And O Diarmuid, it is a hard bed Finn has given you, lying on the stones and wet with the rain. O chone! your blue eyes to be without sight, you who were friendly and generous and pursuing. O love! O Diarmuid! it is a pity he sent you to your death.

"You were a champion of the men of Ireland, their prop in the middle of the fight; you were the head of every battle; your ways were glad and pleasant.

"It is sorrowful I am, without mirth, without light, only sadness and grief and long dying. Your harp used to be sweet to me; it wakened my heart to gladness. Now my courage is fallen down, not to hear you, but to be always remembering your ways. Och! my grief is going through me.

"A thousand curses on the day when Grania gave you her love, that put Finn of the princes out of his wits. It is a sorrowful story your death is today.

"Many heroes were great and strong about me in the beautiful plain; their hands were good at wrestling and at battle. O chone! that I did not follow them.

"You were the best man of the Fianna, beautiful Diarmuid, whom women loved. Dark is your dwelling-place under the sod; mournful and cold is your bed. Pleasant was your laugh today. You were my happiness, Diarmuid."

Then she went back into the Rath, and told her people to bring the body to her there.

Just then it was shown to Angus at Brugh na Boinne that Diarmuid was dead on Beinn Gulbain. For he had kept no watch over him the night before.

One night. In all those years, one night he did not watch.

He went on the cold wind towards Beinn Gulbain, and his people with him. On the way they met Grania's people, bringing the body to the Rath. When they saw him they held out the wrong sides of their shields as a sign of peace, and Angus knew them. And he and his people gave three great, terrible cries over the body of Diarmuid.

Then Angus spoke, and this is what he said:

"I was never one night, since the time I brought you to Brugh na Boinne when you were nine months old, without keeping watch and protection over you — until last night, Diarmuid, grandson of Duibhne. And now your blood has been shed, and you've been cut off sharply, and the Boar of Beinn Gulbain has put you down, Diarmuid of the bright face and the bright sword. And it's a pity Finn has done this treachery, and you at peace with him.

"Lift up his body now and bring it to the Brugh, in the lasting rocks. And if I can't bring him back to life, I'll put life into him so that he can be talking with me every day."

Then they put his body on a golden bier, with his spears over it, pointed upwards, and went on until they came to Brugh na Boinne.

A god can do that much. Not life. Talk. Every day, in the hill, for ever, a voice. It is not the same thing, and Angus knew it was not the same thing.

Grania's people went to her and told her that Angus would not let them bring the body into the Rath, but had carried it away himself to Brugh na Boinne. And Grania said she had no power over him.

Then she sent for her four sons, who were being reared in the district of Corca Ui Duibhne. When they came she gave them a loving welcome, and they came into the Rath and sat down there according to their age. Grania spoke to them in a very loud, clear voice.

"My dear children," she said, "your father has been killed by Finn, son of Cumhal, against his own bond and agreement of peace. Avenge it well on him. And here's your share of your father's inheritance: his weapons and his armour, and his feats of valour and of power. I'll share these weapons among you myself, and may they bring you victory in every battle.

"Here's the sword for Donnchadh, the best son Diarmuid had. And the Gae Dearg for Eochaidh. And here's the armour for Ollann, for it will keep the body it's put on in safety. And the shield for Connla. And make no delay now, but go and learn every kind of skill in fighting, until you come to your full strength to avenge your father."

So they took leave of her then, and of their household.

Some of their people said, "What must we do now, since our lords are going into danger against Finn and the Fianna of Ireland?"

Donnchadh, son of Diarmuid, told them to stay in their own places. "If we make peace with Finn," he said, "there need be no fear on you. And if not, you can make your choice between us and him."

And with that they set out on their journey.

But after a while Finn went, secretly and without the Fianna knowing, to the place where Grania was. He got to see her, in spite of all her high talk, and he spoke gently to her.

She would not listen to him. She told him to get out of her sight, and whatever hard thing her tongue could say, she said it.

But all the same, he went on giving her gentle talk and loving words. Until, in the end, he brought her round to his will.

This is the hardest part of the story to tell, and it is told plainly, so it will be told plainly here.

No news is told of them until they came to where the seven battalions of the Fianna were waiting for Finn. When the Fianna saw him coming, and Grania with him, like any new wife with her husband, they gave a great shout of laughter and of mockery. And Grania bowed down her head with shame.

"By my word, Finn," said Oisín, "you'll keep a good watch on Grania from now on."

Some said the change had come on her because the mind of a woman changes like the water of a running stream. And some said it was Finn who had put enchantment on her.

Nobody asked her. Nobody ever did, in this whole story, except once — her father, in the sunny house, at the very beginning. And she had told him the truth then, and nobody had listened.

As for the sons of Diarmuid, they came back at the end of seven years, after learning all that was to be learned of valour in the far countries of the world. When they came back to Rath Grania they were told their mother had gone away with Finn, son of Cumhal, without leaving any word for them or for the King of Ireland.

They said that if that was so, there was nothing for them to do. But after that they said they would attack Finn. They went forward to Almhuin, and would take no offers, but made a great slaughter of every troop that came out against them.

But at last Grania made an agreement of peace between them and Finn, and they got their father's place among the Fianna. It did them little good. They lost their lives with the rest in the battle of Gabhra.

As for Finn and Grania, they stayed with one another to the end.

Tailc, Son Of Treon



The Fianna were all gathered together once, doing feats and casting stones.

After a while the Druid of Teamhair, who was with them, said: "I'm afraid, Finn of the Fianna, that there's some trouble close at hand. Look at those dark clouds of blood threatening us, side by side, overhead. There's fear on me that some destruction is coming on the Fianna."

Finn looked up and saw the great cloud of blood, and he called Osgar to look at it.

"That needn't knock a start out of you," said Osgar, "with all the strength there is in your arms, and in the men who are with you."

Then all the Fianna looked up at the cloud. Some of them were glad and cheerful, and some were downhearted.

The Druid told Finn to call all his battalions together and divide them into two halves, so that they could be watching for the coming of the enemy.

So Finn sounded the Dord Fiann, and they answered with a shout, every man hurrying to be first. Finn told Osgar and Goll and Faolan to keep watch through the night. And he told Conan the Bald to stay in the darkness of the cave of Liath Ard. "For it's you can shout loudest," he said, "to warn us if you see the enemy coming."

"May I be pierced through the middle of my body," said Conan, "if I'll go watching for troubles or for armies alone, without some more of the Fianna with me."

"It's not fitting for you to refuse Finn," said Lugaidh's Son. "And it's you can shout loudest, if the enemies come near the height."

"Don't talk to me any more," said Conan. "I won't go there alone, for the length of my days, for Finn and the whole of the Fianna."

"Go, then, Conan," said Osgar, "and Aodh Beag will go with you, and you can bring dogs with you — Bran and Sceolan and Fuaim and Fearagan. Go now, and don't begrudge it."

So Conan went to Liath Ard, and Aodh Beag with him, and Finn's hounds.

As for Finn, he lay down to sleep. It was not long before he saw, through his sleep, Aodh Beag his son without his head. And after that he saw Goll fighting with a very strong man. He woke from his sleep and called the Druid of the Fianna to him and asked him the meaning of what he had seen.

"I'm afraid there's some destruction coming on the Fianna," said the Druid. "But Aodh Beag won't be wounded in the fight, nor Goll."

Dreams show you what you are afraid of. They are not always right about what will happen. The Druid knew the difference.

It was not long before Finn heard a great shout. He sounded the Dord Fiann, and then he saw Conan running, and the hounds after him. Finn sounded the Dord Fiann again before Conan came up. When he came, Osgar asked him where Aodh Beag was.

"He was at the door of the cave when I left it," said Conan, "but I haven't looked behind me since. It wasn't Aodh Beag was troubling me."

"What was troubling you, then?" said Osgar.

"Nothing troubles me but myself," said Conan. "Though I'm well pleased at any good that comes to you."

That may be the truest thing Conan ever said.

Osgar went running hard until he came to the cave. There he found Aodh Beag with no fear or trouble on him at all, staying there until he should hear the noise of the shields. Osgar brought him back to where the Fianna were. And they saw a great army coming, as if it were searching for them.

A beautiful woman in a crimson cloak came to them over the plain, and spoke to Finn, and her voice was as sweet as music. Finn asked her who she was and whom she had come

looking for.

"I'm the daughter of Garraidh, son of Dolar Dian, the Fierce," she said. "And my curse on the King of Greece, who bound me to the man who's following me, the man I'm fleeing from: Tailc, son of Treon."

"Tell me why you're shunning him," said Finn, "and I'll protect you in spite of him."

"It's not without reason I hate him," she said. "He has no good look about him. His skin is the colour of coal, and he has the head and the tail of a cat. I've walked the world three times, and I haven't left a king or a great man without asking help of him, and I never got it yet."

Three times round the world, asking. That is a long way to walk to find one man who will say yes.

"I'll give you protection," said Finn, "or the seven battalions of the Fianna will fall for your sake."

With that they saw the big strange man, Tailc, son of Treon, coming towards them. He said no word of greeting to Finn, but called for battle on account of his wife.

So a thousand of the Fianna went out to meet him and his men. They all fell, and not one of them came back.

Then another thousand of the best men of the Fianna, with blue and green shields, went out under Caoilte, son of Ronan. And they were worsted by Tailc and his people.

Then Osgar asked Finn's leave to go out and fight the big man.

"I'll give you leave," said Finn, "though I'm sure you'll fall by him."

So Osgar went out. He and Tailc, son of Treon, fought for the length of five days and five nights, without food or drink or sleep. And at the end of that time Osgar made an end of Tailc, and struck his head off.

When the Fianna saw that, they gave one shout of lamentation for those of the Fianna they had lost, and two shouts of joy for the death of Tailc.

As for the young woman, when she saw all the slaughter that had been done on her account, shame reddened her face, and she fell dead there and then.

To see her die like that, after all she had gone through, preyed on the Fianna more than any other thing.

She had got what she walked the world for. It was too much. Two thousand men had died for her in one day, and she had never asked for any of them by name.

Meargach's Wife



While the Fianna were still gathered on the hill where Tailc, son of Treon, had been put down, they saw a very great champion coming towards them, with an army behind him. He took no more notice of one man than another, but asked in a very rough voice where Finn, the Head of the Fianna, was.

Aodh Beag, who had a quiet heart, asked him who he was and what he had come for.

"I'll tell you nothing at all, child," said the big man. "Your years are short, and I'll tell nothing to anyone but Finn."

So Aodh Beag brought him to where Finn was, and Finn asked him his name.

"Meargach of the Green Spears is my name," he said. "Weapons were never reddened on my body yet, and no one ever boasted of driving me backwards. Was it you, Finn, who put down Tailc, son of Treon?"

"It wasn't by me he fell," said Finn, "but by Osgar of the Strong Hand."

"Wasn't it a great shame for you, Finn," said Meargach, "to let the queen-woman who had such a great name come to her death by the Fianna?"

"It wasn't by me or by any of the Fianna she got her death," said Finn. "It was seeing the army lost that brought her to her death. But if it's satisfaction for her death or for the death of Tailc you want, you can get it from a man of the Fianna. Or you can go quietly from this place."

Meargach said he would fight any man they brought against him, to avenge Tailc, son of Treon.

It was Osgar who stood up against him, and they fought a very hard fight for three days. At one point the Fianna thought Osgar was beaten, and they gave a great sorrowful shout. But in the end Osgar put Meargach down and struck his head off. At that the seven battalions

of the Fianna gave a shout of victory, and the army of Meargach keened him very sorrowfully.

After that the two sons of Meargach, Ciardan the Swift and Liagan the Nimble, came up and asked who would come against them hand to hand, so that they could get satisfaction for their father.

It was Goll who stood up against Ciardan, and it was not long before he put him down.

Conan came out against Liagan. Liagan mocked him. "It's foolishness, your coming, bald man!"

But Conan made a quick blow and struck his head off before the fight had even begun.

"That was a shameful thing to do," said Faolan, "not to stand your ground and make a fair fight."

"If I could make an end of the whole army with one blow," said Conan, "I'd do it, and I wouldn't be ashamed, and the whole of the Fianna couldn't shelter them from me."

So much for fair fights. Conan never pretended to believe in them.

Then the two armies came towards each other and made ready for the attack. And they saw a beautiful golden-haired woman coming towards them, crying and crying. The battle was put off on both sides while they waited for her to come. The army of Meargach knew it was their queen, Ailne of the Bright Face, and they raised a great cry of grief. And the Fianna watched her, and said no word.

She asked where her husband was, and where her two sons were.

"High Queen," said Finn, "for all they were so complete and quick and strong, the three you're asking for fell in the fight."

When the queen-woman heard that she cried out aloud. She went to the place where her husband and her two sons were lying and stood over their bodies, with her golden hair hanging, and keened them there. Her own people raised a sharp lamentation, listening to her, and the Fianna themselves were in grief.

This is what she said:

"O Meargach of the sharp green spears, many a fight and many a heavy battle your hard hand fought, in the gathering of the armies or alone.

"I never knew any wound to be on your body after them; and I am full sure it was not strength but treachery got the upper hand of you now.

"Long was your journey from far off, from your own kind country to Inisfail, to come to Finn and the Fianna, who put my three to death through treachery.

"My grief! to have lost my husband, my head, by the treachery of the Fianna; my two sons, my two men that were rough in the fight.

"My grief! my food and my drink; my grief! my teaching everywhere; my grief! my journey from far off, and I to have lost my high heroes.

"My grief! my house thrown down; my grief! my shelter and my shield; my grief! Meargach and Ciardan; my grief! Liagan of the wide chest.

"My grief! my protection and my shelter; my grief! my strength and my power; my grief! there is darkness come from this thing; my grief tonight that you are in your weakness.

"My grief! my gladness and my pleasure; my grief! my desire in every place; my grief! my courage is gone and my strength; my grief from this night out for ever.

"My grief! my guide and my going; my grief! my desire to the day of my death; my grief! my store and my sway; my grief! my heroes that were open-handed.

"My grief! my bed and my sleep; my grief! my journey and my coming; my grief! my teacher and my share; my sorrowful grief! my three men.

"My grief! my beauty and my ornaments; my grief! my jewels and my riches; my grief! my treasures and my goods; my grief! my three Candles of Valour.

"My grief! my friends and my kindred; my grief! my people and my friends; my grief! my father and my mother; my grief and my trouble, that you are dead.

"My grief! my portion and my welcome; my grief! my health at every time; my grief! my increase and my light; my sore trouble, that you are without strength.

"My grief! your spear and your sword; my grief! your gentleness and your love; my grief! your country and your home; my grief! that you are parted from my reach.

"My grief! my coasts and my harbours; my grief! my wealth and my prosperity; my grief! my greatness and my kingdom; my grief and my crying are until death.

"My grief! my luck altogether; my grief for you in time of battle; my grief! my gathering of armies; my grief! my three proud lions.

"My grief! my games and my drinking; my grief! my music and my delight; my grief! my sunny house and my women; my crying grief, that you are under defeat.

"My grief! my lands and my hunting; my grief! my three sure fighters; och, my grief! they are my sorrow, to fall far off by the Fianna.

"I knew by the great host of the Sidhe that were fighting over the dun, giving battle to one another in the valleys of the air, that destruction would put down my three.

"I knew by the noise of the voices of the Sidhe coming into my ears that a story of new sorrow was not far from me. It was your death it was foretelling.

"I knew at the beginning of the day when my three good men went from me, when I saw tears of blood on their cheeks, that they would not come back to me as winners.

"I knew by the voice of the battle-crow over your dun every evening, since you went from me comely and terrible, that misfortune and grief were at hand.

"Well I remember, my three strong ones, how often I told you that if you went to Ireland, I would not see the joy of victory on your faces.

"I knew by the voice of the raven every morning since you went from me that your fall was sure and certain; that you would never come back to your own country.

"I knew, my three great ones, by your forgetting the thongs of your hounds, that you would not win the day, or escape from the treachery of the Fianna.

"I knew, Candles of Valour, by the stream near the dun turning to blood when you set out, that there would be treachery in Finn.

"I knew by the eagle coming every evening over the dun that it would not be long till I heard a story of bad news of my three.

"I knew by the withering of the tree before the dun that you would never come back as conquerors from the treachery of Finn, son of Cumhal."

She had known. Every sign. She had told them. They had gone anyway, the way men in stories always go.

When Grania heard what the woman was saying, there was anger on her.

"Don't speak against Finn or the Fianna, Queen," she said. "It wasn't by any treachery or any deceit your three men were brought to their end."

Grania. Defending Finn. You may make of that whatever you like; the story does not help you.

But Ailne made her no answer and paid her no heed, but went on with her lament, crying and crying.

"I knew, looking after you the day you went out from the dun, by the flight of the raven before you, there was no good sign of your coming back again.

"I knew by Ciardan's hounds, howling mournfully every evening, that it would not be long till I had bad news of you.

"I knew by my sleep that went from me, by my tears through every lasting night, that there was no luck ahead of you.

"I knew by the sorrowful vision that showed me myself in danger, my head and my hands cut off, that it was you who were without power.

"I knew by the voice of Uaithnin, the hound that is dearest to Liagan, howling early every morning, that death was certain for my three.

"I knew when I saw in a vision a lake of blood in the place of the dun, that my three were put down by the deceit that was always with Finn."

"Don't be faulting Finn," said Grania, "however vexed your heart is. Leave off speaking against the Fianna and against him. If your men had stayed in their own country without coming to avenge the son of Treon, no harm would have happened to them."

"I wouldn't put any reproach on the Fianna, Grania," said Ailne, "if my three men had been put down in fair battle. But they're not living to bear witness to me. And it's likely they were put under Druid spells first, or they'd never have given in."

"If they were living, Queen," said Grania, "they wouldn't be running down the Fianna. They'd tell you it was by bravery and the strong hand they fell."

"I don't believe you or the Fianna when you say that," said Ailne. "No one who came to meet them ever got the better of them by right of the sword."

"If you don't believe what I'm saying, beautiful Ailne," said Grania, "I tell you more of your great army will fall by the Fianna, and not by treachery."

"That's not so," said Ailne. "I have good hopes my own army will do destruction on the Fianna, for the sake of the men who are dead."

"Well, Ailne," said Grania, "I know it's a far journey you've come. Come now and eat and drink with me and with the Fianna."

Two women, both widowed by the Fianna, one way or another. One of them was offering the other supper.

But Ailne would not do it. She said it would not be fitting for her to take food from people who did such deeds, and what she wanted was satisfaction for the death of her husband and her two sons.

First it was settled that two men from each side should go out against each other. Then Ailne said there should be thirty men on each side. Then she said she would not be satisfied to go back to her own country until she brought Finn's head with her, or until the last of his men had fallen.

In the end a great battle was fought, and the Fianna seldom fought so hard a battle as that.

It would take too long to tell, and it would tire the hearers, how many good men were killed on each side. But in the end Ailne of the Bright Face was beaten. She went back with those of her men who were left to their own country, and nobody knew where they went.

And the hill in the west where those battles were fought got the name of Cnoc-an-Air, the Hill of Slaughter.



Book Nine: The Wearing Away Of The Fianna



Ailne's Revenge



One day Finn and his people were hunting on Slieve Fuad. A stag stood against them for a while and fought them with his great rough horns, and then he turned and ran, and the Fianna followed him until they came to the green hill of Liadhas, and from there to rocky Cairgin. They lost him there for a while, until Sceolan started him again, and he went back towards Slieve Fuad with the Fianna after him.

But Finn and Daire of the Songs, who were together, went astray and lost the rest of their people. They did not know whether they were going east or west.

Finn sounded the Dord Fiann, and Daire played some sorrowful music to let their people know where they were. But when the Fianna heard the music, it seemed a long way off. Sometimes they thought it was in the north, and sometimes in the east, and then it moved to the west, so that they did not know where in the wide world it was coming from.

As for Finn and Daire, a Druid mist came around them, and they did not know which way they were going.

After a while they met a young woman, comely and pleasant, and asked her who she was and what had brought her there.

"Glanluadh is my name," she said, "and my husband is Lobharan. We were travelling over the plain together a while ago, and we heard the cry of hounds, and he left me and went after the hunt. I don't know where he is, or which way he went."

"Come on with us, then," said Finn, "and we'll take care of you. We don't know ourselves which way the hunt has gone, east or west."

So they went on, and before long they came to a hill, and heard sleepy music of the Sidhe beside them. After that there came shouts and noises, and then the music began again, and a heavy sleep came on Finn and Daire.

When they woke from their sleep they saw a very large lighted house in front of them, with a stormy blue sea all around it. Then they saw a very big grey man coming through the waves. He took hold of Finn and of Daire, and all their strength went out of them. He carried them across the waves and into the house, and shut the door of the house with iron hooks.

"My welcome to you, Finn of the great name," he said, in a very harsh voice. "We've been waiting here a long time for you."

They sat down on the hard side of a bed. The woman of the house came to them, and they knew her. It was Ailne, the wife of Meargach.

"I've been looking for you a long time, Finn," she said, "to get satisfaction for the treachery you did on Meargach and on my two comely young sons, and on Tailc, son of Treon, and all his people. Do you remember that, Finn?"

"I remember well," said Finn, "that they fell by the swords of the Fianna. Not by treachery, but in fighting."

"It was by treachery they fell," said the Grey Man. "And our witness to it is pleasant Ailne being the way she is, and many a strong army in grief on her account."

"What is Ailne to you, man of the rough voice?" said Finn.

"I'm her own brother," said the man.

With that he put bonds on the three of them, Finn and Daire and Glanluadh, and put them down in some deep, shut place.

They were very sorrowful then. They stayed there five days and five nights, without food, without drink, without music.

Without music. For Daire, that was the worst of it.

Then Ailne went to see them.

"O Ailne," said Finn, "remember the time you came to Cnoc-an-Air, and the way the Fianna treated you with generosity. It isn't fitting for you to keep us now in shame and weakness

and in danger of death."

"I know well I got kind treatment from Grania," said Ailne, in a sorrowful voice. "But for all that, Finn, if all the Fianna were in that prison with you under hard bonds, it would please me well, and I wouldn't pity them."

Then she said to Glanluadh: "And what set you following after Finn? That's not a fitting thing for you to do, and his own kind wife still living."

Then Glanluadh told her the whole story: how she had been walking the plain with Lobharan her husband, and he had followed the hunt, and the mist had come around her so that she did not know east from west, and how she had met Finn then, whom she had never seen before.

"If that's so," said Ailne, "it isn't right for you to be under punishment without cause."

She called her brother the Grey Man and told him to take the spells off Glanluadh. When Glanluadh was set free, she was sorry to leave Daire and Finn in bonds. When she had said goodbye to them she went out with Ailne. Food was brought to her, but a cloud of weakness came on her suddenly, so that it was a pity to see the state she was in.

When Ailne saw that, she brought out an enchanted cup of the Sidhe and gave her a drink from it. No sooner had Glanluadh drunk from the cup than her strength and her own looks came back to her. But all the same, she was fretting after Finn and Daire in their bonds.

"It seems to me, Glanluadh, you're fretting after those two men," said Ailne.

"I'm sorry indeed," said Glanluadh, "that the like of those men should be shut up without food or drink."

"If it pleases you to give them food, you may give it," said Ailne. "I won't make an end of them until I see whether I can get the rest of the Fianna into bonds along with them."

So the two women brought food and drink to Finn and to Daire. Glanluadh gave Finn her blessing, and she cried when she saw the way he was. But as for Ailne, she had no pity at all for the King of the Fianna.

As for the Grey Man, he heard them talking about the Fianna, and saying that Daire had a great name for the sweetness of his music.

"I have a mind to hear that sweet music," he said.

So he went to the place where they were, and told Daire to let him hear what kind of music he could make.

"My music pleased the Fianna well," said Daire. "But I think it likely it wouldn't please you."

"Play it for me now," said the Grey Man, "so I'll know whether the report I heard of you is true."

"Indeed, I have no mind for music," said Daire, "weak and downhearted as I am through your spells that have put down my courage."

"I'll take my spells off you for as long as you play for me," said the Grey Man.

"I could never make music seeing Finn in bonds the way he is," said Daire. "It's worse to me that he's in trouble than that I am."

"I'll take the power of my spells off Finn while you play for me," said the Grey Man.

That is Daire. A harper who will not play while his lord is bound. Remember him when you think of what loyalty sounds like.

So the Grey Man weakened the spells and gave them food and drink. It pleased him greatly, the way Daire played, and he called Glanluadh and Ailne to come and listen to the sweetness of it. They were well pleased with it. And Glanluadh was glad to see the two of them not as discouraged as they had been.

As for the Fianna, they were searching for Finn and Daire in every place they had ever stayed. When they came to this place they could hear Daire's sweet music. At first they were glad when they heard it. Then, when they knew the state he and Finn were in, they attacked Ailne's dun to free them.

But the Grey Man heard their shouts, and he put the full power of his spells on Finn and Daire again. The Fianna heard the music begin to stammer, and then they heard a great noise like the loud roaring of waves. And when they heard that, there was not one of them who did not fall into sleep and the clouds of death, under those sorrowful spells.

Then the Grey Man and Ailne came out quietly from where they were, and brought all the men of the Fianna who were there into the dun. They put hard bonds on them and put them where Finn and Daire were. There was great grief on Finn and Daire when they saw them. And they were all left there together for a while.

Then Glanluadh said to the Grey Man: "If Daire's music pleases you, let him play it to us now."

"If you have a mind for music," said the Grey Man, "Daire must play it for us, and for Finn and his army as well."

So they went to where the prisoners were and told Daire to play.

"I could never play sweet music," said Daire, "at a time when the Fianna are in any trouble. For when they're in trouble I'm in trouble myself, and I couldn't sound any sweet string while there's trouble on any man of them."

The Grey Man weakened the spells on them all then. Daire played first the strings of sweetness, and of the noise of shouting; and then he sang his own grief and the grief of all the Fianna. At that the Grey Man said it would not be long before he put the whole of the Fianna to death. Then Daire played a tune of heavy shouts of lamentation. And then, at Finn's bidding, he played the music of sweet strings for the Fianna.

They were kept a long time in that prison, and got very hard treatment. Sometimes Ailne's brother would come in and strike the heads off some of them, for none of them could rise from the seats they were sitting on, through his enchantments.

But once, when he was going to strike off Conan's bald head, Conan made a great leap from the seat. And he left strips of his skin stuck to it, so that his back was left bare.

Then he came round the Grey Man with pitiful words.

"Stop your hand now," he said, "for that's enough for this time. Don't send me to my death yet awhile. Heal me of my wounds first, before you make an end of me."

The reason he said that was that he knew Ailne had an enchanted cup in the dun, the one that had cured Glanluadh.

Conan the bald, Conan the bitter, Conan who never said a good word of any man. He was the one who was thinking.

The Grey Man took pity on him, and brought him out and told Ailne to bring the cup and cure his wounds.

"I won't bring it," said Ailne. "It would be best to give no time at all to him or to the Fianna, but to make an end of them."

"It's not to be saved from death I'm asking, bright-faced Ailne," said Conan, "but only not to go to my death stripped bare the way I am."

When Ailne heard that, she brought a sheepskin and put it on Conan's back. It fitted, and grew to him, and covered his wounds.

"I won't put you to death, Conan," said the Grey Man then. "You can stay with me to the end of your life."

"You'll never be without grief and danger and fear of treachery if you keep him with you," said Ailne. "There's treachery in his heart, the same as in the rest of them."

"There's no fear of that," said her brother. "Or if there is, I'll make no delay in putting the whole of the Fianna to death."

With that he brought Conan to where the enchanted cup was, and put it in his hand.

Just at that moment they heard Daire playing very sweet, sorrowful music, and the Grey Man went to listen to it, very quick and proud. Conan followed him there. After a while the Grey Man asked him what he had done with the enchanted cup.

"I left it where I found it, full of power," said Conan.

The Grey Man hurried back to the place where the treasures of the dun were kept. No sooner was he gone than Conan took out the cup, which he had hidden, and gave a drink from it to Finn and to Osgar and to the rest of the Fianna. And they, who had been withered and shaking, without strength and without courage, got back their own looks and their strength that same moment.

When the Grey Man came back from looking for the cup and saw what had happened, he took his sword and struck at Conan. But Conan called on Osgar to defend him. Osgar attacked the Grey Man, and it was not long before he made him acquainted with death.

When Ailne saw that, with the grief and the dread that came on her, she fell dead there and then.

She had lost a husband, and two sons, and now a brother, all to the Fianna. The story calls it her revenge. It was mostly more grief.

Then all the Fianna made a feast of the food and drink they found, and they were very joyful and merry. But when they got up in the morning there was no trace or tidings of the dun. They were lying on the bare grass.

As for Conan, the sheepskin never came off him. And the wool used to grow on it every year, the same as on any other sheep.

The Quarrel With The Sons Of Morna



Once, when the Fianna had gone off here and there hunting, Black Garraidh and Caoilte were sitting beside Finn, and they were talking about the battle in which Finn's father was killed.

"Tell me now," Finn said to Garraidh, "since you were there yourself: how was it you brought my father Cumhal to his death?"

"I'll tell you that, since you ask me," said Garraidh. "It was my own hand, and the hands of the rest of the sons of Morna, that made an end of him."

"That's cold friendship from my followers the sons of Morna," said Finn.

"If it's cold friendship," said Garraidh, "put away the liking you pretend to have for us, and show us the hatred you have for us all the while."

For forty years they had all known it. Nobody had said it out loud. Now somebody had.

"If I were to lift my hand against you now, sons of Morna," said Finn, "I'd be well able for you all without any man's help."

"It was by his arts Cumhal got the upper hand of us," said Garraidh. "And when he had power over us, he banished us to every far country. A share of us he sent to Alban, and a share to dark Lochlann, and a share to bright Greece, parting us from one another. For sixteen years we were away from Ireland, and it was no small thing to us to go all that time without seeing one another.

"And the first day we came back to Ireland we killed sixteen hundred men — and no lie in it — and not a man of them but would be keened by a hundred. We took their duns after that, and went on until we were all around one house in Munster with red walls. So great was the bravery of the man in that house, your father, that it was easier to find him than to kill him. We killed everyone of his race out on the hill, and then we made a quick rush at the

house where Cumhal was, and every man of us made a wound on his body with his spear. I was there myself. It was I gave him the first wound.

"Avenge it on me now, Finn, if you have a mind to."

Finn did not. Not that day.

* * * * *

It was not long after that that Finn gave a feast at Almhuin for all his chief men. Two sons of the King of Alban came to it, and sons of the kings of the great world. When they were all sitting at the feast, the serving-men rose and took drinking-horns worked by skilled men, with shining stones in them, and poured out strong drink for the champions. Then mirth rose in their young men, and courage in their fighting men, and kindness and gentleness in their women, and knowledge and foreknowledge in their poets.

Then a crier rose and shook a rough iron chain to silence the clowns and the common lads and the idlers. Then he shook a chain of old silver to silence the high lords and the chief men of the Fianna, and the learned men. And they all listened and were silent.

Fergus of the True Lips rose and sang before Finn the songs and the good poems of his forefathers, and Finn and Oisín and Lugaidh's Son rewarded him with every good thing. Then he went on to Goll, son of Morna, and told the fights and the destructions and the cattle-drivings and the courtings of his fathers. And the sons of Morna were well pleased and high-minded, listening to that.

Then Goll said: "Where's my woman-messenger?"

"I'm here, King of the Fianna," she said.

King of the Fianna. She called Goll that, in Finn's own hall.

"Have you brought me my hand-tribute from the men of Lochlann?"

"I've brought it surely," she said.

With that she rose up and laid on the floor of the hall in front of Goll a load of pure gold the size of a good pig, that would be a heavy load for a strong man. Goll loosened the covering

that was about it, and gave Fergus a good reward out of it, as he always did. For there never was a wise, sharp-worded poet, or a sweet harp-player, or any learned man of Ireland or of Alban, but Goll would give him gold or silver or some good thing.

When Finn saw that, he said: "How long, Goll, have you had this rent on the men of Lochlann — and my own rent on them always along with it, and one of my own men, Ciaran, son of Latharne, and ten hundred men of his household, guarding it and guarding my right of hunting?"

Goll saw there was anger on Finn.

"It's a long time, Finn, I've had that rent on the men of Lochlann," he said. "From the time your father put war and quarrels on me, and the King of Ireland joined him, and I was made to leave Ireland by them. I went into Britain, and took the country, and killed the king himself and did destruction on his people. But Cumhal put me out of it. From there I went to Fionnlochlann, and the king fell by me, and his household. And Cumhal put me out of it. From there I went to the country of the Saxons, and the king and his household fell by me. And Cumhal put me out of it.

"But then I came back to Ireland, and fought a battle against your father, and he fell by me there. It was at that time I put this rent on the men of Lochlann.

"And, Finn, it's not a rent of the strong hand you've put on them, but a tribute for having the protection of the Fianna of Ireland, and I don't lessen that. And you needn't begrudge me that tribute. If I had more than that again, it's to you and to the men of Ireland I'd give it."

Great anger came on Finn.

"You tell me yourself, Goll, by your own story," he said, "that you came from the city of Beirbhe to fight against my father, and that you killed him in the battle. It's a bold thing for you to tell that to me."

"By your own hand," said Goll, "if you gave me the same treatment your father gave me, I'd pay you back the same way as I paid him."

"It would be hard for you to do that," said Finn. "There are a hundred men in my household for every man in yours."

"That was the same with your father," said Goll. "And I avenged my disgrace on him. And I'd do the same on you, if you earned it."

Then Cairell of the White Skin, son of Finn, said: "It's many a man of Finn's household you've put down, Goll!"

When Bald Conan heard that, he said: "I swear by my weapons, Goll was never without a hundred men in his household, every one of them able to get the better of you."

"And is it to them you belong, crooked-speaking, bare-headed Conan?" said Cairell.

"It's to them I belong, you black, feeble, nail-scratching, rough-skinned Cairell. And I'll make you know it was Finn was in the wrong," said Conan.

With that Cairell got up and gave Conan a furious blow of his fist. Conan took it with no great patience, but gave him back a blow in the teeth. From that they went on to worse blows. The two sons of Goll got up to help Conan, and Osgar went to the help of Cairell. It was not long before many of the chief men of the Fianna were fighting on one side or the other, on the side of Finn or on the side of the sons of Morna.

Then Fergus of the True Lips rose, and the rest of the poets of the Fianna with him, and they sang their songs and their poems to check them and quiet them. At the sound of the poets' songs the men left off their fighting and let their weapons fall on the floor. The poets gathered the weapons up and made peace between the fighters. And they put bonds on Finn and on Goll to keep the peace for a while, until they could ask for a judgment from the High King of Ireland.

That was the end, for that time, of the little quarrel at Almhuin.

It is called little. It was the beginning of the end of everything.

But it broke out again. Once there was a falling-out between Finn and Goll over the dividing of a pig of the pigs of Manannan. At Daire Tardha, the Oak Wood of Bulls, in the province of Connacht, there was a great fight between Finn's men and the sons of Morna. The

sons of Morna were worsted, and fifteen of their men were killed. And they made up their minds that from that time on they would set themselves against any friends of Finn or of his people. It was Conan the Bald who gave them that advice, for he was always bitter, and a maker of quarrels and mischief in every place.

They kept their word, and spared no one.

There was a yellow-haired queen Finn loved. Berach Brec was her name. She was wise and comely and worthy of any good man. Her house was full of treasures, and she never refused anyone who asked. Anyone who came to her house at Samhain could stay until Beltaine, and have his choice then to go or to stay.

The sons of Morna had fostered her. They went to her and told her to give up Finn, and then she need have no fear of them. She said she would not give up her kind lover to please them. She was going away from them to her ship, and Art, son of Morna, threw his spear, and it went through her body, and she died. Her people carried her up from the strand and buried her.

Their own foster-child. That is how far it had gone.

As for Goll, he took a little hound that Finn thought a great deal of — Conbeg was its name — and drowned it in the sea. A wave brought its body up on shore afterwards, and the Fianna buried it under a little green hill. Caoilte made a lament over it. He said how swift the little hound had been after deer or wild pigs, and how good at killing them, and that it was a pity it had died out on the cold green waves.

Goll. Who was kind and gentle and open-handed. Who drowned a little dog.

About that time nine women of the Tuatha de Danaan came to meet nine men of the Fianna, and the sons of Morna saw them coming and made an end of them.

When Caoilte met Goll, he threw his spear at him, and it struck the golden helmet off his head and a piece of his flesh with it. But Goll took it very proudly. He put the helmet on again, and took up his weapons, and called out to his brothers that he was in no way ashamed.

Finn went looking for the sons of Morna everywhere, to take vengeance on them. Once they were doing robbery and destruction on Slieve Echtge, which got its name from Echtge, daughter of Nuada of the Silver Hand. Finn and the Fianna were to the west, at Slieve Cairn in the district of Corcomruadh. Finn was not sure whether the sons of Morna had gone south into Munster or north into Connacht. So he sent Aedan and Cahal, two sons of the King of Ulster, with two hundred fighting men, into the beautiful, pleasant province of Connacht, and every day they went looking for the sons of Morna from place to place.

After a while the three battalions of the Fianna who were in Corcomruadh saw the track of a troop of men, and thought it was the track of the sons of Morna. They closed round them at night and made an end of them all.

When the full light came the next morning, they knew them. It was their own people, who had been with the King of Ulster's sons.

They gave three great heavy cries, keening the friends they had killed by mistake.

Caoilte and Oisín went to Rath Medba and brought a great stone and put it over the king's sons, and it was called Lia an Imracail, the Stone of the Mistake.

And the place where Goll took his men when he parted from Finn in anger got the name of Druimscarha, the Parting Hill of Heroes.

When the Fianna began killing each other in the dark, it was not a quarrel any longer. It was an ending.

Death Of Goll



At last it happened that Goll and Cairell, son of Finn, met each other and said sharp words. They fought in the sea near the strand, and Cairell got his death by Goll.

There was great anger and great grief on Finn, seeing his son, who had been so strong and comely, lying dead and grey, like a blighted branch.

Goll had killed the father. Now he had killed the son.

As for Goll, he went away to a cave on a point of land stretching out into the sea. He meant to stay there until Finn's anger had passed.

Osgar knew where he was, and went to see him, who had been his comrade in so many battles. But Goll thought he was coming as an enemy, and threw his spear at him. Osgar got no wound from it, but it struck his shield and crushed it.

Finn noticed the state of the shield. And when he knew that Goll had thrown at Osgar, his anger grew greater again. He sent out his men and told them to watch every path and every gap that led to the cave where Goll was, so that they could make an end of him.

When Goll knew that Finn was watching for his life like that, he made no attempt to escape. He stayed where he was, without food, without drink, blinded by the sand that was blowing into his eyes.

His wife came to a rock where she could speak with him, and called to him to come to her.

"Come over to me," she said. "It's a pity for you to be blinded where you are, on the rocks of the waste sea, with no drink but the salt water — a man who was first in every fight. Come now and sleep beside me. Instead of the hard sea-water I'll nourish you from my own breast, and it's I will do your healing. The gold of your hair is my desire for ever. Don't stay there withering like an herb in the wintertime, and my heart black with grief inside me."

But Goll would not leave the spot where he was, for all she could say.

"It's best as it is," he said. "I never took the advice of a woman, east or west, and I never will. And O sweet-voiced queen, what ails you to be fretting after me? Remember your silver and your gold, and your silks and stuffs. Remember the seven hounds I gave you at Cruadh Ceirrge, and not one of them slack until he's killed the deer. And don't be crying tears after me, queen of the white hands. Remember your constant lover, Aodh, the son of the best woman in the world, who came out of Spain asking for you, and whom I fought at Corcar-an-Deirg. Go to him now. It's bad when a woman is in want of a good man."

He was dying of hunger on a rock, blind, and he was arranging for her to be looked after. That is the whole of Goll, in one speech.

He lay down on the rocks, and at the end of twelve days he died.

His wife keened him there, and made a great lamentation for her husband who had such a great name, who was the second best of the Fianna of Ireland.

When Conan heard of the death of Goll his brother, great anger came on him. He went to Garraidh and asked him to go with him to Finn, to demand satisfaction for Goll.

"I'm not willing to go," said Garraidh, "since we could get no satisfaction for the great son of Morna."

"Whether you've a mind to go or not, I'll go," said Conan. "And I'll make an end of every man I meet, for the sake of yellow-haired Goll. I'll have the life of Oisin, Finn's great son, and of Osgar and of Caoilte and of Daire of the Songs. I'll have no forgiveness for them. We must show no respect for Finn, though we may die in the fight, with no help from Goll. Let's take that work in hand and make no delay. For if Finn is there, his strength will be there, until we put him under his flagstone."

But it is not likely Garraidh went with him, after he had spoken such foolish words.

What happened to Conan in the end is not known.

But there is a cairn of stones on a hill of Burren, near Corcomruadh, and the people of Connacht say it is there he is buried. And they say a stone was found there once with these words on it in the old writing: "Conan the swift-footed, the bare-footed."

But the Munster people say it is on their own side of Burren he is buried.

Nobody could agree about Conan while he lived. It is fitting that they cannot agree about him now.



Book Ten: The End Of The Fianna



The Battle Of Gabhra



With one thing and another, the High King of Ireland had grown somehow bitter against Finn and the Fianna.

Once, when he was holding a gathering of his people, he spoke out to them. He told them to remember all the harm that had been done them through the Fianna, and all their pride, and the tribute they asked.

"And as for me," he said, "I'd sooner die fighting the Fianna, if I could bring them down along with me, than live with Ireland under them the way it is now."

All his people were of the same mind. They said they would make no delay, but attack the Fianna and make an end of them. "And we'll have good days of joy and feasting," they said, "once Almhuin is clear of them."

The High King began to make plans against Finn, and sent to all the men of Ireland to come and help him. When everything was ready, he sent for Osgar to come to a feast he was making at Teamhair.

Osgar, who was never afraid before any enemy, set out for Teamhair with three hundred of his men.

On the way they saw a woman of the Sidhe washing clothes at a river, and there was the colour of blood on the water where she washed them.

"There's red on the clothes you're washing," Osgar said to her, "and it's for the dead you're washing them."

And the woman answered him. "It won't be long," she said, "until the ravens are croaking over your own head after the battle."

That is what she does, the Washer at the Ford. She washes the clothes of the ones who are about to die. You do not get to see her twice.

"Is there any weakness in our eyes," said Osgar, "that a little story like that would set us crying? Do another foretelling for us now. Tell us, will any man of our enemies fall by us before we ourselves are made an end of?"

"Nine hundred will fall by you yourself," she said. "And the High King himself will get his death-wound from you."

Osgar and his men went on to the king's house at Teamhair. They were well treated, and the feast was made ready, and they were three days at pleasure and drinking.

On the last day of the drinking the High King called out in a loud voice and asked Osgar whether he would exchange spears with him.

"Why do you ask for that exchange," said Osgar, "when I and my spear were often with you in time of battle? You wouldn't ask it of me if Finn and the Fianna were with me now."

"I'd ask it of any fighting man among you," said the king, "and rent and tribute along with it."

"Any gold or any treasure you might ask of us, we'd give you," said Osgar. "But it isn't right for you to ask for my spear."

There were very high words between them then, and they threatened one another. At last the High King said: "I'll put my spear of the seven spells out through your body."

"And I give you my word against that," said Osgar. "I'll put my spear of the nine spells between the meeting of your hair and your beard."

Two promises, made across a feasting-table. Both of them would be kept.

With that Osgar and his men got up and left Teamhair. They stopped to rest beside a river, and there they heard the sound of a very sorrowful tune, like keening, played on a harp. A great anger came on Osgar when he heard it. He got up and took his weapons and roused his people, and they went on again to where Finn was.

A messenger came after them from the High King. The message he brought was this: that the king would never pay tribute to the Fianna, or put up with them at all, from that time

on.

When Finn heard that, he sent a challenge of battle, and gathered together all the Fianna he had left. But as for the sons of Morna, it was to the High King of Ireland they gathered.

It was at the hill of Gabhra that the two armies met. There were twenty men with the King of Ireland for every man with Finn.

It was a very hard battle that was fought that day, and there were great deeds done on both sides. There never was a greater battle fought in Ireland than that one.

As for Osgar, it would be hard to tell all he killed that day: five score of the Sons of the Gael, and five score fighting men from the Country of Snow, and seven score of the Men of Green Swords, who never took a step backward, and four hundred from the Country of the Lion, and five score of the sons of kings. And the shame of it was on the King of Ireland.

But as for Osgar himself, who began the day so swift and so strong, at the last he was like leaves on a strong wind, or like an aspen-tree that is falling.

Then he saw the High King near him, and he made for him like a wave breaking on the strand. The king saw him coming, and shook his greedy spear, and threw it. It went through Osgar's body and brought him down on his right knee. And that was the first grief of the Fianna.

The spear of the seven spells, out through his body. As promised.

But Osgar was in no way daunted. He threw his spear of the nine spells, and it went into the High King at the meeting of the hair and the beard, and gave him his death.

As promised.

When the men nearest the High King saw that, they put the king's helmet up on a pillar, so that his people would think he was still living. But Osgar saw it. He lifted a thin bit of slab-stone that was lying on the ground beside him and threw it, and it broke the helmet where it stood.

And then he fell himself, like a king.

The seven sons of Caoilte fell in that battle, and the son of the King of Lochlann who had come to help them. It would be hard to count the number of the Fianna who fell in that battle.

When it was over, those who were left went looking for their dead. Caoilte stooped over his seven brave sons, and every living man of the Fianna stooped over his own dear friends. It was a lasting grief to see all those who were stretched in that place. But the Fianna would not have taken it to heart the way they did, except that they were what they had become: a beaten race.

They had never lost before. That was the thing. Men die in every battle. It is losing that you do not recover from.

As for Oisín, he went looking for Osgar. This is how he found him: lying stretched out, resting on his left arm, with his broken shield beside him, and his sword still in his hand, and his blood around him on every side.

Osgar put out his hand to Oisín. Oisín took it, and gave out a very hard cry.

"I'm glad to see you safe, my father," said Osgar.

Oisín had no answer to give him.

Just then Caoilte came to where they were, and looked at Osgar.

"How are you now, my darling?" he said.

"The way you'd like me to be," said Osgar.

Then Caoilte searched the wound. When he saw how the spear had torn its way through to the back, he cried out, and a cloud came over him, and his strength failed him.

"O Osgar," he said, "you're parted from the Fianna. And they must be parted from battle from now on, and pay their tribute to the King of Ireland."

Then Caoilte and Oisín lifted Osgar on their shields and carried him to a smooth green hill, to take his clothes off him. There was not a hand's-breadth of his white body without a wound.

When the rest of the Fianna saw the state Osgar was in, there was not a man of them who keened his own son or his brother. Every one of them came keening Osgar.

After a while, at noon, they saw Finn coming towards them, with what was left of the Sun-banner raised on a spear-shaft. They all greeted Finn, but he made no answer. He came up to the hill where Osgar was.

When Osgar saw him coming he greeted him. "I've got my desire in death, Finn of the sharp arms," he said.

"You were in a worse way, my son," said Finn, "on the day of the battle at Beinn Edair, when the wild geese could have swum on your breast, and it was my hand gave you healing."

His hands. The water in his hands. The healing he could give, and had given once, to this boy.

"No healing can be done for me now, for ever," said Osgar, "since the King of Ireland put the spear of seven spells through my body."

"It's a pity it wasn't I myself who fell in sunny, scarce Gabhra," said Finn, "and you going east and west at the head of the Fianna."

"And if it was you who fell in the battle," said Osgar, "you wouldn't hear me keening after you. For no man ever knew any heart in me but a heart of twisted horn, covered with iron. But the howling of the dogs beside me, and the keening of the old fighting men, and the crying of the women one after another — those are the things that are vexing me."

He was dying, and what troubled him was the noise of everyone else's grief.

"Child of my child," said Finn, "calf of my calf, white and slender, it's a pity the way you are. My heart is starting like a deer, and I'm weak after you and after the Fianna of Ireland. Misfortune has followed us. Farewell now to battles and to a great name, and farewell to taking tributes. For every good thing I ever had is gone from me now."

When Osgar heard those words he stretched out his hands, and his eyelids closed.

And Finn turned away from the rest, and cried.

He never shed a tear in the whole length of his life except for Osgar, and for Bran.

All who were left of the Fianna gave three sorrowful cries after Osgar. For there was not one of the Fianna beyond him, unless it was Finn or Oisín.

Many of the Fianna were left dead at Gabhra, and graves were made for them. As for Lugaidh's Son, who was so tall a man and so good a fighter, they made a very wide grave for him, as was fitting for a king. And the whole length of the rath at Gabhra, from end to end, was the grave of Osgar, son of Oisín, son of Finn.

As for Finn himself, he never had peace or pleasure again from that day.

Death Of Bran



One day Finn was hunting, and Bran went after a fawn.

They were coming towards Finn, and the fawn called out.

"If I go into the sea below," it said, "I'll never come back again. And if I go up into the air above me, it won't save me from Bran."

For Bran could overtake the wild geese, she was that swift.

"Go out between my legs," said Finn.

So the fawn did that, and Bran followed her. And as Bran went under him, Finn squeezed his two knees together on her, so that she died that moment.

That is how Donn killed the Steward's son, long ago, at Brugh na Boinne. Between his two knees. Finn had seen it done. He had judged it.

There was great grief on him after that, and he cried the same as he did when Osgar died.

Some said it was Finn's mother the fawn was, and that it was to save his mother he killed Bran. But that is not likely. His mother was beautiful Muirne, daughter of Tadg, son of Nuada of the Tuatha de Danaan, and it was never heard that she was changed into a fawn.

It is more likely it was Oisín's mother. Sábh, who was taken from the gate of Almhuin while Finn was away at the wars, and whom he looked for seven years and never found.

If it was her, then after all that time she had come back to him, running. And he had had to choose between her and Bran. And he chose.

But some say Bran and Sceolan are still seen at night, starting out of the thicket on the hill of Almhuin.

The Call Of Oisin



One misty morning, those who were left of the Fianna gathered together to Finn. They were sorrowful and downhearted after the loss of so many of their comrades.

They went hunting near the borders of Loch Lein, where the bushes were in blossom and the birds were singing, and they were waking up the deer, who were as joyful as the leaves of a tree in summertime.

It was not long before they saw, coming towards them from the west, a beautiful young woman riding a very fast, slender white horse.

She had a queen's crown on her head, and a dark cloak of silk down to the ground, with stars of red gold on it. Her eyes were blue, and as clear as the dew on the grass. A gold ring hung down from every golden lock of her hair. Her cheeks were redder than the rose, and her skin whiter than the swan on the wave, and her lips as sweet as honey mixed through red wine.

In her hand she held a bridle with a golden bit, and there was a saddle worked with red gold under her. As for the horse, he had a wide smooth cloak over him, and a silver crown on the back of his head, and he was shod with shining gold.

She came to where Finn was and spoke in a very kind, gentle voice.

"It was a long journey I had, King of the Fianna."

Finn asked her who she was, and what her country was, and why she had come.

"Niamh of the Golden Head is my name," she said. "And I have a name beyond all the women of the world, for I'm the daughter of the King of the Country of the Young."

"What brought you to us from over the sea, Queen?" said Finn. "Is it that your husband has gone from you, or what trouble is on you?"

"My husband hasn't gone from me," she said, "for I've never yet gone to any man. But O King of the Fianna, I've given my love and my affection to your own son, Oisín of the strong hands."

"Why did you give your love to him beyond all the troops of high princes under the sun?" said Finn.

"It was because of his great name," she said, "and the report I heard of his bravery and his comeliness. Many a king's son and high prince has given me his love, but I never consented to any of them until I set my love on Oisín."

When Oisín heard what she was saying, there was not a limb of his body that was not in love with beautiful Niamh. He took her hand in his.

"A true welcome to you in this country, young queen," he said. "It's you are the shining one. It's you are the nicest and the comeliest. It's you are better to me than any other woman. It's you are my star and my choice beyond the women of the entire world."

"I put on you the bonds of a true hero," said Niamh, "to come away with me now to the Country of the Young."

Bonds again. They were all of them bound, from the beginning to the end, by the same few words.

And this is what she said:

"It is the most delightful country of all that are under the sun; the trees are stooping down with fruit and with leaves and with blossom.

"Honey and wine are plentiful there, and everything the eye has ever seen. No wasting will come on you with the wasting away of time; you will never see death or lessening.

"You will get feasts, playing and drinking; you will get sweet music on the strings; you will get silver and gold and many jewels.

"You will get — and no lie in it — a hundred swords; a hundred cloaks of the costliest silk; a hundred horses, the quickest in battle; a hundred willing hounds.

"You will get the royal crown of the King of the Young, that he never gave to anyone under the sun. It will be a shelter to you night and day, in every rough fight and every battle.

"You will get a right suit of armour; a sword, gold-hilted, apt for striking; no one that ever saw it got away from it alive.

"A hundred coats of armour, and shirts of satin; a hundred cows and a hundred calves; a hundred sheep with golden fleeces; a hundred jewels that are not of this world.

"A hundred glad young girls shining like the sun, their voices sweeter than the music of birds; a hundred armed men, strong in battle, apt at feats, waiting on you, if you will come with me to the Country of the Young.

"You will get everything I have said to you, and delights beyond them that I have no leave to tell. You will get beauty, strength, and power. And I myself will be with you as a wife."

The Red Woman had offered Finn the Country of the Young once, a long time ago. He had said that he would not give up his own country for the whole world as an estate, and the Country of the Young along with it.

But that was when Finn was young, and the Fianna were whole. Osgar was under the rath at Gabhra now. Diarmuid was in the hill with Angus. Goll had died on a rock. And Oisín was standing on a hillside above Loch Lein with a woman made of gold holding his hand.

"O pleasant golden-haired queen," said Oisín, "you're my choice beyond the women of the world. I'll go with you willingly."

With that he kissed Finn his father and said farewell to him, and said farewell to the rest of the Fianna, and got up on the horse with Niamh.

The horse set out gladly. When he came to the strand he shook himself, and neighed three times, and then he made for the sea.

When Finn and the Fianna saw Oisín facing the wide sea, they gave three great sorrowful shouts.

"It's my grief to see you going from me," said Finn. "And I'm without a hope of ever seeing you coming back to me again."

He was right. He would not see it.

The Last Of The Great Men



That was the last time Finn and Oisín and the rest of the Fianna of Ireland were gathered together, for hunting, for battle, for chess-playing, for drinking or for music. They all wore away after that, one after another.

As for Caoilte, who was old and had lost his sons, he used to fret and be lonesome after the old times. One day, when there was very heavy snow on the ground, he made this lament:

"Cold is the winter; the wind has risen; the fierce, high-couraged stag rises up. Cold is the whole mountain tonight, yet the fierce stag is calling. The deer of Slievecarn of the gatherings does not lay his side to the ground; he, no less than the stag on the top of cold Echtge, hears the music of the wolves.

"I, Caoilte, and brown-haired Diarmuid, and pleasant light-footed Osgar, we used to listen to the music of the wolves through the end of the cold night. Well the brown deer sleeps with its hide to the hollow, hidden as if in the earth, through the end of the cold night.

"Today I am in my age, and I know only a few men. I used to shake my spear bravely in the ice-cold morning. Often I put silence on a great army that is very cold tonight."

He had drunk the drink of remembrance, in the hill at Ess Ruadh. He forgot nothing. Every one of them was still there in his head, in the cold, listening to the wolves.

After a while he went into a hill of the Sidhe to be healed of his old wounds. Whether he came back from there or not is not known. Some say he used to talk with Patrick of the Bells at the same time as Oisín was with him. But that is not likely, or Oisín would not have complained of his loneliness the way he did.

But a long time after that, a king of Ireland was making a journey. He and his people lost their way, and when night came on they were in a dark wood, with no path in front of them.

A very tall man came to them, shining like a burning flame. He took hold of the bridle of the king's horse and led him through the wood until they came to the right road.

The King of Ireland asked him who he was.

First he said, "I am your candlestick."

Then he said, "I was with Finn one time."

And the king knew it was Caoilte, son of Ronan.

Once, in Teamhair, a king had said that the two eyes of Caoilte were in his candlestick. And Finn had said that Caoilte would never stand serving with a candle for all the gold in the world. But that was a long time ago, and there was nobody left to serve.

Three times nine of the rest of the Fianna came out of the west once to Teamhair. They saw that now, when they had lost their full strength and their great name, nobody took any notice of them or came to speak with them at all. When they saw that, they lay down on the side of the hill at Teamhair, and put their lips to the earth, and died.

And for three days and a month and a year from the time of the destruction of the Fianna of Ireland, Loch Dearg was under mists.

* * * * *

As for Finn, some say he died by the hand of a fisherman. It is likely that is not true, for that would be no death for so great a man as Finn, son of Cumhal. And some say he never died, but is alive in some place still.

Once a smith made his way into a cave he had found. It had a door, and he made a key that opened it. When he went in he saw a very wide place, and very big men lying on the floor. One bigger than the rest was lying in the middle, with the Dord Fiann beside him. And the smith knew it was Finn and the Fianna.

He took hold of the Dord Fiann. He could hardly lift it to his mouth. He blew a very strong blast on it, and the sound it made was so great that it was a wonder the rocks did not come down on him. At the sound, the big men lying on the ground shook from head to foot.

He gave another blast, and they all turned over on their elbows.

Great dread came on him when he saw that. He threw down the Dord Fiann and ran from the cave, and locked the door after him, and threw the key into the lake.

And he heard them crying after him: "You left us worse than you found us."

The cave has not been found since.

That is the rule of the horn. Three blasts. The smith gave two. It is a small and terrible thing, to stop one short.

But some say the day will come when the Dord Fiann will be sounded three times, and at the sound of it the Fianna will rise up as strong and as well as ever they were.

And some say Finn, son of Cumhal, has been on the earth now and again since the old times, in the shape of one of the heroes of Ireland.

As for the great things he and his men did when they were together, it is well they have been kept in mind by the poets of Ireland and of Alban.

One night two men were minding sheep in a valley, and they were saying the poems of the Fianna to each other while they were there. And they saw two very tall shapes on the two hills on either side of the valley. And one of the tall shapes said to the other:

"Do you hear that man down below? I was the second doorpost of battle at Gabhra. And that man knows all about it better than I do."

The dead are listening. They always have been. That is one reason to tell the stories right.

And so we come to the last of it: Oisín, and Patrick.

CHAPTER I

Oisín's Story



As for Oisín, it was a long time after Niamh took him away that he came back to Ireland. Some say he was hundreds of years in the Country of the Young, and some say thousands. Whatever time it was, it seemed short to him.

And whatever happened to him in the time he was away, it was a withered old man they found when he came back to Ireland, with his white horse going away from him, and he lying on the ground.

It was Saint Patrick who had power at that time, and it was to him Oisín was brought. Patrick kept him in his house, and used to teach him and question him. Oisín was in no way pleased with the way Ireland was then. He used to talk about the old times, and fret after the Fianna.

Patrick asked him to tell what had happened to him when he left Finn and the Fianna and went away with Niamh. And this is the story Oisín told.

"When I went away with golden-haired Niamh, we turned our backs to the land and our faces westward. The sea was going away in front of us, and filling up in waves behind us. We saw wonderful things on our journey: cities and courts and duns and lime-white houses, and shining sunny-houses and palaces.

"Once we saw beside us a hornless deer running hard, and an eager white hound with red ears following after it. Another time we saw a young girl on a horse, with a golden apple in her right hand, going over the tops of the waves. And there was a young man following after her on a white horse, with a crimson cloak and a gold-hilted sword in his right hand."

"Follow on with your story, pleasant Oisín," said Patrick, "for you haven't told us yet what country it was you went to."

"The Country of the Young, the Country of Victory, it was," said Oisín. "And O Patrick, there's no lie in that name. And if there are grandeurs in your Heaven the same as there are there, I'd give my friendship to God.

"We turned our backs to the dun then, and the horse under us was quicker than the spring wind on the backs of the mountains. It wasn't long before the sky darkened, and the wind rose in every part, and the sea was as if it were on fire, and there was nothing to be seen of the sun.

"But after we'd been looking at the clouds and the stars a while, the wind went down, and the storm, and the sun brightened. And we saw ahead of us a very delightful country in full blossom, with smooth plains in it, and a king's dun that was very grand and had every colour in it, and sunny-houses beside it, and palaces of shining stones made by skilled men.

"We saw three fifties of armed men coming out to meet us, very lively and handsome. I asked Niamh whether this was the Country of the Young, and she said it was.

"And indeed, Oisin,' she said, 'I told you no lie about it. You'll see everything I promised you in front of you for ever.'

"After that a hundred beautiful young girls came out, in cloaks of silk worked with gold, and gave me a welcome to their own country. Then came a great shining army, and with it a strong, beautiful king, in a shirt of yellow silk with a golden cloak over it, and a very bright crown on his head. And there was a young queen following after him, with fifty young girls.

"When everyone had come to the one spot, the king took me by the hand and said out before them all: 'A hundred thousand welcomes to you, Oisin, son of Finn. As for this country you've come to, I'll give you news of it without a lie. Long and lasting your life will be in it, and you yourself will be young for ever. And there's no delight the heart ever thought of but it's here, waiting for your coming. You can believe my words, Oisin, for I myself am the King of the Country of the Young, and this is its comely queen, and it was golden-headed Niamh, our daughter, who went over the sea looking for you, to be her husband for ever.'

"I thanked him then, and I bowed myself down before the queen, and we went forward to the royal house. All the high nobles came out to meet us, men and women both, and a great feast was made there that lasted ten days and ten nights.

"And that's how I married Niamh of the Golden Hair, and that's how I went to the Country of the Young — though it's sorrowful to me to tell it now, O Patrick from Rome."

"Follow on with your story, Oisín of the destroying arms," said Patrick, "and tell me how you left the Country of the Young, for I'm longing to hear that. And tell us, had you any children by Niamh, and was it long you were in that place?"

"Two beautiful children I had by Niamh," said Oisín, "two young sons, and a comely daughter. Niamh gave the two sons the names of Finn and of Osgar. And the name I gave the daughter was The Flower."

He named his sons for his father and his son. Of course he did. Even in the Country of the Young, he was carrying them.

"And I didn't feel the time passing, and it was a long time I stayed there," he said, "until the desire came on me to see Finn and my comrades again. I asked the king and Niamh for leave to go back to Ireland.

"'You'll get leave from me,' said Niamh. 'But for all that, it's bad news you're giving me. I'm afraid you'll never come back here again, for the length of your days.'

"But I told her not to fear, since the white horse would bring me safe back from Ireland.

"'Bear this in mind, Oisín,' she said. 'If you once get off the horse while you're away, if you once put your foot to the ground, you'll never come back here again.'

"'And O Oisín, I tell it to you now for the third time: if you once get down from the horse, you'll be an old man, blind and withered, without liveliness, without mirth, without running, without leaping.

"'And it's a grief to me, Oisín, that you should ever go back to green Ireland. It isn't now as it used to be. You won't see Finn and his people, for there's nothing now in the whole of Ireland but a Father of Orders and armies of saints. Here's my kiss for you, pleasant Oisín, for you'll never come back any more to the Country of the Young.'"

That is the rule of the horse. Do not get down. She said it three times. She knew.

"That's my story, Patrick," said Oisín, "and I've told you no lie in it. And O Patrick, if I was the same the day I came here as I was that day, I'd have made an end of all your clerks, and there wouldn't be a head left on a neck after me."

"Go on with your story," said Patrick, "and you'll get the same good treatment from me that you got from Finn. For the sound of your voice is pleasing to me."

So Oisín went on with his story. And this is what he said:

"I have nothing to tell of my journey until I came back into green Ireland. I looked about me on all sides, but there was no news to be got of Finn.

"It wasn't long before I saw a great troop of riders, men and women, coming towards me from the west. When they came near they wished me good health. And they all wondered when they looked at me, seeing me so unlike themselves, and so big and so tall.

"I asked them whether they'd heard if Finn was still living, or any other of the Fianna, or what had happened to them.

"'We've often heard of Finn, who lived long ago,' they said, 'and that there never was his equal for strength or bravery or a great name. There's many a book written down by the sweet poets of the Gael about his doings and the doings of the Fianna, and it would be hard for us to tell you all of them. And we heard Finn had a son,' they said, 'who was beautiful and shining, and a young girl came looking for him, and he went away with her to the Country of the Young.'

"When I knew by their talk that Finn was not living, nor any of the Fianna, I was downhearted, and tired, and very sorrowful after them. I made no delay, but turned my face and went on to Almhuin of Leinster. And there was great wonder on me when I got there, to see no sign at all of Finn's great dun, and his great hall, and nothing in the place where it had been but weeds and nettles."

Like Fionnuala, coming home after nine hundred years to Sidhe Fionnachaidh, and finding green hillocks and thickets of nettles. Every one of them, in the end, comes home to nettles.

And there was grief on Oisin, and he said: "Och, Patrick! Och, ochone, my grief! That was a bad journey for me. To be without news of Finn or the Fianna has left me in pain all my life."

"Leave off fretting, Oisin," said Patrick, "and shed your tears to the God of grace. Finn and the Fianna are slack enough now, and they'll get no help for ever."

"It would be a great pity," said Oisin, "for Finn to be in pain for ever. And who was it got the victory over him, when his own hand had made an end of so many a hard fighter?"

"It was God got the victory over Finn," said Patrick, "and not the strong hand of an enemy. And as for the Fianna, they're condemned to hell along with him, and tormented for ever."

"O Patrick," said Oisin, "show me the place where Finn and his people are, and there's not a hell or a heaven there but I'll put it down. And if Osgar, my own son, is there — the hero who was bravest in heavy battles — there's not a troop in hell or in the Heaven of God so great that he couldn't destroy it."

"Let's leave off quarrelling on each side now," said Patrick. "Go on, Oisin, with your story. What happened to you after you knew the Fianna had come to an end?"

"I'll tell you that, Patrick," said Oisin.

"I was turning to go away, and I saw the stone trough the Fianna used to put their hands in, and it was full of water. When I saw it I had such a longing for it, and such a feeling for it, that I forgot what I'd been told. And I got down off the horse.

"And in that minute all the years came on me. I was lying on the ground. The horse took fright and went away and left me there — an old man, weak and spent, without sight, without shape, without comeliness, without strength or understanding, without respect.

"There's my story for you now, Patrick, and no lie in it, of all that happened to me going away and coming back again from the Country of the Young."

A stone trough full of water. That was all. He wanted to put his hands where their hands had been.

Oisín In Patrick's House



Oisín stayed on with Saint Patrick. But he was not very well content with the way he was treated.

"They say I'm getting food," he said once, "but God knows I'm not, or drink. And I, Oisín, son of Finn, under a yoke, drawing stones."

"It's my opinion you're getting enough," said Saint Patrick, "and you getting a quarter of beef and a churn of butter and a griddle of bread every day."

"I've often seen a quarter of a blackbird bigger than your quarter of beef," said Oisín, "and a rowan-berry as big as your churn of butter, and an ivy leaf as big as your griddle of bread."

Saint Patrick was vexed when he heard that, and he told Oisín he had told a lie.

You can say many things to a man of the Fianna. That is not one of them.

A great anger came on Oisín. He went to where there was a litter of pups, and told a serving-boy to nail the hide of a freshly killed bullock up on the wall, and to throw the pups against it one by one. Every one he threw fell down off the hide, until it came to the last. That one held on with its teeth and its nails.

"Rear that one," said Oisín, "and drown all the rest."

Then he told the boy to keep the pup in a dark place and look after it well, and never let it taste blood or see the daylight. At the end of a year Oisín was so well pleased with the pup that he gave it the name of Bran Og, Young Bran.

One day he called the serving-boy to come on a journey with him, and to bring the pup on a chain. They set out and passed by Slieve-nam-ban, where the witches of the Sidhe sit spinning at their spinning-wheels. Then they turned eastward into Gleann-na-Smol.

Oisin raised a rock that was there, and told the lad to take three things out from under it: a great sounding horn of the Fianna, and an iron ball they used for throwing, and a very sharp sword.

When Oisin saw those things, he took them in his hands.

"My thousand farewells to the day when you were put here," he said.

Someone had hidden them, a long time ago, for a day that never came. He was the only one left who knew where.

He told the lad to clean them well. When he had done that, he told him to sound a blast on the horn. The boy did it, and Oisin asked whether he saw anything strange.

"I don't," said the boy.

"Sound it again, as loud as you can," said Oisin.

"That's as hard as I can sound it," said the boy, when he had done it, "and I can't see anything yet."

Then Oisin took the horn himself and put it to his mouth, and blew three great blasts on it.

Three. Not two. He knew the rule of the horn.

"What do you see now?" he said.

"I see three great clouds coming," said the boy, "and they're settling down in the valley. The first cloud is a flight of very big birds, and the second cloud is a flight of birds that are bigger again, and the third flight is of the biggest and the blackest birds the world ever saw."

"What's the dog doing?" said Oisin.

"The eyes are starting out of his head, and there isn't a hair on him but is standing up."

"Let him loose now," said Oisin.

The dog rushed down to the valley and attacked one of the birds, the biggest of them all, whose shadow was like a cloud. They fought a very fierce fight. But at last Bran Og made an

end of the big bird, and lapped its blood.

And when he did, madness came on him. He came rushing back towards Oisin, with his jaws open and his eyes like fire.

"There's dread on me, Oisin," said the boy. "The dog is making for us, mad and raging."

"Take this iron ball and throw it at him when he comes near," said Oisin.

"I'm afraid to do that," said the boy.

"Put it in my hand, and turn it towards him," said Oisin.

The boy did that. And Oisin — blind, and old, and withered — threw the ball. It went into the dog's mouth and down his throat and choked him, and he fell down the slope, twisting and foaming.

That is the rule of the Fianna's dogs. Never let them taste blood until the day they are needed. And once they have tasted it, there is no getting it back.

Then they went to where the great bird lay dead. Oisin told the lad to cut a quarter off it with the sword, and he did. Then he told him to cut open the body. And in it they found a rowan-berry, the biggest he had ever seen, and an ivy leaf bigger than the biggest griddle.

So Oisin turned back and went to where Saint Patrick was, and showed him the quarter of the bird, which was bigger than any quarter of a bullock, and the rowan-berry, which was bigger than a churning of butter, and the leaf.

"And you know now, Patrick of the Bells," he said, "that I told no lie. This is what kept us all through our lifetime: truth that was in our hearts, and strength in our arms, and fulfilment in our tongues."

"You told no lie indeed," said Patrick.

Once, Grania was asked what was whiter than snow, and she said: the truth. It was the Fianna's whole religion. It was the thing Oisin had left.

When Oisín had no sight left at all, he used to put one of the serving-men up on his shoulders every night and carry him out to see how the cattle were doing.

One night the servants had no mind to go, and they agreed among themselves to tell him it was a very bad night.

This is what the first of them said: "Outside there's a heavy sound, with the heavy water dropping from the tops of the trees. The sound of the waves can't be heard for the loud splashing of the rain."

Then the next said: "The trees of the wood are shivering, and the birch is turning black. The snow is killing the birds. That's the story outside."

And the third said: "It's to the east they've turned their faces, the white snow and the dark rain. What's making the plain so cold is the snow that's dripping and getting hard."

But there was a serving-girl in the house, and she said: "Get up, Oisín, and go out to the white-headed cows, since the cold wind is plucking the trees off the hills."

So Oisín went out with the serving-man on his shoulders. But this is what the serving-man did: he brought a vessel of water and a birch broom with him, and kept dashing water in Oisín's face, so that he would think it was rain.

But when they came to the pen where the cattle were, Oisín found the night was quiet.

And after that he asked the servants for no more news of the weather.

He did not shout. He did not strike anyone. He was old and blind and the last of the Fianna, and he had learned what they were. He simply stopped asking.

The Arguments



Saint Patrick undertook to convert Oisín and bring him to baptism. It was no easy work. Whatever Patrick said, Oisín had an answer for it.

This is how they used to talk and argue with one another, as the poets of Ireland wrote it down afterwards.

PATRICK: "Oisín, your sleep is long. Get up and listen to the Psalm. Your strength and your readiness are gone from you, though you used to go into rough fights and battles."

OISÍN: "My readiness and my strength are gone from me since Finn has no armies living. I have no liking for clerks. Their music isn't sweet to me after his."

PATRICK: "You never heard music so good from the beginning of the world to this day. A fine one you'd be to serve an army on a hill — you, old and silly and grey."

OISÍN: "I used to serve an army on a hill, Patrick of the closed-up mind. It's a pity you should be faulting me. No shame was ever put on me until now."

"I've heard music sweeter than your music, however much you praise your clerks: the song of the blackbird in *Leiter Laoi*, and the sound of the *Dord Fiann*; the very sweet thrush of the Valley of the Shadow, or the sound of the boats striking the strand. The cry of the hounds was better to me than the noise of your schools, Patrick."

"Little Nut, little Nut of my heart, the little dwarf that was with Finn: when he made tunes and songs, he'd put us all into deep sleep."

"The twelve hounds that belonged to Finn, when they were let loose, facing out from the *Siuir* — their cry was sweeter than harps and pipes."

"I have a little story about Finn. We were only fifteen men. We took the King of the Saxons of the feats, and we won a battle against the King of Greece."

"We fought nine battles in Spain, and nine times twenty battles in Ireland. From Lochlann and from the eastern world there was a share of gold coming to Finn.

"My grief, that I'm staying on after him, without delight in games or in music, withering away after my comrades. My grief it is to be living. I and the clerks of the Mass-books are two that can never agree.

"If Finn and the Fianna were living, I'd leave the clerks and the bells. I'd follow the deer through the valleys. I'd like to be close on his track.

"Ask Heaven of God, Patrick, for Finn of the Fianna and his race. Make prayers for the great man. You never heard of his like."

PATRICK: "I won't ask Heaven for Finn, man of good wit that my anger is rising against, since his delight was to be living in valleys with the noise of hunts."

OISIN: "If you'd been in the company of the Fianna, Patrick of the joyless clerks and the bells, you wouldn't be attending on schools, or giving heed to God."

PATRICK: "I wouldn't part from the Son of God for all who have lived, east or west. O Oisín, O shaking poet, harm will come on you in satisfaction for the priests."

OISIN: "It was a delight to Finn, the cry of his hounds on the mountains, the wild dogs leaving their harbours, the pride of his armies. Those were his delights."

PATRICK: "There was many a thing Finn took delight in, and there's not much heed given to it after him. Finn and his hounds aren't living now. And you won't always be living, Oisín."

OISIN: "There's a greater story of Finn than of us, or of any who've lived in our time. Of all that are gone and all that are living, Finn was better at giving out gold than any of them."

PATRICK: "All the gold you and Finn used to give out, it does little for you now. He's in Hell, in bonds, because he did treachery and oppression."

This is the only time in the whole long story that anyone says it plainly. Treachery and oppression. A boar on Beinn Gulbain. Water let slip through the hands, three times. Patrick

was not wrong. That is what makes this so hard to read.

OISIN: "I believe little of your truth, man from Rome with the white books: Finn, the open-handed Head of the Fianna, to be in the hands of devils or demons."

PATRICK: "Finn is in bonds in Hell, the pleasant man who gave out gold. In satisfaction for his disrespect to God, he's under grief in the house of pain."

OISIN: "If the sons of Morna were in there, or the strong men of the sons of Baiscne, they'd take Finn out of it, or they'd have the house for themselves."

PATRICK: "If the five provinces of Ireland were in there, or the strong seven battalions of the Fianna, they wouldn't be able to bring Finn out of it, however great their strength."

OISIN: "If Faolan and Goll were living, and brown-haired Diarmuid, and brave Osgar, Finn of the Fianna couldn't be held in any house that was made by God or devils."

PATRICK: "If Faolan and Goll were living, and all the Fianna that ever were, they couldn't bring Finn out of the house where he's in pain."

OISIN: "What did Finn ever do against God, but attend on schools and on armies? Giving gold for a great part of his time, and for another while trying his hounds."

PATRICK: "In payment for thinking of his hounds, and for serving the schools of the poets, and because he gave no heed to God, Finn of the Fianna is held down."

OISIN: "You say, Patrick of the Psalms, that the Fianna couldn't take Finn out, nor the five provinces of Ireland along with them.

"I have a little story about Finn. We were only fifteen men when we took the King of Britain of the feasts, by the strength of our spears and our own strength.

"We took Magnus the Great, the son of the King of Lochlann of the speckled ships. We came back in no way sorry or tired. We put our rent on far places.

"O Patrick, it's a pitiful story, the King of the Fianna to be under locks: a heart without envy, without hatred, a heart hard in earning victory.

"It's an injustice for God to be unwilling to give food and riches. Finn never refused strong or poor, though cold Hell is his dwelling-place now.

"This is what Finn had a mind for: to listen to the sound of Druim Dearg; to sleep at the stream of Ess Ruadh; to hunt the deer of Gallimh of the bays.

"The cries of the blackbird of Leiter Laoi; the wave of Rudraighe beating on the strand; the bellowing of the ox of Magh Maoi; the lowing of the calf of Gleann da Mhail.

"The noise of the hunt on Slieve Crot; the sound of the fawns round Slieve Cua; the scream of the sea-gulls out there on Iorrus; the screech of the crows over the battle.

"The waves vexing the breasts of the boats; the howling of the hounds at Druim Lis; the voice of Bran on Cnoc-an-Air; the outcry of the streams about Slieve Mis.

"The call of Osgar going to the hunt; the voice of the hounds on the road of the Fianna; to be listening to them and to the poets — that was always his desire.

"One desire of the desires of Osgar was to listen to the striking of shields; to be hacking at bones in a battle — that's what he always had a mind for.

"We went westward once to hunt at Formaid of the Fianna, to see the first running of our hounds.

"It was Finn who was holding Bran, and it was with me Sceolan was. Diarmuid of the Women had Fearan, and Osgar had lucky Adhnuall.

"Conan the Bald had Searc. Caoilte, son of Ronan, had Daol. Lugaidh's Son and Goll were holding Fuaim and Fothran.

"That was the first day we loosed out a share of our hounds to a hunt. And och, Patrick, of all who were in it, there isn't one left living but me.

"O Patrick, it's a pity, the way I am now: a spent old man without power, without quickness, without strength, going to Mass at the altar.

"Without the great deer of Slieve Luchra; without the hares of Slieve Cuilinn; without going into fights with Finn; without listening to the poets.

"Without battles, without taking spoils; without playing at nimble feats; without going courting or hunting, two trades that were my delight."

He names every hound. He names who held each one. It was one morning, a lifetime ago — several lifetimes ago — and he remembers exactly who was holding which leash.

PATRICK: "Leave off, old man. Leave your foolishness. Let what you've done be enough for you from now on. Think of the pains that are in front of you. The Fianna are gone, and you'll be going yourself."

OISIN: "If I go, may you not be left after me, Patrick of the hindering heart. If Conan, the least of the Fianna, were living, your buzzing wouldn't be left to you long.

"Or if this were the day I gave ten hundred cows to the headless woman who came to the Valley of the Two Oxen. The birds of the air carried off the ring I gave her. I never knew where she went herself from me."

PATRICK: "That's little to trouble you, Oisín. It was only for a while she was with you. It's better for you to be as you are than to be among them again."

OISIN: "O Son of Calphurn of the friendly talk, it's a pity for anyone who gives respect to clerks and bells. Caoilte my friend and I, we weren't poor when we were together.

"The music that put Finn to sleep was the cackling of the ducks from the lake of the Three Narrows; the scolding talk of the blackbird of Doire an Cairn; the bellowing of the ox from the Valley of the Berries.

"The whistle of the eagle from the Valley of Victories, or from the rough branches of the ridge by the stream; the grouse of the heather of Cruachan; the call of the otter of Druim-re-Coir.

"The song of the blackbird of Doire an Cairn — indeed I never heard sweeter music, if I could be under its nest.

"My grief that I ever took baptism. It's little credit I got by it, being without food, without drink, doing fasting and praying."

PATRICK: "In my opinion it did you no harm, old man. You'll get nine score cakes of bread, and wine and meat to put a taste on it. It's bad talk you're giving."

OISIN: "May this mouth that's talking with you never confess to a priest, if I wouldn't sooner have the leavings of Finn's house than a share of your own meals."

PATRICK: "He got only what he gathered off the banks, or whatever he could kill on the rough hills. He got hell in the end, because of his unbelief."

OISIN: "That wasn't the way with us at all, but our fill of wine and meat; justice, and a right beginning at the feasts; sweet drinks, and everyone drinking them."

"It's fretting after Diarmuid and Goll I am, and after Fergus of the True Lips, when you won't let me speak of them, O new Patrick from Rome."

PATRICK: "We'd give you leave to speak of them. But first you should give heed to God. Since you're at the end of your days now, leave your foolishness, weak old man."

OISIN: "O Patrick, tell me as a secret, since it's you have the best knowledge: will my dog or my hound be let in with me to the court of the King of Grace?"

Of all the questions a man might ask at the end of the world, this is the one he asks.

PATRICK: "Old man, in your foolishness that I can't put any bounds to: your dog or your hound won't be let in with you to the court of the King of Power."

OISIN: "If I had acquaintance with God, and my hound at hand, I'd make whoever gave food to me give a share to my hound as well."

"One strong champion who was with the Fianna of Ireland would be better than the Lord of Piety, and than you yourself, Patrick."

PATRICK: "O Oisín of the sharp blades, it's mad words you're saying. God is better for one day than the whole of the Fianna of Ireland."

OISIN: "Though I'm without power now, and my life is spent to the end, don't put abuse, Patrick, on the great men of the sons of Baiscne."

"If I had Conan with me, the man who used to run down the Fianna, it's he would break your head in among your clerks and your priests."

Conan. He is calling for Conan now. There is nobody else left to call for.

PATRICK: "It's a silly thing, old man, to be always talking of the Fianna. Remember your end has come, and take the Son of God to help you."

OISIN: "I used to sleep out on the mountain under the grey dew. I was never used to going to bed without food, while there was a deer on the hill over there."

PATRICK: "You're astray at the end of your life between the straight way and the crooked. Keep out of the crooked path of pains, and the angels of God will come beneath your head."

OISIN: "If I and open-handed Fergus and Diarmuid were together now on this spot, we'd go down every path we ever went down, and ask no leave of the priests."

PATRICK: "Leave off, Oisin. Don't speak against the priests who are telling the word of God in every place. Unless you leave off your daring talk, it's great pain you'll have in the end."

OISIN: "When the leader of the Fianna and I were looking for a boar in a valley, it was worse to me not to see it than for all your clerks to be without their heads."

PATRICK: "It's pitiful, seeing you without sense. That's worse for you than your blindness. If you got sight inside you, great would be your desire for Heaven."

OISIN: "It would be little good to me to be sitting in that city, without Caoilte, without Osgar, without my father being with me.

"The leap of the buck would be better to me, or the sight of badgers between two valleys, than all your mouth is promising me, and all the delights I could get in Heaven."

He had already had a paradise. He had lived in the Country of the Young, for longer than anyone knows. He had left it, for a stone trough of water. He knew exactly what he was turning down.

PATRICK: "Your thoughts are foolish. They'll come to nothing. Your pleasure and your mirth are gone. Unless you take my advice tonight, you won't get leave on this side or that."

OISIN: "If the Fianna and I were on the top of a hill today, drawing our spear-heads, we'd have our choice of being here or there, in spite of books and priests and bells."

PATRICK: "You were like the smoke of a wisp, or a stream in a valley, or a whirling wind on the top of a hill, every tribe of you that ever lived."

OISIN: "If I were in the company of the people of strong arms, the way I was at Bearnna da Coill, I'd sooner be looking at them than at this troop of the crooked croziers."

"If I had Scolb Sceine with me, or Osgar, who was smart in battles, I wouldn't be without meat tonight at the sound of the bell of the seven tolls."

PATRICK: "Oisin, since your wits are gone from you, be glad at what I say. It's certain to me you'll leave the Fianna, and receive the God of the stars."

OISIN: "There's wonder on me at your hasty talk, priest who's travelled in every part, to say I'd part from the Fianna, a generous people, never niggardly."

PATRICK: "If you saw the people of God, the way they're settled at feasts — every good thing is more plentiful with them than with Finn's people, however great their name was."

"Finn and the Fianna are lying now, very sorrowful, on the flagstone of pain. Take the Son of God in their place. Make your repentance and don't lose Heaven."

OISIN: "I don't believe your talk now, O Patrick of the crooked staves — Finn and the Fianna to be in there, unless they find pleasure in being in it."

PATRICK: "Make right repentance now, before you know when your end is coming. God is better for one hour than the whole of the Fianna of Ireland."

OISIN: "That's a daring answer to make to me, Patrick of the crooked crozier. Your crozier would be in little bits if I had Osgar with me now."

"If my son Osgar and God were hand to hand on the Hill of the Fianna, if I saw my son put down, I'd say that God was a strong man."

"How could it be that God or his priests could be better men than Finn, the King of the Fianna, a generous man without crookedness?

"If there were a place above or below better than the Heaven of God, it's there Finn would go, and all his people with him.

"You say a generous man never goes to the hell of pain. There wasn't one among the Fianna who wasn't generous to all.

"Ask God, Patrick, whether He remembers when the Fianna were alive, or whether He's seen, east or west, any man better than they were in their fighting.

"The Fianna didn't use to speak treachery. We never had the name of telling lies. By truth and the strength of our hands we came safe out of every battle.

"There never sat a priest in a church — though you think it sweet to be singing psalms — who was better to his word than the Fianna, or more generous than Finn himself.

"If my comrades were living tonight, I'd take no pleasure in your crooning in the church. As they aren't living now, the rough voice of the bells has deafened me.

"Och, in the place of battles and heavy fights, where I used to have my place and take my pleasure — the crozier of Patrick being carried, and his clerks at their quarrelling.

"Och, slothful, cheerless Conan, it's great abuse I used to give you. Why don't you come to see me now? You'd get leave for making fun and reviling through the whole of the niggardly clerks.

"Och, where are the strong men gone, that they don't come together to help me? O Osgar of the sharp sword of victory, come and free your father from his bonds!

"Where is the strong son of Lugaidh? Och, Diarmuid of all the women! Och, Caoilte, son of Ronan, think of our love, and travel to me!"

Nobody came. There was nobody left to come.

PATRICK: "Stop your talk, you withered, witless old man. It's my King who made the Heavens. It's He who gives blossom to the trees. It's He made the moon and the sun, the

fields and the grass."

OISIN: "It wasn't in shaping fields and grass my king took his delight, but in overthrowing fighting men, and defending countries, and carrying his name into every part.

"In courting, in playing, in hunting, in baring his banner at the start of a fight; in playing at chess, at swimming, in looking around him in the drinking-hall.

"O Patrick, where was your God when the two came over the sea who carried off the queen of Lochlann of the Ships? Where was He when Dearg came, the son of the King of Lochlann of the golden shields? Why didn't the King of Heaven protect them from the blows of the big man?

"Or when Tailc, son of Treon, came, the man who did great slaughter on the Fianna — it wasn't by God that champion fell, but by Osgar, in the sight of all.

"Many a battle and many a victory was won by the Fianna of Ireland. I never heard of any great deed done by the King of Saints, or that He ever reddened His hand.

"It would be a great shame for God not to take the locks of pain off Finn. If God Himself were in bonds, my king would fight for His sake.

"Finn left no one in pain or in danger without freeing him, by silver or by gold, or by fighting until he won the victory.

"For the strength of your love, Patrick, don't forsake the great men. Bring the Fianna in, without the King of Heaven knowing.

"It's a good claim I have on your God, to be among his clerks the way I am: without food, without clothing, without music, without giving rewards to poets.

"Without the cry of the hounds or the horns, without guarding coasts, without courting generous women. For all I've suffered by the want of food, I forgive the King of Heaven, in my will."

He forgives God. It is the last thing a man of the Fianna has to give, and he gives it, the way Finn would have: openly, and without being asked.

Then Oisín said: "My story is sorrowful. The sound of your voice isn't pleasant to me. I'll cry my fill — but not for God. Because Finn and the Fianna aren't living."



PART TWO. THE FIANNA

Book Ten: The End Of The Fianna



Oisín's Laments



Oisín used to make laments. Sometimes he would make praises of the old times, and of Finn. These are some of them that are remembered still.

I saw the household of Finn. It was not the household of a soft race. I had a vision of that man yesterday.

I saw the household of the High King, he with the brown, sweet-voiced son. I never saw a better man.

I saw the household of Finn. No one saw it the way I saw it. I saw Finn with the sword, Mac an Luin. Och, it was sorrowful to see it.

I can't tell out every harm that is on my head. Free us from our trouble for ever. I have seen the household of Finn.

It is a week from yesterday I last saw Finn. I never saw a braver man. A king of heavy blows; my law, my adviser, my sense and my wisdom; prince and poet, braver than kings; King of the Fianna, brave in every country; golden salmon of the sea, clean hawk of the air; rightly taught, avoiding lies; strong in his doings, a right judge, ready in courage; a high messenger in bravery and in music.

A week from yesterday, he says. It had been hundreds of years. Some say thousands. To Oisín it was a week, and it always would be.

His skin was lime-white, his hair golden. Ready to work, gentle to women. His great green vessels were full of rough, sharp wine. Rich was the king, the head of his people.

Finn's house had seven sides, and seven score shields on every side. He had fifty fighting men about him in woollen cloaks; ten bright drinking-cups in his hall; ten blue vessels; ten golden horns.

It was a good household Finn had: without grudging, without lust, without vain boasting, without chattering, without any slur on any one of the Fianna.

Finn never refused any man. He never turned away anyone who came to his house. If the brown leaves falling in the woods were gold, if the white waves were silver, Finn would have given away the whole of it.

Blackbird of Doire an Chairn, your voice is sweet. I never heard, on any height of the world, music sweeter than your voice, and you at the foot of your nest.

It is the sweetest music in the world. It's a pity not to listen to it for a while, O son of Calphurn of the sweet bells. You'd catch up on your nones again afterwards.

If you knew the story of the bird the way I know it, you'd be crying lasting tears, and you'd give no heed to your God for a while.

In the country of Lochlann of the blue streams, Finn, son of Cumhal, of the red-gold cups, found that bird you hear now. I'll tell you its story truly.

Doire an Chairn, that wood there to the west, where the Fianna used to linger — it was there they put the blackbird, in the beauty of the pleasant trees.

The stag of the heather of quiet Cruachan; the sorrowful croak from the ridge of the Two Lakes; the voice of the eagle of the Valley of the Shapes; the voice of the cuckoo on the Hill of Brambles.

The voice of the hounds in the pleasant valley; the scream of the eagle on the edge of the wood; the early outcry of the hounds going over the Strand of the Red Stones.

In the time Finn lived, and the Fianna, it was sweet to them to listen to the whistle of the blackbird. The voice of the bells would not have been sweet to them.

It is still there, the blackbird. Or its children's children are. Finn brought it from Lochlann, and it outlived him, and it is singing somewhere in a wood to the west, and nobody listening knows who put it there.

There was no one of the Fianna without his fine silken shirt and his soft coat, without bright armour, without shining stones on his head, two spears in his hand, and a shield that brought victory.

If you searched the world you wouldn't find a harder man: best of blood, best in battle. No one got the upper hand of him. When he went out trying his white hound, which of us could be put beside Finn?

Once we went hunting on Slieve-nam-ban. The sun was beautiful overhead. The voice of the hounds went east and west, from hill to hill. Finn and Bran sat on the hill a while, and every man was eager for the hunt. We let out three thousand hounds from their golden chains, and every hound of them brought down two deer.

Patrick of the true crozier, did you ever see, east or west, a greater hunt than that hunt of Finn and the Fianna? O son of Calphurn of the bells, that day was better to me than listening to your lamentations in the church.

* * * * *

There's no strength in my hands tonight. There's no power in me. It's no wonder I'm sorrowful, thrown down in the sorrow of old age.

Everything is a grief to me beyond any other man on the face of the earth: to be dragging stones along to the church and the hill of the priests.

I have a little story of our people. Once Finn had a mind to make a dun on the bald hill of Cuailgne, and he put it on the Fianna of Ireland to bring stones for building it: a third on the sons of Morna, a third on me, and a third on the sons of Baiscne.

I gave Finn, son of Cumhal, an answer. I said I'd be under his rule no longer, and that I'd obey him no more.

When Finn heard that, he was silent a long time — the man without a lie, without fear. And then he said to me: "You yourself will be dragging stones before your death comes to you."

He had drunk from the salmon. He had drunk from the well of the moon. He knew. He always knew, and it never once saved anyone.

I got up then with anger on me, and a fourth of the brave battalions of the Fianna followed me. I gave my own judgments. There were many of the Fianna with me.

Now my strength is gone from me, I who was adviser to the Fianna. My whole body is tired tonight: my hands, my feet, and my head. Tired, tired, tired.

It's bad, the way I am, after Finn of the Fianna. Since he went away, every good thing is behind me.

Without great people, without mannerly ways. I'm sorrowful after our king who is gone.

I am a shaking tree with my leaves gone from me. An empty nut. A horse without a bridle. A people without a dwelling-place. I, Oisín, son of Finn.

* * * * *

Long are the clouds over me tonight. Long was last night. Though this day is long, yesterday was longer to me. Every day that comes is long to me.

That's not the way I used to be: without fighting, without battles, without learning feats, without young girls, without music, without harps, without bruising bones, without great deeds; without increase of learning, without generosity, without drinking at feasts, without courting, without hunting, the two trades I was used to; without going out to battle. O chone, the want of them is sorrowful to me.

No hunting of deer or stag. It's not like this I'd wish to be. No leashes for our hounds. No hounds. Long are the clouds over me tonight.

Without rising up to do bravery as we used to; without playing as we had a mind to; without the swimming of our fighting men in the lake. Long are the clouds over me tonight.

There's no one at all in the world the way I am. It's a pity, the way I am: an old man dragging stones. Long are the clouds over me tonight.

I am the last of the Fianna, great Oisín, son of Finn, listening to the voice of bells. Long are the clouds over me tonight.

That is where the story ends. Not with a battle. Not with a god. With an old blind man who could have stayed young for ever, sitting in the rain that is not rain, carrying stones, and remembering the names of dogs.

The gods came to Ireland in a mist. The Fianna went out of it under clouds. Everything in between is what we have left, and it is enough. It will have to be.

NOTES

I. The Apology

Lady Gregory explained, at the end of her book, how she had made it.

The Irish text of most of these stories had already been published, and she worked from that text, making her own translation as far as her scholarship went, and, where it failed, taking the meaning given by better scholars. Where the Irish text had not been printed, she worked by comparing and piecing together various translations. She put in a connecting sentence of her own here and there. She fused different versions together, condensed many passages, and left out many — "the choice that is a perpetual refusing," as she put it — trying to get a clear outline of the doings of the heroes.

She said she found it more natural to tell the stories in the manner of the thatched houses, where she had heard so many legends of Finn and his friends, and Oisín and Patrick, and the Ever-Living Ones, and the Country of the Young, than in the manner of the slated houses, where she had never heard them told at all.

She told why she had done the work. Four years before, Dr Atkinson, a Professor of Trinity College, Dublin, giving evidence before the Commission of Intermediate Education, had said that the old literature of Ireland was untouched by the great literatures of the world; that it was "the untrained popular feeling," and almost intolerably low in tone; that where the Greek and Latin and French books each had something with an ideal ring about it, a lasting treasure a child might carry away, he could find nothing ideal in the Irish books, and very little imagination.

Dr Atkinson was an Englishman, she noted, but other professors at Trinity, and students there, had been influenced by his opinion that Irish literature was a thing to be despised. She did not quote him to draw attention to a battle still being fought, she said, but to explain her own purpose: to make part of Irish literature available to many, especially young Irish people, who had neither the chance to read the translations of the scholars, scattered

through learned journals, nor the patience and time to untangle overlapping and contradictory versions — so that they could judge for themselves its "lowness" and its "want of imagination."

She believed that those who once learned to care for the story of Cuchulain of Muirthemne, and of Finn and Lugh and Etain, and to recognise the enduring belief in an invisible world and an immortal life behind the visible and the mortal, would not be content with her version, but would go first to the fuller versions of the best scholars, and then to the manuscripts themselves. She believed the forty students of Old Irish lately called together by Professor Kuno Meyer would not rest until they had explored the scores and scores of uncatalogued and untranslated manuscripts in Trinity College Library, and that the enthusiasm the Gaelic League had given birth to would lead to much fine scholarship.

She mentioned a letter from one of the best Greek scholars and translators in England, himself an Irishman, who said her Cuchulain had opened up to him a great world of beautiful legend he had never known, and that he was sending copies to Irish friends in Australia, expecting them to feel, as he had, something like pride in the beauty of the Irish mind. And she mentioned that President Roosevelt had written to her that, after reading Cuchulain of Muirthemne, he had sent for every other translation from the Irish he could get, to take with him on his journey to the Western States.

She gave those words, she said, not from vanity — for they were not for her, but for her material — to show the effect the old literature had on those who came fresh to it, and that such readers did not complain of its want of imagination. She was proud and glad to have helped make it known, and the task had been pleasant, though toilsome. On the sixth of October, writing that note, she was tired enough, she said, and thought with sympathy of the old Highland piper who complained that he was "withered with yelping the seven Fenian battalions."

II. The Age and Origin of the Stories of the Fianna

Lady Gregory drew on Mr Alfred Nutt's pamphlet, *Ossian and the Ossianic Literature*, number three in his series *Popular Studies in Mythology, Romance, and Folklore*.

Nutt set out that the body of Gaelic literature connected with the name of Ossian — Oisín — is very large and of respectable age. The oldest texts, mostly prose but some in verse, survive in Irish manuscripts of the eleventh and twelfth centuries, and go back at least a hundred and fifty to two hundred and fifty years before that. Most of the Ossianic literature, in the form we have it, is later. A number of important prose texts survive in fourteenth-century manuscripts, probably shaped in the thirteenth and twelfth centuries. But by far the largest mass consists of narrative poems, usually dramatic in form, which have come down in manuscripts written in Scotland from the end of the fifteenth century to the middle of the seventeenth, and in Ireland from the sixteenth century down to the middle of the nineteenth. And the Gaelic-speaking country people of both Ireland and Scotland had preserved by word of mouth a large number of these ballads, and a great mass of prose tales about Ossian and his comrades.

If every Ossianic text in manuscripts older than the nineteenth century were printed, Nutt reckoned, they would fill eight to ten thousand pages. For five hundred years this body of romance had been the chief imaginative recreation of the Gaelic world, in Ireland and Scotland alike, and a peasantry that could not read or write had kept it almost whole.

On whether the stories were history, Nutt said the question hardly mattered. The romances take place in a world entirely romantic, full of divine and half-divine beings, monsters and giants, men and women changing shape with animals, heroes' lives stretched by miracle: a land of Faery. And the conditions they describe do not match anything known of the third century, when Finn was supposed to have lived. The Fianna are always guarding Ireland against over-sea raiders called Lochlannach, clearly thought of as Norsemen — but the Norse only came to Ireland at the end of the eighth century, their great period of invasion running roughly from 825 to 925, followed by a time of settlement in the tenth century, until the battle of Clontarf, fought by Brian, the great chieftain of the south, at the start of the eleventh century, broke up the separate Norse powers and absorbed them into Irish life. So if the stories ever reflected the third century, that reflection was later distorted, and a pseudo-history built on events of the ninth and tenth centuries was put in its place. What the historian looks for in legend, Nutt said, is a picture of the society in which it arose, more than a record of the events it claims to remember.

Nutt went on to ask whether third-century customs could be found in the stories; which parts first found their way into writing; and whether the Oisín and Patrick dialogues were written under the influence of real Pagan feeling surviving from Pagan times, or of a change in the feeling of the Gaelic world during the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries, when those dialogues began to be written in their present form. His conclusion was that "well-nigh the same stories that were told of Finn and his warrior braves by the Gael of the eleventh century are told in well-nigh the same way by his descendant to-day."

Nutt did not ask how long the stories were told before the first was written down. But Larminie — whose early death, Lady Gregory said, was the first great loss of the Irish intellectual movement — pushed them back into untold ages, in the introduction to his *West Irish Folk Tales and Romances*. He argued, carefully and in detail, that the Scottish Highlands and Ireland received their folklore from both "Aryan and non-Aryan sources," and that there is more non-Aryan influence and blood in the Highlands than in Ireland. Nothing, he said, is less likely than that all folk-tales are Aryan. They bear the stamp of more than one race: the pure, placid, often cold imagination of the Aryan in some; in others, the more picturesque fancy, the fierceness and sensuality, the finer sense of artistic elegance, of older peoples. And since the greatest art has often come from a blending of Aryan with other blood, he thought the same might be true in the humbler realm of the folk-tale.

Larminie divided the larger body of Irish legend into three cycles: the divine, the heroic, and the Fenian. The Fenian cycle was so well known by word of mouth in Scotland that people had argued over which country it belonged to — and in fact, he said, it belonged to both. But the divine cycle was, as far as he knew, wholly unknown in Scotland, and the heroic cycle comparatively unknown. Why? Professor Zimmer had not established his view that Finn was a late historical figure, and scholarly opinion had been moving towards seeing Finn as mythical. Mr O'Grady, seeing the difficulty while still believing Finn historical, had placed him before Cúchulain and his companions — but that could not stand once Finn was understood not to be historical at all.

There remained one explanation, Larminie said. The bodies of legend came into Ireland earlier or later with the different races they belonged to. The wider spread of the Finn saga showed it belonged to an early people who had lived in both Ireland and Scotland. Then

came the Aryan Gael, who ruled the island, and whose own bards sang his own gods and heroes — a court poetry, an aristocratic literature. When the Gael conquered Scotland he brought his gods and heroes with him, but the bardic system never took hold there, so only faint echoes of the heroic cycle survived in the northern mountains. In Ireland itself the heroic cycle survived almost entirely through bardic writing; the people had all but forgotten it, if they ever knew it. But they had not forgotten the Fenian cycle. It was everywhere, still loved by the conquered peoples, holding its ground in Scotland and Ireland alike, and in Ireland forcing its way even into written literature, so gaining a double lease of life. The Fenian cycle, in a word, was non-Aryan folk-literature partly given Aryan treatment.

The whole problem, Lady Gregory said, is extremely complex, and others had written on it. Mr Borlase, for instance, had argued in his big book on the dolmens that the cromlechs — and so, presumably, the legend of Diarmuid and Grania — were connected with old religious rites of an erotic kind, coming down from a very primitive state of society.

She came to her own conclusion less by weight of argument than because she found it impossible to arrange the stories in any coherent form while she thought of them as history. She had tried to build on the Annalists and fit the Fianna into a definite historical period, but the whole story seemed trivial and incoherent until she began to think of them as almost contemporary with the battle of Magh Tuireadh, which even the Annalists put back into mythical ages. In this she followed some of the storytellers, who made the mother of Lugh of the Long Hand the grandmother of Finn, and gave Finn a shield soaked in the blood of Balor. She could not think of any of the stories as modern in origin, or believe that the century in which each was written down said anything about its age. "How Diarmuid got his Love-Spot," for instance, taken down only a few years before by Dr Hyde from an old man's recitation, might well be as old as "Finn and the Phantoms," which is in one of the earliest manuscripts. There was as good evidence, she said, for Finn being of the blood of the gods as for his being, as some of the people told her, "the son of an O'Shaughnessy who lived at Kiltartan Cross."

Dr Douglas Hyde, though he had placed the Fenian cycle after the Cuchulain cycle in his *History of Irish Literature*, allowed her to print his view: that while he believed the Fenians really existed, as a body of household troops who lived, ruled and hunted in King Cormac's

time, it was equally certain that hundreds of stories, traits and legends far older and more primitive than anything they themselves could have given rise to had gathered around them. There was probably as much primitive mythology in the Finn legend as in that of the Red Branch. The story of the Fenians was a kind of nucleus to which a great deal of the flotsam and jetsam of a far older period had attached itself, and so been preserved.

Since she could not give the stories a historical date, Lady Gregory, without adding anything to support her theory, left out names such as Cormac and Art and other more or less historical figures, putting "the High King" in their place. In the Battle of the White Strand she left out the name of Caelur, Tadg's wife, because she had already followed another chronicler in giving him Ethlinn for a wife. And in the earlier part of the book she gave back to Angus Og the name of "the Disturber," which she believed had strayed from him to the saint of the same name.

III. The Authorities

Lady Gregory listed the authorities that had most helped her, in putting the stories together and in translating the texts. She said the list could not be quite exact, since she had sometimes moved a phrase, or a whole passage, from one story to another where it seemed to fit better, and sometimes, in the second part of the book, used stories preserved in Scottish Gaelic. She wrote her notes away from any library, and could not check them, but thought them fairly correct.

For The Coming of the Tuatha de Danaan, and Lugh of the Long Hand, and The Coming of the Gael: O'Curry, Manners and Customs of the Ancient Irish; O'Curry's MSS. Materials; Atlantis; De Jubainville, Cycle Mythologique; Hennessy, Chronicum Scotorum; Atkinson, Book of Leinster; the Annals of the Four Masters; Nennius, Historia Britonum (Irish version); Zimmer, Glossae Hibernicae; Whitley Stokes, Three Irish Glossaries; the Revue Celtique and Irische Texte; Gaedelica; Nutt, Voyage of Bran; Proceedings of the Ossianic Society; O'Beirne Crowe, Amra Columcille; the Dean of Lismore's Book; Windisch, Irische Texte; Hennessy and others in the Revue Celtique; the Kilkenny Archaeological Journal; Keating's History; Ogygia; Curtin's Folk Tales; Proceedings of the Royal Irish Academy, MSS. Series; Dr Sigerson, Bards of Gael and Gall; Miscellanies of the Celtic Society.

For Book Four, The Ever-Living Living Ones, she used many of those, and for particular stories:

Midhir and Etain: O'Curry, Manners and Customs; Whitley Stokes, Dinnsenchus; Müller in the *Revue Celtique*; Nutt, *Voyage of Bran*; De Jubainville, *Epopée Celtique*; and a manuscript lent her by Standish Hayes O'Grady.

Manannan at Play: S. Hayes O'Grady, *Silva Gaedelica*.

His Call to Bran: Professor Kuno Meyer in Nutt's *Voyage of Bran*; S. Hayes O'Grady, *Silva Gaedelica*; De Jubainville, *Cycle Mythologique*.

His Three Calls to Cormac: Whitley Stokes, *Irische Texte*.

Clodna's Wave: S. Hayes O'Grady, *Silva Gaedelica*; Whitley Stokes, *Dinnsenchus*.

His Call to Connla: O'Beirne Crowe, *Kilkenny Archaeological Journal*; Windisch, *Irische Texte*.

Tadg in the Islands: S. Hayes O'Grady, *Silva Gaedelica*.

Laegaire in the Happy Plain: S. H. O'Grady, *Silva Gaedelica*; Kuno Meyer in Nutt's *Voyage of Bran*.

The Fate of the Children of Lir: O'Curry, *Atlantis*.

The Coming of Finn, and Finn's Household: *Proceedings of the Ossianic Society*; Kuno Meyer, *Four Songs of Summer and Winter*; the *Revue Celtique*; S. Hayes O'Grady, *Silva Gaedelica*; Curtin's *Folk Tales*.

The Birth of Bran: *Proceedings of the Ossianic Society*.

Oisín's Mother: Kennedy, *Legendary Fictions of the Irish Celts*; Mac Innis; *Leabhar na Feinne*.

The Best Men of the Fianna: the Dean of Lismore's Book; *Silva Gaedelica*; *Leabhar na Feinne*.

The Lad of the Skins: Waifs and Strays of Celtic Tradition; Larminie's Folk Tales; Curtin's Tales.

The Hound: Silva Gaedelica; Whitley Stokes, Dinnsenchus.

Red Ridge: Silva Gaedelica.

The Battle of the White Strand: Kuno Meyer, *Anecdota Oxoniensia*; Hanmer's Chronicle; the Dean of Lismore; Curtin's Tales; Silva Gaedelica.

The King of Britain's Son: Silva Gaedelica.

The Cave of Ceiscoran: Silva Gaedelica.

Donn, Son of Midhir: Silva Gaedelica.

The Hospitality of Cuanna's House: Proceedings of the Ossianic Society.

Cat-Heads and Dog-Heads: the Dean of Lismore; *Leabhar na Feinne*; Campbell's Popular Tales of the Western Highlands.

Lomna's Head: O'Curry; Cormac's Glossary, O'Donovan, edited by Stokes.

Ilbrec of Ess Ruadh: Silva Gaedelica.

The Cave of Cruachan: Stokes, *Irische Texte*.

The Wedding at Ceann Slieve: Proceedings of the Ossianic Society.

The Shadowy One: O'Curry.

Finn's Madness: Silva Gaedelica.

The Red Woman: Hyde, *Sgealuidhe Gaedhealach*.

Finn and the Phantoms: Kuno Meyer, *Revue Celtique*.

The Pigs of Angus: Proceedings of the Ossianic Society.

The Hunt of Slieve Cuilinn: Proceedings of the Ossianic Society.

Oisín's Children: O'Curry; *Leabhar na Feinne*; Campbell's Popular Tales of the Western Highlands; Stokes, *Irische Texte*; the Dean of Lismore; the Celtic Magazine; *Waifs and Strays of Celtic Tradition*.

The Birth of Diarmuid: The Pursuit of Diarmuid and Grania (Society for the Preservation of the Irish Language); Campbell's Popular Tales.

How Diarmuid Got His Love-Spot: Hyde, *Sgealuidhe Gaedhealach*.

The Daughter of King Under-Wave: Campbell's Popular Tales.

The Hard Servant: *Silva Gaedelica*.

The House of the Quicken Trees: manuscripts in the Royal Irish Academy, and in Dr Hyde's possession.

Diarmuid and Grania: the text published by S. Hayes O'Grady in the Proceedings of the Ossianic Society, and re-edited by N. O'Duffey for the Society for the Preservation of the Irish Language; Kuno Meyer, *Revue Celtique*, and *Four Songs*; *Leabhar na Feinne*; Campbell's Popular Tales; the *Kilkenny Archaeological Journal*; *Folk Lore*, volume vii, 1896; the Dean of Lismore; Nutt, *Waifs and Strays of Celtic Tradition*.

Cnoc-an-Air and the rest: Proceedings of the Ossianic Society.

The Wearing Away of the Fianna: *Silva Gaedelica*; the Dean of Lismore; *Leabhar na Feinne*; Campbell's Popular Tales; Proceedings of the Ossianic Society; O'Curry; *Waifs and Strays of Celtic Tradition*; Stokes, *Irische Texte*.

The End of the Fianna: Hyde, *Sgealuidhe Gaedhealach*; Proceedings of the Ossianic Society; *Silva Gaedelica*; Miss Brooke's *Reliques*; the *Annals of the Four Masters*; the Celtic Magazine.

Oisín and Patrick, and Oisín's Laments: Proceedings of the Ossianic Society; the Dean of Lismore; the *Kilkenny Archaeological Journal*; Curtin's Tales.

She took Grania's sleepy song, the description of Finn's shield and of Cumhal's treasure-bag, and the fact of Finn's descent from Ethlinn, from Duanaire Finn, then being edited for

the Irish Texts Society by Mr John MacNeill, who let her see the proofs. She sometimes used parts of stories, or comments on them, gathered directly from the people, who had kept these heroes so much in mind.

The story of Caoilte coming to the help of the King of Ireland in a dark wood, she said, was the only one she had given without either a written or a folk ancestry. Mr Yeats had heard or read it, he could not remember where, and with it in his mind had written of "Caoilte's burning hair" in one of his poems.

She gave special thanks to those good workers in the discovery of Irish literature, Professor Kuno Meyer and Mr Whitley Stokes, translators of so many manuscripts; and to her friend and kinsman Standish Hayes O'Grady, for what she had taken from that wonderful treasure-house, his *Silva Gaedelica*.

IV. The Pronunciation

Lady Gregory gave the approximate pronunciation of some of the harder names:

Adhnuall: Ai-noo-al. Ailbhe: Alva. Almhuin: All-oon, or Alvin. Aobh: Aev, or Eev. Aodh: Ae (rhyming with "day"). Aoibhill: Evill. Aoife: Eefa.

Badb: Bibe. Beltaine, or Bealtaine: Bal-tinna. Bladhma: Bly-ma. Bodb Dearg: Bove Darrig.

Caoilte: Cweeltia. Cam Ruidhe: Corn Rwee. Ciabhan: Kee-a-van. Cliodna: Cleevna. Coincheann: Kun-Kann. Crann Buidhe: Cran bwee. Credhe: Crae-a. Cumhal: Coo-al.

Deaghadh: D'ya-a. Dubhthach: Duffach. Duibhreann: Dhiv-ran. Duibhrium: Dhiv-rinn. Dun: Doon.

Eimher: Aevir. Emhain: Avvin. Eochaid: Eohee. Eoghan: Owen.

Fionnchad: Finn-ach-a. Fodhla: Fóla. Fodla: Fola.

Gallimh: Gol-yiv. Glas Gaibhnenn: Glos Gov-nan.

Leith Laeig: Leh Laeg. Loch Dairbhreach: Loch Darvragh. Lugaidh: Loo-ee, or Lewy. Lugh: Loo.

Magh an Ionganaidh: Moy-in-eean-ee. Magh Cuilleán: Moy Cullin. Magh Feabhail: Moy Fowl. Magh Macraimhe: Moy Mucrivva. Magh Mell: Moy Mal. Magh Rein: Moy Raen. Magh Tuireadh: Moytirra. Manannan: Mananaun. Midhe: Mee. Midhna: Mee-na. Mochaomhog: Mo-cwee-vog. Muadhan: Moo-aun. Murchadh: Murachu.

Nemhnain: Now-nin. Niamh: Nee-av.

Og: Og.

Rath Medba, or Meadhbha: Ra Maev-a. Rudraighe: Rury.

Samhain: Sow-in. Scathniamh: Scau-nee-av. Sceolan: Skolaun. Searbhan: Sharavaun. Sidhe: Shee. Slieve Echtge: Sleev Acht-ga.

Tadg: Teig. Teamhair: T'yower, or Tavvir. Tuatha de Danaan: Too-a-ha dae Donnan. Tuathmumhain: Too-moon.

She said she had followed no fixed rule for spelling Irish names. She took her spellings from various good authorities, but they varied so much that complete accuracy was not easy, and she sometimes went by custom and convenience. She used "Slieve" for "Sliabh," for instance, because it came up so often and a mispronunciation would spoil so many names. She treated "Inbhir," a river-mouth, the same way, spelling it "Inver," and even adopting it as an English word, because it was so useful. The forty scholars of the new school of Old Irish, she said, would do good service if they worked at the spelling and pronunciation of the old names and settled them as far as possible.

V. The Place Names

These are the places of the stories, with the names they carried in Lady Gregory's day:

Accuill: Achill, County Mayo. Aine Cliach: Cnoc Aine, County Limerick. Almhuin: near Kildare. Ath Cliath: Dublin. Athluain: Athlone. Ath na Riogh: Athenry. Badhamain: Cahir, County Tipperary. Baile Cronin: Barony of Imokilty, County Cork. Banna: the Bann. Beare: Berehaven. Bearna na Eadargana: Roscommon. Bearnas Mor: County Donegal. Beinn Gulbain: Benbulbin, County Sligo. Beire do Bhunadas: Berehaven. Bel-atha Senaig: Ballyshannon. Belgata: in Connemara. Benna Boirche: the source of the Bann, and the

Mourne Mountains. Berramain: near Tralee. Buas: the River Bush. Boinn: the River Boyne. Bri Leith: County Longford.

Cairbre: Carbury. Cairgin: three miles south of Londonderry. Carrthach River: the River Carra, near the Dunkerrin Mountains. Ceanntsaile: Kinsale. Ceiscorainn: County Sligo. Cill Dun: Killaloe, County Clare. Cliodna's Wave: at Glandore, County Cork. Cluantarbh: Clontarf. Cnoc Aine: County Limerick. Cnoc-an-Air: County Kerry. Cnoc-na-righ: County Sligo. Corca Duibhne: Corcaguiny, County Kerry. Corrslieve: the Carlow Mountains. Crotta Cliach: the Galtee Mountains. Cruachan: County Roscommon. Cruachan Aigle: Croagh Patrick.

Doire an Cairn: Derrycarn, County Meath. Doire-da-Bhoth: in Slieve Echtge. Druim Cleibh: County Sligo. Druim Lis: near Loch Gill. Druimscarha: near the River Arighis, County Cork. Dun Sobairce: Dunseverick, County Antrim. Durlas: Thurles.

Ess Dara: near Sligo. Ess Ruadh: Assaroe, County Donegal. Fidh Gaible: Fergill, County Sligo. Finntraighe: Ventry. Fionn: the Finn. Fionnabraic: Kilfenora, County Clare. Fionntulach: County Limerick. Fleisg: County Kerry.

Gabhra: near Tara. Garbh-abha-na-Fiann: the River Leamhan, which flows from Killarney. Gairech and Ilgairech: hills near Mullingar. Gallimh: Galway. Gleann na Caor: County Cork. Grellach Dollaid: Barony of Rathconrath.

Hill of Bairnech: near Killarney. Hill of Uisnech: County Westmeath.

Inver Cechmaine: the east coast of Ulster. Inver Colpa: Drogheda. Inver Slane: the north-east of Leinster. Irrus Domnann: Erris, County Mayo. Island of Toraig: Tory Island, County Donegal.

Laoi: the River Lee. Leith Laoi: Leitrim. Linn Feic: near the Slaney. Loch Bel Sead: County Tipperary. Loch Cé: County Roscommon. Loch Dairbhreach: Lough Derryvaragh, County Westmeath. Loch Derg Dheirc: Lough Derg on the Shannon. Loch Erne: Lough Erne. Loch Feabhail: Lough Foyle. Loch Lein: Killarney. Loch Orbson: Lough Corrib. Loch na-n Ean: in County Roscommon. Loch Neathach: Lough Neagh. Luimneach: Limerick.

Maen Mhagh: the plain around Loughrea. Magh Cobha: Iveagh, County Down. Magh Cuilenn: Moycullen, County Galway. Magh Femen: County Tipperary. Magh Lorg: County Roscommon. Magh Leine: King's County. Magh Luirg: County Roscommon. Magh Maoin: County Wexford. Magh Mucruimhe: near Athenry. Magh Nia: the same as Magh Tuireadh. Magh Rein: County Leitrim. Magh Tuireadh: Moytura near Sligo, scene of the great battle; and Moytura near Cong, scene of the first battle. The marsh of Finnliath: the River Lee, near Tralee. Midhe: Meath, west of Ardagh. Inis Geadh: in the Bay of Erris. Muaid: the River Moy. Muc-inis: Muckinish, off Connemara.

Nas: Naas. Nem: the Nem.

Aonach Clochair: Morristown, County Limerick. Osraige: Ossory.

The Paps of Dana: County Kerry. Portlairge: Waterford.

River Maigh: County Limerick. Ros-da-Shoileach: Limerick. Ruirtech: the Liffey.

Samair: the River Cumhair, which runs through Bruff. Sionnan: the River Shannon. Siuir: the River Suir, County Tipperary. The Siuir and the Beoir and the Berba: the Suir and the Nore and the Barrow. Slieve Baune: County Roscommon. Slieve Bladhma: Slieve Bloom. Slieve Buane: Slieve Bawn, County Roscommon. Slieve Conaill: on the border of Leitrim and Donegal. Slieve Crot: County Tipperary. Slieve Cua: County Waterford. Slieve Cua and Slieve Crot: in the Galtee Mountains. Slieve Cuailgne: County Louth. Slieve Echtge: County Galway. Slieve Fuad: County Armagh. Slieve Guaire: County Cavan. Slieve Luachra: County Kerry. Slieve Lugha: County Mayo. Slieve Mis: County Kerry. Slieve Muice: County Tipperary. Slieve-nam-Ban: County Tipperary. Sligach: Sligo. Srub Bruin: in West Kerry. Sruth na Maoile: the Mull of Cantire.

Tailltin: Teltown. Teamhair: Tara, County Meath. Teamhair Luachra: near Castleisland, County Kerry. The Beith: the River Behy, Barony of Dunkerrin. The Beoir: the Berba. The Islands of Mod: in Clew Bay. The Lemain: the River Laune, County Kerry. The Muaidh: the River Moy, County Sligo. Tonn Toime: Toomies, near Killarney. Traigh Eothaile: near Ballysadare. Tuathmumhain: Thomond.

Ui Chonaill Gabhra: County Limerick. Ui Fiachrach: County Mayo.

Wave of Rudraighe: the Bay of Dundrum.

Every one of those places is still there. You can stand on most of them. The stories are not, strictly, anywhere; but if you want to look for them, that is where you would start.